

PHYNLEY MEYERS

GREEK ROW



Freek Row

Phynley Meyers

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AUTHOR'S NOTE

When I began writing this book, I quickly realized that a reference glossary might be useful for any readers who are unfamiliar with the ways of Greek life. If you'd like a quick reference for the sorority phrases and terms used throughout the book, you can find them on the next page.

SORORITY TERMINOLOGY

BID: An official invitation of membership from a sorority.

BIG/LITTLE: The Big/Little reveal is a process in which an older, well-adjusted member of the chapter (typically a sophomore or junior) is assigned to a specific incoming member, with an overall goal of providing mentorship and friendship. In addition to these titles, there are also *g-bigs*, *g-littles*, and so on as the “family” grows by one to two members each year.

CHAPTER (*Context-Specific*):

(1) A school-specific band of a national sorority’s organization. For example: If the fictional Alpha Omega were a sorority organization that was active at fifty different universities across the U.S., then Cabot University’s Alpha Omega would be one chapter out of those fifty.

(2) A weekly meeting required for all active members that typically discusses upcoming events and deadlines.

EXECUTIVE BOARD: A board of chapter members who have been elected to various roles that assist with important chapter functions. This typically includes some variation of the following: President, Vice President, VP of Membership, VP of Judicial, etc.

INITIATION: The process through which pledging members are officially sworn in as active members, ending their probationary period.

PLEDGE: A partial member of a chapter, who is on a probationary period until initiation.

PLEDGING PERIOD: The probationary period between when a bid is accepted and when a new member is initiated.

PNM: Potential New Member. A term used for incoming freshman, sophomores, or even juniors that are actively participating in recruitment on the new-member side.

RECRUITMENT: The official process by which fraternities and sororities recruit new members from their specific school. Processes vary between chapters, but the method described in the White Rose Ceremony in the book is a general tactic.

PROLOGUE

I've never run this fast in my life.

The echoing of my name through the trees only fuels me to go faster, though my heart is already pounding outside of my chest—as if it could explode any minute.

My legs are on autopilot now, but they take me exactly where I need to go. I continue through the trees, barreling through each of them as the pounding footsteps come closer behind me.

I'm running.

Faster.

And faster.

Until I hear the sound.

The familiar, deafening noise of a gunshot ringing through the woods.

Pop.

Before I can stop myself, my legs crumble to the ground, and my face slams down into the cold, hard dirt.

The sounds of snapping branches and crunching leaves fill my ears as I hear the footsteps slowly coming towards me.

Closer. And closer.

And closer.

Then, everything goes black.

1

LEIGHTON

2024

W*elcome to Brookwood.*

I gaze at the sign through my windshield as I pass through the small Northern Alabama community.

This drive marks my departure from the rural, compact Tennessee town I've known my entire life. As of today, I've officially left everything behind for a fresh start as a student at the prestigious university I've dreamed of attending since my junior year of high school. Now—several miles and two gas station stops later—I've finally arrived in the lovely little town that will serve as my home for the next four years.

Cabot University's main campus is on the far edge of town, and my GPS puts me arriving at my residence hall in about five minutes.

“—And don't forget to text when you're all settled in.”

My mother's voice echoes out from my car's display, finishing a sentence I droned out the majority of. This is the fifth time she's called since I left home earlier, so I haven't really been listening to her this time around.

“I will, Mom,” I reply softly. “Try not to worry too much.”

“I can't help it,” she says with a twinge of stress that is noticeable even through the distortion of my car speaker's audio. “It's my job to worry about you.”

When I broke the news to my parents that I was planning to attend an out-of-state school, my mother didn't take it very well. She's always been very family-oriented, and my departure from the household officially deems her and my father empty-nesters, so it's needless to say that she has been struggling with my decision. Nonetheless, both of my parents knew better

than to hold me back from attending a school that could heavily influence my future career.

So now, I'm here.

Hundreds of miles away from home, and ready for my new beginning.

As my mother rambles on about women's safety tips she learned from an article, I spot the familiar school buildings a short distance ahead, and my Maps app is now announcing arrival in less than a minute.

The moment I make the turn onto campus, it is evident that the Cabot grounds are just as beautiful as they looked on the website. The sidewalks are filled with lively students chatting amongst each other, and white stone buildings with sparkling blue windows illuminate the setting in the background. Perfectly-landscaped bushes and trees line every walkway and building, and hundreds of colorful flowers are scattered throughout the grassy areas. As I cruise through campus, I feel as if I've been transported onto the set of a feel-good college movie.

When I eventually reach the parking lot outside of my assigned residence hall, I slide my car into park and unmute my side of the phone call.

"Mom?" I chime in. "I have to go. Just made it to Norman."

The two of us say a quick, loving goodbye before I tap the *end call* button upon the display. As soon as I'm sure the call has finished, I step outside to take a closer look at my new home.

Norman Hall is a five-story freshman/sophomore dorm building in the North Village section of Cabot's campus. The rooms are suite-style, so I'll have my own space, and it's the closest dorm to the Student Union, so it's not far from the academic buildings. Norman was built recently—within the past few years—and it once held a reputation as being the most desired residence hall among students at Cabot University.

Until one night last November, when two well-known students and Norman Hall residents walked out the main entrance, only to never be seen again.

Some would find it disturbing to learn this type of information about their new place-of-living, but being a true crime fanatic and an incoming criminal justice major, it intrigues me more than it unnerves me. My mother, however, would undoubtedly call the administration demanding a room change if she found out that I will be residing in a dorm that's directly associated with disappearances and death.

Which is exactly why she can't find out. Moving residence halls would put a serious kink in my plan for the semester.

For context, the Criminal Justice program at Cabot University is highly esteemed; some of the country's finest criminal investigators have walked the same halls of the very school that I am soon to be enrolled in. All incoming freshmen hoping to pursue a major within the criminal justice field must complete general education courses for their first semester at school, after which they are considered eligible to apply to the Bradshaw School of Criminal Justice—named for Cabot alumni and legendary FBI investigator, Douglas Bradshaw.

The only obstacle I'm currently facing is that the school only accepts the top 10% of all applicants, and the candidates I'm up against are guaranteed to be well-educated and highly accomplished students. They wouldn't have been accepted into the university otherwise.

Because of this, I'll have to work even harder to earn a spot.

Last month, I emailed my newly-assigned academic advisor in hopes of her being able to help me come up with an action plan to guarantee my acceptance to the program. She responded with a list of the top three necessities for my application within a few days, so I've had plenty of time to drill the points into my head.

BRADSHAW ACCEPTANCE PLAN

INVOLVEMENT: Join a student-led organization and get as involved as possible.

MAKE CONNECTIONS: Find a recommendation from the Criminal Justice department—preferably a teacher or an older student pursuing the same focus.

DISTINCTION: What sets you apart from other applicants?

I spent the better part of a month analyzing the list, wracking my brain to find something about myself that sets me apart from the general student body of Cabot University. I've always been a great student—my grades have never dropped below an A-minus, and I was elected Class Representative on student government all four years of high school. I was even a member of three sports teams, winning regional awards for two—cross-country and track.

Still, despite my extensive involvement, I've never really done anything extraordinary. I needed to come up with something, and quickly.

The idea didn't come to me until Cabot released housing assignments for the upcoming school year. When I refreshed my student portal that mid-summer evening, the message appeared in my inbox: I would be living in Norman Hall, and my assigned roommate would be an incoming freshman named Marley.

Though I was excited about my roommate assignment, my attention was fully grabbed by the familiarity of the dormitory name. After unsuccessfully trying to make the connection on my own, I decided to research the name.

Following an extensive day of researching the internet, I discovered that Norman Hall had been a topic of conversation in the media for the past year. This was the last place that Riley Walker and Caroline Rowe—sophomores at Cabot University and close friends—were formally seen before disappearing for good. Nobody has seen or heard from them since November 2023, and the mystery aspect of the case has completely swept the online true-crime community.

With that, the idea came to mind, and a plan soon formed.

Solving the girls' disappearance would not only bring much-needed closure to the friends and families of the victims—it would also guarantee my acceptance into my dream program. After all, there's no better way to stand out to the Bradshaw Admission's Board than to solve the mystery that has stumped local and federal investigators for the last nine months.

Finding out what happened to Riley and Caroline is going to be my first-class ticket into Bradshaw. Unless I somehow come up with a better plan in the next few weeks, I'm committed to uncovering the truth.

And I have a feeling that Cabot University has a few secrets they'd rather keep buried.

2

Patience is a virtue, especially for college students.

After nearly an hour of waiting in line, I've finally reached the front desk of Norman Hall—the place where all incoming residents must first go in order to retrieve their room keys. With over 4,000 freshmen reportedly moving onto campus this year, I had mentally prepared for move-in to be a long process, so I haven't felt stressed about the wait.

Plus, it's kind of exciting to get a sneak-peek at all of my new neighbors.

"Name?"

My train of thought is interrupted when the boy behind the desk motions to me, barely looking up from his computer as he speaks. As I shuffle to the front of the crowd, I'm able to tell that he's around my age—probably a sophomore or late freshman.

"Leighton Adams," I reply.

He nods, then quickly types my name into the system while squinting at the screen in front of him.

"It looks like your original roommate, Marley, has requested a change of residence halls." He runs his finger across the computer screen, eventually landing on whatever he's looking for. "Your newly-assigned roommate will be Alison Hartnell—she arrived this morning."

I suppress a laugh. Marley probably didn't feel too comfortable cozying up in a residence hall where two presumed-dead girls lived, and I guess I can't really blame her for that.

When I first researched Norman Hall, I saw a concerning number of reviews from past residents who genuinely believe that the dormitory is haunted by the ghosts of Riley and Caroline—or even that the building is cursed. I'm hoping that Alison will be a little more thick-skinned, whoever she is, because having a revolving door of random roommates in and out of my living space isn't exactly living the dream.

"Sounds great," I say with a smile. "Thanks."

The boy slides a sealed envelope across the counter and wishes me a good day before kindly shoos me off to handle the next incoming resident.

The envelope has black, bold writing across the front.

Fourth Floor, Room 433B.

After a quick review of the residence hall directory, I'm soon heading up the elevator with a cart of my belongings in tow. I mash the fourth-floor button and ride to the top, then begin pushing my cart down the hallway in hopes of eventually finding my new room. There are limited directories, but I notice the room numbers beginning to fall closer to the one listed on my envelope.

As I cruise the hallways, I pass many other smiling faces toting their belongings into their new homes. Most seem as excited as can be, and I find myself wondering if any of them are even aware of the history of this building.

The case is easy enough to research if you know where to look, but Cabot University has done their best to distance themselves from the investigation—typically censoring any articles that specifically link the case to the school or Norman Hall. Their only acknowledgment of any affiliation to the girls was a short condolences statement released several months into the investigation, right around the time that the Brookwood Police Department publicly announced that they were no longer investigating any leads relating to the disappearance. Otherwise, the school has avoided association with Riley and Caroline entirely.

I can't help but wonder why.

My eyes soon catch a glimpse of the number 433 out of the corner of my eye. I take this as my cue to open the envelope I was given, slide out the room key, and turn it into the lock—opening up the door that leads to my brand new home.

My assigned dorm is a traditional 2 x 2 style suite, meaning that my roommate and I will each have our own bedrooms, but will share the common areas—the bathroom, shower, and the living room. As I step inside, I see that the first bedroom visible from the door has been adorned from floor to ceiling with bright pink decorations, along with a few large, leafy plants. Large bins full of clothing lay atop the bed and the floor, as if she got tired of unpacking her clothes halfway through.

I step forward to look around, internally preparing for an awkward first introduction, but I quickly notice that nobody is inside the room. My roommate must've stepped out to explore campus.

I've been assigned to the second room, so I draw out the smaller key from the envelope and use it to unlock the door marked with a large *B* in black lettering at the top.

When the door swings open, I'm surprised by how much space I have. I have always heard the term "*shoebox*" as a descriptor for the size of freshman dorm bedrooms, but this room is only slightly smaller than my room at home.

The space has been entirely pre-furnished by the university. Underneath the twin bed sits a dresser with four large drawers appearing to be made from an expensive type of dark wood—maybe walnut or hickory. A mini fridge stands to the right of the dresser, and finally, a small chair is tucked beneath a desk that sits below my window—staring out at the Greek Row houses across the street.

Looks like I'll be neighbors with the sorority girls.

My next half-hour is spent setting up basic necessities throughout the suite—toothbrush/ toothpaste, bed sheets, etc. The three hour drive has tired me out, and I don't feel like spending the rest of my night tediously hanging up decorations. Besides, the time is rapidly approaching 8:00 p.m., so I've probably missed my window to make new friends today.

Instead, I pull out my notebook and computer and begin composing a plan for the upcoming months. If I'm going to have a shot in the dark at solving this case, I need to come up with a solid line of investigation. After opening up my laptop and placing it on my new desk, I walk over to my cart of belongings and grab a bulky white shoebox from the top of the pile.

When I first had the idea to investigate the disappearance, I compiled all of the information that I could find into my own, handwritten case file. Afterwards, I printed out a few other related documents that might help me find something, then categorized folders: maps of downtown Brookwood and campus, official statements, surveillance photos... you get the point.

Now, they're all neatly organized into this singular box.

After choosing the top two stapled sets of documents off the paper stack, I place them carefully on my desktop and put on my reading glasses.

It's time to get to work.

CASE DETAILS:

DISAPPEARANCE OF CAROLINE ROWE AND RILEY WALKER

ALL INFORMATION HAS BEEN COLLECTED FROM NEWS ARTICLES, OFFICIAL POLICE DOCUMENTS, AND RELEASED FOOTAGE

Riley Walker and Caroline Rowe—roommates and best friends, who were sophomores at Cabot University—departed from Norman Hall on November 20th, 2023 at 9:30 p.m. The cameras in the student lounge captured their movements as they walked out the door toward the parking lot. It was a Saturday night, and the girls had planned to skip the annual pre-Thanksgiving break parties that most other students were attending. Instead, they intended to pick up takeout and stay in for the night.

According to a few friends who had invited them to the Theta Mu Turkey Bash that night, Caroline had broken up with her boyfriend (a member of the fraternity) the week before—this being the main factor in the girls' decision to trade the most popular event of the year for a quiet night in.

Caroline placed a to-go order for two at Marciello's—a local Italian restaurant—via phone call at 9:22 p.m, which was verified by the restaurant's phone records. The order was ready for pickup by 9:50 p.m., but as closing time approached, no one ever arrived to retrieve it. Investigators believe something must have happened to pull the girls away from their plan during the fifteen-minute drive to the restaurant, as surveillance footage confirmed that Riley's car had originally departed in the direction of the restaurant.

The girls were not reported missing until the next morning, when neither of them showed up for a previously planned event. Summer Harding—a close friend and classmate of Riley and Caroline—made several phone calls to the girls and knocked on their door numerous times, but sadly it was to no avail. When no contact was made on behalf of the two by 6:00 that evening, Summer decided to involve local police. Unfortunately, by the time investigators were notified of the potential disappearance, the 48-hour surveillance footage at local businesses had expired, leaving the police with no confirmation about their final movements while driving.

Investigators attempted tracking their cellular devices via local cell towers, but they soon found that the girls had switched off their phone locations following their departure from Norman Hall. This discovery raised suspicion regarding the nature of their disappearance, and instilled doubt in many of the officers.

It wasn't until they found Riley's car at a train station 25 miles outside of Brookwood that the police came up with the runaway theory, though the station explicitly stated that the girls could not have possibly rode out of this station on November 20th. The tracks were closed for construction at the time, and no trains were scheduled for that entire week.

No foul play was suspected in the first few days of the investigation, but as weeks passed with no leads and zero contact from either of the girls, people began to press the Brookwood Police Department for answers. Investigators originally theorized that Riley and Caroline had run off together due to the immense pressure of the academic system at Cabot, but anyone who actually knew the girls knew better than to believe that. Both were excellent students, known to spend many a late night in the school library studying for an upcoming test or working on a class presentation. The pressure didn't bother them—it just drove them to do better.

The case plagued the media for the following months, with the local police department coming under intense scrutiny for their inability to find any evidence that would assist in locating the two girls. This pressure sparked a media frenzy that led to several false leads and zero genuine answers, along with several speculative theories that involved other Cabot students. Most of these theories had no supporting evidence and were simply attempts to place blame for their disappearance. However, one potential suspect did appear to be promising.

Noah Banks—Caroline's recent ex-boyfriend and a member of Theta Mu Beta—allegedly disappeared from the Turkey Bash around 10:00 p.m. on November 20th, only to return the next morning looking disheveled and confused, according to his fraternity brothers. He claimed he simply had too much to drink at the pregame the night before, and had slept at a close friend's place to escape the loud party at the frat house— a story that was corroborated by the friend himself.

Despite his alibi, the general running theory among case-followers is that Noah Banks killed Caroline and took out Riley as collateral. This is the leading theory by a landslide, and even with no evidence supporting it,

Noah has been declared guilty by the court of public opinion. However—in the United States court system, no body discovery means no conviction, so the case eventually went cold and no further suspects were identified.

As of August 2024, there have been no confirmed sightings of the two girls, though many false reports have been made. Many still raise awareness for the case through fundraising and social media efforts, but the Brookwood Police Department has yet to re-open an investigation.

3

I wake up drenched in sweat.

My neck and back feel stiff, and upon opening my eyes I realize that I've fallen asleep on my desk. As I'm lifting myself up and straightening up the files that are now scattered across my desk, I realize I never brushed my teeth earlier, so I swiftly get up and head over to the shared bathroom.

While I'm in the hallway, I glance over at Alison's room to see if she's returned home yet, but her door is hanging open and the lights are off. She must not have made it back yet.

At least one of us has had an eventful first night of college.

The digital clock sitting atop her desk reads 2:36 *a.m.* This is an hour of the night where most freshmen are presumably drinking in large groups of newly-made friends throughout the dorms—asking each other a variation of the same three conversation-striking questions.

Where are you from?

What are you majoring in?

Which residence hall are you in?

Since I've never been one for small-talk, I can't say that I really feel like I'm missing out on anything, but I know that I should likely focus on making a few friends these next few weeks. Bradshaw prefers to admit students who are socially involved, so I doubt that becoming a case-investigating social reject will help me to earn an acceptance into my dream program. My advisor listed involvement as the highest priority on my list, so I need to find a way to put myself out there as soon as possible.

I pull out my phone and run a quick search for the Cabot University Facebook page. The student admissions packet I received over summer mentioned that the school would be posting new-student celebrations and involvement opportunities on this page for the first few weeks of the semester, so I figure this is the best place to look.

Conveniently enough, the first post that pops up seems to be the answer to all of my problems.

STUDENT ORGANIZATION FAIR:

Friday, August 20th, 2024

Find your perfect fit at the annual Fall Student Organization Fair this Friday! From Chess Club, to Greek organizations, to the student newspaper—we have a club for every student, so don't miss out!

Our 200+ clubs will be lined up along Wallis Road from 11AM-4PM.

It's almost too well-timed that the student org fair is happening right outside my residence hall, so there's really no excuse for me to skip it. Maybe I'll even learn something helpful towards my investigation.

But I won't know until morning.



I wake in the morning to the sound of a door closing outside of my bedroom. It seems like my new roommate has finally made it back to the dorm.

I turn on my phone and check the time.

10:36 a.m.

Perfect timing.

After crawling out of bed, I walk over to my still-packed belongings to pick out an outfit for the fair. Getting ready only takes five minutes, so afterwards I decide to step out and meet my new roommate in my spare time. Right as I'm about to walk out of my room, though, a quick knock sounds at the door before it comes swinging open.

A beautiful girl with long blonde hair, sunkissed skin, and sparkling blue eyes stands behind it, her cheeks creased with dimples as she smiles at me. She's dressed like a 2000s style icon—low waist jeans and all—and she's carrying a flyer in her hand.

"Hi, you must be Peyton," she exclaims. "I'm Alison, your new roommate!"

"It's *Leighton* actually," I say with a smile. "And it's so nice to meet you, too."

"Leighton, got it," she says, placing emphasis on the *L* at the beginning of my name. "I was wondering if you'd want to come down to the Org Fair with me? I'm hoping to get to talk to some of the sorority tables before recruitment—you know, just to put my name out there early on. What do you think?"

“I’m not sure if sororities are really my thing...” I hesitate for a moment before rethinking myself. “But I was planning on going to the fair anyways, so I’d love to go with you!”

Socializing will be much easier if I have another person with me. There’s always strength in numbers.

While the two of us walk out of our room and head downstairs, we circle through the regular introductory questions to learn more about the other. Considering we’ll be living together for an entire year, it feels important to get to know each other on at least a basic level.

I learn that Alison grew up in a small town in Southern Alabama—the name of which I can’t remember—and came to Cabot for their Marketing program. She’s one of three kids, and her parents own a large tech company based in Huntsville. I tell her about my desire to join the Bradshaw program and my need for student involvement on my application this fall, but decide to leave out my interest in investigating Riley and Caroline’s case. After all, I don’t want to scare her away already.

As we begin to approach the first few tables set up along the street, I tell her about my hesitation to join a sorority.

“I get it,” she responds. “It’s not exactly my thing either, but my mom and sisters—hell, even my grandmother—were all in sororities at their colleges. It’s pretty much been ingrained in my head that I would be a sorority sister since I took my first steps.”

Suddenly, Alison’s eyes brighten with an idea.

“How about this? We’ll talk to a few different chapters today, and if we hate it, I’ll help you find another option to satisfy your student involvement requirement.”

I hesitate before answering, but I eventually realize I don’t have much of a better plan.

“Sounds great.”

The street is completely lined with colorful tables—large informative trifolds and twinkling lights sitting atop each one. As we walk further down the rows, I see several options of clubs to stop and talk to. Mathletes, Dance Club, Democrats of Cabot University, Cabot Chemistry Club...the list goes on.

Towards the middle of the street, the sorority tables begin to come into view, and Alison gives me a run down of each chapter.

“That’s Gamma Xi,” she whispers, pointing out a bright green table decorated with small ceramic turtles and polka dotted ribbons. “They’re mainly known for being good at STEM-related subjects. Great fit for science majors, but not a good choice if you want to actually have fun this semester.”

She shifts her focus to a blue table up ahead, adorned with bright white fairy lights and a smaller trifold reading *Kappa Phi Beta* at the top. Two sophomore-aged girls stand in front of the setup in matching lettered shirts, smiling at passersby.

“Those are the Kappas. Mostly nice girls, but their hazing is insane.” Alison’s eyes widen as she speaks. “Rumor has it—they make their new members sit on top of a running washing machine, then they circle any spots that jiggle. The member has to lose the circled parts before initiation, or else they get dropped.”

“Maybe we’ll just skip their table, then,” I reply.

Past the Kappas, my eye is caught by a bright pink table in the near distance that’s decorated with red satin bows and white flowers in vases. A tall balloon arch I gesture towards the table.

“What about them?”

“Great minds think alike,” Alison answers, grabbing my hand to keep me from walking past the table. “Alpha Omega—the party girls. They have a reputation for being the top sorority on campus, and they always mix with the best fraternities. We should *definitely* go talk to them.”

As we walk closer to the table, I’m able to get a clearer image of the occupants surrounding it. Three girls—one blonde and two brunettes—stand beside the table, donning matching light-pink lettered shirts and white tennis skirts. They all look straight out of a magazine, and one look at their wardrobe makes it clear that they each have unlimited access to their parents credit cards.

“Hi girls! Thinking about joining a sorority this fall?”

The blonde girl waves us closer to the table as she speaks.

“Definitely,” Alison says through a bright smile. “Can you tell us a little more about your philanthropy and events?”

I try not to laugh as she asks the rehearsed question. As we were walking down to the fair earlier, she mentioned that most chapters are impressed with potential members who ask about their philanthropic efforts.

They like to pretend that they actually care about charity during recruitment, she had said.

The girls spew off the details of their chapter in a rehearsed manner, passing the conversation down the line as they go along.

“Our chapter’s philanthropy is the Brookwood Humane Society—we raise money for this organization through various fundraisers such as our spring soccer tournament, Kicks for a Cause,” the first brunette says. “Last year we raised over \$20,000 in donations.”

“We also host two major social events during the Fall semester: the End-of-Summer Cocktail, and the joint Turkey Bash with Theta Mu on Thanksgiving—the biggest event of the year.” The second brunette motions her hand at the blonde girl as she speaks. “Ashley here is actually our Social Chair, so she’s in charge of planning and executing the events.”

“Ashley Worthington,” the blonde says, extending her arm to shake our hands. “And, it’s ‘Vice President of Events’, but *Social Chair* is easier. This is Kimberly Nguyen and Summer Harding.”

I try not to gasp at the reveal of the second brunette’s name. Could this be the same Summer Harding who was close friends with Riley and Caroline, and even reported them missing?

It has to be.

Suddenly, my interest in joining a sorority has skyrocketed.

“You know, the End-of-Summer Cocktail is actually later tonight. We’d love it if you two came by,” Ashley exclaims, moving her hand to motion towards a large white house nestled on Greek Row. “Our house is a five minute walk from here, so it’s not far.”

Before Alison has a chance to speak, I cut in.

“We’d love to!”

She throws a surprised look in my direction, but quickly replaces the expression with a nodding smile. The five of us then exchange phone numbers, and Ashley promises to text us later with more details. Afterwards, we part ways, and Alison and I walk back—my mind racing with questions.

How close was Summer with Riley and Caroline?

How did they know each other?

Does she know anything that hasn’t been shared?

And of course, my biggest question:

How will I ask her about the case without freaking her out?

“See? I told you sororities aren’t all that bad,” Alison says, interrupting my train of thought. “Told you—we just had to give them a chance.”

“Looks like you know me better than I know myself,” I tease. For now, I’ll keep the real reason behind my sudden interest in sororities to myself. But tonight, that’ll have to change.

Alpha Omega, here I come.

4

The sun has fallen behind the houses of Greek Row. A bright halo of orange light is illuminating each building— as if the sky is calling for us to venture over there.

I hastily check the time on my phone.

7:49 p.m.

There are still forty-one minutes until we begin our walk to the Alpha Omega house, where we're pregaming with Ashley, Summer, Kimberly, and their friends. I picked out tonight's outfit earlier in the day, so I'm now freshening up my makeup while Alison gets ready in her room. After adding a touch of blush and coating mascara onto my lashes, I swipe one last coat of tinted lip gloss across my lips and walk to my closet to get dressed.

Tonight's outfit consists of a satin halter dress in a rosy shade of pink, paired with a set of white platform heels with light pink bows that dangle down the backs of my ankles. Before I left for school, my mom dragged me to every local boutique in town and spent exorbitant amounts of money on a preppier wardrobe for myself, so I have her to thank for being able to dress like a real sorority girl. If it were up to me, I'd spend the rest of my life in a tank top and sweatpants.

After strapping on my second heel, I migrate to the living room to grab Alison and I's bottle of wine, then pour myself a glass.

Alison raided her parents' wine cellar before moving out, so her storage ottoman holds about ten expensive-looking bottles of varying red and white brands. I was expecting a high-class brand based on the bottle's design, but a quick google search of tonight's brand nearly makes me spit out the last sip of my drink when I discover that our casual party-wine is valued at over \$1,000 per bottle. Clearly my new roommates parents are either high-class wine connoisseurs, or they're extremely wealthy.

As I try to calculate how much my first glass was worth, Alison shuffles out of her room and stands to face me.

“How do I look?” she asks.

To answer her question, Alison looks incredible. Her long blonde hair is curled to perfection and dangling down to her midriff—swaying effortlessly as she walks. She’s wearing a pastel yellow dress with a large pink Hawaiian flower branded across the stomach area, and the colors perfectly complement her tan skin.

“Amazing,” I say. “They’ll definitely give you a bid.”

“You look even better...I don’t know how we’ll keep all of the guys off of us,” she teases. “Anyways, we leave in twenty minutes and I’m not even buzzed. Pass me a glass.”

We finish off our outrageously priced wine in the next few minutes, and right as we take our last sips, my phone starts to ring. I see that Ashley is calling, so I quickly swipe the answer button and place her on speakerphone.

“Are you guys on the way yet?” Ashley asks as soon as the line connects. The faint sound of rap music plays in the background, so I’m guessing the Alpha Omega pregame has already commenced.

“We’re about to head there. Just finished our pre-pregame.”

“Perfect! We have drinks here waiting for you. Call me when you get to the house and I’ll come walk you guys in.” She pauses for a second. “And hurry—I have so many people to introduce you to!”

The line goes dead before either of us can respond.

“Guess that’s our cue to get going,” Alison beams, basically hopping out the door with excitement.

The walk to Greek Row takes twice as long in our high-heels, but we eventually reach the massive white brick house with familiar Greek letters at the top. Even if the letters hadn’t pointed us in the right direction, the large groups of college-aged girls in brightly-colored cocktail dresses would’ve likely soon revealed our final destination.

As we file in behind them, I shoot Ashley a text letting her know we’re on our way in. But before we walk inside, I take a moment to gawk at the house standing in front of us.

It’s at least three stories—I’m guessing there’s a basement that raises the total to four—and each floor has 1-2 large balconies that overlook the north side of campus. Varying pink and gold decorations cover the exterior

of the house, and a banner with colorful Hawaiian flowers dangles above the entryway from the second-floor balcony. The banner has large white lettering that reads *ALΩHA from Alpha-O*, which I have to admire the cleverness of.

Maybe the stigma around sorority girls is wrong, because I personally am not creative enough to think of something like that.

When we step inside, Ashley immediately runs out to greet us with three drinks in her hands—handing us each a cup and keeping one for herself. She already looks decently intoxicated, but even as she stumbles down the hall in her sky-blue maxi dress, she looks like a runway model.

“It’s party juice,” she says, quickly picking up on my skeptical glance at the mysterious red liquid in our cups. “You don’t want to know what’s in it—trust me—but it tastes good, and it’ll get you drunk fast.”

“Say less.” Alison grins before chugging her entire glass.

I take a few sips from my cup, but I’m already feeling a little buzzed from our pregame earlier, and I know I need to keep a clear mind if I’m planning on investigating anything tonight.

That reminds me—I need to find Summer.

As if she’s read my mind, Ashley tells us to go find Summer and Kimberly over by the bar set-up, where they are waiting to introduce us to more Alpha sisters. On her orders, we make our way through the living room and kitchen area to reach the back door.

The door opens out to a fenced-in backyard area draped with outdoor string lights and ropes of pink Hawaiian flowers. Large speakers blasting with music sit in front of perfectly-trimmed hedges lining the yard, and remnants of summer flowers decorate the perfectly-manicured lawn. As we walk over to the bar, I can’t help but wonder how much it costs to maintain this house’s property.

The bar set-up is across the yard from the back door upon exiting, and it’s currently being manned by a guy wearing an unbuttoned Hawaiian shirt and a backwards hat—dirty blonde strands of hair wildly poking out from the cap. I see him flirting with two girls in floral dresses, who we quickly recognize as the sisters we met earlier as they turn around. Once they lock eyes with us, they wave us over—smiling brightly as we approach them.

“You two look so good.” Kimberly looks us up and down as soon as we arrive, slightly slurring her speech. She’s clearly just as drunk as Ashley was.

“Look at you,” Alison pokes back, fluffing up Kimberly’s hair as she takes in a full look of her outfit. “Where’d you get this dress? I’ve been dying to find one just like that.”

While the two of them break off into a drunken conversation about warm-weather fashion trends, Summer grabs my arm and ushers me over to a bar seat.

“Let’s get you a better drink than this,” she says, tossing my original cup in one of the trash cans nearby. “Ashley swears by the party juice, but it gets her way too drunk at every social event. You wouldn’t expect it, but she’s a nursing student—a great one, too.”

She’s right. I wasn’t expecting that, but I guess I can see it. Over half of the blondes I know are pursuing med-related degrees.

“She looks like she’d be a nurse,” I reply. “I haven’t really gotten to know her yet, but she seems great.”

Summer smiles and leans closer to me. “You and Alison can talk to her more tomorrow night, at our rush event...”

“Are we allowed to come?” I ask. “Alison told me that those kinds of things are normally invite-only.”

She cocks her head a little, then laughs. “Did that not sound like an invitation?”

“Well thank you, I guess.”

“Of course!” she beams.

Her tone of voice quickly shifts to a hushed whisper, as if she’s going to tell me a secret.

“I’m not supposed to tell you this, but you were already on our interest list before you got to campus. Your mom sent in a letter of recommendation the day you submitted your intent to enroll. We hadn’t heard of Alison, but when we met the two of you at the fair, we could tell you were a package deal.”

I’m annoyed by this drop of information, but unfortunately not surprised. My mother has had a desire for me to join a sorority since the moment I was born. She’s a true southern belle, and even meets with her high school cotillion friends at least once a month. Since she never went to college, she didn’t get to join a chapter of her own, so I think she wants to live vicariously through me.

“I never would’ve thought about joining if it wasn’t for my mom—and Alison of course,” I say, unable to come up with much else of a response.

“Why not?” Summer inquires.

“I’m not the best at small talk,” I say. “And pasting on a smile for two days of recruitment is like, my personal nightmare.”

I regret the intensity of my words the moment they leave my mouth, but it’s too late to backtrack. I’m not sure why I’m oversharing so much with Summer, but it probably has something to do with the amount of alcohol I’ve consumed so far.

As I’m internally hoping I haven’t freaked her out, I quickly realize that she doesn’t seem bothered by my feelings at all.

“Between you and me, it’s not my cup of tea either,” she says, letting out a heavy sigh. “But we’re young and pretty, so I figure day-drinking with hot people is a decent way to spend our college days. It doesn’t seem fair to waste an opportunity that someone else would die for.”

She’s right. Some people *would* die for this opportunity.

Earlier, I spent time researching Alpha Omega on the campus sorority-ranking website and read many of the ratings from the past few years, which all basically repeated the same sentiment. Year-after-year, hundreds of freshman girls try to rush the chapter, and only about 20-30 of them are lucky enough to receive a bid. The rest disperse among the lower-tier houses and dedicate themselves to posting hate comments online about the exclusivity, calling the girls in the chapter *shallow* or *evil*. It’s clear that many hold a grudge solely based on their rejection from the sorority—at least, enough to justify hundreds of hate comments online.

“Anyways,” she continues, her face now back to a bright smile. “I’d love for you to meet a few more of our sisters before the event. We’ll grab you a new drink first, though—what do you want?”

“Vodka Cranberry,” I answer. “My favorite.”

She snaps her fingers at the attractive blonde barkeep that I made note of earlier, ordering two Vodka Cranberries the moment he turns around. Now that I’m seeing him up close, I can see that he looks the same as every stereotypical frat boy you see in the movies—pretty douchey, but hot enough to where you can ignore it.

He stares lovingly at Summer as he mixes our drinks, only breaking his glance to hand me my cup.

“Leighton, this is Tanner. He’s a sophomore, and a total idiot,” she teases.

He extends his other hand towards mine and smiles.

“Nice to meet you, Leighton,” Tanner says with a wink. “I’m a brother of Theta Mu, and *not* a total idiot.”

“It’s nice to meet you, Tanner,” I say as I shake his hand. “And what is Theta Mu exactly?”

Summer chimes back into the conversation. “The Thetas are our ‘brother frat’, which basically just means that we host all of our mixers and parties with them. The other brothers should be making their way here soon, if they don’t get lost on the way here...”

With a smirk, Tanner pipes back into the conversation.

“I’m the first one here, luckily for all of you.”

“And to what do we owe that pleasure?” I joke.

He leans in closer and hushes to a whisper. “First to arrive gets the first pick of the girls. I already have a prospect for later.” As he mixes our drinks, he discreetly nods towards a short blonde girl in a navy blue dress, immediately triggering Summer to hit his arm.

“Don’t you dare!” she snips at him. “Lauren’s boyfriend *just* broke up with her, and she hasn’t stopped crying for a week.”

He throws his hands in the air. “Don’t hate the player.”

Summer shoots him a glare before grabbing our drinks and moving me away from the bar. She mutters a few disappointments about Tanner under her breath before turning to face me with a smile.

“Sorry about that,” she begins. “I promise not all of the Theta Mu guys are like that. You’ll meet a few more of them tonight, so I hope your impression will change.”

“No worries. That wasn’t my first interaction with a rich douchebag...I have plenty of them in my hometown.”

“Good—well, not *good*, but I’m glad I haven’t scared you off already,” Summer laughs. “Anyways, I need to go give Lauren the heads-up to stay away from him. Can we meet back in five?”

Though the party has successfully distracted me thus far, I suddenly remember the entire point of this outing—my investigation. At that moment, an idea pops into my head.

“Of course,” I say, grabbing her arm before she can leave the area. “But hey—you live here right? Could I use your bathroom?”

She hesitates for a moment, then answers.

“Sure, why not? My room is on the third floor. Last door down the left hallway when you’re getting off the elevator. Room 300. See you in a bit!”

Summer turns and walks off towards Tanner's apparent prospect before I can ask any follow-up questions.

I make my way back through the doorway and re-enter the house, easily finding the entrance to the elevator in the hallway behind the kitchen. I step inside the empty elevator and mash the 3 button on the controls, then patiently wait for the cab to make its way up to the top floor.

As soon as I step outside, my vision is overwhelmed by color. The hallways of the third floor are painted a light shade of pink, and the bright fluorescent lighting casts a sparkle upon the white tile flooring. Crystal chandeliers with gold framing line the hallway, and each door is framed similarly. As I cruise down the hall, I feel as if I'm walking through a pink cloud at sunset.

I glance down at my phone to check the time—9:32—before taking the last steps toward the door at the end of the hall. Soon enough, I'm standing in front of a white door with a crystal knob, which shows the number 300 on a plaque above the doorframe.

This is Summer's room.

I left the backyard two minutes ago, so I only have about five more minutes to look around the room in order to keep my bathroom story plausible. Eight minutes if I swipe on some extra lipstick and pretend I was fixing my makeup. Turning the knob, I step into the room and shut the door quietly behind me.

Summer's room is the shape of a square, and her bed sits perfectly against the wall opposite the door. The back wall is filled with pictures of her friends and family members, which are perfectly spaced out in rows of twenty above her headboard. A white-wood desk sits to the left of her bed, boasting three large drawers beside the knee-hole and a thin drawer with a lock at the very top. To the right of her bed, a large storage cabinet stretches from floor to ceiling. A storage ottoman sits beside her vanity, and a small white dresser is visible inside of her open closet.

Shit.

This is a lot of ground to cover in five minutes.

My eyes narrow in on the thin desk drawer with a keyhole in the center, and I walk over towards it. I jumble with the drawer for a moment before accepting that it's locked, then quickly move on to the larger ones, which appear to only be filled with varying psychology textbooks and graded homework assignments.

Not exactly what I'm looking for.

As I stand up to circle the bed and check the storage cabinet, one of the photos upon the wall catches my eye.

It's a picture of Summer and two other girls—all three donning matching white shirts with "AΩ" sewn across the chest in stitched pink lettering. The girls are sitting on a couch that I recognize from the living room downstairs, and a colorful banner reading *Homecoming 2023* hangs in the background. On Summer's left, a brunette girl with a bright smile and a messy bun places her arms around the two girls and looks away from the camera. On her right, a beautiful girl with bright red hair and sunkissed skin kisses Summer's cheek.

Even though neither of them directly face the camera in this photo, I would recognize those two faces anywhere.

It's Riley Walker and Caroline Rowe.

I've spent the past five weeks scrolling through every single article related to the girls' disappearance, and never once have I seen any mention of the two being members of a sorority—let alone the exact sorority that I happen to be rushing for. How has their sorority involvement been entirely wiped from the news, considering every other detail of their lives has been made public? Did something happen between them and the chapter before their disappearance?

After several minutes of being lost in thought about the photo, I finally remember to check the time on my phone: 9:41. I need to get back downstairs before Summer comes up to check on me.

As I'm about to leave, I pull out my phone and snap a quick photo of the picture upon the wall, then turn on my heel and start walking towards the door. But right as my head turns, I see a large, shadowy figure standing silently in the door frame.

Just my luck. It's Summer.

5

S hit. Shit. Shit.

“Hey!” I say brightly, hoping she didn’t notice me taking that photo. Summer smiles back at me, giving me some hope that she didn’t see it after all. “There you are. I was starting to think you got lost.”

“I did, actually,” I lie. “Couldn’t find the elevator at first.”

“Well I’m glad I found you. Let’s get you back downstairs so you can socialize,” she says, holding out a drink in her right hand as an offering.

There’s no guarantee that I’ll get an invite back to Alpha Omega after tomorrow night’s event, so right now might be my only chance to ask Summer any questions I have about the girls. As much as I’d love to socialize, my investigation needs to come first.

“Of course! Really quick, though—who are the other two girls in this photo?” I motion to the photo of the trio upon the wall. “They look super familiar to me.”

Summer gazes down to the floor for a long moment, and I can vaguely make out a glimpse of a tear forming in her left eye. I can already tell that my question has crossed the line, but before I can change the subject, she responds in a choked voice.

“Riley and Caroline. We were best friends, and they were in my pledge class. You’ve probably seen their faces on the news...”

In my response, I decide to downplay my knowledge of the case in order to avoid sounding like a total psycho.

“Yeah, I think I have,” I reply softly. “I didn’t know you were friends with them, or that they were even in a sorority.”

She takes a glance over her shoulder as if someone might be listening. After seemingly deciding the coast is clear, she hushes to a whisper yet again.

“Our chapter advisor, Eleanor Stephens—you’ll meet her tomorrow—practically paid off every news station in the state to keep it out of the newspapers. She thought that Alpha Omega’s involvement with the case

might give us a ‘*bad reputation*’ during recruitment. Half of us protested it, but at the end of the day, her status and money won most everyone over.”

She pauses for a moment, shaking her head in disgust.

“If you ask me, it’s blood money. She even paid off Brookwood PD to keep them from questioning our members. She told us that something *unflattering* might have come out about us, and that it was better to play it safe.”

My mouth gapes at the new information. No wonder the case was never solved—it sounds like the entire disappearance was swept under the rug to upkeep the posh reputation of Cabot’s top-ranked sorority.

I try to think of something to say in response, but I’m speechless.

Summer takes note of my shock and continues.

“I really shouldn’t have told you that, but it just angers me so much,” she begins. “The police pushed the runaway theory so hard to hide their own incompetence, but we all know something terrible happened to them. They *never* would’ve left without telling me. Especially Riley. The two of us met on the first day of school, and we met Caroline after recruitment the next week. We were inseparable for two whole years.”

I hesitate to ask my next question, but proceed anyway.

“What about Noah Banks? Most of the articles I read speculated about his involvement. Do you think he had something to do with it?”

Summer’s lips twist at this statement.

“Trust me,” she says. “Noah had nothing to do with it.”

“Oh?” I ask. “How can you be so sure?”

She glances off to the right, as if considering whether or not she can trust me for a moment. After a few seconds, she turns to face me again.

“The news reporters fluffed that story up because everyone needed someone to blame for what happened,” she mutters. “The night Caroline disappeared, Noah got overly drunk because he was sad about the breakup, and he hooked up with one of our sorority sisters. The two kept it quiet for a while because everyone still thought Caroline and Riley would come back, and they were worried Caroline would strangle them both. Then, you know, they never *did* come back...”

Summer takes a deep breath before continuing.

“After a while, rumors started to spread about Noah’s possible involvement, so he decided to tell the police the truth about where he was that night. That’s why there were never any formal charges pressed against

him. He told us the police cleared his alibi—just never reported it to the media.”

There goes my number one suspect. I guess I’ll need to find out who else the girls spent time with.

“Most people at Cabot know that Noah is innocent, but there are still a handful of people who press for his arrest once a month or so,” she tells me. “He ended up having to leave the University, but he still lives in the area. I run into him at Roxy’s sometimes—you know that little bar right off campus?”

After listening to the horde of information she just dropped, I only have one question left for Summer at the moment.

“If you don’t mind me asking, what do *you* think happened? If you’re sure Noah is innocent, that is.”

Yet again, she hesitates to answer, but does so anyway.

“I loved Riley and Caroline, but let’s just say they made a lot of enemies during their time at this school. I really shouldn’t go into detail, but just trust me. My best guess—I think that they took one of their schemes too far and pissed off the wrong person.”

She pauses before speaking again, shuddering at her own words.

“Honestly, it freaks me out too much to even think about it. I mean—can you imagine walking around the same campus as the person that might’ve killed your best friends, and you just have no idea?”

“No,” I say sorrowfully. “I can’t.”

I desperately want her to further elaborate on Riley and Caroline’s supposed enemies, but I don’t press the matter. If I ask too many questions early on, it might scare her away, and I don’t want to lose my main source of information about the girls. Besides, I’ll be back here again tomorrow night for the pre-rush event.

After our chat has ended and a few moments of awkward silence pass by, I mention that Alison is probably looking for me, and the two of us head back down to the main party.

It’s nearly 10:30 by the time we make it downstairs, and massive hordes of people are now making their way through the house and into the backyard. As we walk down the pink-carpeted stairs, I lock eyes with Alison, who is now surrounded by several frat guys that look pretty much exactly like Bar-Boy Tanner from earlier.

These must be the Theta Mus.

Alison steps in front of the boys and waves me over. As I go to walk over, Summer tells me she'll find me again as we part ways for a moment.

"Where have you been?" Alison squeals, waiting until I'm close enough to hear her over the music. "I have someone for you to meet."

She gestures behind me, pointing at a tall brunette standing amongst the other guys she was talking to.

"He's cute."

"I know," she says, shoving me lightly in his direction. "Go talk to him."

Now that I'm closer to the mystery man that Alison has picked for me, I'm able to get a better look at him. He's easily over six feet tall—exactly my type—and his messy brown hair sticks up in sections around his face. His blue eyes contrast with his tan skin and dark hair, and his perfectly straight smile is almost blindingly white. He looks like he could've been a Hollister model back in its prime.

I take a final step in his direction, locking eyes with him now. As soon as I get the chance, I speak first.

"Alison told me I have to talk to you."

"It's nice to meet you too," he laughs. "Where's your drink?"

I look down at my hands and instantly remember that I downed my Vodka Pineapple in Summer's room. Awkward conversations always make me drink faster, so it was bound to happen.

"I drank it," I say. "Want to come with me to the bar?"

We make our way back towards the outdoor bar area, sitting in the same spot I had been at with Summer just an hour ago. After a few moments of waiting, Tanner walks over to our end of the bar.

"Nathan, I see you've met the lovely Ms. Leighton." He prepares two cups of ice for us as he speaks.

Nathan cracks a smile at me before facing Tanner to respond.

"Actually, we hadn't quite made it to the name exchange yet. She's being forced to talk to me." He turns back to me and winks. "I'm Nathan, if you haven't already heard."

"Leighton," I reply. "Are you in Theta Mu with my dear friend Tanner here?"

"Fall Pledge Class of '22. Check it," he says, extending his right hand to reveal a prominent tattoo on the back of it.

In bold lettering, his hand displays the Greek letters ΘM stacked on top of the number 22. If Nathan is part of the 2022 class, then that makes him a junior, which means he might've known Riley and Caroline.

He orders two drinks from Tanner—vodka sprite for me, whiskey coke for him—and we quickly break into conversation about ourselves.

I learn that Nathan is an out-of-state student too; he moved here from Boston to pursue Criminal Justice at Cabot. He just finished a summer internship at a defense attorney's office in Brookwood, and he plans to pursue a career as a lawyer after finishing his undergrad through the Bradshaw program. He's the youngest of two sons, and his older brother is a professional tennis player. He also lives over at the Theta Mu house, so he's right down the street from Norman Hall.

The two of us were so invested in our conversation that we didn't even notice the party beginning to die down. Our conversation is soon interrupted by my phone's ringtone, and I look down to see an incoming call from Alison—which I immediately answer.

She starts talking as soon as I accept the call.

"Hey! I think people are starting to go home, so we should probably head out soon. Where are you?"

"I'm in the backyard talking to Nathan, at the bar," I reply. "I can meet you."

"Perfect," she says loudly over the background voices. "I'm in the kitchen, over by the sink. You'll see me."

The phone beeps twice, and the call ends.

"I guess that's my cue to leave," I say, speaking to Nathan this time.

"Let me walk you out," he says. "But first—can I get your number?"

After I hand him my phone and he types his digits into my contacts list, the two of us head inside towards the kitchen.

Thankfully, Nathan is tall enough to see over the hordes of frat boys standing in the way, so he is quickly able to locate Alison's spot in the kitchen. Once I'm back with her, Nathan pulls me into a hug before telling me to call him sometime, then disappears into the crowd of people.

"I knew you two would like each other," she teases. "You're welcome."

Alison and I make our rounds to say goodbye to Ashley, Summer, and Kimberly—all of whom remind us of the pre-rush event tomorrow night.

We confirm that we'll be there, then make our way out the front door onto the street.

The walk back will take us about fifteen minutes, so I decide to make conversation and ask Alison how her night went.

"*Amazing*," she says expressively. "I talked to a lot of the sisters, and obviously a few of the Theta Mus. I think the two of us would fit in perfectly here."

I nod in agreement. "I can't believe we got an invite for tomorrow already. They must've liked us."

"I know. So glad I have a hot roommate," she jokes, playfully hitting my arm. "By the way, where'd you run off to when we first got there? Summer dragged you off, and then I couldn't find you for another hour."

I'm still not keen on letting anyone in on my investigation quite yet, so I quickly come up with a plausible story as to why I might've disappeared for as long as I did at the party.

"I was just using Summer's bathroom, but the two of us got caught up in conversation for a while."

"What about?" Alison asks.

"Mainly just opportunities on campus, and Alpha Omega of course." I suddenly shift the conversation. "I also got to see the upper floors, and it's insane. The place is basically a castle."

"If we get bids next weekend, we should definitely live there next year," she declares, accepting my change-of-topic.

I'm glad I've been assigned a roommate who doesn't seem to ask too many questions. Most people I meet are inherently nosy, but not Alison.

The rest of the way back, I tell her of my interest in Nathan—detailing the entire story of our interaction beginning directly after she introduced me to him. She tells me how she had met him earlier in the night and thought he would be a perfect fit for me, and I thank her for not stealing him for herself.

When our conversation comes to a close, we've reached our dorm room—each of us now heading to our separate spaces for bed. Just as I finish changing out of my cocktail dress, I glance down at my phone and see a missed text from an unsaved number.

11:46 PM

GLAD I GOT TO MEET YOU TONIGHT. IF YOU EVER WANT TO TALK ABOUT BRADSHAW, OR MAYBE DO DINNER, LET ME KNOW.

— NATHAN (*THE GUY ALISON FORCED YOU TO TALK TO*)

I shoot back a quick message.

11:57 PM

TO MY SURPRISE, I ENJOYED MEETING YOU TOO. I'LL CALL YOU SOMETIME.

After the message reads *delivered*, I throw my phone on my bed and plop down onto my desk chair. I need to write down everything I learned earlier tonight and restructure my investigative plan accordingly. Riley and Caroline being members of AO opens up a whole new suspect list, and Summer mentioned something earlier about the two girls having several enemies.

My head is spinning with information, so I take out a piece of paper and scribble down a few quick notes. Hopefully tomorrow's event will hold even more answers.

CASE UPDATES:

Caroline Rowe and Riley Walker were members of Alpha Omega up until their disappearance. The AΩ Chapter Advisor—Eleanor Stephens—bribed or persuaded the local precinct and media to keep the sorority's involvement with the case to a minimum. The police never questioned the majority of the Alpha Omega sisters.

Noah Banks allegedly has an alibi for the night of Riley and Caroline's disappearance. According to Summer Harding, he was hooking up with a friend of Caroline's, and is too embarrassed to step forward publicly with this information.

Riley and Caroline allegedly made a decent number of enemies throughout their time at Cabot. Summer Harding states that she believes this behavior is what led to their disappearance and possible death. She also believes it was a student.

QUESTIONS

Who was Noah Banks with on the night of the disappearance?

Who did Riley and Caroline blackmail, and did this really lead to their disappearance, or was something else at play?

Could Summer know more than she's letting on?

6

Alison and I spend the majority of the day familiarizing ourselves with our new campus.

We each take time to locate our classroom buildings for the upcoming semester, then focus on the more exciting things—checking out the restaurants, and walking through the Student Union.

During this walkthrough, we found out that Cabot has an on-campus Japanese buffet, so we stacked our plates high with sushi rolls before taking a seat in the large cafeteria-style area on the second floor of the Union. The energy in the dining area was buzzing with new-student excitement, and hundreds of other students were eating with their new friends—just like us.

The first weekend of college is so wholesome.

After we cleared our plates, the two of us threw out ideas for which section of campus we should explore next. I proposed a visit to Bradshaw and Colburn—the two criminal justice buildings at the school—but Alison looked less than thrilled about that idea. Instead, she proposed that we should split up and explore the buildings related to our own separate majors, then meet back at the dorm to get ready for our rush event tonight.

Now, I'm following the online directory and making my way towards the Criminal Justice buildings on my own.

It's 3:30 right now, so I have a little over an hour before I need to head back to my dorm. The walk takes longer than expected, but after a few wrong turns, I finally find myself standing in front of the Douglas A. Bradshaw Building.

Though I've seen it a million times in website photos, standing in front of the building feels surreal. This is the home of my dream program, and the birthplace of some of the country's most renowned criminal investigators. Acceptance into the Bradshaw program would open up so many doors in my future career.

Unable to wait any longer, I take a deep breath, then push my way inside the main floor.

A rush of cool air hits me as I enter, with the AC knocking out the Alabama summer heat in an instant. Looking around, I see that most of the light-grey walls are covered with large photos of graphs and presentations from award-winning Bradshaw students— each picture flaunting a golden or silver medal dangling beside it. The lobby area stands mostly empty since the semester hasn't begun yet, but I see a few students studying in lounge chairs throughout the room.

An open elevator stands a few feet away from the entrance, which I confidently hop into in hopes of getting a better look at the classrooms. I press the button for the fourth floor—the top floor of the building—where senior-level courses are held. After a thirty-second trip, the elevator comes to a stop and opens up on the fourth floor.

I quietly step out into the hallway.

The fourth floor looks mostly the same as the first, except the walls are painted with a darker shade of gray that makes the fluorescent lighting much more bearable. I walk towards a floor-plan map that outlines the classroom and office numbers of each professor.

Scanning down the list, I see several familiar names.

Seth Boswell

Mark Hankel

Harold Johnson

These are names of Cabot professors that I've seen listed in several news articles and magazines—mostly those discussing the program's most accomplished staff members. I browsed many of these articles when I first began researching Cabot's criminal justice program, already mentally forming a future course schedule for when I'm hopefully admitted into the program.

The first name on the list stands out to me for more than one reason. A few articles I've read about the case mentioned that Seth Boswell was Riley Walker's professor when she was a student of the program, and that he had contributed to the search for the two girls given his investigative expertise.

Prior to teaching, Professor Boswell held a very successful career as a criminal investigator and homicide detective, with over fifty solved murder cases under his belt by the time he turned thirty. Sadly, that career came crashing down when he was shot in the neck by a homicide suspect while in

a solo pursuit—roughly five years ago or so. He survived the attack, but was forced to retire from field work entirely. Now, he spends his days teaching highly-educated students behavioral analysis techniques—which he has proven to be pretty great at.

I was able to snag a spot in his Introduction to Criminal Justice for this semester. Unfortunately, it's just a baseline class, so I won't be learning nearly as much as I would be in his upper-level courses. But I'm thankful for the opportunity to be taught by such an esteemed professional no matter what.

I decide to stroll down the hallways and peer into the classrooms, which are all equally as empty as the lobby. After taking in a good look at the general layouts of each room, I take another left at the end of the hallway, hoping one more turn will lead me back to the elevators.

Just as I pass by a few more classrooms, I notice a slightly-ajar door that is not marked by a numbered plaque. Through the crack in the door, I am able to see several stacks of paper and used coffee cups lining a countertop, which sits atop three large filing cabinets.

Just as I am feeling the urge to creep into the room and peer at whatever is in those files, a deep voice comes from behind me.

"Can I help you with something?"

I turn to see a man in his mid-to-late thirties with untamed dark hair and a 5 o'clock shadow on his face. I recognize him immediately from the articles as Seth Boswell—the white round scar on his neck gives it away instantly.

"This room," I say, gesturing at the open door. "What is it?"

"Just the student record room. Nothing exciting," he says.

I wouldn't consider a chance to peek at Riley Walker's student file to be *nothing exciting*, but to each their own. Still, I don't want to seem overly interested, so I downplay my response.

"Oh."

He cracks a slight smirk at me.

"Were you thinking about taking a look at the files?"

"Of course not!" I say defensively, crossing my arms as I speak.

"You're lying," he says promptly, but with a hint of playfulness in his tone. "I've spent over ten years interviewing liars and murderers, so you could say I'm pretty good at detecting dishonesty."

Clearly I've been caught, so I give up my half-assed charade and throw my hands back down to my sides.

"Yeah, I was lying," I confess. "You saved me from my curiosity, because I was two seconds away from walking in there."

The smile upon Professor Boswell's face grows larger.

"Technically, I should report this, but I don't like to discourage investigative initiative. I think it's a valuable quality."

He pauses for a moment, scanning the hallways for other students.

"If you don't mind me asking, what exactly are you looking for?"

I question to myself whether or not I should bring up Riley and Caroline's disappearance. This case could potentially be a sore spot for him, and I don't know how close he was to Riley as a student. On the other hand, this might be my only interaction with Professor Boswell, and he's already established somewhat of a safe space between the two of us.

Knowing what to say now, I take a breath, then respond.

"Something to help with my investigation."

His eyebrows raise. "Your investigation...?"

"I've been looking into the disappearance of Riley Walker and Caroline Rowe," I say. "I thought I might be able to find something useful in the files."

He chokes at my response, but recovers after a few moments. I can't quite tell if he's angry with me for bringing up the case until he begins to speak.

"I'm happy to hear that someone still cares about finding out the truth. Most people around here act like speaking their names is a curse, and they will disappear next if they talk about what happened to them." He looks to the ground and shakes his head. "Riley was a student of mine. Top of the class. It's truly a shame what happened—the agencies would've been fighting over who gets to snag her after graduation."

I take his second pause as a chance to cut in. "You helped with the investigation in the beginning, didn't you?"

He appears slightly surprised that I recognize him, shooting me a quick glance to determine if he knows who I am. After confirming that I am a stranger to him, he shrugs it off and responds.

"Brookwood PD brought me in to interview a few of the leading suspects in the case. By that time, they had honed in on that Noah kid and all-but declared him guilty," he states. "I spent two hours in a room with

him, and never once did I see any signs of deception. That whole thing was a frame-up. The kid just hooked up with another girl, and the media made him out to be a cold-blooded killer for it.”

“I’ve heard that,” I reply. “Apparently he’s one of the only people still looking for the girls.”

He shakes his head. “There aren’t too many of us left that care about what happened. The police haven’t even opened the case file in months.” He glances around the hallway again, scanning for passersby. “I’ve re-offered my services countless times, but they always decline. I’m starting to think the case might really go unsolved.”

The two of us are silent for a moment, taking in the terrible possibility that the world may never have answers for what happened to the girls. It’s a horrible thought, and nobody deserves to be failed by the police.

“Any particular reason you’re investigating the case?” He asks, finally breaking the silence.

I hesitate to answer yet again—I think my real answer may appear selfish.

“Morality,” I lie.

It doesn’t appear that he believes my response entirely, but he soon lowers his voice to a whisper and leans closer to me.

“I’ve always had my theories about what happened to those girls, but one thing I know for sure—Riley wouldn’t have run away. The whole week before they left, she was hounding me about extra credit opportunities to round her 89% to a 90%. What type of runaway cares that much about their GPA?”

He makes a good point.

“If I were you,” he continues, “I’d look into her sorority sisters. The cops never interviewed any of them, and I always felt like a few of them may know more than they let on.”

On that statement, he shoots me a slight grin and walks down the hallway, exiting left. I remain standing in my exact position, unsure of how to proceed after the conversation I’ve just had. If only Professor Boswell had mentioned a few specific names, or even any details that might actually help me.

Nonetheless, I have a pretty good idea of where to start.

7

W*ear all white tonight.*

I glance down at the message on the handwritten note that has just been slid under the door of our dorm room. When I flip over the light pink card, the letters $A\Omega$ are stamped upon the back in glittery white ink. After walking into Alison's room, I hand her the card to get a look of her own.

"Mysterious," she says.

"I know. Almost creepy."

"Give it a chance." She rolls her eyes jokingly. "Besides—at least we already have friends there."

I suppose Alison makes a good point. I smile at her menacingly before walking back to my room to pick out an outfit, temporarily closing the door behind me as I step inside.

Luckily, I own several white pairs of shoes and dresses, so this theme shouldn't be too much of a problem for me. After rotating through my wardrobe for a few moments, I settle on a lacy white dress with a low V-neck. The stark white ends up looking great on my tan skin, so I'm not too mad about the dress-code anymore. I pick out a pair of tall white heels and throw on a few gold bracelets, then walk back out to the living room—taking a seat while I wait for Alison to finish getting ready.

It's a little past 5:30 right now, so we have just less than thirty minutes to spare before we need to be there. Fifteen of those will be spent on the walk to the Alpha Omega house.

Alison eventually emerges from her closet in a stunning, silky white dress—her blonde locks straightened perfectly down the open back of the

dress. She gives a playful spin and twirls her hair for me, then asks if I'm ready to walk over to the house.

As we make our way over, I ask Alison about the rush event.

"What exactly will we be doing?"

"We won't really know until we're there," she laughs. They keep their rush ceremonies super top-secret, so only those who get invited get to find out."

Alison seems excited about this secrecy, but it sounds a bit unnerving to me. I've always heard that sororities are similar to cults, and I'm not particularly looking forward to being forced to participate in some ritualistic ceremony.

Then again, I don't want to dampen her spirit, so I bite my tongue instead.

"How...exciting," I say through a forced smile.

When we arrive at the sorority house, a group of other girls dressed in all-white are standing in the front yard. They all look to be about the same age as us, so we make our way over to stand with the large group.

As we approach them, a lovely girl with long dark hair steps forward to greet us. She smiles brightly and holds out her right hand to us.

"You must be here for the rush event," the girl says. "I'm Imani—I'm a freshman this year."

She waves her hand at another girl, who is still chatting amongst the group of girls that was here before us. The girl quickly wraps up her conversation before walking over to join our trio.

"I'm Maeve," says the girl—a bombshell blonde with a kind smile. "We've been looking for two girls like us to group up with, just in case this event turns weird. Strength in numbers, you know?"

I laugh at this statement. I'm glad it's not just me that's worried about the ceremony. I reach out my hand and shake both of their hands, with Allison quickly following my lead.

“I’m Leighton,” I say. “And this is my roommate.”

“Alison,” she replies, finishing my sentence. “We’re freshmen too—which dorm are you guys in?”

Maeve speaks up first.

“I’m over in Norman, but Imani here is a lucky bitch. She’s in Caswell.”

Caswell is the newly-proclaimed nicest building on campus, since Norman Hall is often associated with mysterious disappearances. I’ve heard it costs twice as much as our residence hall does, so Imani’s family must be pretty financially well-off.

“We’re in Norman too!” Alison squeals. “You guys will have to come over sometime. We haven’t had any visitors yet.”

As the four of us continue our conversation, the grand doorway slowly begins to swing open. The movement silences our crowd of about forty girls, who have mostly shown up while we were talking to Imani and Maeve.

Once they are completely open, two $\Lambda\Omega$ members emerge from the doorway, stepping outside to stand in front of each side of the entrance. Immediately after they’ve taken their places, a tall blonde walks out from the center—dressed in a white satin gown that brushes her ankles. Her hair is blown out to perfection, and her makeup is soft and glowy, making her appear ethereal. After a few moments of silence, the girl parts her lips and begins to speak in a soft voice.

“Good evening ladies, and welcome to Alpha Omega. My name is Juliette Lane, and I am the president of our chapter. Tonight is the first step in finding your forever home, and we’re so happy all of you could make it. Receiving an invite to an Alpha Omega rush event is an honor, and tonight you will be further honored with the opportunity to take a special glimpse into our chapter.”

A light applause erupts from the crowd of potential members. The girl smiles softly at her audience, then continues speaking.

“Tonight is our White-Rose Ceremony. The color white symbolizes *new beginnings*, and tonight will be just that for a lucky twenty of you. Following the conclusion of tonight’s event, those who will be able to proceed to tomorrow night’s rush event will be notified.”

The ethereal blonde pauses for a moment, waiting for her words to settle into the crowd.

“Now without further adieu,” she says excitedly. “Please file into a line and prepare for entry.”

As we merge into the front of the line with the rest of the group, a knot begins to form inside of my stomach. I don’t know what I’m in for yet, but I know I have to play it cool no matter what. If I don’t get a bid from Alpha Omega, I won’t have any more insight into Riley and Caroline’s involvement with the sorority.

I take a deep breath, attempting to push my thoughts aside.

“It’ll be fine. Just be yourself,” Alison says from behind me, clearly having picked up on my nervousness.

I mouth a quick *thank you* to her as we make our way through the doorway.

As soon as I step inside, I feel a hand wrapping itself around my left arm. I look over to see who is grabbing me, and quickly recognize Summer leading me to our place in the living room. She smiles before sitting me down in a wooden white chair, then sits in the chair directly across from me.

I glance over at Alison, who has clearly been picked up at the door by Kimberly. The sorority must have assigned us members who we’ve already spoken to before. Ashley is sitting Maeve down in a chair, so I’m assuming the two must have met at the Student Org Fair.

“I’m glad you got my note,” Summer says, interrupting my thoughts.

“Thanks for the memo,” I reply, “I was originally going to wear light blue.”

She laughs. “How scandalous that would have been...”

Before we can converse any further, Juliette begins to speak again.

“Now that you’ve been assigned your first White-Rose Sister, you’ll have three minutes to chat before the second rotation. Get to know each other, and have fun!”

As Juliette finishes talking, I am taking a quick glimpse around the living room, when suddenly, I notice something.

An older woman is sitting in the corner, viciously typing notes on her computer as she examines each incoming girl. Her long pink nails make an irritating clicking noise as she taps each key, which I can hear from all the way across the room. Her short bob of hair is as white as a sheet—to the point where I’m positive it can’t be natural—and there is bright pink lipstick pasted upon what I’m assuming is a permanent frown on her face.

I shift my attention back to Summer, silently gesturing to the woman in the corner. “Is that the woman you were talking about—your advisor?”

She nods warily. “Yeah. That’s Eleanor...”

Eleanor Stephens. The woman who wiped all evidence of Riley and Caroline’s affiliation with their own sorority because she thought it might negatively affect the chapter.

She seems like a real bundle of joy.

In an attempt to keep myself from wondering what notes Eleanor might be typing about me on that computer, I change the subject.

“So, what exactly are we doing tonight?”

She leans in closer. “Basically, you’ll talk to four or five sisters other than me, and they’ll rate you based on your interaction. No pressure, but I really want you to be in this sorority, so don’t screw it up.”

She says it in a joking manner, but I can tell that Summer really means it—she really does want me to get a bid. I wasn’t planning on blowing my

chance, but her encouragement keeps me going.

“I’ll do my best,” I say nervously.

Summer spends the remainder of our time coaching me on what to say to the next few girls that I’ll be talking to. She tells me to say that I’m interested in fundraising, beauty products, and pop culture.

“That’s pretty much all our members want to talk about anyways,” she laughs.

“Got it. Is there anything I should *avoid* talking about?” I ask.

Her eyes widen. “Right, I almost forgot. Remember your three B’s—boys, booze, and Bible. Never talk about religion, alcohol, or hookups. That’s an instant *no* for us.”

Right as she finishes her sentence, another brunette girl comes and stands beside Summer. At this cue, she stands up and wishes me luck before walking up to another pair of girls across the room. The brunette girl takes a seat in Summer’s now-empty chair—staring me up and down as she shifts in her chair—and I notice that a sour look is displayed across her face.

“Hi,” the girl says in a monotonous tone. “My name is Gracie, I’m a senior in AO. How are you feeling so far?”

The girl seems casual enough, so I deliver an honest answer.

“I’m a bit nervous,” I reply, “but I’m starting to get more comfortable.”

She looks at me rudely before inquiring about my answer. “Why should you feel nervous? Are you not excited to be invited to one of the most prestigious rush events on campus?”

Her tone is now snappy, and she appears somewhat annoyed at my previous statement.

“Of course I’m excited!” I insist, attempting to backtrack on what I’ve just said. “I guess this is just kind of out of my comfort zone...but I’m thrilled to have the opportunity.”

Gracie continues staring at me, so I make a last-ditch effort to fix the tone of the conversation.

“I’m sorry, can we start over?” I’m hoping to salvage our conversation as best I can. “I’m Leighton, I’m a friend of Summer Harding, and I’m so happy to be here with you all tonight. I love your dress, by the way!”

Her lips tighten the moment I mention Summer’s name, and she leans in closer to keep our conversation private.

“Summer, huh? Well you better be careful about who you choose to befriend in this chapter. If you don’t watch your back, your own sisters will betray you in the blink of an eye.”

Gracie pauses before delivering her final line.

“And you’re not off to a great start, honey.”

Her tone is so cold that it sends a chill down my spine.

I have no idea what to say to this sentiment, so I stumble over my words in response. Before I can speak up, she has gotten up from her chair and is storming out of the room, even though we still have a minute left of our conversation time. Before she can reach the entrance to the hallway, Eleanor suddenly rises from her chair and yanks Gracie out of the room by her wrist.

What the hell just happened?

The other girls in the room glance in my direction curiously—likely wondering what I could have done to make this girl so irritated in just two minutes. Summer and Alison both shoot me inquisitory looks from across the room, mouthing words to me that I can’t quite see.

Juliette seems to take note of the altercation and starts walking in the direction of my chair. She doesn’t seem quite surprised by what just happened, which leaves me wondering if Gracie often acts like this.

“I am so sorry about that,” Juliette begins softly. “Gracie is going through a lot right now, and sometimes recruitment can really send people over the edge. Don’t worry, you won’t be penalized for that conversation.”

I breathe a sigh of relief. “Okay, awesome. I was worried I might’ve done something wrong...”

She smiles in response. “Not at all! The next rotation is about to begin anyways—go have fun!”

After a few seconds, the members stand again to migrate to their next potential member, and I eventually find myself locked into other, more productive conversations.

The remainder of my interactions go by much smoother than Gracie and I’s chat—most of the older members are very sweet and easy to talk to. I circle the topics of the newest albums, the newest makeup line releases, and my hometown fundraiser 5K for ALS Awareness that I helped to organize the last three years. Summer was right, these were exactly the right topics to discuss, because each girl seemed fascinated with our conversation.

By the time my final chat comes to an end and Summer returns to her seat across from me, I find myself with a genuine smile on my face.

“How do you think it went?” she asks nervously. “Other than your second conversation, of course.”

“Great! I used your topic ideas, and I didn’t even consider bringing up boys,” I answer. “I just hope the other girls liked me.”

“I’ll find out here in a minute,” she says. “But I’m not worried.”

Juliette then directs the potential members to stay in the room while the older members gather in the dining area to vote on who should be invited back tomorrow.

Although the majority of my conversations went swimmingly, I can’t help but feel a little bit nervous. What if my interaction with Gracie keeps me from getting an invite back? Not only would that be embarrassing, but I’d miss out on a huge chunk of information that is likely crucial to my investigation.

I move from my seat to find Alison, who is now sitting across the room with Imani and Maeve. As soon as I sit down with them, they erupt with questions about my conversation with Gracie.

“What was the deal with that one girl?” Imani asks. “You talked to her for less than a minute.”

“No idea. She told me to watch my back...very ominous.”

Maeve pitches into the conversation. “The girl I was talking to said that Gracie does that a lot. Apparently she wasn’t allowed to recruit last year—something about having an uncontrollable attitude...”

That’s weird. Juliette mentioned to me that Gracie was going through a lot right now, but that doesn’t explain her behavior from an entire year ago.

“Don’t let it get to you though,” Alison says encouragingly.

“Apparently the other girls really liked you!”

Leave it to Alison to help me feel better in a situation like this.

Before I can thank her for her words, the door to the dining room re-opens, and the members are soon filing out after Juliette—Eleanor close behind them. Pink cards fill each of their mostly-empty hands.

As the group stares at us, Juliette begins to make an announcement—commanding the entire room as she speaks.

“Thank you all again for joining us tonight. As you exit the house, you will each be handed a card that reveals your fate in the chapter,” she explains. “If you find the letter *A* written on your card, you are cordially invited to our next rush event tomorrow night. If you find the letter Ω , we appreciate your dedication, but we no longer wish for you to join our chapter. Please refrain from opening your cards until you have left Greek Row.”

I immediately feel the knot in my stomach re-forming.

What if nobody in my newly-formed friend group receives an invite back?

Or worse—what if only some of us do?

Following the announcement, Summer makes her way over towards our group to hand me a card. She leaves it flipped upside down, with the writing facing the floor.

As she places the card in my hand, she smiles menacingly, then leans close to me to whisper something in my ear.

“I’ll see you tomorrow.”

The feeling in my stomach loosens, and I catch Summer flashing me a wink before she exits the room. If I’m officially invited back for tomorrow’s event, I only have to worry about Alison, Imani, and Maeve now.

The four of us exit the sorority house and make our way back towards North Village, where Norman and Caswell Hall reside. We decide to avoid reading our cards until we are all in our individual rooms to avoid potential embarrassment if one of us isn’t invited back. The three of them seem incredibly nervous as we make our walk back, so I feel eternally grateful to have already learned my fate.

As we reach the Norman Hall entrance, we part ways with Imani and enter the elevator with Maeve. Alison and I step off on the fourth floor, waving goodbye to Maeve as we click down the hallway in our heels.

When we approach our room, Alison asks if the two of us should reveal our cards at the same time.

“It’s like ripping off a band-aid,” she compares.

I agree to do so— though I already know I’ve been invited back—and the two of us count to three quietly before revealing our fate. When we hit *three*, we flip our cards over.

As soon as they are flipped, Alison and I see matching *A*’s stamped across the backs of our cards in the same glittery ink as the note that was left under our door earlier tonight. We breathe a collective sigh of relief, and then part ways to get ready for bed.

Tonight has been exhausting, and now the both of us are expected to do it again the next day.

Hopefully tomorrow night, we’ll both get a bid.

8

Tonight's rush event went significantly better than the night before.

When we arrived, I was pleased to see that Maeve and Imani had been invited back as well, and the four of us stuck together as much as possible throughout the event.

Earlier in the night we had received another card under our door that told us to wear light pink dresses to the house, which made sense when we were told of tonight's theme: The Celebration of Harmony. According to Juliette, the color pink represents inner peace and femininity—qualities that Alpha Omega members tend to embody. Everything went pretty much the same as yesterday, except we spoke with a different group of older members and had longer conversations than the day before.

Now, after a few hours of chatting with sisters and listening to group announcements, we are all about to be released from the house.

"Tonight at midnight, you will be notified if you have received an invitation to join our chapter," Juliette announces to our group. "Only a select few of you will receive this honor. Thank you all again for joining us tonight, and we wish you the best of luck."

The clock has struck eleven by the time Alison and I make it back to Norman Hall, but we are both far too nervous to sleep. Before we left the house earlier, we were told that only twenty of the thirty girls who attended tonight's event will receive membership invitations, meaning there's a 30% chance that one of us will not get into the sorority.

So—to help suppress our nerves—we decide to pull up a comedy movie and eat leftover snacks on the couch to keep our mind off of things.

A little less than an hour into our film of choice, the both of us are drifting off in our seats. Just as my eyelids begin to close, a loud knock at our door wakes me from my trance, sending me into a state of panic for a moment. Alison appears equally confused, so I'm sure she also wasn't expecting any visitors at this time of night.

I glance down at my phone and see the time—exactly one minute past midnight. I stand up quietly and look through the peephole, where I can eventually make out a blurred image of Summer and Kimberly standing outside.

“Oh my God,” I say, suddenly wide awake. “We’re totally in.”

I fling open the door with excitement, and the two girls quickly rush inside of our room with perfect bouquets of pink roses in hand. Kimberly immediately wraps Alison in a hug, but Summer and I share a glance—confirming to me that neither of us is the hugging type. Instead, she hands me the light-pink bouquet and smiles.

Although her face appears bright and happy, something about her stance makes her appear uneasy about being in our room.

“Congratulations, girls. If you’re willing to join, Alpha Omega would like to extend a formal bid of membership to both of—”

“We accept!” Alison squeals, cutting off Summer’s sentence.

Kimberly and Summer smile brightly at us, then share a quick look.

“I know it’s late, but we need you to come with us,” Kimberly pipes in mysteriously. “Your celebration awaits you.”

I hope to myself that Maeve and Imani will be at the celebration as well.

“What do we need to wear?” I ask. By this point I’ve grown used to dressing for specified themes when attending Alpha Omega events.

Summer looks the two of us up and down. “Just come as you are.”

I glance down at my outfit. My navy blue sweatpants and white bandeau top are a stark difference from the high-class attire I’ve been sporting the past two days, but then again, Summer and Kimberly are dressed in sweats too. Alison and I are basically wearing the same thing, though she has pink flare sweatpants on that make her appear a bit more put-together than myself.

After evaluating whether I should change, I shrug off my concerns, and the four of us walk out of the room. Summer takes a quick look back at our door—still appearing unnerved by something—but she quickly shakes the nervous look off of her face and catches up with our group as we move down the hallway.



Moments after arriving at the AO house, we discovered that our two newest friends—Maeve and Imani—also received bids, and they are further into celebrating than we are.

The house is swarming with hundreds of girls—some of whom I met during the past two rush events, and others that I have never seen before. Throughout the night, several older members come and introduce themselves to me, expressing how thrilled they are that Alison and I joined the chapter. I’ve never felt such a warm welcome in my entire life.

Ashley has been feeding the two of us drinks since we walked in the door, so by the time one o’clock rolls around, I’m slightly hammered. In my drunken haze, I notice that I haven’t seen Summer since we arrived, and I really want to thank her for helping me along with the recruitment process. Catching a glimpse of Kimberly across the room, I navigate my way over to where she is standing and ask if she’s seen her.

“Summer? I think she went upstairs,” Kimberly slurs. “She’s probably in her room.”

Perfect. I know exactly how to get there.

I thank her for the directions before quickly scurrying off towards the elevator. When it opens up, I step inside and mash the familiar top button. The elevator begins slowly moving upwards, which makes me feel slightly nauseous given all the drinks in my system, but I’m luckily able to withstand throwing up.

When the doors reopen, I turn down the left hallway and walk to the end, knocking on the large white door at the end. Through the door, I hear a soft voice telling me to come in, so I turn the crystal knob and step inside.

As I enter, I can see Summer sitting on her bed. She appears much more upset than she was before, but still pastes a smile on her face for my sake.

“Sorry I’m not down there to celebrate,” she says, wiping a tear from her cheek.

“Is everything okay?” I ask, curious as to why she has seemed upset since arriving at my dorm.

She looks down at her lap and fiddles with her bedsheets. “I haven’t been back there since last year... I guess it was just really hard for me to see the place where Riley and Caroline lived.”

Finally, it clicks for me. Summer is upset because she harbors memories of her missing friends from Norman Hall, which is coincidentally the same

building that I've been assigned to. I totally get how this re-visitation could upset her, so I mentally prepare to apologize for putting her in this position.

Before I have a chance to speak, though, she cuts in—and nothing could prepare me for her next statement.

“I mean, what are the odds that you guys are living in the *exact* same room that they lived in?”

9

Riley Walker

AUGUST 2023

(Three Months Before)

“Pink or red?”

I hold the two dress options up for Caroline to examine—secretly hoping she’ll pick the latter.

“Definitely pink,” she replies. “I don’t like the red one.”

My shoulders sag with disappointment at her response, but I cast the red dress aside anyways. Sometimes I feel as if Caroline chooses the option that would make me look the worst, but then again, why would she do that?

After all, she is my best friend.

“You know who’s supposed to be there tonight?” Caroline asks through a smirk, clearly not taking note of my disappointment.

I let out a long sigh.

“Caroline,” I snip. “How many times do I have to tell you that I’m not going to hook up with Jake?”

“Why not? You can’t stay single through all of college,” Caroline insists. “Plus, he’s rich.”

Jake Morton might have a lot of money, but he also only has about two brain cells to rub together on a good day. I’m not even sure why Caroline would think I would want to be with someone like that, especially considering I’ve always told her that my ideal man needs to be at least as smart as I am.

“I don’t need his money,” I push back at her. “My family is generationally wealthy, remember?”

At my response, Caroline shrugs me off and returns to burying her face in her cell phone—making it clear that my rejection has annoyed her. Her boyfriend, Noah, is fraternity brothers with Jake, so she’s relentlessly tried to set us up in an attempt to arrange double dates between the four of us. No

matter how many times she suggests it to me, my answer never changes—much to her annoyance.

However, there's something that she doesn't know.

I've been seeing someone for the past week, but in secret. He's a great guy—nice, smart, and actually good looking—and I'm really starting to like him. Therefore, I can't let Caroline find out about him just yet. I don't want to risk jinxing it.

After walking back into my room, I throw on the lacy pink dress and model it in front of the mirror. I much preferred the red option, but I know Caroline would be upset if I didn't wear the option she chose, so I need to find a way to make this one work. Luckily, I have a pair of light-pink pumps that will perfectly match the dress, and a white clutch that will really help to complete the look.

Tonight, it's important that I look my absolute best. It's the night of the annual End-of-Summer Cocktail—one of the biggest Alpha Omega events of the year—and my new Mystery Man will most likely be there.

Mystery Man aside, I need to look amazing anyways; a select few potential Alpha recruits will be attending tonight, and we need to make the best impression we can. As our advisor Eleanor always says, *the first impression is the most valued impression*.

With her sentiment in mind, I decide to spend the next twenty minutes curling and volumizing my hair. My dark brown curls seem to perfectly contrast with the pink lace of the dress, and after a few spritzes of dry shampoo, I feel ready to take on the night.

Before walking out the door, I take a final longing gaze at the red dress that lays atop the bed. I'm well aware that it would look much better than the one I'm wearing right now, but the last thing I would want to do is start an argument before we leave for the party.

Whatever Caroline Rowe says goes—even if it concerns something as simple as a dress.

As if she knows I'm thinking about her, she pops her head into my room.

"Are you ready?" she asks. "Noah's picking us up in five."

I nod at her before taking one last quick moment to myself, inhaling in and out deeply before grabbing my purse and walking outside.

Even though I've been in Alpha Omega for a year now, the pre-event nerves still find a way to cloud my brain before each function. Caroline has

managed to rack up quite a few enemies over our short time at Cabot University, and I am often turned into an enemy by association. Unfortunately, this has led to several uncomfortable confrontations at social events, where I am left to clean up the mess that my best friend has left behind.

Lately, it seems as if the drama is getting worse by the day.

If you're wondering why I would choose to be friends with someone like Caroline, it's important to first understand that none of my past friendships or relationships have ever ended well. Being friends with such a chaotic individual might not make sense to the average person, but when you've spent your life hopping from one broken connection after another, chaos can begin to feel a bit like home.

I've never had the best support system in my family—I'm basically estranged from my siblings, and my mother has spent regular stints in mental health treatment facilities since I was twelve years old. My father left our family for his secretary when I was just in the sixth grade, and I haven't seen or heard a word from him since. My once-normal mother soon lost her ability to function, and it didn't take long for her to become an angry, resentful person that none of us could stand to be around.

Sometimes I remember the woman she used to be—the one who baked us cookies every Friday night and spent tireless hours helping my siblings and I with homework—and I feel a sense of grief for someone who isn't really gone.

With no parental support half of the time, our grandparents would periodically take us in for many weeks at a time. Even with their help, though, my sisters and I would have been screwed without the hefty inheritance from our mother and father's family lines—courtesy of our ancestors' hard work.

As the oldest child, I always felt a sense of responsibility to parent my two sisters, especially given the fact that our mother couldn't accomplish that task on her own. I spent the better part of five years feeding and bathing them on days my mom couldn't lift herself out of bed, and even began taking them to school and doctors appointments as soon as I received my driver's license.

Though I was biologically their sister, I began to feel like their mother as my responsibilities increased. That's why it hurt even more when I realized their vile tendencies from their childhoods had grown into

unbreakable habits, and that I could no longer bring myself to stay in contact with them.

The familial issues that have rocked my entire life for several years are the exact reason that I put up with Caroline. She may do terrible things to undeserving people, but she provides a sense of support in my life that I've barely ever felt. She's the best friend and the best accomplice I've ever had, and I can't afford to lose such an important person in my life, no matter how terrible she may be in the public eye.

It's boilerplate psychology—traumatized people with limited personal relationships latch onto those who provide a nurturing environment for them, no matter what poor behaviors they may engage in.

Cabot University has provided me with a true support system for the first time, and I have found such a sense of family in Alpha Omega.

This school has allowed me to leave my mother and siblings in the past and create a new life for myself, where I can pursue my dream career alongside distinguished students from across the country.

My two best friends—Summer and Caroline—have created a family where I truly feel as if I belong.

So far, Cabot has brought me nothing but joy and happiness.

I can't wait to see what this semester brings.

10

LEIGHTON

2024

Twenty-four hours have passed since I discovered that our dorm room was the last known residence of Riley Walker and Caroline Rowe.

Summer and I decided it would be best to keep this information from Alison, mainly since the truth might make her feel uneasy about living here. Granted, I'm not entirely sure if Alison knows anything about the case to begin with, so it might not affect her very much.

Either way, I'd rather keep this tidbit of information between the two of us.

The whole situation feels incredibly coincidental. What exactly *are* the odds of my being assigned to the exact same room pertaining to my investigation? I never mentioned any interest in investigating the case in my college application, and certainly not in my housing application.

Although there is no other alternative than this whole thing being a crazy coincidence, I find it hard to accept.

Despite feeling overwhelmed by this new development, I have to push my thoughts aside temporarily and focus on my classes. Today is Monday, which officially marks the first day of school at Cabot. I have two class periods to attend throughout the day—Advanced Writing at 11:00, and Intro to Calculus at 1:00.

When I was a senior in high school, I participated in a dual enrollment program with a local community college, which boosted my credits in certain subjects. Advanced Writing is a junior-level class, so I'm expecting a heavy workload going into the course.

I arrive at the Language Arts building ten minutes early, so I'm able to find a good seat in the classroom without a problem. Once I'm sitting down,

I unzip my newly-bought backpack to grab out my notebook and computer, which I place upon the desk in preparation for the syllabus review.

As the minutes pass, more students file into the seats behind me—the professor eventually succeeding them. He slowly crawls his way down to the front of the room, then plops down at his chair after placing his briefcase down on the desk.

My Advanced Writing professor is a burly older man with wiry gray hair and a permanent frown upon his face. He introduces himself as Professor Davis, then proceeds to go on a ten minute tangent about how he doesn't accept late work, participation is expected, and two unexcused absences will result in a failing grade. He also mentions that all assignments are to be handwritten, so it seems like this class is going to be a real blast.

When he has completed his rant, Professor Davis walks back towards his desk and grabs a white sheet of paper from his briefcase. He lets us know to speak out if our name is called, then begins droning down a long list of about fifty students. I'm used to being called first for attendance—my last name is Adams—so I try to tune out his voice once I've made my presence known.

That is, until one of the names catches my attention.

"Nathaniel Murphy?"

My head jerks up when I hear the name, and I instantly scan the room for the cute brunette that I met at the End-of-Summer cocktail. His name was Nathan, and he was a junior, so it would make sense for him to be in this advanced section of Writing.

As I'm searching, I hear a deep voice from across the room.

"Here."

My eyes land upon Nathan after he speaks, and one glance is all it takes to confirm that this is the same Nathan from the party. He is already staring directly at me, so I jerk back around in my seat as fast as possible—internally hoping he didn't notice me searching for him.

For the remainder of the class period, I remain facing forward and listen to the review of the syllabus, keeping my focus away from Nathan. After the professor dismisses us, I remain at my desk to place my belongings back into my bag. Just as I'm zipping my bag and preparing to stand, I feel a hand on my shoulder, so I spin around to see who is behind me.

Lo and behold, it's Nathan.

He looks even better today than he did at the party. He's wearing a dark blue oversized sweatshirt with faded stitch letters reading *ΘM*—the name of his fraternity—and his messy, chocolate-brown hair falls in his face.

As I stare at him, I find myself wondering why I never called him.

"Looks like fate has brought us together again," he says, flashing a smile.

I smile back. "Lucky me."

"You never called," Nathan complains to me. "I was starting to think I wouldn't see you again."

My cheeks flush, but I keep my cool as best as possible.

"Actually, you'll be seeing a lot more of me," I say. "Alpha Omega bidded Alison and I. We're official sorority girls now."

Nathan's smile widens at my reveal.

"You won't regret it," he says. "Alpha O's are the best on campus. That's why I'm not surprised—I knew you'd have no problem getting in."

My heart begins to pump quickly, and I don't know how to respond to him. I soon realize that I haven't said anything in a moment, so I focus my attention on Nathan and come up with something to say.

"You'll have to come to one of our date parties with me."

He smiles again. "Count me in."

The two of us make our way out of the building together, parting ways once we step outside.

"I have class in five minutes," he says. Suddenly, he pastes a familiar smirk on his face, then speaks again. "But I'll be expecting your call, Miss Leighton."

Nathan readjusts his backpack and walks off into the distance, falling out of my sight as other students merge into the walkway.

I feel like I've been winning the lottery ever since I came to Cabot, and I've only been here for four days. My random roommate turned out to be normal, I've joined the top sorority on campus, and now, I've found a new crush for myself within the first weekend. It doesn't seem like things could get much better.

Though I'm overwhelmingly excited about my new life at this school, I can't help but feel that this is all a bit too good to be true. My mother always tells me that I am too skeptical, or that I am a bit pessimistic when it comes to romantic connections, but even she would have to admit that I've

never been wrong about someone's true nature. I pretty much have a built-in radar when it comes to that stuff.

Right now, alarm bells are ringing. Nathan feels too good to be true.

Then again, I barely even know him.

Maybe I'm just being paranoid.



After my classes had finished for the day, I trudged my way back to Norman Hall in the blazing heat. The walk itself is only about half a mile, but given the combination of the 95° Alabama weather and the fact that the campus is rested on a hill, it basically feels like you're hiking through hot sand in the Mojave desert. My Tennessee town never seemed to surpass 80° on our hottest summer day, so this climate is going to take some adjusting.

Shortly after I made it back to our dorm, Alison texted and asked if I wanted to meet for lunch in the Student Union, which I happily agreed to. Now, I'm making my way across the street towards The Starship—the student dining hall for North Village residents. Thankfully, the walk to the Union only takes about five minutes, so the heat doesn't affect me much this time.

After I reach the top of the staircase, I walk over to the line of people waiting to be scanned into The Starship. All freshmen are required to have a meal plan, so our Student IDs basically serve as a season pass to unlimited half-decent meals and desserts for the remainder of our first year.

As I'm waiting in line, I catch a glimpse of Alison across the second floor, who seems to be talking to an attractive man wearing a button down and dress pants. He's decently tall, and has clean-cut dirty blonde hair that's clearly been styled today. If I had to guess, he probably had a presentation in class this morning and chose to wear business casual.

As I stare at them from across the floor, Alison catches my gaze and waves the man goodbye before prancing across the room towards me.

When she makes it to my vicinity, I poke at her. "He was cute."

"Very," she laughs. "But you'd never guess how old he is."

I take a moment to think, but she's right—I'll never guess.

"I'm stumped," I say.

Alison smirks. "He's 26, and he's my professor—William Darcy."

I'm surprised by this answer. He certainly looked older than twenty, but it didn't even cross my mind that he could be a professor.

As I repeat the name in my head, I realize that the last name rings a bell.

"Darcy?" I ask.

"Yep," Alison says, "His dad is Edmund Darcy. Apparently their family has put millions of dollars into this school. One of my classroom buildings is even named after his grandfather—the Darcy College of Business. Their family pretty much owns this place by this point."

"I've never been above sleeping with a professor," I say jokingly. "Maybe it's time you give older men a try."

She laughs at this statement as the two of us finally reach the front of the line to scan ourselves in. We quickly shuffle inside to claim the only available booth, then set our keys down on the table before separating to check out the food options.

After making a round of the room, I transfer a measly piece of pepperoni pizza onto my plate—a better alternative to the "Chicken & Rice" that's on the menu for today. Next, I head to the fruit section and make a quick parfait with the strawberry yogurt that's available. I crumble some granola on top before heading back to our booth.

Yum. Pizza and yogurt for dinner.

If this is what the meals are like every night, I'll have no problem avoiding the freshman fifteen.

Alison is already back at the table when I arrive, and I notice that her plate looks just as barren as mine. She's only selected a few pieces of miscellaneous fruit, a large breadstick from the Italian section, and some marinara sauce.

"No chicken and rice?" I joke as I slip into our booth. "It looked so delicious."

"First of all, that looked disgusting." Alison pushes her plate aside as she speaks. "Second—this is probably a good time to tell you that I'm a vegetarian."

"Really?" I ask. "Since when?"

She shrugs.

"It's a family thing. My mom and dad watched a sad documentary about slaughterhouses when we were kids, so after that they decided that we wouldn't support that system again. I haven't had any kind of meat since I was ten."

Coincidentally, my investigation of Riley and Caroline's disappearance had brought up a restaurant with extensive meat-free options. Marciello's—the restaurant that the girls ordered food from prior to their disappearance—is known for their popular vegetarian and vegan dishes.

I've been meaning to visit the place, in hopes that some type of revelation about the case is waiting there for me. I wonder if Alison would be interested in coming with me, given that the restaurant surely has better food options than the ones in front of us.

"There's this place off campus—Marciello's," I mention hopefully. "It's an Italian restaurant with a bunch of vegetarian options, according to their website. We should go sometime."

"How about for dinner?" Alison tosses a napkin on top of her plate. "I'll drive. I'm starving after this pathetic excuse for a meal."

I nod, and the two of us set a time for our dinner-date before making our way back home.

11

Gnocchi Alla Sorrentina. Pasta Primavera.

These are the two menu items that Riley and Caroline ordered from Marciello's on the night of their disappearance, which the two girls never had a chance to pick up.

I stare at the two familiar entrees on the printed menu in front of me, wondering what the restaurant employees ever did with the order that the girls had placed. It's interesting that two plates of pasta can provoke so many questions in my mind.

What kept Riley and Caroline from getting to the restaurant?

Were they ever really planning to pick up their food, or did they have other plans in mind? If so, why even order it?

As my mind races with questions, Alison interrupts my train of thought to ask which menu options are vegetarian.

"It's anything marked with a V," I reply.

"Any suggestions?" She scans the menu several times. "I've never been somewhere like this."

I laugh to myself. "I've heard the Pasta Primavera is popular."

Alison throws a weird look in my direction before shrugging to herself and putting her menu down.

When the waitress finally comes around to take our order, I order the Spicy Rigatoni entree with a Diet Coke to drink. Alison follows my suggestion and puts in an order of the vegetarian pasta I mentioned, also ordering a water to drink. Her vegetarian diet kind of puts my attempt at being healthy to shame.

Our food takes a while to come out given how busy the restaurant is, so I take the time to examine the dining room—hoping I might find some sort of information relating to my investigation.

The room is dimly lit, though the large, floor-length windows cast a warm glow upon the tables in the front. Bustling tables of people fill the room with loud chatter and the sounds of clinking silverware. Though I was

aware of the restaurant's popularity, I wasn't expecting this many people to be here on a quiet Monday night.

Shifting my focus to the back of the room, I spot a pick-up shelf for call-in orders sitting beside the cashier area, where several orders are sitting upon the shelves wrapped in brown paper bags. Underneath the cashier's counter lies a stand of brochures up against the wall, containing several colorful flyers and packets about semi-local attractions. From my seat, I scan the name of each attraction in hopes of discovering something.

Carrigan Hill Farms: A Local Petting Zoo.

Birmingham Botanical Gardens.

Cheaha State Park.

These places all seem exciting, but it doesn't seem like they'll help my investigation whatsoever. Other than the pick-up counter, I don't see anything in the restaurant that gives me any ideas.

After the two of us receive our meals, we quickly scarf down our food and finish our drinks. One meal at the student dining hall was enough to leave us starving, so we both have our plates cleared in under five minutes.

As soon as we receive our check, I tell Alison that I'll pay for the meal—secretly hoping to sneak in a conversation with the cashier for a minute. If I'm lucky, she might know something that can help me with the case.

Otherwise, this whole trip was a dead-end.

"I'm not gonna stop you," she replies teasingly. "I'll stay here."

I swiftly walk over towards the cash register, still looking for any potential clues along the way. Once I'm there, I place my card on the counter and slide it towards the cashier, who is a middle-aged woman with dark hair. She isn't wearing a nametag, but she looks like her name would be *Theresa* or *Kathy*.

"Is that all for you, sweetie?"

The woman speaks with a thick southern accent, and I forget for a moment that I'm now in the Deep South. We had a few country boys in Tennessee, but they mainly live in the mountainous area of the state.

I smile in response. "Yes, please."

"Are you in school?" She flashes me an inquisitive glance. "We have a discount for Cabot students."

I nod, and watch the price on the Clover screen reduce from \$34.73 to \$26.05. If every restaurant in town offers a 25% discount for students, I may not be avoiding the freshman fifteen after all.

As I swipe my card, I remember why I came up here in the first place, so I pose a question to the nice woman.

“How long have you lived in Brookwood?”

The woman smiles back at me, as if she’s excited that someone cared to ask her a personal question. “Born and raised. I went to Brookwood University—it’s a few miles down the interstate. I guess I just never got the itch to leave town...”

“Well it seems great here so far,” I say. “I’ve only been in town for about a week, but Cabot seems amazing.”

I notice a slight twinge in her expression at the mention of the university, which I can only assume has something to do with Riley and Caroline.

“Just be careful at that school, honey,” she whispers. “I’m sure you’ve heard about those two girls. I think it was a human trafficking ring that got them. Those types of people see beautiful little girls like you as a target...”

I’m a bit unnerved by this response, but I respond anyway.

“Don’t worry, I’m very careful.” I smile at the woman before asking another question. “I actually *have* heard about the case though...isn’t this the last place they spoke with before their disappearance?”

“That’s right,” she answers sorrowfully. “I was working here at the time, and the girls were regulars. I rang them and their friends up a few times, but I didn’t really know them all that well. Still—it’s terrible what happened.”

The screen begins to flash *APPROVED*, and the machine starts to beep at me to take my card out.

“Need a receipt?” she asks—our conversation suddenly at an end.

I politely decline, then place my card back inside my purse. Before I go, I thank the woman for the service, and she reminds me to stay vigilant. Afterwards, Alison and I hop in the car and drive back towards campus—finally feeling satisfied after starving all day.

By the time we make it back to our room, it’s almost 8:30, and the sun is beginning to fall. The first day of classes has officially come to an end, and syllabus day is over. From this point forward, we actually have to do work in our classes.

The thought of that sends a spike of anxiety into my chest, but I do my best to shake it off. Tomorrow, I have two new classes to attend—

Introduction to Criminal Justice being one of them. It's officially time to focus on my academics, and that starts with getting a good night's rest.

12

My first week of classes flew by faster than expected.

Nathan and I began sitting together in Advanced Writing this week, so I at least have someone to compare notes with in that class. Calculus has been miserably boring all three times I have attended it, but I can at least understand the work we are doing in this unit. Sociology was easy—we still haven't even covered anything other than the syllabus, and my professor seems very low-maintenance.

Intro to Criminal Justice, however, was my favorite.

When I first arrived to class Tuesday, Professor Boswell shot me a quick wink that assured me he remembered our interaction last weekend. Though this wasn't how I planned to meet my professors, I'm glad I've already made an ally in at least one of them.

It's now Friday night, and Alison and I were planning on staying in. We don't have fake IDs yet—we've been hoping someone will involve us in their group order sooner or later—so for now we have no way of going to the bars. Thankfully, most of the other freshmen don't have their own yet either, so we are all in the same boat of not being able to go to the bar.

Earlier in the night, Maeve had messaged us to ask if we'd like to come to a cocktail night at Imani's dorm. Now, we are heading downstairs to meet with her in a few minutes in order for us to walk to Caswell together.

I'm happy that I'm getting to know more girls on campus, because I was really worried about my ability to make friends here at Cabot. Friendship hasn't always come easy to me—I only had a few in high school, and most of them were only base-level. Now that I've joined a top sorority, I'm hoping that won't be a problem anymore.

A few minutes later, the three of us are walking through the paths of North Village to reach Imani's building, where she lives in a two-bedroom, apartment-style dormitory.

"You'll be so jealous when you see Imani's room," Maeve tells us as we near the place. "Caswell's top two floors put Norman Hall to shame."

Through the entrance windows of the building, I see a vague image of a girl with dark hair bouncing towards us before Imani comes busting through the door to let us inside. Once we're in, she scans her student ID to send the elevator to the fifth floor, which already tells me that Caswell is much more high-tech than Norman.

Once we get to Imani's room, though, my jealousy grows immensely.

The bedrooms are larger than Alison and I's rooms combined, and each one has an attached bathroom and a walk-in closet. The common space consists of a kitchen, a washer/ dryer, and a large pantry for food and storage. It seems more like a penthouse suite than a dorm room, but I'm happy that Imani gets to experience this kind of dorm-life. Compared to her, the three of us are slumming it over in Norman Hall.

Nonetheless, this is the perfect location for a girls night.

After getting settled in the living area with four store-bought Moscow Mules in hand, we begin to discuss our experience with recruitment.

"I thought it would be a lot more cult-y," I joke to them. "Especially when they told us we had to wear all white."

Maeve laughs. "I was thinking it would be more dangerous or drug-related. I definitely wasn't expecting the anti-drug policy."

For context, Juliette recently sent out a long email to our new member class detailing the rules of our pledge to Alpha Omega. Along with the ban on drugs, we are prohibited from posting alcohol on social media, standing on elevated surfaces at parties, or expressing our political beliefs on the internet.

It doesn't stop there, though. The list goes on beyond explanation.

"A few of the older girls told me that you can get away with doing small amounts of stuff," Imani says knowingly, as if she's been planning to break this rule since she learned of it. "Just as long as you're not rolling on the floor or something."

She locks eyes with me and smirks. "They also told me how we can get our hands on some fake IDs, but you'll never guess who makes them."

"I'm stumped," I say. "Who is it?"

She takes a long sip of her drink before responding. "Gracie Franklin—that psycho girl who freaked out at you during the white Leighton ceremony."

Great, I think to myself.

"Guess I'm screwed then. She hates my guts."

Alison waves a hand. “It’ll be fine. She doesn’t hate you...I’m sure she was just in a bad mood.”

“It’s better to have one uncomfortable conversation with Gracie than to be stuck staying in every weekend,” Maeve cuts in, making a pretty decent point. “The worst she can say is no.”

I throw my head back in defeat before accepting Maeve’s words.

“Fine...but no promises she’ll actually make one for me.”

Imani grins.

“Perfect, because I already told her I have four orders coming her way,” she says. “We’ll each get two IDs for \$60. All you have to do is send a photo of yourself, your signature, and the other general information you’d see on a license. Super easy.”

“We sent ours this morning,” Maeve adds excitedly. “Here—I’ll send you her phone number.”

She whips out her rhinestone-studded phone to share Gracie’s contact with the two of us.

Alison runs her hands through her hair before grabbing a tube of lipgloss out of her purse—applying a quick layer before using her phone camera to check her reflection.

“Okay,” she says, clearly satisfied with how she looks. “Who wants to take my picture for me?”

I volunteer myself, and the two of us spend the next few minutes trying to get a photo of each other that might seem convincing enough to a bouncer. Thankfully, we are able to find an area with lighting that made us look just as bad as a DMV does, and Imani’s white wall serves as a perfect blank backdrop for the pictures.

Once we each get the perfect shot, Imani helps us submit our information to Gracie’s phone number. I hesitate to hit the *send* button, but the thought of missing out on countless nights out was enough to make me get over it.

Afterwards, the four of us get tipsy off of a 12-pack of seltzers while taking turns playing Just Dance on Imani’s roommate’s Wii. By the time I finish a duet of *Timber* with Alison, my ribs are plagued with cramps from dancing so hard. I hardly even realize that an hour has passed until my phone buzzes with a message, prompting me to check the time.

1:30 a.m.

Upon checking the text, I see that Gracie has reacted to my message with a thumbs up. This doesn't quite give me the feeling that we will be best friends, but at least I can assume that this means she's actually going to complete my order for me. I wasn't expecting much from her, so I'm pleasantly surprised.

Stepping back towards the group, I turn my phone screen outwards to Alison. "Looks like we're all set."

Her eyes light up as she walks towards the couch to retrieve her phone, which she immediately checks in hope of a response from Gracie. Sure enough, her gleaming look tells me that we've both made it onto the order list.

After confirming the message, I notice her typing out a short text to a separate contact— quickly turning the phone off and placing it in her hoodie pocket as soon as she hits *send*.

When she notices me staring, she locks eyes with me.

"Wanna head out?"

I nod in agreement, and we make our way to the kitchen area where Maeve and Imani are gathered. The two of them are noticeably drunk and rooting through the pantry together to find something filling to eat. As we walk into the small room, I can hear the two of them discussing a late-night McDonalds trip enthusiastically.

"Hey," I say to them both, then turn back to Maeve. "We're planning on heading back to Norman in a sec. Do you want to come with us, or are you staying here?"

She giggles in response, looking much more intoxicated than Alison or I.

"I'm gonna stay with Imani tonight," she says.

"We're going to get food," Imani adds with a grin.

Since the two of them have made their own plans, Alison and I thank Imani for the invite and step out towards the elevator. Once we've made it back to the street, I notice that she has been oddly invested in her phone the past few minutes, so I point it out to her.

"Who might you be texting at this hour?" I tease.

Alison rolls her eyes and glances into the distance for a moment, clearly hesitant to answer my question. Eventually, she lets out a deep breath and responds.

“A guy I met at the End-of-Summer party,” she caves. “I think he’s in Theta Mu—I can’t keep up with the fraternity names yet. I can’t tell you his name yet. It’s bad luck.”

I noticed Alison talking to a few different guys on the night of the party, but nobody specifically comes to mind. It seemed like she was mainly interacting with Nathan’s friend group, so I immediately wonder if they know each other.

“Does your guy know Nathan?”

Her eyes flicker. “Probably...and that’s exactly why I can’t tell you who he is. Frat boys can never keep quiet.”

Before I can begin a line of questioning, Alison speaks again.

“Speaking of—I think you should have Nathan come over tonight. I’m going over to this guy’s house, so you’ll have the dorm to yourself. Think of the opportunities.”

“Yeah right,” I say, protesting her statement. “I’m good.”

Though I have to admit, it’s not a bad idea. Nathan is a really great guy, and it would probably be nice to have some company while Alison is gone. Plus, I’ve always been nervous about being home alone, especially given the fact that I’ve researched hundreds of cases where women were attacked and murdered while being alone in their homes. Having a man over would solve that problem.

If I’m going to invite Nathan over, though, I need to wait until Alison leaves. I don’t want her to know that she was right.

Not yet, at least.

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Nathan will be at my door in less than five minutes.

I'm currently scrambling to re-organize my desk area, which has a combination of makeup products and textbooks scattered on top of it. I quickly stack the books atop one another, then throw the makeup into a drawer before straightening up the clothes in my closet.

Once everything looks suitable, I run a brush through my hair and hastily swish a capful of mouthwash. All the while, I'm repeatedly checking my phone to make sure I haven't missed anything from Nathan.

Sure enough, a message comes through a few seconds later. I walk back to the counter where my phone is lying and read the text.

1:59 AM

HERE. FRONT DOOR.

Shit.

It's been a long time since I've spent time one-on-one with a guy—*especially* one that is two years older than me, and shockingly attractive. My palms are filled with sweat, and my chest is bubbling with anxiety from the thought of being completely alone with Nathan. Still, he is waiting outside Norman Hall, and my nerves won't change anything about that.

It's too late to back out now.

After taking one final glance in the mirror, I trot out the door and make my way towards the elevator.



A few minutes later, Nathan and I are sitting on opposite sides of my twin bed as we discuss our favorite true crime cases from the 21st century.

Not a single soul in my hometown showed the least bit of interest in learning about true crime or historical murders, so it's quite refreshing to discuss the topic with someone who knows what they're talking about.

Given that he's been studying Criminal Justice at Cabot for two years, Nathan probably even knows more than I do about modern crime, which I find intriguing.

"I've actually been to the exact courthouse that Ted Bundy escaped from in Colorado—you know, before he committed all of those murders in Florida."

He pulls up a photo of a small courthouse that I recognize from a documentary I watched a few months ago about the life of the serial killer.

"My family and I were on vacation in Aspen, so I figured I may as well check it out while we were there."

As weird as it is, I completely relate to everything he is saying.

"I feel you," I reply. "For my sixteenth birthday, I dragged my family on a tour of true crime locations across California. We hit a few Golden State Killer murder locations, and a few from Edmund Kemper. It felt pretty surreal to stand in the same spot where someone lost their life like that..."

I still remember the strange sensation of standing in a place where someone spent their final moments. It's one thing to read about a murder, but it's another thing to physically be at the scene of the crime.

Nathan nods. "I completely get what you mean. Boswell takes all sophomore criminal justice students on a field trip to the site of the Geneva County massacre in the Fall semester—I went last year. Putting myself in the shoes of the victims like that...it was *unnerving*, to say the least."

Finally, I think. Someone else understands.

My thoughts suddenly revert back to the first night I met Nathan, when I wondered if he might've possibly known Riley and Caroline. Theta Mu and Alpha Omega are paired organizations, and Nathan was in the same grade as them, so I have to assume that their paths crossed at some point. Maybe he knows something about the case that I haven't already learned.

It's worth asking, either way.

"Speaking of murder cases," I cut in. "Did you know Caroline Rowe and Riley Walker?"

His eyes fill with a sense of surprise at my question, and I hope to myself that I haven't struck a nerve. After a moment, he answers.

"I did."

Though his response is clipped, I persist. "What are your thoughts on the case? Do you have any theories?"

Nathan stays quiet, his hesitation written all over his body language. I don't want to risk him shutting down and keeping something useful to himself, so I give him as much time as he needs.

After a hesitant sigh, he finally begins to talk.

"I'll be honest," he begins. "Caroline and Riley weren't necessarily nice people at all. I know the media made them out to be saints, but trust me, they made life hell for a lot of people at this school."

Nathan's words bring me back to the night of the End-of-Summer Cocktail, when Summer described the girls in a similar way. She never provided any specifics, though I desperately wanted to ask her.

"What did they do?" I ask.

Still hesitant to say anything, he shakes his head before beginning his story.

"My freshman year, there was a girl named Maya Belton that went through recruitment at the same time as the girls. They all ended up pledging Alpha Omega together and becoming friends—Summer too—and nobody could separate the four of them. They were all well-liked around campus, and all of our brothers were hoping for a chance with one of them."

That's weird. Summer never mentioned anyone named Maya in the sorority—only her, Riley, and Caroline.

"One night, Maya had one-too-many to drink at one of our parties," he says. "She ended up going home with one of the Theta Mu's that Caroline had apparently claimed for herself, and the group all found out about it the next day. But—instead of confronting her about it, they acted like they had no idea anything had happened. They just kept pretending to be her friend."

I'm beginning to wonder what the point of this story is.

Still, Nathan continues on.

"A week later, Maya was taking a Chemistry midterm—one that was worth a huge portion of the final grade. Halfway through the test, a few Cabot officials came into the classroom and removed her for a mandatory bag search. They claimed that they had reason to believe that Maya was cheating on the exam she was taking, which is obviously a huge violation of the school policy—grounds for immediate expulsion."

I nod, hoping he will go on. I'm on the edge of my seat.

Thankfully, he does.

“Allegedly, the school had received an anonymous phone call from a concerned student that morning, who I claimed that Maya had bragged to a few students about planning to cheat on her upcoming exams. When the officials went through her backpack, they found printed exam keys to every single midterm she was assigned that week—even the ones she had already taken. She claimed that she had no idea how the papers got there, and that she had a clean academic record, which was true, but nobody believed her. I knew her, though, and she never would have cheated. She didn’t even need to.”

My jaw drops.

“So, Caroline made the anonymous call?” I ask.

Nathan nods knowingly. “Everyone knows it, even though there’s no proof.”

I shake my head.

“So, what happened to Maya?”

“Cabot expelled her pretty much immediately, and I think she had to move back home—somewhere up North,” he answers. “She tried to apply for another university that would suit her academic goals, but it was hard to be accepted anywhere with an expulsion on her record. Last I saw, she was working for her family’s company—some coastal restaurant. She stopped posting anything a long time ago.”

My jaw drops at the information I’ve just learned. It’s not like I was expecting Riley and Caroline to be perfect, but I certainly wasn’t expecting this.

“Did they do anything else?” I ask, still full of questions.

Nathan laughs at first, but then catches himself. “All kinds of things, to all kinds of people. Blackmail, extortion—you name it. They even did it to their own friends...”

He shakes his head again after a moment of consideration.

“I always got the feeling that Caroline was the ringleader of all that stuff, and Riley kind of just went along with it. It doesn’t make her innocent, but less culpable for sure.”

I press for more details on his last statement. “How so?”

“Riley was pretty nice to everyone when she first got here,” he explains. “Her and Caroline didn’t meet until rush week was over, so we all got a small taste of what she was like without her new partner-in-crime. She would make conversation, help people out, and even compliment the other

girls around us. It's like when she became close with Caroline, she became a completely different person."

Nathan clearly knows way more about this case than I do, so I submit to my urge to ask him my most burning question.

"What do you think really happened to them?"

He stares into the distance for a moment, as if he's contemplating what his answer should be. After a few seconds, he finally responds.

"I've given it a lot of thought, and the most realistic solution I can come up with is that Caroline pissed off the wrong person, and she decided to drag Riley down with her. Other than that assumption, I have absolutely no idea...and neither do the police."

I nod in response.

It seems that the consensus among the people who knew the girls is that they made an enemy through their harmful actions, and one of their scorned victims must have killed them.

I wonder to myself how hard it would be to track down a few of these said victims.

Following our long conversation, the both of us are visibly tired. It is 3:00 in the morning, after all.

Nathan gets up to leave, grabbing his jacket as he stands.

"Goodnight, Leighton," he says softly. "I had fun tonight."

I smile back at him. "I did too."

He looks over at me one more time before walking out, closing the door behind him. After he's gone, I slump into my bed and relive the moment when he was here. I already like this guy so much.

After a few minutes of marveling in the moment, I remember how late it is. I set my alarms before crawling into bed for the night, then I lay quietly as I attempt to fall asleep. But something is still on my mind, and I can't seem to shake it off.

Earlier, when Nathan was telling me about Riley and Caroline's blackmailing tendencies, he made a comment that stood out to me.

They even did it to their own friends.

If the two girls were blackmailing their own friends, the pool of people seems to be very limited. Other than Maya Belton, there is only one person I know of who was officially friends with the two girls and could've possibly been a victim of their habits.

And it's someone I know pretty well.

Summer.

14

According to Alpha Omega tradition, Hell Week is to commence after the first week of classes is complete.

They do it this way in order to test the new members' ability to balance the pledging period with our schoolwork, as our chapter has held the highest GPA of all sororities on campus for ten years straight. Anyone that can't handle the pressure will be 'relinquished of membership', as they said.

I barely knew what I was getting into when I joined this sorority, so I'm a bit nervous to find out what this upcoming week is going to entail. I've heard countless horror stories of hazing in fraternities and sororities, so I'm not particularly excited to participate in dangerous, demoralizing activities all week.

Unfortunately, Alpha Omega is the best connection I have to my investigation at the moment, so I can't risk losing my membership over one week of torture. If I want to find any answers, I have to see this through.

It's Sunday night, so tonight is my last full night of freedom for the next seven days. To make the most of it, I've spent the last two hours putting on face masks and taking a long, hot shower. Alison is at the library, so I thankfully have a few hours to myself to enjoy the tranquility before I head to bed.

Once inside my bedroom, I pull out my phone to check for any new messages from Nathan—sadly, there's nothing. I'm thankful I got to see him once before Hell Week kicks off, though, because something tells me I won't have much time for boys in my life over this next week.

After spending a while scrolling through all the new social media updates I can find, my eyelids begin to lower, and I'm asleep before I can set my alarm.



“Wake up, bitch.”

My eyes jolt open at the sound of an unfamiliar voice in my bedroom.

I quickly sit up in my bed, jerking my head around to find the owner of the voice. Through the darkness, I can make out the shape of two girls in my doorway, with another girl standing directly beside my bed. I don't recognize any of them, but I can vaguely make out the Alpha Omega Greek letters upon the shirts they're wearing.

After taking a quick glance at my alarm clock through all of the chaos, I see that it's exactly 12:00am.

Just as it clicks in my head, one of the girls speaks through the shadows in a haunting voice.

“Hell Week has officially begun.”

Before I can ask any questions, the two girls lunge forward and forcefully tie a blindfold over my eyes. The three pairs of arms grab me from each direction, moving me off of the bed and walking me towards the front door of our dorm room.

“Where is Alison?” I croak, still half asleep and confused.

From across the room, I hear her voice — which seems surprisingly calm.

“I'm here too, Leighton.”

The two of us are then forced through the hallways by an unknown number of girls—I think there are five of them, but I'm not sure.

We make it down the elevator and out the front door without running into another resident, which I'm thankful for. Willingly submitting to being blindfolded and taken to an unknown location wouldn't be a very good look for me.

Once outside, I feel a rush of hot summer air against my bare skin. I had worn a skimpy top and a breezy pair of shorts to bed, thinking I would be in for the night, but I guess I was wrong. Hopefully my outfit is suitable enough for whatever we're about to do.

I hear a car door open up before I am placed into the car beside Alison.

“Scoot over,” one of the girls commands, which we quickly follow.

Still blindfolded, I can make out the sound of another person scooching onto the leather seat. I'm unable to tell if it's another pledge member, or if one of the older Alphas is supervising us in the back, but either way, the feeling of uncertainty makes me nervous.

“Who’s that?” Alison asks, confirming to me that she must also be blindfolded.

The mystery third person pipes up.

“Alison? Is that you?”

I breathe a sigh of relief.

“Maeve?”

“Leighton?” she asks. “Oh, thank god. I’m so glad I don’t have to do this alone.”

Me too, Maeve, I think to myself. Me too.

The drive takes about fifteen minutes—most of which is spent listening to creepy, old-fashioned sorority music on full blast. Whoever is driving our trio is clearly trying to screw with us, so at least there is some humor in this partially-terrifying trip.

When the car finally drifts to a stop, the music cuts out. In the absence of the creepy old tunes, I hear what sounds like a mass of women cheering at the top of their lungs. The loudness is intimidating, and it’s only worsened when someone opens the car door beside me.

The moment the door opens, a new hand latches onto my shoulder and pulls me out of the car.

As we move forward, I can feel the screams and cheers surrounding me. The sound is almost deafening, and I still can’t see a thing from behind my blindfold, so I’m pretty much down to having three out of five of my senses.

As we pass through the crowd, my attention is pulled by a few of the statements being said within the group.

“Good luck!”

“Don’t back out!”

“Happy Hell Week!”

And lastly:

“Don’t forget to hold your breath!”

I find more than a few of these statements intimidating, especially since I’m still unsure of where we are and what we are doing.

My bedroom slippers are scraping what I can safely assume is concrete as we walk, and I hear crickets chirping loudly over the cheers, so I’m sure

we must be outside. There haven't been any passing vehicles since we got out of the car, so I don't think we're near a road.

Still—I don't have any reasonable guesses as to where we are and what we are about to do.

Eventually, all of us are filed into a line and spaced apart by about a foot. I can hear Alison to my right, and Maeve is presumably down the line somewhere. Right when we're all settled in our places, a booming female voice comes from behind us.

"Hello ladies, and welcome to Alpha Omega Hell Week!"

The crowd of girls roars in response.

"Turn around to face me, then take off your blindfolds," the voice commands, which I quickly follow.

When I remove my blindfold, I now recognize the booming voice to be Juliette speaking through a megaphone. She is standing atop a picnic table, and is surrounded by seemingly hundreds of other sisters, who are all beaming with excitement. Behind everyone, I can make out a field of grass and a forested area, which only increases my curiosity about what we are doing here.

Before I can wonder any longer, Juliette continues.

"Night one of Hell Week is crucial to weeding out the weakest ones early on," she begins. "If you can't take a leap of faith and trust your sisters, then you can't expect to survive in our chapter for four years."

A leap?

"Without further adieu," Juliette says. "Turn around and meet your fate."

I don't know what I was expecting.

Maybe an obstacle course of some sort, or some kind of keg race.

What I certainly wasn't expecting, was a fifty-foot cliff drop into a large, open lake. From the looks of the faces on the others, I don't think anyone else was expecting this either.

The "leap of faith" comment is suddenly making a lot more sense, and the gears are slowly turning in my head.

They are going to make us jump off this cliff.

I glance over to Alison, who looks surprisingly unfazed. Maybe it's just me, but I wouldn't think that any average person would be excited to jump fifty feet into an ice-cold lake on a school night.

Plus, I'm not even entirely sure it's safe.

I scan the crowd—hoping to make eye contact with Summer for reassurance—but I don't see her anywhere. Before I can look further, I direct my attention back to Juliette, who is now speaking again.

"Jump off, then take the stairs back up," she says. "When you get back, each of you will have a surprise waiting for you." She pauses for a moment, allowing the surrounding girls to cheer us on. Once the crowd dies down, she finishes. "And for those of you who can't take the pressure, you can go ahead and leave. This isn't the right place for you."

At Juliette's command, a girl from the far end steps forward and begins walking away, pulling her cell phone to her ear in the process. I recognize her from a few of the pre-rush events—I think her name is Anne, or Anna.

Being honest, I strongly considered joining her for a second. I'm not too keen on making this jump either. Instead, I watch as the girl disappears behind the crowd of cheering members.

My chance to back out has passed.

The roar of the crowd starts to muffle in my ears as I narrow my focus onto the lake below. The drop is easily fifty feet long—there's no question about it. It's dark outside, but the moon is casting enough light upon the water to show that there are no large rocks in the area we are jumping in, so at least I can find comfort in that.

"Let's go first," Alison whispers at my side. "It'll make us stand out."

As shocked as I am about Alison's lack of fear in this situation, I know that she's probably right. We're going to have to jump either way, so it would be better to get it over with.

"Okay," I gulp. "I guess so."

The two of us take a step closer toward the ledge, which feels more like a one-hundred foot drop now that I'm looking straight down at it. Just before the knot in my stomach can worsen, I feel Alison's hand enclosing around mine.

She turns to me. "On three?"

I nod nervously, then turn back to face the lake. Before I have the time to second-guess my decision, Alison begins to count down warily.

"One..."

My heart pounds faster with each passing second, and my ability to feel my hands and legs quickly begins to fade away.

"Two..."

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Three.

On the third count, Alison and I barrel forward and propel ourselves off of the fifty-foot cliff.

I hear the screams of the crowd fading away as we drop further and further towards the water. The fall seems to last forever, and I'm able to fully take in the image of the deep blue surface sparkling from the moonlight as my feet rapidly approach it.

Just as the feeling of floating takes over me, my body plunges into the cold, dark water.

I sink deep down into the lake—feeling the water grow colder upon my skin the further I become submerged. After a moment, the force behind the fall fades away, and I'm able to paddle my way back up towards the distorted image of the moon that I can see through the surface. Right when my breath begins to run out, my head breaks through the water, and I feel a rush of air filling my lungs.

I'm alive.

A splash comes from behind me, followed by a loud gasp for air. It sounds like Alison survived too.

"Holy shit," she says, still out of breath from our time underwater.

Still gasping for air, I manage a response as I tread the water. "I can't believe we just did that."

From above, the crowd of Alphas loudly cheer for the two of us as the rest of the pledges stare downward in fear. I can't make out Imani or Maeve from down here, but I'm sure they're up there preparing for the fall.

Alison points to the tall, man-made staircase that will bring us back up to the remainder of the group, so the two of us begin quickly doggy-paddling towards it. As we swim, the sounds of loud splashes can be heard, accompanied by the cheering of the crowd, so I can assume that the rest of the group has followed our lead and jumped off behind us. After a few minutes, my feet finally graze the murky bottom of the lake, and I am able to walk the rest of the way out.

I feel like kissing the ground when I finally pull myself up onto land, but I refrain. We each take a few seconds to shake the water out of our sleep clothing, which is completely soaked now.

I would have worn a bikini to bed if I had known I'd be going late-night cliff-diving.

After drying off as best as we can, we begin to trudge our way up the staircase in our bare feet. I kicked my slippers off before taking the jump—I didn't think they'd survive the fall—but now I'm wishing I had some kind of footwear on. The stairs are a mixture of broken concrete and sharp gravel, and the sharpness digs into the soles of my feet as I take each step.

Eventually, Alison and I limp our way to the top and rejoin the group.

"I wonder what the surprise is," I say to Alison.

Before we made the leap, Juliette mentioned that there would be a surprise waiting for us when we arrived back. Given the fact that our last "surprise" was being told to hurdle ourselves off a cliff, thinking of what the next one might be makes me anxious.

Alison nods in agreement. "I'm scared to find out."

We make our way over to the group of girls, who are cheering loudly for the two of us. It looks like Alison was right—being the first people to jump definitely made a good impression on the Alpha Omegas.

Scanning the crowd once again, I still can't locate any familiar faces. Summer is nowhere to be found, and I don't see Kimberly or Ashley either. I can't help but wonder where they might be, and why they would have missed out on a chance to see us jump off of a cliff.

When we finally push through the crowd to where Juliette is standing, she embraces the both of us in a big hug and squeals.

"I knew I was going to like you two," she says. "The first ones to make the jump normally go the farthest in this chapter. I was the first in my class to do it."

"So everyone has to jump when they first join?" I ask. I suppose I had just assumed that we had been the first people to do it.

She smiles proudly. "Yep—we call it the *Leap of Faith*. Fun, right?"

Fun isn't the word that comes to mind for me, but I'm glad Juliette was able to find excitement in a near-death experience. Maybe her and Alison should be friends.

"I loved it," Alison pipes in. "I'd do it again."

She can count me out of that.

“So, “ I begin. "What's the surprise?"

“I thought you’d never ask.” Juliette grins at my question, then motions ahead of herself. “Look behind you.”

I turn around towards the crowd, only to see that a space has now cleared, and Summer and Kimberly are now standing directly behind us. Within each of their arms lies a pink T-shirt—which I immediately recognize as the stitched-letter ΑΩ shirts that I’ve seen several of the older members wearing.

“You two have serious balls, jumping off first like that,” Kimberly exclaims. “You’ve definitely earned these.”

On her word, the two of them hand Alison and I our brand-new lettered shirts. I unfold mine, discovering an extra stitch below the Greek letters reading *PC 2024*. I couldn’t love this shirt more.

“And...” Summer reaches into her tote bag, grabbing out a small golden pin and handing it to me. “Your ticket to freedom for the next five days.”

“What do you mean?”

Kimberly and Summer exchange a look and laugh.

“Every year, the first person to jump off—or the first two, in this case—wins the Leap of Faith Award,” Kimberly explains. “Whoever has the award gets to skip out on all Hell Week activities until Saturday—the final test.”

Summer chimes in. “So *do not* lose them.”

I look over at Alison’s palm, which is holding an identical pin to the one in my hand. Taking a closer look at my own, I notice that they are actually quite beautiful. They’re made of a shiny gold material, and the design consists of small pink and white jewels outlining a diamond symbol traced upon the metallic plate. It looks expensive, so I really wasn’t planning on losing it anyways.

“We won’t,” I reply. “And thanks for the shirts—I love mine.”

The two of them usher Alison and I over to Summer’s car, and all of us begin to drive back towards campus.

For the first time tonight I notice that I don’t have my phone, nor can I remember the last time I used it. Since I’m assuming I’ll be able to find it back at the dorm, I decide to join the conversation instead of searching for it.

Kimberly is mid-sentence when I tune in.

“—got so much water up my nose. I’d never even jumped off a diving board before, so I didn’t know what to expect.” Summer laughs. “I jumped off wearing my flip-flops, and they completely fell apart on impact. Walking up those concrete steps with no shoes on was one of the worst experiences of my life.”

“Since we jumped first, nobody warned us about the steps,” Alison pipes in. “The gravel made it feel like I was walking on nails.”

Kimberly shakes her head. “I still can’t believe you went first.”

A thought suddenly pops into my mind, and I decide to vocalize it.

“Who jumped off first when your pledge class did it?”

At my words, Summer and Kimberly exchange a quick look in the front seat, followed by a few moments of silence. Alison and I awkwardly shift in the backseat as I mentally scold myself for asking the question.

Although their silence told me everything I needed to know, Summer eventually speaks up.

“It was two girls, actually—a lot like you guys,” she says. “Caroline Rowe and Riley Walker.”

At this reveal, I feel a pang of sadness.

Since I arrived a week ago, I have already found several similarities between myself and the missing girls—especially Riley Walker. My friendship with Summer, Alpha Omega, Room 433... the list goes on. The more I learn about the two girls, the more personal this investigation becomes to me. Riley and Caroline weren’t so different from Alison and I, and it hurts that they haven’t received justice for whatever may have happened to them.

I lock eyes with Summer in the rear-view mirror—stammering as I try to come up with a response.

“I’m sorry...I...didn’t mean to bring them up.”

Through the mirror, she forces a smile at me before resting her face in an upset position. Kimberly is awkwardly silent in the passenger seat, and Alison raises her eyebrows at me to acknowledge the discomfort of the situation. After an extended period of silence, Kimberly reaches over and cranks up the volume of the music, so the mood is thankfully fixed for the rest of the ride.

When we finally pull into the Norman Hall parking lot, we say our goodbyes to the two of them before walking up to our room. I’m desperately in need of a shower after my midnight rendezvous with the

lake, so I feel an immense sense of relief as I turn the key into the lock of our dorm door at nearly 3:00 in the morning. Just as we're stepping in, Alison pipes up.

"What was all that about in the car?" she asks suspiciously. "Summer was acting so weird towards you."

I sometimes forget that Alison probably isn't familiar with the case. Or at least—she's *definitely* not as familiar as I am.

"She was good friends with those girls," I begin. "They went missing last year. Their car was found at a train station outside of town, and they were never seen again."

She sucks in through her teeth. "I didn't know she was friends with them. I've heard a few of the older girls talking about that case...didn't the boyfriend do it or something?"

"Maybe," I reply. "They never found any bodies, so nobody could be charged with murder."

At that moment, Alison says something unexpected.

"I know it's wrong to speak ill of the dead, but..."

She hesitates for a moment.

"I heard they were real bitches, you know."

I'm taken aback by her comment for a moment. "Who told you that?"

A slight image of concern creeps across her face. "Kimberly. She said that half the members of the chapter were being blackmailed or harassed by the girls before they went missing. Even Summer, apparently."

The other night, Nathan had repeated the familiar sentiment that the two girls were known for their extortive ways—even when it came to their own friends. I had wondered if Summer had been targeted in any way, but now I know for sure.

"What did they do to Summer?" I ask.

Alison grabs a t-shirt from her closet and changes into it as she speaks.

"She didn't know many of the details, but apparently the three of them had a huge falling out a month before they went missing. It was Riley and Caroline against Summer, and apparently it got really messy. I guess they were all starting to make up and be friends again, but then they disappeared."

Suddenly, Summer's demeanor each the girls are brought up makes a lot more sense to me. She probably feels an immense amount of guilt for feuding with her friends during what was likely the last month of their lives.

“That’s not all though,” Alison cuts in. She shifts her stance, as if she is nervous to tell me something. “Kimberly mentioned that some of the girls think—well...”

“They think...?” I prod.

She clears her throat before speaking. “You can’t tell anyone I told you this, but you know the ex-boyfriend? Noah something?”

I nod.

“Well, according to everyone, his alibi on the night of their disappearance was sleeping with another girl. Kimberly and a few of the other girls said that Noah stayed over with *Summer* that night, and that the two of them had been hooking up while he was still with Caroline.” Alison shrugs. “Maybe that’s what caused the falling out.”

I try to stifle my expression, but I’m completely shocked by this information.

When I was in Summer’s room on the night of the cocktail party, she insisted on Noah’s innocence and validated his mysterious alibi, but I hadn’t gotten the feeling that she was hiding anything from me at the time. She did seem a little bit off when she was talking about the girls, but I had chalked it up to her just being upset about the disappearance of her friends.

“I had no idea,” I gasp, shaking my head with surprise. Up until this moment I’ve trusted Summer, but now I’m not sure what to think.

Alison turns to her room again, turning off the living room light in the process. “I know you and her get along really well, but just be careful. If she can sleep with a dead girl’s boyfriend, who knows what else she’s capable of...”

She wishes me a good night before shutting her door.

I take a moment to reel from tonight’s new findings once I have a moment to myself. I have so many questions, and I’m not sure who I can even ask them to. It’s not like I can trust too many people with my investigation, and most of my friends are already close with Summer. Asking the wrong person could be detrimental to my reputation.

Instead, I choose to jot my questions down in my investigative notebook.

Who else was being blackmailed?

Did Summer really sleep with Noah that night?

My pen hovers above the page before I write my final question

Can I trust Summer?

16

Riley Walker

AUGUST 2023

(Three Months Before)

At last year's End-of-Summer Cocktail, two people were arrested.

I was a freshman at the time, and Summer and I had scored an invite to the party as Potential New Members while we were eating at the dining hall. A few other girls had been invited throughout the week, so about ten other potential members were at the party that night.

At some point, one of the freshman girls who had been asked to attend had one-too-many, grabbed the first half-attractive Theta Mu she could find, and hooked up with him behind the garage of the AO house. The police had already been dispatched for a noise complaint, and they coincidentally parked directly in front of the garage when they arrived—coming face to face with two half-naked college kids. They were caught like deer in the headlights—literally—and both of them received Public Indecency and Public Intoxication misdemeanors.

Ever since then, I always laugh when I pass the couples making out alongside the house.

When we make it to the entryway, I quickly separate from Caroline and Noah to go and find Summer, who I eventually locate in the backyard. She's chatting with a group of girls in our pledge class when I approach, and she engulfs me in a large hug as soon as she sees me.

"Finally!" she cheers.

"Sorry," I say. "Noah took forever to pick us up."

She rolls her eyes, but I catch the flash of a smirk across her face.

"What?" I ask.

"Nothing...but also, Jake Morton is staring at you."

Summer gestures towards a group of guys huddled near the bar area, where Jake is, in fact, staring at me.

Without a second thought, I grab her wrist, then yank her across the yard and into the kitchen. There is absolutely no chance I'm having a conversation with him right now.

"Chill out Riles," she says with widened eyes. "You can't go psycho in front of the PNM's."

That's a good point, actually.

"Sorry," I reply. "Caroline has been playing Cupid a little bit extra this week. I think they're plotting something."

Summer laughs. "She just won't give that a rest, will she?"

We both laugh, then the two of us grab drinks and head into the main area to catch up with the people we haven't seen all summer.



After nearly an hour has passed, I notice that I haven't seen Caroline since I arrived. I've spotted Noah a couple of times, but she hasn't been with him, so she must be off somewhere on her own.

That makes me nervous.

Just as I begin to internally pray that she isn't off harassing somebody, I spot Gracie Franklin—an Alpha Omega in the pledge class above ours—hastily walking across the room with tears in her eyes.

Looks like I'm too late.

I race down from the second floor balcony, moving towards the hallway that Gracie just came from. I have a gut feeling that Caroline is the one who caused those tears—she's always seemed to have it out for Gracie for no particular reason.

Once I pass through the first floor door that leads to the residential hallway, there are four different bedrooms that I can potentially enter. Thankfully, I get lucky with the second room, which belongs to a girl in our pledge class.

Caroline is fixing her lipstick in the mirror when I walk in, looking quite pleased with herself.

"Hey Riles," she says casually. "How's the party?"

I ignore her question. "What happened to Gracie?"

She laughs. "Why? Was she still crying when she left?"

She seems completely unperturbed by this possibility.

"Seriously," I say. "Whatever you did really upset her."

Caroline looks surprised by my concern about the situation, but returns to adjusting her makeup as she speaks.

“Let’s just say a little birdie told me that Gracie was turning pills, and they told me where to find her stash,” she says. “We were able to work out a little arrangement, though. She’s going to give me 75% of her sales, or else Eleanor is going to find out about her little business.”

“Caroline!” I snap.

She throws her hands up in defense. “It’s not my fault that she wanted to turn the AO mansion into a *trap house*. I’m just looking out for the chapter, really.”

“Did you say anything else to her?” I press.

A taunting smile creeps across her face.

“I might’ve called her a cracked-out junkie too...I couldn’t help myself.”

If I hadn’t seen the good side in her over the past year, I would think that my best friend is an absolute monster. Gracie has never done anything wrong to anyone, yet Caroline felt the need to cook up a blackmail scheme against her on a random night when we all should have been enjoying the party.

“Holy shit, Caroline,” I gasp. “She didn’t do anything to deserve that.”

She leans closer to the mirror to add a final layer of lip gloss.

“Gracie isn’t as innocent as she seems. What if someone had overdosed on the pills she’s pushing?” Caroline sneers. “I’m just looking out for her, really.”

As if she actually cares about that.

I scoff.

“Whatever.”

Without another word, I push my way out of the room despite Caroline calling for me to come back.

I’m going to find Gracie and apologize—I can’t keep getting blamed by association anymore. I’m not sure where to find her, but I’m 90% sure that she lives on the third floor. I passed her in the hallway when I was going to find Summer’s room once.

After walking three flights of stairs in my five-inch heels—which would’ve been much more grueling if I wasn’t intoxicated—I’m looking around the rooms on the third floor for Gracie. Eventually, I land on a room

where I can hear audible sobbing, so I lightly tap on the door before walking in.

Gracie hides her face upon my entry in an attempt to conceal her tears.

“Riley?” she asks, her eyebrows lifting. “What do *you* want?”

The anger in her voice is clear, but I push forward anyways.

“I’m sorry, Gracie,” I say softly. “I had nothing to do with any of that.”

She scoots further away from me and picks up her phone to ignore what I’m saying.

“I just wanted to tell you,” I continue, though it’s evident she isn’t listening to me. “I’ll get that money back to you. All of it.”

This gets her attention.

She looks confused at my statement. “How?”

Even though my dad left us, and my mom is an unsuitable parent, I’m fortunate enough to have been born into quite a family fortune that has more than supported me through college so far. I’m assuming that 75% of Gracie’s pill-popping proceeds can’t be a super high number, and I’m happy to pay her off in order to make reparations for my friend's behavior.

“Don’t worry about it,” I say. “Just let me know how much each week, and I’ll get it to you.”

Though she previously seemed convinced, her face returns to a frown.

“I’m not falling for this, Riley,” she snaps. “If Caroline put you up to this, you can tell her to just go to he—“

“She didn’t,” I cut in. “But if you want the money, you can’t tell anyone about this. If Caroline finds out, she’ll kill me. Like, actually.”

Gracie considers my words for a moment—clearly still hesitant to accept my olive branch. Eventually, she reaches for her phone and begins typing a series of numbers into the calculator app. After a few seconds, she turns back towards me with a defeated look.

“That would be almost \$200 per week, depending on sales. There’s no way you can afford that.”

Damn I think to myself. Who knew drug dealing m could be such a high source of income for a college student?

Still, a few hundred dollars isn’t above my price range.

“Done,” I say promptly.

She is taken by surprise at my immediate agreement.

“Why would you want to help me, Riley?” she asks, her voice barely above a whisper. “You don’t even like me.”

I'm not sure how to answer her question.

The truth is, I don't know why I want to help Gracie. She's never done anything bad to me, but she's never done anything nice for me either. We're not even friends.

As of lately, though, I've grown tired of making so many enemies throughout the school, and I've instead felt a burning urge to help out as many of Caroline's victims as I can. I participated in my fair share of blackmailing and extortion last year, but I've no longer been finding any joy in this behavior—unlike Caroline.

It's time to make my reparations, before karma comes back around.

"Let's just say I'm turning over a new page in life."

I paste a smile on my face that I can only hope looks sincere. I'm happy to fund Gracie's drug-dealing business if I have to, but it would be nice if Caroline hadn't started this mess in the first place.



When the party is nearing an end, Caroline and Noah track me down in the living room to let me know that we're leaving soon. At that moment, I realize I haven't seen Mystery Man at all throughout the party—though I remember him mentioning that he would be here.

Still, instead of searching for him, I go to find Summer to say goodbye before we head out.

Once we're all back in the car, I don't make an attempt to be nice to Caroline again—even though I've worked out a deal with Gracie, and all is mostly well with the world again. The three of us make it all the way back to our room Norman Hall before she pulls me into the bathroom to talk.

"Look, Riley, I can tell that you're mad," she sighs. "I don't know what's up with you lately, but you never want to help me out with our little projects anymore. You can't go soft on me now."

I stare to the side for a second before answering.

"Nothing is up with me. I'd just rather do bad things to people who *actually* deserve it, you know?"

"Like I said, she's not as innocent as she looks," Caroline sneers. "But fine—you can choose our next target, then. Make it a good one, though."

On that note, she bids me goodnight and returns back to her room, where Noah is waiting for her.

Since I'm already in the bathroom, I decide to go ahead and shower off in order to prepare for bed. Just as I finish rinsing out my conditioner—the final step of my extensive nightly routine—I hear my text ringtone go off from the bathroom counter.

I throw on my robe and place my hair into a towel before checking the notification.

3:11 AM

COULDN'T MAKE IT TONIGHT. CAN I COME SEE YOU?

It's past three o'clock in the morning, and if I didn't know any better I would think that Mystery Man is booty-calling me. But he wouldn't do that—I'm sure of it. For once, I've actually found a decent guy for myself.

I quickly type a response back.

3:12 AM

TEXT ME WHEN YOU'RE HERE.

When he finally arrives at the front door of Norman, he appears noticeably disheveled and exhausted. I can't put my finger on it, but something is off with him. It's written all over his face.

"Are you okay?" I ask, stroking my hand across his face as soon as we're sitting in my bedroom.

The sound of my voice seems to agitate him for a moment, but he eventually answers in a short tone. "I'm fine."

"Why couldn't you make it tonight?" I ask him. "You didn't miss much, but still—I wish you had been there."

His eyes dart around the room, still avoiding my gaze.

"I just wasn't feeling good," he says. "That's it."

I've only been seeing this man for about a week, but I know him well enough to know that this behavior is unusual. Something is up with him, I just have no idea what it could possibly be.

If I were crazy, I would think he was strung out.

After a few moments of sitting in silence with one another, he suddenly gets up and starts putting on his shoes.

"Sorry, Riley," he begins, the exhaustion clear in his voice. "I don't feel up to anything tonight...I think I need to go home. I didn't mean to waste your time."

This whole interaction has been nothing but strange, but I'm not mad that he's leaving. He's acting too weird, and I want nothing to do with it.

Tonight has already been long enough.

"It's fine," I snip. "I'm getting ready to go to bed anyways."

I walk with him over to my room door to say goodbye, and the two of us share a quick kiss.

Before turning the handle, he turns to me one last time—something familiar, finally, in the way he looks at me.

"I'm sorry again," he says. "I'll make it up to you this week."

He takes a step out the door. "Goodnight, Riley."

I flash a tight smile at him. "Goodnight, Nathan."

17

LEIGHTON

2024

Following Monday's revelations, I've decided to reevaluate the list of people that I can trust.

Surprisingly, Nathan ended up at the top of my list—other than Alison of course. Though I trust her the most, I'm still not quite ready to let her in on my investigation, and I needed a fresh mind to run my new discoveries across. Nathan also has an inside perspective that can really come in handy.

I texted him early in the week asking to meet at some point, and he suggested a light lunch at a café right off campus on Friday afternoon.

Now, it is 2:00 p.m. on the decided Friday, and I have just slipped into a corner booth in Nathan's restaurant of choice. He already let me know that he was running a few minutes late, so I went ahead and ordered a salad for myself at the counter.

After a few minutes pass, I see his familiar tall figure ducking into the entryway. He steps in my direction as soon as our eyes meet—soon setting his keys down at our booth before placing his order.

As soon as he's seated, I give him the rundown of everything that Alison told me as we wait for our orders to arrive—especially the part about Noah and Summer.

"I remember that, actually," Nathan remarks after I finish speaking. "Noah was in my pledge class, so we lived in the house together. I remember some of the brothers asking him about it, but he never let up anything."

"Were you friends with him?"

He shakes his head. "Not really. He was a rich kid, and he mainly hung out with a group of our brothers that were from his hometown. I never

really got to know him very well.”

I wonder to myself for a moment. “What even brought him and Caroline together in the first place?”

Nathan laughs, and I feel as if I’m missing something.

“His wallet, probably,” he soon answers. “Everyone knows that she wanted him for his money, but the poor bastard actually really loved her.”

If Noah really loved Caroline, why would he cheat on her with Summer—or anyone for that matter? Especially with one of her closest friends?

The further I look into this case, the more questions I have.

“I don’t know how to find out the truth about Noah and Summer,” I say, returning to my original point. “I can’t just ask her, and I don’t even know who I can really trust in the chapter.”

Nathan ponders my statement for a moment, then chimes in.

“Tanner.”

“Tanner?” I tilt my head.

“Not in your chapter, but my own. You’ve met him. He was working the bar at the End of Summer Cocktail,” he says. “He’s Noah’s Little and childhood friend, and they’re still in touch—even after everything. If anyone’s gonna know the truth, it’ll be him.”

My mind flashes back to last weekend at the cocktail party, where Summer introduced me to a Theta Mu named Tanner who was working as a bar boy. I talked to him a few times throughout the night, but I barely got to know him. I doubt he would be willing to share personal secrets about his friends with someone he’s spoken to twice.

“Could you talk to him for me?” I suggest. “You know him better than I do, and this is personal information. I think he’d be more likely to clue *you* in.”

Nathan grins, as if he’s excited to help me with my investigation.

“I’m on it.”

As we wrap up our conversation, the waitress brings our food to the table, and we go the rest of our lunch without discussing the case.

18

After skipping out on a full week of Hell Week festivities, it's finally time to face the music.

Tonight is Alpha Omega Hell Night.

Each year, the initiated sisters of the chapter come up with a detailed night of activities that test the mental, physical, and emotional capabilities of each incoming pledge. There's no doubt that we'll all be forced to participate in some type of humiliating ritual, and I've been dreading this moment for a week.

Our report time is 8:00 tonight, and a little birdie told us that we will be awake and moving for the next twelve hours straight. By a little birdie, I mean every older member of Alpha Omega that's been through Hell Week once before.

Alison and I have spent our Saturday evening mentally preparing for the rough night ahead of us—drinking a glass of wine and watching old rom-com movies on the couch. Neither of us know what's in store for tonight, but getting buzzed off of top-shelf Red is helping to ease our nerves.

If I'm lucky, I'll still be a little bit drunk whenever we arrive at the AO house in thirty minutes.

The time quickly passes, and before I know it, we are walking towards Greek Village—in casual attire for a change. We didn't exactly know how to dress for a night of the unknown, so I figured a T-shirt would be suitable.

Alison looks over to me. "Are you nervous?"

"Just ready to get it over with," I mumble.

I solely joined this sorority in hopes of getting further in my investigation, so playing the part of a pledge hasn't been easy. I'll admit, the cliff-jumping trip gave me a bit of a rush—but I would've been just as happy to leave the thrill-seeking behind after that.

Escaping my train of thought, I turn back over to Alison.

“What do you think we’ll have to do this time?”

“Snort a line of coke,” she jokes. “Or maybe run naked across campus.”

I sneer in response, hoping that there’s no truth to what she’s said.

“Really though,” she begins. “Kimberly was pretty tight-lipped about tonight, but she mentioned having to chug an entire bottle of Svedka when she first joined. I wouldn’t be surprised if that’s how the night starts out.”

Great. Alcohol poisoning.

When I chose to attend Cabot, I never imagined being forced to consume mass amounts of liquor in the basement of a multi-million dollar mansion. Then again, college is all about new experiences.

“Thrilling,” I say through a forced grin.

When we reach the front yard of the Alpha Omega house, we are quickly able to locate Imani and Maeve, who are sitting with a group of girls near the fountain. Imani quickly locks eyes with us before waving us over to her location.

“How about that jump the other night?” Imani lightly applauds us as we approach the group. “I couldn’t find you guys to tell you, but seriously—that was impressive.”

Maeve chimes in. “I couldn’t believe it. We heard you both got a free pass on Hell Week too...be thankful for that.”

The group of girls nods in agreement at her statement, which reminds me how grateful I am for having missed out on this week’s activities. Tonight is already going to be bad enough.

“Was it that bad?” Alison sucks in through her teeth.

Imani shakes her head. “Don’t even ask.”

Just as I’m about to ask for more details, the front door of the house pops open, and two robed figures emerge from the entryway. One of them is Juliette—I can tell from the perfect blonde hair falling from the robe’s hood—but I can’t identify the other. Their robes make them look like 17th-century sorcerers, and I have to stifle a laugh.

The waiting crowd goes silent, and all of us begin to observe the display upon the porch. Juliette and her partner linger for a moment, staring at the group of our pledge class members that are scattered throughout the yard. After an extended period of silently watching us, she finally speaks in a low, creepy tone.

“Your fate awaits you inside,” she says. “Happy Hell Night, girls.”



The first hour of our night consists of playing multiple drinking games of which I’ve never heard. By the time we have chugged our final drink, I’m fairly inebriated, and I never want to hear the song Thunderstruck by AC/DC again.

On one hand, the alcohol is completely clouding my ability to think, and I feel defenseless against whatever task they give us next. On the other hand, the vodka and hawaiian punch combo that is beginning to settle in my stomach is the only thing steadying my nerves, so I’m not too mad about the drinking games.

Alison, Maeve, Imani, and I are standing in a group in the corner, while the other ten-or-so girls are grouped up throughout the space. The older members—like Summer and Juliette—left us alone a little more than ten minutes ago, explaining that they would come back when it was time for our *next task*.

“I’m kind of nervous to find out what we’re doing tonight,” Imani begins. “Ashley told us they have something different planned this year.”

“What do they normally do?” Alison inquires, seemingly more sober than the rest of us.

Summer and I haven’t had a chance to talk much about Hell Week-related activities, so I’m kind of in the dark compared to the others.

“When she was a freshman, they all had to steal road signs and traffic lights,” Maeve tells us. “Anyone who was caught by campus police got kicked out immediately after.”

I hope we don’t have to do that.

My nerves are getting the best of me, even with the alcohol in my system, so I attempt to make a joke.

“Maybe they’ll lock us in the basement all night or something.”

Though it was a joke, the three of them seem pretty concerned about this prospect, so I quickly give up on trying to pitch into the conversation.

A few minutes later, Juliette and a few other sisters return to where we are grouped—now each holding a bandana in their hand. It’s pretty obvious that our next task involves being blindfolded, so I’m just hoping it doesn’t include jumping off any more surfaces.

Juliette orders us all to line up, and we are all quickly blindfolded from behind. Our group is then led across the room, where I can hear the sound of a door swinging open and creaking stairs.

Despite my vision being obstructed, the combination of sounds tells me that my joke has unfortunately come true.

We're going to be locked in the basement.

After blindly navigating about twenty wooden steps, I finally feel the solid pavement beneath my feet. We must have reached the cold basement floor.

The stairs soon stop creaking with movement, and Juliette begins to speak in a quiet voice.

"For the next four hours of Hell Night, you all must stay in the basement and bond with your new sisters," she says. "Nobody can leave for any reason— barring immediate illness or death. Any questions?"

Our group remains silent.

"Perfect," she continues. "You may now take your blindfolds off."

I don't hesitate to remove my bandana, which is uncomfortably wrapped around my eyes. I've developed an even stronger respect for the blind tonight, because walking down the stairs without the use of my sight was absolutely terrifying.

As Juliette and the other sisters walk up the stairs, she turns to speak to us one last time.

"Oh—and I almost forgot." Juliette smiles scarily. "You'll be completely in the dark for the remainder of this task."

As soon as the words leave her mouth, she reaches over and flips the light switch, plunging the basement into immediate darkness as she jumps out the door. I hear the familiar sound of a lock turning from the top of the stairs and know that our fate is sealed for the next few hours.

The locking noise sends one of the girls into a panic, but another unfamiliar girl thankfully moves her to another area to console her. As I'm attempting to feel my way around, I hear a familiar voice from behind my shoulder, which I quickly recognize as Alison's.

"Leighton?"

"Over here, Ali," I say.

Her hand soon wraps around my wrist, and I pull us over to the stairs so that we can take a seat. We summon Maeve and Imani to our location

through a glorified game of Marco-Polo, and a few other girls come over to our area as well.

Since we can't see one another, we go around in a circle stating our names. As each of the twenty girls introduces themselves, I catch the first names of a few of the unfamiliar people that I've been seeing the past few weeks. Some of them even seem really nice.

Eventually, the conversation segues from introductions to campus horror stories we've learned about Cabot thus far.

"I read a news article about how, in 2019, the Alpha Omega president got arrested after one of their hazing activities went way too far," one of the unfamiliar girls tells the group. "They told a new member that she had to swim fifty laps in the school's swimming pool at midnight—but she tired out halfway through and went unconscious in the water. One of the overnight janitors found her just in time, but she was in the hospital for a week."

Another voice pitches in. "I heard that too. Apparently the president at the time got expelled from Cabot."

Maybe that's why our "Hell Night" seems so tame comparatively. Alpha Omega has clearly faced their fair share of legal difficulties over the past five years, and I doubt they're actively looking for more.

Then again, being locked in a dark basement probably isn't the best experience for some people.

I hear Alison's voice to the right of me.

"Has everyone heard about the two girls that went missing last year? They were in Alpha Omega, apparently."

Most of the girls appear to be familiar with the case, with only a few voices uttering confused remarks through the darkness. Considering how successful Cabot has been in media-cleansing their involvement with the case, I'm surprised that so many of them even know about Riley and Caroline.

To aid the confusion of those who are unfamiliar with their disappearance, Alison and I go back and forth relaying the public details of the case to the group, with a few other girls pitching in to fill in the holes that we've missed. At the end of our recap, one of the girls who has previously been silent the whole time speaks up quietly.

"My dad is one of the Brookwood Police officers who worked on the case, and he told me about one of the theories that was proposed within the

department,” she says shyly. “A few of the cops think that one of the girls killed the other and ran off—even though there’s no proof. They mainly focused on Riley, since she was the one driving that night.”

Maeve seems completely convinced by this theory, because I can hear her inhaling sharply beside me.

“But why would she do that?” Maeve asks. “Weren’t they friends?”

“More like why *wouldn’t* she do that,” Alison snorts.

Even though Alison never met Riley or Caroline, she has seemingly already made her mind up about them being terrible people—even though she never even met either of the girls. I’m not so easily convinced. There’s always more to the story than people are aware of.

Imani pipes up. “Not to be disrespectful, but I’ve heard awful things about them. Mainly Caroline, but Riley didn’t seem innocent either.”

“Everyone that knew them before they disappeared has said that they deserved what happened to them.” An unfamiliar voice is speaking this time. “I’m not sure what they did, but it must’ve been pretty bad.”

It feels like everyone around me constantly crucifies Riley and Caroline’s behavior, even though they aren’t around to defend themselves. It feels wrong to jump to conclusions about them—even despite all of the things I’ve learned about their past.

I’m still convinced that someone else hurt the girls. Maybe a friend—maybe an enemy. Whoever it was has done a damn good job of hiding the truth for nearly a year. In any case, someone has to defend them.

“Summer knew them, and she always loved them.”

I speak loudly and proudly, though Alison jabs my arm from beside me. My statement seems to render people uncomfortable about the topic, so the conversation quickly shifts back to other stories they’ve heard about the university. As the hours tick by, I pitch a few reassuring words into the conversation to seem like I’m engaged, but I mainly spend the time thinking about the next steps in my investigation.

If I had a little bit more information about Riley and Caroline’s blackmailing habits, I could identify a few more possible suspects to focus on. Since I can’t go directly to the source, I need to ask someone who was close with the girls before their disappearance.

I think it’s time to finally bite the bullet and ask Summer some deeper questions about her friends.

Once Hell Night is over, it’s the first thing on my list.

19

Riley Walker

SEPTEMBER 2023

(Three Months Before)

Nearly three weeks have passed since the End-of Summer party, and I haven't seen or heard from Nathan since.

He was acting unusual the last time I saw him—the night he came over to Norman Hall—but I couldn't quite tell what was wrong with him. Whatever it was must have been serious, because he has ignored all of my text messages and calls ever since.

I'm not one to make a fool of myself over a guy, so I gave up on contacting him after a few days. I'm beginning to re-think my prior assumption that Nathan is such a great guy anyways.

Outside of Nathan ghosting me, life has been pretty standard. My arrangement with Gracie has been working out well so far, and some weeks are less expensive than others.

The important thing is that Caroline has no idea that I've been pulling the strings on her blackmail scheme, and she hasn't come close to finding out. As she brags to me about this week's proceeds while we eat lunch, I have to stifle my laugh.

"That's great, Caroline." I fake an enthusiastic smile to avoid suspicion. She throws a skeptical glance at me, but continues the conversation.

"Anyways," she says. "How are your classes going?"

Finally—a morally acceptable topic.

"Good so far," I reply. "My gen-eds are easy, but my focus classes are getting more advanced. Nothing I can't handle though."

"I feel you," Caroline replies with a sigh. "My teachers have been loading me with homework already. I chose an easy major for a reason—you know? I'm not sure when International Business became the new rocket science."

Though the Bradshaw School of Criminal Justice is Cabot's most esteemed program, the Darcy College of Business is a close runner-up. I am a Criminal Justice major, and Caroline is pursuing International Business, so we both are taught by the best-of-the-best professors from around the country. Unfortunately for us, that means being constantly slammed with assignments and projects.

Nonetheless, neither of our semesterly GPAs have dropped below a 3.5 so far, so I can't say it isn't manageable.

As we finish eating, a few notifications sound off from my phone—each one turning my head. It's pathetic, but every time I glance at the screen, I'm hoping that it's Nathan.

It never is.

"You've been jumping at every notification for the past hour," Caroline notes. "What's up with you?"

"Nothing," I shoo her off. "It's stupid."

She leans back in her chair as she sips a Diet Coke.

"I've heard worse. Let's hear it."

The last thing I want to do is tell Caroline about my failed relationship venture, but I know better than to think that she's going to let up on the subject. I bite my pride, then hit her with a vague response.

"There was this one guy that I liked, but I think it was over before it even really started."

I'm internally praying that she won't ask for his name. This would all be much less embarrassing for me if it was a complete stranger, but she will definitely know a member of Theta Mu.

Caroline sips her drink slowly, clearly waiting for more details.

"So," she says. "Who is he?"

Great.

I flip my sunglasses on, attempting to shield my face from her reaction.

"It's Nathan," I whisper. "Nathan Murphy."

She nearly chokes on her drink when the words leave my mouth. After a short coughing fit, she locks eyes with me.

"You better be joking."

"You don't even know him," I snap. She constantly criticizes my choices in men, and I won't take it from her this time. "He's actually really nice."

“Know him?” Caroline laughs. “He’s funding half of my weekly allowance.”

I’m not sure what she means by that, so I don’t know how to respond.

“What are you talking about?” I ask.

Caroline shakes her head, “Riley, Nathan is Gracie’s largest buyer. He pops more pills than Jesse Pinkman.”

She reaches over to grab my hand.

“He’s a drug addict, Riles.”

There it is.

The reason behind Nathan’s strange behavior the last time I saw him, and for his inability to show up at any social events in the past few weeks. He’s been strung out on pills, and I haven’t even noticed.

“I had no clue,” I choke out. “He seemed so nice.”

“He used to be,” Caroline says in a much more collected tone.

“Apparently the pressure of his classes got to him, and he started banking on prescription pills a little bit too much.”

She sips her drink again, stirs it with her finger and sets it down.

“Maybe you could fix him, though.”

She continues talking, but I’m no longer processing anything she says. My mind is darting all over the place, and I can’t wrap my head around anything she’s just told me.

Other than the one encounter, Nathan was nothing but wonderful when we spent time together. Not once did I get the feeling that he was high on anything other than locker room fumes...or maybe alcohol.

I can’t believe this.

Caroline cuts in as my mind continues to race.

“You know,” she says suggestively. “I’m sure Nathan wouldn’t want too many people finding out about his little secret...”

“Caroline,” I huff. “We are *not* going to blackmail him.”

She throws her head back and rolls her eyes.

“Fine,” she sighs. “But I’m adding him to the Hot Sheet anyway. You might change your mind eventually.”

She pulls a familiar Index card from her bag and begins to scribble Nathan’s initials—writing the word *addict* beside it in large bold lettering.

Caroline and I created the Hot Sheet freshman year—right when the two of us first began blackmailing our fellow students. Each time we found dirt on someone, we would add their initials to the card instead of their

name, in case anyone ever found it, and would list their secret beside the initials. We would fill up a card every few months and switch to a new one, each time filling the sheet with hot information about our peers. Once one of our blackmailing schemes had dried up, we'd move on to extorting the next person on our list—sometimes even a few at a time.

I know it's horrible, but like I said, I've turned over a new leaf. Caroline is the one who hasn't changed. She even keeps our old Hot Sheets hidden in her room, as if they're some kind of trophy.

"I hate when you take that thing out in public," I hiss. "What if someone sees it?"

Caroline ignores my grievances—still proudly writing on the card.

"That's the point of the initials, right?"

"How would you feel if you ever saw your man's name on the sheet?" I ask. "This is embarrassing."

"If Noah ever wrongs me, he'll go straight on here," she says. "But he wouldn't dare."

She folds the list up and carefully places it back in her purse before the two of us get up from our table and leave the restaurant.



When we make it back to Room 433, we both make our way into our separate rooms and close our doors—finally giving me time to reflect upon what I've learned today.

Nathan and I are most likely over—drug addicts aren't really my type—but I can't find it in myself to hold any ill will against him. From how Caroline described him, it sounds like he's a good student who was facing too much academic pressure, which led him to turn to drugs.

As a fellow Criminal Justice major who understands the immense course load that Bradshaw students receive, I can't really fault him for that.

My main concern is with Caroline's knowledge of the situation.

During our last hush-money exchange, Gracie mentioned to me that she's considering putting her side business to an end. She picked up a part-time internship that pays well, and she no longer wants to risk criminal charges by trafficking prescription medications—understandably so.

Though I'm happy for her, I know that the moment Gracie closes up shop, Caroline will be on the hunt for a new extortion scheme that can serve

as an income for her. I'm worried that her victim search might lead her straight to Nathan. He may have some issues to sort out, but he doesn't deserve to be blackmailed for his bad habits.

Plus, neither of us know what type of pills he is even taking. Certain non-prescribed medications can lead to violent reactions or thoughts, and a threat to their stability could send them off the edge. Caroline could seriously be putting herself in danger by making a threat towards Nathan.

After all, who knows what a drug addict is capable of?

20

LEIGHTON

2024

Surprisingly, all of us survived our stint in the basement.

After we were allowed back upstairs, we were put through a series of strange-but-tame tests that seemingly served no purpose whatsoever, but I was simply happy to not feel endangered at any point. Now, I never have to endure Hell Night as a new member again.

Over a week has passed since then, and I've found that I have much more time to focus on the case than I did when I was focused on pledging activities. However, that's about to change—at least a little bit.

At the end of our long night, Juliette made our exhausted group aware of a new responsibility we will have—chapter meetings. As she explained it, Chapter is basically a one-to-two hour meeting that is held each Sunday night, where our Executive Board presents upcoming deadlines, events, and anything else that's important that week. Each Chapter is mandatory for all members, and we're only able to miss two per semester without incurring fines.

When I first listened to Juliette's description, I almost considered dropping the sorority. Marking off every Sunday night for the rest of college feels like a huge commitment, so I definitely had to take the time to consider if it would be worth it.

Nonetheless, I have nothing better to do on those nights—and besides, my sorority membership is temporary. Our pledge class will be officially initiated in a few weeks, but I'm hoping I'll have solved my investigation before then. After all, once the case is closed, I'll no longer have a need for the sorority.

In hopes of asking a few more in-depth questions about Riley and Caroline, I've been reaching out to Summer to plan a lunch date sometime

soon. After a few days of nagging her, she finally found time for a late-night dessert date at the local Fro-Yo shop in Brookwood.

When we arrive at the shop, the two of us each place an order for a different type of yogurt—Cotton-Candy for me and Triple-Chocolate for Summer. Afterwards, the two of us find a high-top in a far corner of the store and take a seat.

“So,” Summer begins, raising a spoonful to her mouth. “What did you want to talk about?”

I’ve already planned out how I’m going to approach the topic without raising suspicion, so I know exactly how to answer her.

“Okay, so, hear me out,” I preface. “My advanced writing teacher assigned us a project where we have to write about a true crime event from the past ten years, and we’ll get extra credit if we cover a case that took place in Alabama.”

She nods, encouraging me to go on.

“I was thinking,” I continue. “What if I covered Riley and Caroline’s case? The top highest paper gets highlighted in the school newspaper, and I thought it could be a way to bring more attention to the case. Maybe it could help bring in a new lead or something.”

I’m partially telling the truth. I *do* have an Advanced Writing assignment, and we really are supposed to cover an important event from the past decade. The true crime part was a stretch, but I thought it would make my reasoning sound more convincing.

“Um,” Summer bites her lip as she speaks, considering my idea. She’s silent for a moment, but eventually speaks again. “What exactly would the paper be about?”

“A little bit of everything—who they were, their case, and maybe a few theories surrounding it. Everything would be written with complete respect for them, of course.”

I try to sound as convincing as possible. If Summer shuts down my made-up writing assignment, there’s no way she’ll answer any of my questions going forward.

It’s clear that she is hesitant to approve of my idea, which I completely understand. I wouldn’t want someone writing a tell-all about my missing friends either. Luckily for her, the paper will never actually be written.

Just as I’m sure she’s going to shoot me down, Summer speaks back up.

“Okay—but I want to know everything you’re planning to write about,” she says, pausing for a moment. “—And who all you’re planning to interview.”

I spend the next few minutes going over the basic case facts with Summer, allowing her to confirm or deny certain things as we go along. Eventually, we circle around to the potential events that could’ve led up to their disappearance.

This is my chance to find out the truth about Summer and Noah.

“Off the record,” I begin. “A few weeks ago, you told me that you thought the girls’ behavior might’ve had something to do with their disappearance. Do you have a specific person in mind?”

She shakes her head.

“It’d be hard to choose just one person. I was friends with them for almost two years, and I’m one of the only people I know that actually liked them.”

“That must’ve been hard on you,” I say. “Did all the drama ever cause any issues between you guys?”

I’m giving Summer a perfect opportunity to tell me about the fight that happened between the three of them. There’s no way she doesn’t remember it, because it happened just before their disappearance.

“Not really,” she shrugs. “We had a few fights, like all friends do, but nothing serious.”

Not exactly the answer I was looking for.

I attempt to redirect the conversation. “So you’re still convinced that Noah Banks is innocent, then?”

Summer shoots me a suspicious look, as if she’s irritated that I’ve brought Noah up again.

“One-hundred percent convinced.” Her lips tighten. “Noah wouldn’t hurt anyone. Especially not Caroline.”

Now is my opportunity to really turn up the pressure on Summer.

“Would you be able to tell me the name of the girl he was with that night?” I ask. “Maybe I could cover it in my paper—clear his name, you know? Telling the truth about what he was doing *has* to be better than constantly being called a murderer.”

“Maybe,” she shoots in, appearing more nervous than before. “Last I heard, Noah still wants that whole thing to be kept private.”

At this moment, I realize I have nothing to lose. I only joined Alpha Omega for one reason: to solve Riley and Caroline's case. If I burn my bridges with a few people by asking some uncomfortable questions, so be it.

"You're going to call me crazy," I tread lightly. "But some of the girls in my pledge class think that *you're* the one who was with Noah that night. I told them it wasn't true of course, but I thought you should know."

Summer's face suddenly turns as white as a sheet of paper. She doesn't confirm or deny anything, but her demeanor is making me awfully suspicious.

After a moment, she straightens up and stares directly into my eyes.

"Do you have something you want to ask me, Leighton?"

Even though she's clearly already mad, I have to push through with my line of questioning. I lean forward, placing my elbows on the table in front of me, then drop my question after a deep breath.

"Have you ever hooked up with Noah Banks?"

Summer looks at me with disgust—only responding with one word.

"No."

I jump back in, but am quickly interrupted.

"Then why does ev—"

"I don't *know* why everyone thinks that," Summer yells. "But I'm telling you right now, I've never slept with Noah Banks. Not now, not then, not ever."

Her lips curl even more as she speaks, as if she's disgusted by the prospect of being romantically involved with Noah. I can't help but feel like she's telling the truth.

"Okay," I say, now retreating from my question. "Sorry."

I retreat from the table for a moment, then revert my questions to those that regard blackmailing once the mood is back to normal.

Summer is able to answer a few of my questions, but appears to hold back on others. She names a few Greek-life members who had fallen victim to the girls' schemes a few years back, and a handful of girls in Alpha Omega. She's not going too into detail about the more serious allegations against the girls, so I decide to push my luck one more time.

"Do you know who Maya Belton is?"

She shakes her head.

"Jesus—where are you getting this information from?"

“A good journalist never reveals their sources,” I reply.

Summer goes to sip her water before realizing it’s empty.

“I swore I’d take that secret to the grave, but they beat me to it.” She chuckles to herself. “She can’t get in trouble now anyways, so yes—Caroline framed her for cheating.”

“But why?” I press.

“Maya got too close to a guy Caroline had claimed, and Caroline never liked competition,” Summer shrugs. “What she did was awful, but she had done so much worse before...she didn’t even feel bad about it.”

“And Riley?” I ask. “Was she involved?”

She laughs. “I don’t think she knew about it until afterwards. She definitely helped cover up Caroline’s involvement, though—perks of having a CJUS major as your best friend.”

As a criminal justice major myself, I can confidently say that I would never cover up a cheating scandal that resulted in a wrongful expulsion—but to each their own.

“One last question,” I say. “If you didn’t hook up with Noah that night, who really did?”

“That, you’ll have to find out on your own,” Summer says, throwing her hands up. “I’ve been sworn to secrecy.”

When we eventually part ways, I leave with the feeling that Summer is telling the truth. Despite the rumors I’ve heard, she really seemed like she was being honest when I asked her about Noah in a face-to-face context. She was also open about the Maya Belton situation, so that earned her a few trust points.

The problem is, I’m now back to square one.

I need to find out who Noah was with on the night of the girls’ disappearance, and the sooner the better. The clock is ticking on my Bradshaw application, and I need to solve this investigation as soon as I possibly can.

As of right now, my standing theory is that Noah and whoever he was with that night confronted the girls, and things went terribly wrong. I’ve heard several stories about Caroline’s poor attitude, and I wouldn’t be surprised if it got the best of her during a heated confrontation. Therefore, I won’t know the truth until I find this mystery girl.

And I have a feeling I know just where to look.

ROXY'S TONIGHT?

I shoot the text to Nathan, hoping that he'll say yes.

It's only Thursday night, but I've heard that Roxy's—the off-campus bar that lets in underage students—is pretty popular during the week. It's a perfect place to hang out with friends, or in my case, interrogate a bar regular.

Since I got here a few weeks ago, the only two things I've learned about Noah Banks are that he isn't a murderer, and that he likes to drink at Roxy's every night. Talking to a drunk, widowed ex-boyfriend about his scandalous affairs might not be a great look for me, but that's another risk I'll simply have to take.

As I'm typing the last words for my Criminal Justice discussion board, my phone dings with a text message—which I quickly see is from Nathan.

8:30 PM

IT'S A THURSDAY.

I quickly write a response back.

8:31 PM

WHERE'S YOUR SENSE OF ADVENTURE?

Just a few moments later, I hear my ringtone going off, and see an incoming call from Nathan. I drag the button across to answer and press the phone to my cheek, speaking as soon as the call connects.

“Is this your way of saying yes?”

Nathan laughs through the phone. “I'd love to hear why you want to go to Roxy's on school night.”

“Maybe I just want to see you,” I say. “Or, maybe I want to talk to Noah Banks.”

“How come?” Nathan asks.

I realize I haven't yet told him about my conversation with Summer, and how sure I am that she was being honest.

“There’s no way Summer was hooking up with him,” I say insistently. “I asked her, and she said no. She has no reason to lie to me, so I think she’s actually telling the truth.”

I breathe in deeply.

“But, that puts me back at square one.”

“Let me get this right—you’re planning to just ask him who he was with that night?” Nathan asks. “I don’t think he’s going to like that.”

Having to convince Nathan was something I anticipated, so I’m already prepared to answer this.

“That’s why it’ll be best to talk to him while he’s boozed up,” I reply. “He’ll probably forget about it by morning.”

Nathan is silent for a while, presumably trying to decide if he’s willing to come with me. “Listen, I have a big Psych test in the morning, so tonight’s no good. But next Thursday, I promise we can go.”

Now I take the opportunity to be silent while I consider his proposal. I’m not sure if my investigation can really afford to wait for a week, but I don’t think I have another option at the moment.

Nathan picks up on my silence—soon asking if I’m still there.

“Fine, we’ll go next week,” I eventually say. “Drinks are on you though—since you’re delaying my plans and all.”

“Okay,” he laughs. “Next week then.”

The phone beeps, and the call cuts out.



The next day, Alison and I decide to invite Imani and Maeve for a shopping trip in downtown Brookwood. We’ve never been to the stores before, but the Alpha Omega sisters claim the boutiques in town are some of the best they’ve been to.

All of us have an Alpha Omega date function the weekend after next—the theme being Kentucky Derby—so we all needed to go to the local boutiques to find fascinators and hair accessories. After searching through three separate stores to no avail, we eventually hit the motherlode of Derby supplies at an antique clothing store on the far end of town.

“How does this look?” Alison asks as she carefully places a pastel green hairpiece on the crown of her head.

Maeve shakes her head.

“The colors would clash. Aren’t you wearing blue?”

Alison nods in response, and Imani tosses a white head-piece over to her.

“Try that one instead.”

The other three find their headpiece of choice within minutes, but I have a harder time choosing my own. My dress is pastel yellow, and I can’t seem to find a color that wouldn’t clash with my pre-planned outfit.

As soon as I relay my stress to the others, they dash around the store searching for a shade that will match my dress, and within a few minutes, I’m being presented with options of all colors and patterns.

“This one will go best with your dress,” Imani says—holding two different scarves in her hands. She lifts the second one. “But this one could be a statement piece.”

Alison grabs the latter option from Imani and places it atop my head. It’s a thin, white headband with a large white flower blooming from the top. It’s almost the size of my head, but somehow, it doesn’t look half bad.

They all insist I buy it, and we are soon making our way back to Alison’s car with our shopping bags in hand.

After we get back to the dorm, the four of us keep the hangout going in my room—taking turns walking the runway for each other in our now-complete Derby outfits. Imani’s pink-on-pink look steals the show, but after a few accessory additions, I’m finally satisfied with my outfit.

Once we’ve all finalized our options, the conversation turns to our dates.

“I just haven’t found anyone I’m that interested in yet,” Maeve remarks. “We need to go to another party first, or something. I need more options.”

Alison seemingly agrees, which makes me wonder what happened to her mysterious new hookup from a few weeks ago. She never told me who it was.

“We could always go alone,” she jokes. “Or with each other.”

Imani cuts in. “We can’t do that for our first date function. It’ll look like we’re incapable of getting a date.”

Even though it’d be much simpler to go as a group, I know Imani is right.

“Good point,” I admit. “But how do we find dates in under two weeks?”

Alison lightly smacks my shoulder from across the bed.

“If only someone had already found a perfect guy for you to bring.”

I feel my cheeks starting to fill with redness, but I keep a straight face. “Fine, you’re right,” I say. “That doesn’t help any of you, though.”

The four of us put our minds together to come up with a way to meet new men in the next few days. With no upcoming parties this weekend, our social options are limited, so we’re having to come up with an elaborate scheme to meet decent boys.

“We could camp out at Bama Burger,” Maeve suggests. “The football field is right beside it, and apparently all of the players go there after practice.”

Alison nods. “They’re playing the game here tomorrow night, so that might work. Apparently they practice, like, five times a week on home-game weeks.”

“Or we could try to meet guys *at* the football game,” Imani points out.

She reaches into her purse, pulling out a small box and opening it. Inside are several white cards with red writing.

“Our fakes came in the mail, so we could buy drinks inside the stadium.”

On the arrival of our fake IDs, an idea suddenly comes to me—something that works out in everyone’s best interest.

“If we have our IDs, why don’t we go to Roxy’s tonight?” I try to keep up an enthusiastic tone, hoping that it will make them more likely to want to go. “We need to know if they work or not anyways, so this would be the perfect way to test them.”

“Like, right now?” Maeve asks.

I check the time on my phone and see that it’s almost ten o’clock.

“Why not? It’s a Friday.”

Imani smiles. “You know I’m in.”

Alison slips out of the room to change, and Imani and Maeve sift through my closet to find something more suitable to wear.

I’ve heard that Roxy’s is more of a biker-bar, so I decide on a pair of leather mini-shorts and a plain black crop top. I slip on my favorite black fold-over boots, throw on some jewelry, then prance to the living room to chug a few drinks while the others finish getting ready.

Nathan might be hurt that I went to the bar without him, but I need to talk to Noah sooner rather than later. There’s a chance we’ll still need to go back Thursday anyways, but I’m hopeful that I can find him tonight. A Friday night is probably my best bet.

Imani is the first to emerge from my room, dressed in a mixture of leather and leopard print—then Maeve, who’s chosen a tight slip-dress. Alison comes last, donning a similar outfit to my own. All of them look incredible, and I don’t think any of them will be struggling to find a date after tonight.

Imani passes out our IDs, which I immediately slide into the clear slip of my wallet for safekeeping. I make sure it’s secure in its place, then make an attempt to encourage the group.

“Time to see if these were worth \$60.”



Thirty minutes later, we are standing in front of a tall, brick building that has clearly been coated in several layers of charcoal-black paint. Varying colors of neon lights frame the long, tinted windows upon the sides of the building, and many other bright signs illuminate the property. Upon the black wall sits a large pink LED light reading *Roxy’s* in cursive, confirming for me that we’ve been dropped off in the right place.

I wave the driver off, and our group begins to walk inside.

The bouncer asks for my ID as soon as I crest the doorway, and I thankfully get into the bar without any issues. He gives Alison’s ID a moment of consideration, but eventually we are able to make our way towards the bar seats.

Only two spots are open, so Alison and I sit and order for everyone.

“That was close,” I say, acknowledging the ID incident.

“I know,” she says, eyes widened. “I thought I was a goner.”

The bartender approaches us, and we order four vodka cranberries for the group—on my suggestion, of course.

“The vitamin C helps to curb hangovers,” I explain, defending my choice in drink. “They’ve always been my go-to.”

Alison nods. “I’m more of a seltzer person, or maybe—“

She trails off in the middle of her sentence, suddenly focusing her attention across the room. I glance around the bar on the far-side, catching a glimpse of Summer’s face through the crowd.

“No way,” I cheer. “We should go say hey.”

Alison agrees, and we quickly hand off the extra drinks to Imani and Maeve—explaining that we’re going to talk to Summer. The two head off to

the bathroom, and we start walking across the room towards the area we saw her.

Just as we're approaching her bar seat, though, I see Summer stretch her arm towards a tall male figure wearing a dark blue hoodie, who is just now walking inside. The man sits down in the seat beside her before removing his hood, revealing a dirty blonde mop of hair. Summer places a hand against the left side of his face—turning it to where Alison and I can get a clear view of him—then plants a kiss on him.

I stop dead in my tracks, digging my fingers into Alison's wrist to prevent her from moving forward any further. The face of the man that Summer is all over is more than familiar. I've seen it a hundred times in news articles.

Summer is with Noah Banks.

22

Summer lied to me.

I gave her the opportunity to be honest about Noah, and she chose to lie right to my face.

The warmth of the anger is beginning to spread to my cheeks, and I clench my fists tightly at my sides. Even though I asked Summer about Noah for my own ulterior motives, I still can't believe that my own friend would be so blatantly dishonest with me. I had believed everything she said, and was even looking for other suspects.

Summer is hiding something, and I need to find out why.

"Is that...?" Alison asks, her lips twisted in disgust.

I slowly nod my head, my mouth still agape.

"That's Noah Banks."

We simultaneously turn around and search for a better place to peep on the couple without them noticing us. Eventually, we settle on a low-seat booth in a dimly-lit corner, which we tell Maeve and Imani to meet us at through our group message.

From across the room, we see Summer and Noah chatting humorously—each one smiling wider than the other. Their body language tells me that this couldn't possibly be a coincidental meeting, or even a friendly reunion. Anyone with a basic concept of human behavior could tell that these two have slept together just by watching them. They look like a married couple.

"If I died, and you started sleeping with my ex-boyfriend, I'd come back and haunt you from beyond the grave." Alison takes a long sip of her vodka-cran, eventually hitting ice.

"Don't worry," I say, slamming my own drink. "Some of us have morals."

She grabs her phone, shooting our next two drink requests into the groupchat. When Maeve and Imani finally arrive with our orders, we fill them in on what we've seen.

Maeve is the most surprised of all of us, as she seems to always see only the best in people.

“Are you sure it was him?” she asks. “I can’t see her doing something like that...it’s horrible.”

Alison confirms that it was, in fact, Noah.

“It’s not a complete surprise, either. Kimberly had mentioned the possibility to me—especially the idea that Summer was hooking up with Noah the night of Caroline’s disappearance. It makes you wonder...”

“Yeah,” Imani joins in. “It’s pretty suspicious.”

Even though Summer has been a great friend to have throughout the sorority rush process, I have to admit that my trust in her is dwindling more and more by the day. The more information I learn about her, the clearer it is that she has more secrets than she lets on.

I wonder what else she’s hiding.

“Definitely suspicious,” I say smugly, downing my new drink in one sip.

The content of the drinks I’ve had are beginning to get to me, and I can feel my vision getting hazier.

The more time the alcohol has to sit, the more I can feel the anger brewing inside me. I want to confront Summer—ask her why she lied to me and what she is hiding from everyone. If she’s so easily able to hide things from her friends, what else could she be capable of?

I need to find out.

I push up from my chair. “I’m going to talk to her.”

A hand comes across my shoulder before I can walk forward, and Imani pushes me back into my seat.

“Easy there, Leigh,” she says calmly. “What do you want to say to her?”

“I want to know why she lied to me,” I say. “And why she helped Noah cheat on Caroline. And I want her to tell me why she is *still* hooking up with her missing best friend’s ex-boyfriend.”

I’m basically huffing and puffing now, and I probably look insane to passersby.

While the others hold me back, Alison gets up from her seat and comes back with an ice water within seconds, which the three of them force me to chug.

“I can’t let you talk to her,” Imani explains finitely. “We love you, and we don’t want you to get kicked out of Alpha Omega already.”

Alison and Maeve agree, still physically restraining me.

A few minutes pass, and my brain starts to de-fog itself. I’m still extremely upset with Summer, but I don’t feel the overwhelming urge to attack her anymore.

Once I’m thinking reasonably straight again, I realize that I now have the upper hand over Summer. As far as I know, she hasn’t seen me yet, so she likely doesn’t know that I’ve figured out her secret. I can use this to my advantage, I’m just not sure how yet.

I need some time to think.

“Sorry guys, I’m good now.” I throw my empty water cup in a nearby trash can. “You can go find your dates now.”

On my word, Maeve and Imani gleefully depart from our booth and set out for two attractive guys across the bar. Alison, however, hesitates to leave—squinting at me from the other side of the table.

“Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Just pissed,” I reply. “But I’m fine. I’ll ask Nathan to come pick me up.”

She raises an eyebrow at me.

“Go have fun, seriously,” I insist. “I’ll be fine. I promise.”

After some further hesitation, she smiles at me.

“Okay. I’ll slap the bitch for you if I see her again.”

She winks, then turns and walks into the crowd.

Once she’s left, I whip out my phone and type up a text to Nathan—asking if he can pick me up at Roxy’s, and apologizing for going without him. Thankfully, he doesn’t seem too offended, because he immediately confirms that he’ll be on the way soon.

To avoid running into Summer while I wait for Nathan to arrive, I crouch into the booth and turn towards the wall. This behavior attracts a few desperate men from the bar who offer to buy me a drink of my choice, but luckily not much of anyone else.

Eventually, I get a notification for an incoming message and see that Nathan is waiting in the parking lot.

I gather my purse and keys before glancing around the room in search of my friends. Maeve and Imani are still locked in conversation with the same two guys, and Alison is nowhere to be found. It doesn’t seem like a

goodbye is particularly needed, so I make a quick exit before anyone else sees me.

As soon as I'm in the parking lot, I'm able to spot his silver Dodge Ram over by the entrance area. I rush over, then open the car door and hoist myself inside—immediately locking eyes with him once I'm seated.

“You'll never guess who I saw in there.”

“Noah?” Nathan asks, appearing genuinely curious.

I shut the door before continuing.

“Yep. With Summer.”

He begins to drive out of the parking lot, and I can tell by his casual demeanor that he's not shocked by this revelation.

“It doesn't surprise me at all. Those girls were always awful to each other,” he says. “Sleeping with each other's boyfriends was honestly the bare minimum for what I expected from them.”

“I think it's disgusting,” I say. “It would've been one thing if they started hooking up a year later, but it was pretty obvious that they've been doing this for a while now.”

Nathan is silent for a moment, clearly considering the right thing to say.

“Are you going to say anything to her?”

“Not yet.” I shake my head vigorously. “I need to find a way to use it to my advantage.”

He nods, then glances off in thought.

“Thanks for picking me up, by the way,” I cut back in. “I would've waited until next Thursday, but this was an urgent matter.”

“I'm glad you went,” Nathan replies. “Now we know for sure that Summer and Noah are together, we just can't prove that they were together the night the girls disappeared.”

He has a point. I can't put Summer on my suspect list solely based on a feeling, or based on my elementary-level analysis of their body language. There has to be a way to find out whether or not they were hooking up that night.

“So what should I do?” I ask. “How can I find proof?”

Nathan takes yet another moment of consideration before answering me, as if he's really having to work to come up with something. When he's been thinking for an uncomfortable amount of time, he randomly shifts his grip on the steering wheel before glancing over at me.

Suddenly, he whips a U-Turn at the first traffic light in sight.

He accelerates the truck—a mad look now in his eyes.
“I think I have an idea.”



After a short ten minute drive, we’re now parked in front of the Theta Mu house. I’m not exactly sure what we’re doing here, but Nathan clearly thinks that something here can help my investigation.

“Why are we here again?” I ask.

He grabs my wrist and begins leading me towards the house.

“You’ll see.”

Instead of going in the front door, he walks us around the side of the house and directs me towards a separate building, which we enter through an old door that’s draped in vines and moss. The entryway leads to a small porch-like area that appears to be connected to the pool cabana, but it is clear that this room is hardly visible from the pool deck area—where the parties are held.

“What is this place?” I ask, shining my flashlight around at the items within the room.

There are four lawn chairs set up in an oval-like shape, and a small table sits in the center. An unemptied ashtray lays atop the table, and several empty beer cans take up the remaining space—several of which have flies buzzing around them.

Nathan turns up his nose at the mess. “This is The Den. Noah and his buddies used to spend a lot of time here when they lived in the house. It’s hidden from plain view, so nobody came back here but other brothers.”

“I can see why they liked it so much,” I sneer, still disgusted by the nature of the room. “What does this have to do with Summer, though?”

He steps over towards the far back wall, where my flashlight illuminates several signatures and numbers upon the wall. As I step closer, I can make out a few names that I recognize.

“Noah’s friends started this,” he explains. “They called it ‘The Bang Board’, or something like that.”

He points to one of the examples on the wall above.

“Any time one of them would hook up with a new girl, they’d write the girl’s name and the date they did it, then sign it at the bottom.”

The abhorrence of fraternity boys never ceases to amaze me.
Thankfully, it's working out in my favor just this once.

"So we just need to find Summer and Noah's name?" I ask.

He confirms this, and the two of us spread apart to search the wall.

After striking out on my section, I ask if Nathan has had any luck.

"Nope," he says. "But I think it has to be here."

Just as I'm about to give up, a small portion of writing in the corner of the wall catches my eye.

"Nathan, look."

He shines his flashlight into the corner, and the handwriting is quickly illuminated.

Summer Harding

09/18/2023

Noah Banks

"There's our answer". Nathan takes a quick flash-photo of the writing.
"For investigative purposes," he says.

I trace the date with my finger. "September 18th. Was there a party that night?"

He shakes his head. "A mixer. I didn't go—too much... homework. That was the party where the cops got called, and everyone got drinking tickets."

"I wonder how that would've led to a hookup."

"Unfortunately," he starts, "the wall won't tell us that." He pauses. "But at least now we have somewhere to start."

Nathan is right. Finding confirmation of Summer and Noah sleeping around behind Caroline's back is a huge step forward in the case. At the very least, we've established two people with a genuine motive to hurt one or both of the girls.

I think it's time to re-write my suspect list.

And Summer's going at the very top.

23

Riley Walker

SEPTEMBER 2023

(Three Months Before)

I already want to go home.

Once again, I'm riding backseat in Noah's car as we drive towards the Theta Mu house. It isn't far from Norman Hall, but it's far enough to be considered non-walkable in heels, so Noah volunteered to drive us.

As we approach the house, I hear rap music blasting from twenty yards down the street, and I feel a glimmer of hope that the cops might bust the party.

This is the last place I want to be right now.

Tonight is Alpha Omega's first monthly mixer with Theta Mu of the semester, and our president made it clear that our attendance was mandatory. It's a Monday night, and I really need this time to work on classwork, but I know better than to not follow Alpha Omega orders.

So now, I'm in a dress and heels, and I'm five seconds away from cresting the doorway of one of Alabama's most disgusting fraternity houses.

We step through the door, and Noah parts ways with Caroline with a kiss. The two promise to meet each other back once they've caught up with their friends, and he confirms that he'll be driving us home. After he's disappeared into the house, we sneak through the back hallway and into the hidden guest bathroom. Since she's dating a resident, Caroline knows her way around the house better than most people, so she's able to find us an empty bathroom.

Once the door is closed, we come up with a game plan.

"We stay for thirty minutes," I suggest. "We can talk to as many people as we can, and then leave."

"Agreed," she says. "I already asked Noah if he can drive us back around then, and he said he can."

“Perfect.”

Just as I finish my sentence, we hear a loud banging on the door. A muffled voice can be heard through the door, though it’s partially drowned out by the music from the living room. Eventually, I can make out the words being said.

“It’s Summer! Let me In.”

When we open the door, Summer stumbles in with an ear-to-ear smile plastered upon her face. Her eyes are blank, and she’s double-fisting two wine box drinks. It’s clear that she’s plastered.

Caroline takes the top drink from Summer’s hand and places it on the counter. “Slow down, babe. It’s not even ten yet.”

Summer huffs in response. “You’re no fun. I need that.”

She reaches across Caroline to attempt grabbing her wine, knocking the liquid down the drain in the process.

“My point exactly,” Caroline laughs. “Don’t be such a mess.”

Summer jerks up, staring her straight in the eyes now with a serious look across her face.

“Don’t fucking talk to me like that.”

I step forward, hoping to prevent whatever is about to happen. Summer just took things from 0-100 really quickly.

“Okay, let’s all take a breath,” I suggest. “I know none of us want to be here, but we don’t have to fight.”

Summer seems to be disappointed with my attempt to cool things down. She glares at the both of us for a moment before thrusting open the door and basically sprinting away.

Caroline and I are equally confused by this, each taking a moment of silence to process that entire interaction.

I’m the first to speak up.

“What the hell was that?”

Caroline instantly collects her belongings and heads for the door.

“No idea,” she says angrily. “I’m going to talk to her.”

I watch the door close behind her, then take another moment to recollect my thoughts. While I’m standing there alone, I feel my phone vibrate in my pocket, so I pull it out and place it on the bathroom counter.

The last thing I am expecting to see is a text message from my younger sister, but nonetheless, that’s exactly what I’m looking at.

9:38 PM

NEED YOUR HELP WITH MY APPLICATION.

When I first applied to Cabot as a senior in high school, she had expressed interest in pursuing her education here as well—solely based on the reviews of the party scene, of course. But as we all know, a lot of things change between your sophomore and senior years of high school, and I assumed she would've simply changed her mind about wanting to come here in the fall.

At least, I had *hoped* she would.

Our history is complicated. The two of us went through a lot in our childhood—especially when my dad walked out on us—and the constant emotional tension in the household caused by my mother only strained our relationship even further. We never got along as children, and our disagreements about how to handle our mother's tendencies kept us from bonding as teenagers.

Still, our familial issues are not what sealed our fate as enemies.

At the end of my senior year of high school—when she was a sophomore at the same school—I was getting ready for my final Prom before heading off to college. My boyfriend at the time, whom I had been dating for nearly a year by that point, was set to pick me up at seven o'clock that evening to attend a pre-event dinner.

Yet—as the minutes ticked closer to his supposed arrival time, I received no word on when he was picking me up, or even when he was planning to leave. I spent nearly an hour trying to keep myself from crying, constantly wondering where my boyfriend was and why he was trying to ruin my final Prom. I couldn't figure it out.

Until we got the phone call.

Just before eight o'clock, my mom received a call from an unsaved number. It was only after she picked it up that she discovered she was speaking with our local police station, who were calling to notify her that her daughter had been arrested for Public Indecency at a park a few miles away.

Here's the kicker. My sister—who we had believed to have been at her friend's house at the time—had actually been hooking up with my boyfriend in his car while he was supposed to be on the way to get me.

A group of moms taking their children for a walk had caught them in the act and called the police, who arrested both of them upon arrival. After the smoke of the misdemeanor cleared, we found out that the two had been

sleeping together for almost three full months, and that he was planning to break up with me in order to be with her.

It was an incredibly screwed up situation, and I haven't forgiven her even after two years. No matter how hard she tries.

So—like I said—college is my only safe space. The only place where the horrors of my family can't completely overtake my being, both physically and emotionally. The last thing I need is for my only refuge to be destroyed by an ill-blooded family member.

I swipe away the notification and place my phone back in my pocket before returning to the main gathering.

The main room is filled with heads bobbing to the music, and it's hard to get a clear picture of anyone's face with the neon lights flashing above my head. Instead of attempting to break through the crowd, I decide to walk over to the familiar bar area and grab a cup of the mysterious red liquid that is being dispensed from an orange water cooler.

I've found that it's best to ignore the potential ingredients of the party juice and just chug the drink, so I knock mine back within seconds.

"Is it any good?"

A familiar voice appears behind me, and I turn to see Ashley Worthington—a girl in my Alpha Omega pledge class.

We've barely spoken two words to each other before, but she's always seemed really nice from afar. I know that she's a nursing student, and that she always receives a gift card from the chapter for keeping up a 4.0 GPA every semester, but not much else. I've also never seen her miss a party, so her balance in life is pretty admirable.

"If you like the taste of Hawaiian Punch cut with rubbing alcohol, you're going to love it," I reply.

I offer her a taste from my own cup.

She shrugs in response, filling up her cup anyways.

"It hasn't killed me yet."

I suddenly am reminded of the bathroom altercation that just went, and realize that I should probably go make sure Caroline and Summer haven't clawed each other's eyes out.

"Have you seen Caroline around here?" I ask Ashley. "Or maybe Summer Harding?"

Ashley shakes her head before sipping her drink.

“Not Caroline,” she answers. “But Summer, I did see. She just spent half an hour crying to me about her midterm, actually. Apparently she failed it.”

A failed midterm would explain Summer’s erratic behavior, but it doesn’t explain why she would open up to Ashley Worthington instead of Caroline or I. *We’re* her friends, not Ashley.

Or at least, I think that’s the case.

“Are you two close?” I ask, leaning forward with curiosity.

“Not until tonight, I guess,” she says. “I felt really bad for her...she seems really stressed out about school in general.”

Her eyes suddenly brighten with an idea.

“Maybe one of you should talk to her...you’re good friends with her, right?”

I nod. “Do you know when you saw her last?”

Ashley peers around the surrounding hallways, unsuccessfully attempting to find her. Eventually, she gives up and returns to where I’m standing.

“That was forty-five minutes ago, so I’m not sure where she is now,” she tells me. “But she’s been down by the pool all night. I’d check there.”

Ashley and I part ways, and I quickly walk out the back door and onto the porch area that overlooks the pool area. I’m able to spot Caroline within seconds, who is talking to a group of guys and girls by the pool chairs. Unfortunately, I still haven’t been able to lay eyes on Summer.

Making my way down to the area where I saw Caroline, I continue glancing around the party. If Summer isn’t inside, or at the pool, where could she be?

Caroline grabs my arm once I make it to her, pulling me away from the group she had been chatting with. “Have you seen her?”

Great. She doesn’t know where Summer is either.

“I was about to ask you the same thing,” I say. “I have no clue.”

Before Caroline gets a chance to say anything, the music playing from the speakers increases immensely in volume, and we have to walk further away to be able to hear properly. Eventually, we find a quiet-enough space in the wooded area toward the front of the house.

“I looked for her when I left the bathroom, but I couldn’t find her,” Caroline says, continuing our unfinished conversation. “I can’t find Noah either, so pretty much everyone I need is missing.”

I sip my drink. “What do you need Noah for?”

She laughs.

“To *leave*. These people have been here for two hours, and they’re all way more drunk than we are. We’ve already been seen here by a few of the girls, so we’ll be marked for attendance—which means it’s time to go.”

Caroline is obviously riled up, which I’m guessing has a lot to do with Summer’s behavior earlier.

“Leaving sounds great,” I say. “I’m sure he can’t be far...let’s go look for him inside.”

We quickly turn towards the door, pushing past the trees to reach the yard of the house.

But just as we’ve almost crested the woods, two SUVs with flashing blue lights pull into the paved driveway—now directly blocking the exit of the house. Four men in uniforms emerge from the cars, immediately pulling out their notebook pads as they approach a group of Theta Mu guys on the front porch.

“Shit,” Caroline mumbles quietly. “Cops.”

The two of us lock eyes for a moment, trying to silently come up with an idea of what to do next. We hide behind a large tree, and Caroline quickly pulls out her phone. She calls Noah several times in an attempt to warn him of the incoming problem—only to be sent to voicemail each time.

“Noah isn’t answering,” Caroline snips, aggressively moving her thumbs as she messages him. “Where the hell is he?”

As she blows up his phone, I feel a knot of stress forming in my chest that tightens more and more by the second.

I *cannot* get a drinking citation tonight. I’m over eighteen years old, so everything counts now, and a mark like that on my record would ruin my chances of pursuing any criminal justice-related career.

I can’t be here right now, and I certainly can’t talk to any cops.

We need to get out of here, and now. If Noah doesn’t answer, we’ll just have to flee through the woods.

“He’s not texting or calling back,” Caroline huffs. “I don’t know what the hell he’s doing, but I’m going to tear him a new one the second he turns his phone back on.”

“We have bigger problems than that.” I peek out from behind our tree to see a few girls in our sorority—whom I know to be under 21—handing their IDs over to the officers. “I think they’re arresting people.”

I can't make out the words being said, but one of the girls begins to talk back to the officer in an aggressive manner, eventually pointing a finger directly in his face. This prompts him to handcuff her and one other boy who comes to her defense, which has seemingly angered the entire crowd in the front yard.

"We need to leave," I say with more urgency. "*Now.*"

Caroline takes note of the situation out front and hesitates to turn back to face me. "I can't just leave him. What if he gets himself arrested?"

She pauses for a moment.

"He can be so stupid when he's drunk."

I'm glad she cares for Noah so much, but right now, I don't. I'm not getting a misdemeanor just so that we can save him from his own childish behavior. Plus, we don't even have eyes on him. He could've left without telling Caroline.

"Stay here then," I snap. "I'm getting out of here before we get breathalyzed and arrested."

With a stomp, I turn away from her dramatically, then begin trudging through the woods in my heels.

My phone's flashlight helps to illuminate the path in front of me, which consists of several puddles and fallen-down sticks from last night's thunderstorm. As I walk, I feel excessively grateful that I chose to wear block heels tonight, since my stilettos would be sinking far into the mud with every step.

Just as I feel that I've walked a good distance from where I was standing with Caroline, I hear a twig snap behind me, and I turn to see her walking up towards me.

"Screw Noah," she says, accelerating her pace until she's up to my point. "I'm not going to jail for him."

In our matching platform heels—the two of us escape the police.



The next morning, I wake up feeling clean and unbothered compared to the night before.

Last night, Caroline and I both showered as soon as we made it home, then stood by our phones to await the news of the outcome of the mixer. Eventually, the news started flooding in.

Three Alpha Omegas arrested; five Theta Mus.

Over fifty drinking citations given out.

Multiple fights.

Lots of tears.

Pretty much everyone we know was texting us, wondering if we had escaped the chaos somehow—which we thankfully did.

The strange thing is, Caroline never heard from Noah, and I never heard from Summer. Both of them disappeared within five minutes of our arrival at the party, and we couldn't get in contact with either of them after that. Even now, several hours later—nothing. It's very strange for the two people we're closest with to go radio silent all of a sudden.

When I go into the living room to make my coffee, Caroline is already sitting on the couch with a scowl on her face. She lifts her gaze from her phone to glance at me as I walk in, but says nothing at all. Even after I wish her a good morning, she waves me off.

“Still nothing from Noah, I assume?”

She shakes her head. “Nope. Something's definitely up.”

I sit down beside her on the couch as my coffee brews.

“Well, at least we know he wasn't arrested.”

We received a full report on every person who was detained or jailed last night, and Noah thankfully wasn't one of them. In fact, his friends said he disappeared before the police even arrived.

“This would be a lot worse if he were in the county lockup,” I say.

Caroline sneers at me. “He'll be wishing he had been in jail when I find out what he's been doing.”

She aggressively stands up and marches into her room, which I recognize as her usual signal to leave her alone. My coffee finishes right at that moment, so I mix in cream and sugar before returning to my room.

As I sit and sip my coffee, I can't help but wonder what Noah might have been doing last night.

There's no real basis for it, but for some reason I have an overwhelming feeling that his active silence has something to do with Summer. They both stopped responding to text messages around the same time, and it doesn't seem like either of them were around when the cops busted up the party. It all seems a little bit too coincidental.

That being said, I could still never share this theory with Caroline. I'm sure she's already assuming the worst, which means she's likely already

devised a revenge plan that will destroy the lives of both Noah and his mistress. If I'm wrong about Summer, I don't want to be responsible for someone wrongfully unleashing that type of wrath on a person.

I push the idea out of my head as soon as it comes to me.

Noah is a great boyfriend, and he doesn't even seem like the cheating type. I can rest assured knowing that Noah wouldn't do that to Caroline, and neither would Summer.

Still—deep down, I know something is wrong.

Caroline was right.

Something is definitely up.

24

LEIGHTON

2024

In America, 83% of the population will be victimized by at least one violent crime in their lifetime.

81% of women can expect to experience sexual harassment or violence.
19% of women will experience attempted or completed rape.
.15% will go missing.
.13% will be murdered.

In this week's Intro to Criminal Justice class, Professor Boswell is covering the various types of victimization. From grooming, to prostitution, to human trafficking—we went through it all. He skims over the topics of murder and rape, since we'll be covering those throughout the semester, but he goes into immense detail on others.

Along with our general examination of American crime, we also touch on several notorious crimes from the past few decades—looking over pretty much every notorious crime and varying charge I can think of. The Ivy League Admissions scandal, the Menendez Brothers, the Anthrax murders, and more.

We spend a large portion of time learning about teacher-student transactional relationships—both monetary and sexual—and even looked into the Ivy League Admissions Scandal as an example of the consequences these actions can bring. He greatly encouraged us to report any inappropriate advances by faculty members to the Dean, which made me wonder if Cabot has had a few instances of this in the past.

I haven't seen any headlines about it, but that doesn't mean that it hasn't happened before.

After we review our last slide on American human trafficking hotspots, class is dismissed, and we all begin packing our belongings to leave.

As soon as I step outside of the Bradshaw building, the warmth of the sun hits my bare shoulders, and a cool breeze runs across my face in a way that perfectly cuts out the heat. For the first time since I got here, the weather is nice enough for a reasonable person to be able to enjoy a walk through campus, so I feel like I need to take advantage of it.

In light of everything I discovered this weekend, a long stroll might actually help to take my mind off things.

I decide to walk towards our school's coffee shop across campus, which is hidden directly inside the South Village Center—the south end of campus's equivalent to the Student Union on the north end. I've only been to the Center itself once, and I figure I need to familiarize myself with the entire campus as soon as I can.

The views of my walk consist of a few large art sculptures, some perfectly-maintained landscaping, and tall brick buildings with sparkling glass windows. I pass by a few memorial benches and dedication plaques, as well as a couple of statues of Cabot campus founders and old mascots—and the walkway is lined with brightly-colored flowers of all shapes and sizes, which add a pop of vibrance to the atmosphere.

As the lively voices of other students pass me by, I feel like I've hopped straight into a Pinterest photo.

The walk from Bradshaw to the shop takes about ten minutes, so I arrive after only a short while. The line for the café is filled with other students, but I don't mind waiting, so I simply settle into the back and pull out my phone.

As I move closer to the register, I am able to hear each student give a name for their order, so I listen closely to see if I can catch a familiar name. After several people go, my eyes fall upon the newest arrival at the counter—a girl with dirty blonde hair and a large baggy T-shirt.

When the barista asks for a name for the order, the girl's response makes me do a double-take.

"Marley," she says. "M-A-R-L-E-Y."

The name sends a pang of familiarity through me, and it takes a moment to remember that *Marley* is the name of my original roommate who requested a housing swap before the year began.

Yes, it's a common name, but I still find myself wondering if this is the same girl that I could've been spending my freshman year with. Even the spelling is the same.

As I'm considering whether or not I should approach her, the barista calls for me to step forward, and I quickly place an order for a caramel iced mocha. I had already perused the online menu during my walk, so I had planned out my order much earlier on.

Now, all I have to do is wait around for my name to be called.

Coincidentally, mine and Marley's drinks come out around the same time, and we end up at the self-serve station together. Although I'm perfectly aware that it's weird to talk to strangers in a coffee shop, I feel like it's somewhat excusable when that coffee shop is located within a college campus. Everything on school grounds is fair game for social interaction, especially for freshmen that are trying to make friends. If I tried to strike up a conversation with Marley right now, it wouldn't be *that* out of the ordinary.

I unwrap a straw as I speak to appear casual.

"This is so random, but are you Marley Harris?"

The girl narrows her eyes at me, blinking in confusion. I'm starting to rethink my choice of talking to her.

"Who's asking?" she asks.

"I think we were supposed to be roommates," I reply. "Norman Hall? Room 433, right?"

The moment the words leave my mouth, Marley's eyes widen immensely, and I notice her hands tensing around her cup. Before I can say another word, she walks away in a quick fashion—taking one glance back in my direction before disappearing into the ground floor of the building.

I remain standing at the station, grabbing a few napkins to keep my hands busy and avoid any further awkward moments. I'm not sure what just happened, but it was extremely embarrassing, and I'm silently berating myself for ever trying to talk to her.

I swallow my humiliation and prance through the room to reach the exit—my drink still in hand. Once outside, I take a long drag from my drink and attempt to relax my posture. That whole situation made me tense.

After a few breaths of fresh air, I'm able to begin my walk across campus to get back to Norman Hall.

As I pass back through the rows of vibrant flowers along the pathway, I try to process the interaction with Marley a little bit more—maybe to understand where I went wrong. It's like in middle school, when you'd have an argument with someone during class, then later you would repeat the

exchange in your head to make sure you sounded cool—that’s exactly how I feel.

I re-run through the interaction in my head.

Only a few sentences were spoken throughout the whole conversation, and nothing hurtful or out-of-the-ordinary was said.

So what happened?

Why did Marley act that way?

The thought stays with me for my entire walk back to Norman, where I run into Alison at the main entrance. She’s wearing her backpack, so I’m assuming she just came from class too, and the two of us talk about the events of our day as we ride the elevator to the fourth floor.

Alison tells me about her Intro to Marketing class today, where another student yelled at the professor in front of the entire class about a poorly-graded assignment. Nobody was injured, thankfully, but class was dismissed early.

When the conversation comes back to me, I tell Alison everything about my strange conversation with my possible ex-roommate at the coffee shop—down to the last detail about Marley’s weird expression.

Alison shrugs. “Maybe there’s something wrong with her.”

“It was more than that, though,” I say insistently. “Something was off about the whole situation.”

“Don’t be paranoid,” she laughs. “At least you didn’t get her as a roommate. She kind of seems like a spaz.”

Alison might be able to shrug it off, but I’m not sure I can just yet. She picks up on my silence, and speaks again.

“Your *real* roommate is actually pretty cool,” she says. “So cool that she bought us both alcohol for Derby with her brand new fake ID.”

With both of her hands, she reaches into her backpack and grabs two 12 oz bottles of white wine from her bag—both of which look incredibly expensive. Last time I ran an internet search for one of Alison’s wine brands, I nearly spat out my drink with surprise at the price, so I wouldn’t be surprised if she splurged on these as well.

Still, I thank her for the wine, and the two of us place them in the school-issue mini-fridge to keep them cool before next weekend’s event.

Afterwards, we go into our separate rooms.

Even as I’m getting ready for bed, I’m still re-running the events of today in my head. The four-sentence exchange with Marley is on an endless

loop in my head—no matter how much I try to think of anything else.

The problem isn't the words that were said—that's not what's bothering me. What's repeating in my mind is the expression that set on her face when I mentioned the possibility of her being my old roommate.

The tense jaw. Flushed cheeks. Wide eyes.

It didn't seem like she was confused, embarrassed—or even angry.

It's almost like she was...

Afraid.

25

W*hen you're in doubt, always map it out.*

These are the wise words of my sixth grade chemistry teacher, Mrs. Burke. During our long division section, she taught us this sentiment, and I took it to heart for pretty much any other purpose than what she intended.

Throughout my time as both a student and a follower of true crime, I've come to realize that criminal investigation and chemistry share more similarities than one might expect. In any general murder case, individual factors such as motive or mental instability act like reactive agents. When they combine in the right conditions, they trigger a reaction—leading to a violent outcome. In chemistry, we call it a chain-reaction. In the world of crime, it's called a breaking point.

Now, I need to map out exactly which elements were part of the chain reaction that led to Riley's and Caroline's disappearance—though I'm clearly missing a few key pieces of information. Since so many strange discoveries have been clouding my train of thought recently, I thought it'd best to write everything down before I forget any important details. I need to write a new suspect list too.

Once my files are splayed upon my desk, I brew a lukewarm cup of tea and put on my robe before pulling out a pen and pad. It's going to be a long night.

CASE UPDATES:

Riley Walker and Caroline Rowe resided in Room 433 at Norman Hall—also Alison and I's room.

Despite the positive personality descriptions of Riley and Caroline, they engaged in blackmailing and extortion. According to several sources, they made a good number of enemies in the time they spent at Cabot.

Caroline was responsible for orchestrating the academic scandal involving Maya Belton, who was caught in possession of multiple exam keys for her upcoming midterms. Allegedly, Caroline was angry that Maya hooked up with someone that she had previously expressed interest in, so she took matters into her own hands. There is no evidence to support this claim.

Summer Harding had a falling out with Caroline and Riley two months prior to their disappearance due to an unknown reason. My personal theory is that one of them discovered the romantic relationship between Noah Banks and Summer, then confronted her with evidence.

Summer Harding is evidently hooking up with Noah Banks. Body language, topic of conversation, and rumors spanning the previous year have helped to fuel this theory, along with the alleged confirmation from the signature on the Theta Mu house wall.

26

Riley Walker

SEPTEMBER 2023

(Two Months Before)

The events of last Monday night were detrimental to many of our fellow students' future careers and social lives.

Typically, an occurrence such as this one would provide Caroline with several months of fuel for her blackmail schemes, and she'd be through the roof with joy right now. The difference is—this time, the events have negatively affected her as well.

When she couldn't get in touch with Noah after the cops arrived, I immediately got a terrible feeling that something weird was going on—and I'm sure she felt it too.

Noah never texted or called Caroline back that night, nor did he reach out in the morning to explain the silence from his end. He eventually showed up at our dorm an entire day later—claiming that his phone had been lost in the midst of the chaos—but neither of us believed that. After nearly a year of dating, she has learned to recognize his habitual lies, so she knew not to trust a word that he said. Too many alarm bells were going off.

What Noah didn't know was that Caroline had already checked with everyone who was present for the police frenzy, and all of them confirmed that Noah had been M.I.A long before the cops' arrival. In fact—nobody had seen him at all since a little while after we arrived.

The more we learned, the guiltier Noah began to look.

In the following days, the two of us tried to brainstorm any possible justification for his strange behavior. Sadly, we were quickly able to disprove each possibility.

Had Noah been arrested, and simply couldn't contact Caroline at the time?

Nope. We checked the Brookwood Police Department arrest reports for Monday night, and though we found several of our classmates' names on there, Noah's name wasn't listed.

Had he been in the hospital for some unknown injury?

Doubtful. Any injury worthy of a hospital visit would likely be difficult to visibly conceal from us within the timeframe that Noah was given—24 hours.

Had Noah had a family emergency, and was simply too busy to answer until the chaos had passed?

Also doubtful. This would've been a forgivable excuse, but he didn't mention anything about it. If there was such a simple explanation for his behavior, I think it's more likely that he would've just told Caroline that.

After going through our list of questions and eliminating all the logical possibilities, we eventually landed on the most dreaded question of all. A question which—in the bottom of our hearts, we were hoping wouldn't be true.

Was Noah cheating on Caroline?

Unfortunately, this is the only theory we couldn't disprove.

All of the evidence was pointing to this possibility, and we had no solid facts to point us in any other direction.

The moment we acknowledged the possibility, Caroline was absolutely dead set on finding out exactly what—or *who*—Noah was doing that night. And as you may be able to assume by now, it's hard to put a stop to her ways once she has an idea in her head. For this reason, I'm thankful that I've chosen to keep my suspicions about Summer to myself.

Although I had an overwhelming feeling of Summer's involvement at the very beginning of Noah's short disappearance, I had no way of confirming my suspicions. A feeling is just that—a feeling, but an accusation as serious as this one would need much more damning evidence before I considered mentioning it to Caroline. If the two really did hook up, I'm pretty certain that she would kill Summer with her own bare hands, and there would be nothing I could do to help either of them.

In order to hopefully clear Summer of involvement, I've arranged for her to come to our dorm tonight. Caroline will be gone tonight, so I'll have the opportunity to ask Summer any questions that relate to her sudden disappearance at the mixer.

I'm hopeful that this will eliminate the constant, nagging feeling of distrust for her that I've been feeling since that night.

When the sound of our front door opening fills my ears, I look up at the entrance from my bed and invite Summer—who is now standing in my doorway—into my room.

Though my bedroom is within listening distance from the living room, I felt that this would be the safest place for us to talk. If Caroline were to come home early and catch Summer in the act of confessing, I'm not even sure what would happen. Honestly, I don't want to find out.

I latch the door behind us, and we both walk over to sit atop my bed.

Summer picks up on my mysteriousness immediately.

"So," she inquires. "What did you want to talk to me about?"

She doesn't appear nervous or upset, nor suspicious of my asking her to come over here alone. I've already given some thought to what I can say to get the most information out of her regarding Monday night, so I'm fully prepared for this conversation.

I clear my throat nervously before speaking.

"I just wanted to make sure you were alright after our bathroom conversation on Monday," I say. "It seemed like something was wrong."

Her eyes flicker, and I can sense a hint of suspicion in them.

Nonetheless, she answers in a collected tone.

"Nothing was wrong," she says defensively. "But you can't say that *you* don't get fed up with Caroline sometimes. You of all people know how overbearing she can be sometimes."

Summer is right. I *do* get fed up with Caroline—more often than not. But the way she says it gives me a pang of worry. It sounds as if she's completely done with Caroline's behavior, and I don't want anything like this causing issues throughout our friend group.

"Of course I do," I state. "But she's our best friend. I know she can be irritating, but we just have to deal with it, I guess."

She shifts her stance in my bed, now facing fully towards me and leaning inward.

"But that's just the thing," she says. "I've been doing some thinking, and I remembered that we actually *don't* have to be friends with her. Think about it—you and I were friends before she came along, and we were doing just fine on our own."

Summer pauses.

“Since Caroline came around, we’ve just become victims by association of her horrific behavior.”

I quickly speak back up before she can continue.

“First of all, we were only friends for a week before she came around,” I point out. “We had just joined a sorority and were the fresh new faces on campus, so *obviously* we were doing fine on our own.”

Summer tries to cut back in, but I push on anyway.

“Second—I understand that Caroline has made some poor decisions over the years, but you have to remember that *I* used to be directly involved with those decisions.”

“But you grew up, and you became a better person,” she snaps. “I don’t think she’s ever going to, Riley.”

“You don’t know that,” I say.

Her voice is now raised, and the two of us are pretty much arguing.

“Actually, I do,” Summer asserts. “I’ve waited long enough for her to get her shit together, and I know that I deserve better than that in a friendship. And so do you.”

“I know, but—“

She cuts me off.

“Then why don’t you *do* something about it Riley?” she asks. “I’m not going to stick around and let her ruin my life. I thought you were smart enough to do the same.”

On her last word, she gets up from my bed and begins to storm out of the room. Before she can crest the doorway, I run over and grab her by the wrist to stop her.

“Summer,” I say.

She spins around angrily. Since she’s seconds from leaving anyways, I ask her the burning question I’ve been holding in.

“Did you sleep with Noah at the mixer?”

She stops in her tracks, glaring intensely into my eyes with a shocked look. When she speaks again, she’s basically spitting with anger.

“I don’t know, Riley,” Summer sneers. “You’re the criminal justice major. If that’s what you think, why don’t you *prove it*?”

Before I can respond, she slams my bedroom door and departs into the living room. I hear the sound of the main door slam shut as well, and the dorm soon falls silent.

I stand in place for a few moments to collect myself after yet another strange interaction with Summer. Just as I'm about to sit down, I hear the main door to our dorm opening once more.

I open my room door, hoping to see Summer back here to apologize. Instead, Caroline is now in the common area. She immediately picks up on the shell-shocked look across my face and walks into my room.

"What happened to you?"

Though Caroline and I have discussed the possibility of Noah cheating on her this past week, I never brought my suspicions about Summer to her attention, as I thought my gut feeling must've been wrong. Now, I'm 99% sure. If Summer hadn't slept with Noah, she would've outright denied my question.

But she didn't.

It's time to tell Caroline.

"I think you should sit down," I say, gesturing towards our couch outside the room. She raises her eyebrow at me, but sits anyway. "I need to tell you something."

She leans toward me. "You're scaring me, Riles. What's going on?"

"It's about Summer," I say, pausing for as long as I can to avoid the truth.

After a long hesitation, I finally drop the bad news.

"I think she slept with Noah."

I meant to tell Caroline about my theory in a better way, but my interaction from the past half hour has left me unable to think clearly. Surprisingly, she takes a deep breath, and asks me to relay any details as to why I might think that our closest friend slept with her boyfriend.

When I finish the story of what just occurred in the dorm a few minutes ago, it's clear that she is convinced.

"I'm going to *destroy* her," Caroline says, shooting up from her place on the couch. "I knew something was off about her in the bathroom that night. She must've been plotting it all along."

"I think so too," I reply sorrowfully. "I wanted to give her the benefit of the doubt, but I don't think I can anymore."

Following a rant from Caroline that lasts several minutes, she locks herself inside of her room and remains quiet for the rest of the night.

It isn't until the next morning that I see her again, while I'm on my way out the door to walk to class. Instead of appearing angry or disheveled

about the events of the previous night, she seems to be happier than ever before.

When I run into her in the living room, she is grinning from ear to ear.

“Good morning,” she cheers. “Good luck with your quiz today.”

As I pour my coffee into my to-go cup and quickly mix in some creamer, I respond to her—disregarding her good-luck wish.

“You seem excited about something.”

Caroline nods, and keeps her response short.

“It’s nothing, really,” she says with a scheming grin. “Just that I came up with a perfect plan to get back at Summer.”

I’m already running late, and I don’t have time to stick around and hear the lengths of Caroline’s master plan yet—though I’m sure it has something to do with destroying Summer’s social life. Instead, I make her promise to relay the details to me later tonight, which she agrees to do.

For now, it will just have to wait.

27

Riley Walker

SEPTEMBER 2023

(Two Months Before)

The next Wednesday, the entirety of Alpha Omega woke up to an urgent mass-text from our chapter advisor, Eleanor.

In this message, she furiously stated that the entire chapter would need to be present for a mandatory meeting the following night—no excuses accepted. As if the angrily-worded content of the text wasn't enough, we all already know what an urgent message from our chapter advisor means.

We're all about to be in huge trouble.

When the dreaded Thursday evening comes around, Caroline and I are preparing to leave our dorm room and walk to Greek Row. As I grab my things to make the walk, my mind is racing with ideas as to what this meeting could possibly be about, and the possibilities I've thought of all seem to work out negatively for me.

Last week, Caroline promised to disclose the details of her master plan against Summer, but we never seemed to circle back to it. Deep down, I have an overwhelming feeling that tonight's mandatory meeting might have something to do with it. I hope I'm wrong, but I've found that it's best to assume the worst when it comes to her.

"Caroline," I begin, grabbing my keys. "Please tell me this meeting isn't about something that you did."

She smirks at my statement, squinting her eyes at me.

"I guess we'll find out tonight, won't we?"

We begrudgingly walk the quarter mile over to the Alpha Omega house, where the majority of the chapter is gathered in the living room. Though our sorority's house is incredibly big, it's still a tight fit to squeeze hundreds of girls into one space.

I do a quick scan of the room, hoping to find Summer's face, but it seems as if she's lost in the crowd somewhere. Her car wasn't parked outside in its usual spot, so I begin to wonder if she has somehow been excused from this little gathering.

After waiting around for several minutes and socializing with some girls in the pledge class above ours, the front doors swing open—revealing our advisor, Eleanor Stephens, and our chapter president, Juliette. The room hushes to just a few murmurs when it's clear that they have stern looks on their faces, and they're walking with a sense of serious importance in their step.

This is going to be bad.

A few seconds later, they both arrive at the front of the room where our chapter has been patiently waiting.

"I'm sure many of you are wondering why we've summoned you here today," Juliette begins, glancing around the room as she speaks. "An incident involving one or more of our members has been brought to our attention, and Eleanor is here to discuss it with you all."

She takes a step back, allowing Eleanor to stand in front of her. As soon as she opens her mouth to speak, I'm dreading the southern drawl that is about to fill my ears.

"As Juliette mentioned, I have been made aware of some behavior that is completely unacceptable for a member of Alpha Omega—a sorority."

My eyes remain stuck on her gaudy lipstick as she rambles on.

"I'd like to take a moment to allow this perpetrator to step forward," Eleanor continues. "If someone takes responsibility right now, we will avoid punishing the chapter as a whole."

Following her statement, she closes her lips and scans the room in hopes of someone stepping out of the [crowd](#). As she does this, I glance over at Caroline out of the corner of my eye, who looks as calm and collected as ever. If she has anything to do with this alleged incident, nobody would be able to tell.

After a few moments of murmuring from the crowd, nobody steps forward, and Eleanor continues.

"Alright, then."

She clears her throat before beginning her story.

"Two nights ago, one of our members was parked outside of a classroom building, where she has a 7:30-10 p.m. class. On this night, when

the member returned to her vehicle, she discovered that it had been completely vandalized in her absence. Sugar had been poured into the gas tank—destroying the engine and fuel lines, three tires were slashed, and the sides of the car were spray painted with vulgar language and graphic images.”

From around the room, I can hear several whispers and gasps in reaction to the new information. After a few seconds of silence, Eleanor begins again.

“We are giving the member responsible twenty-four hours to admit involvement,” she explains. “If ownership of the crime is taken, then like I said, the chapter will not be punished. If not—all of you can wave goodbye to any social events for the next year.”

Once she’s finished speaking, Eleanor takes a sharp turn on her six-inch heels and stomps out of the room, each shoe clicking the ground at every step she takes. Juliette takes her exit as a cue to end the meeting, and addresses the group one last time.

“I’m very disappointed in whoever did this,” she says sorrowfully. “Eleanor and I already have our suspicions, so I hope this person is very aware that they will not get away with this behavior.”

Unlike usual, her tone is stern and clipped. This must be serious.

After the meeting ends, we are all released to go home. It isn’t until Caroline and I have nearly made it back to Norman when the gears begin to turn in my head, and the context of the meeting begins to make more sense.

Summer has a 7:30 to 10 p.m. class on Tuesday nights.

Summer’s car wasn’t parked outside the house tonight, nor was she present at the mandatory meeting.

Just a few days ago, Caroline told me that she had plans to get back at Summer, and now her car has potentially been vandalized and destroyed.

I’m starting to think that these similarities are more than coincidental.

“So,” I say to Caroline as we walk. “That was you, right?”

She nods her head, grinning as widely as she was the other night.

“Of course.”

I don’t know what to say. Caroline has done some pretty terrible things to people throughout our time at Cabot, but this is taking it to the next level.

This is vandalism.

This is a felony.

This is jail-time.

I can't believe she's even laughing about something like this.

"Caroline, that is a 30,000 dollar car," I shout. "If you get caught, you're absolutely screwed. For real this time."

She shoves a hand over my mouth and scans the area for other people, visibly annoyed by my outburst.

"First of all, keep your voice down. Second—it was a \$35,000 car."

She looks around once again before finishing.

"And third," she says. "That bitch is lucky I left her a tire after she fooled around with my boyfriend behind my back."

The anger that I expected to see from Caroline all along has clearly bubbled to the front, and she is no longer as calm and collected as she's been acting the past few days.

"Summer probably already told them it was you," I snap at her.

I'm nearly 100% sure that she would have already mentioned it to Juliette and Eleanor. Summer's very first suspect would easily be Caroline, especially in light of recent events.

"I doubt that," she smirks. "Let's just say I left her a little message that should more or less guarantee her silence."

I stop her at this sentence.

The more I hear about what she did to Summer's car, the more of an accessory to the crime I am. I may defend Caroline to the ends of the Earth, but I draw the line at sacrificing my future career over a love triangle.

Once we reach Room 433, I lock myself into my room and head straight for the bed. I lay on my phone for several hours, watching the messages flood into my phone regarding the situation today. After reading and responding to several, I notice a new message popping up in my inbox from my sister.

9:10 PM

SERIOUSLY? NO ANSWER?

I've been regularly ignoring her messages all month, and I can't bring myself to respond to this one either—so I *especially* won't be answering her request for help on her Cabot application. In addition to everything that's happening within my immediate social group, the last thing I want to deal with is my sister.

She's psychotic.

Now that my phone is no longer a safe space, I throw it face-down on my sheets and flop onto the bed, preparing to go to sleep.

Maybe in my dreams, my life won't be falling apart.

28

LEIGHTON

2024

I've officially invited Nathan to tomorrow night's date function.

The two of us spent the day together roaming the streets of Brookwood and testing out local restaurants. Halfway through our hangout, I decided that it would be a perfect time to ask him if he wanted to come.

Nathan was overjoyed when I invited him, and he's been talking about potential outfits he could wear ever since. As he drives into the Norman Hall parking lot to drop me off, he's describing a bright blue suit he owns to me in very specific detail.

"Do you have anything pastel yellow?" I ask.

"I don't really know what pastel yellow is, but I'll look it up later," he says. "When should I pick you up tomorrow?"

I give him a specific time of seven o'clock, then head inside the building.

Once I'm back in our dorm, Alison greets me in passing as I walk past her room to reach my own. I get distracted in the bathroom while fixing my hair for a moment, but I eventually head into my bedroom.

That's when I notice it.

The moment I walk in, it's evident to me that a few things are out of place from how I left them earlier. My desk drawer has been left slightly ajar—which I would never have done—and a few of my class papers have been rearranged. My memory never fails me, and I know that I didn't leave it like this.

I thoroughly peruse the room for any other missing objects, but find nothing else that comes to mind.

Immediately, I walk over to Alison's room.

“Did you have anyone over today?” I ask.

She nods brightly, as if she’s unaware that anything has happened.

“Ashley and Kimberly came over for like, half the day,” she replies.

“They were trying on a few of my dresses for Kentucky Derby tomorrow. They just left, actually.”

“That’s fun,” I say, hoping she won’t pick up on my intensity and hold back any important information. “Do you know if they went into my room at all?”

Alison frowns, then thinks for a moment.

“Not while I was here, but I did leave the dorm for a while to meet Imani downstairs—I’m borrowing her heels.”

She begins to read my concerned expression and shifts her tone.

“Is something wrong?”

It takes a second for me to decide if I want to accuse one of them of going through my belongings, but I can’t think of another possibility as to why my things were moved.

“A few things on my desk were misplaced, and it wasn’t that way when I left,” I disclose to her. “But I’m sure they wouldn’t do that.”

“Definitely not,” she agreed. “Is there anything missing?”

I shake my head. “No. I’m sure I’m just overreacting.”

The thing is, though—I’m not overreacting. I know for a fact that someone went into my room, I just can’t be quite sure of *why*. Other than my case files, I have nothing in my room that’s worth hiding.

So why would Ashley or Kimberly be looking for anything?

Although this thought continues to plague me for the rest of the night, I try to push it aside. Tomorrow is my first Alpha Omega date function, and the theme is so exciting. My dress is beautiful, my date is perfect, and I’m going to get to spend time with all of my friends. I can’t let this ruin my experience.

Besides, maybe I’m just looking too far into things. Maybe Ashley or Kimberly just wanted to borrow something from me, but were unable to ask me since I wasn’t here. Plus, there was nothing incriminating inside my drawer, so I can find relief in knowing that my investigation can still remain secret to everyone—except Nathan, of course.

Tomorrow is a new day.

Everything will be fine.

I hop in the shower to complete my full-body routine, and the water helps to wash away the excessive thoughts. Afterwards, I step into the main bathroom area to quickly apply my self tanner.

While I begrudgingly swipe the dark liquid across my skin, I get a flashback to my high school prom, where everyone was first introduced to pre-event spray tans. I never thought I would be getting ready for a formal event again, so I wasn't prepared to complete a full self-makeover just yet.

Nonetheless, I'm laying in bed with heartless curlers in my hair and a fresh coat of tan on within fifteen minutes.

The final touch of the night is to paint my nails and toenails, which takes longer than expected. As I'm waiting for them to dry, Nathan and I exchange text messages about what outfit he should wear tomorrow. He found out that one of his roommates has a bright yellow button-down that perfectly matches my dress, which he plans to pair with white khaki shorts. I have to say—his excitement about the fashion aspect of my function is pretty adorable.

Before I can even wish him a goodnight, my eyelids begin to fall, and I'm asleep before the clock strikes eleven.

29

Nathan picks us up at 7:30 p.m. on the dot.

Alison stayed true to her word of attending the function alone, so it's just the three of us in the car together on the way to the pregame. Though it may seem like a drab experience, we make the two-minute ride over to the Alpha Omega house as fun as we can in preparation for tonight's event.

Alison and I have already been drinking for two hours, so we're already way ahead of Nathan, who has stayed sober for our drive over. Despite our drunkenness, we've both managed to keep our dresses stainless as of now, which is a great personal accomplishment for me.

As soon as we pass through the entrance, it's clear that the house is filled to the brim with people. The men are all surprisingly dressed to the nines—a feat I thought was impossible for fraternity boys—and every girl is dolled up to perfection. Large flowers and bows stick up above the heads in the crowd from the girls' fascinators, and the mix of pastel spring colors makes for an aesthetically pleasing view of the crowd.

Nathan catches up with some of his fraternity brothers that have been invited to the function, so Alison and I decide to make our way around the function to greet our friends.

We quickly locate Maeve and Imani in the backyard, who have brought the two guys they met at Roxy's as their dates. We talk to them for a few minutes, but we eventually realize that they'd rather be getting one-on-one time with their new men, so we decide to vacate to a different area of the house.

Ashley spots us from the kitchen and waves us over to the area where she's standing. When we arrive, she introduces us to her date—another Theta Mu member.

"This is Leighton Adams," Ashley says, gesturing to each of us as she speaks. "And Alison Hartnell."

He vaguely acknowledges us, then introduces himself.

"I'm Jake," her date says, then turns toward me. "You're here with Nathan, right?"

I confirm his question with a nod, which somehow makes him want to speak to me even more than before.

“Nathan’s in my pledge class, so we’ve been through a lot of hazing together.” He laughs to himself. “We lived in the Theta Mu house together too.”

“We’ve been talking for a few weeks,” I say. “He seems pretty great—*so far* at least.”

Though I say the last part jokingly, the tone of our conversation suddenly shifts.

“He’s a good guy, really,” Jake says—shaking his head sorrowfully as he speaks. “I’m glad he got past all that stuff last year...he definitely seems to be doing a lot better now.”

I’m not sure how to respond to this, so I stand there in silence as Jake finishes his sentence.

“It’s good for him to have someone like you to help him with everything.”

Confused by what he means, I press him to elaborate.

“What stuff from last year?” I ask.

As soon as he realizes that I’m in the dark as to whatever he’s talking about, he sucks through his teeth and looks away—almost as if he’s just revealed something he wasn’t supposed to.

“My bad, man,” Jake says with his hands thrown in the air. “He told me he was going to talk to you about everything, so I just thought...”

I continue to press him to tell me, but he still seems worried about what he’s already let slip.

“I’ve already said too much,” he says. “Maybe you should talk to him.”

Before I can inquire any further, he disappears into the crowd of people behind me. It’s not until I hear Alison’s voice from behind me that I’m suddenly snapped back into reality.

“What was he saying to you?” she asks.

“Nothing,” I reply—still in deep thought.

Before I have any more time to think, I’m turning around to search the house for my date. He has some explaining to do.

“I need to go find Nathan,” I yell back to Alison. “I’ll find you as soon as I’m done.”



It takes nearly twenty minutes to locate Nathan, but I eventually find him a little more than half an hour before we're supposed to get on the bus to head to the venue. As soon as I find the right moment, I pull him into one of the vacant bedrooms on the first floor of the house and direct him to sit down on the bed.

"Leighton," he says, reading my expression and treading lightly with his words. "Is everything okay?"

"I was just talking to Ashley's boyfriend," I say. "Did something happen to you last year? What is he talking about?"

My question was evidently unexpected, because his jaw drops suddenly when I'm finished talking. He can tell by my seriousness that there's no getting out of this conversation, so he quickly shifts his posture and grabs my hand.

"Do you want to talk about this right now, or do you want to wait until after the function?" Nathan asks carefully.

I'm unsure of what he might have to say, so I don't know how to answer.

"What would you suggest?"

"Let's do it later tonight," Nathan says quickly. "We'll talk as soon as the function is over, I promise."

I hesitate to agree, but our bus leaves soon, and we don't have time for an important conversation right now. Still—I have to say, it's going to be really hard to keep my mind off this all night.

"Okay," I say begrudgingly. "But that means *as soon* as it's over."

Though I've agreed to his terms, I'm still internally angry about his secret-keeping. Clearly whatever he's hiding is bad enough to warrant a serious conversation, and I'm finding that fact pretty hard to ignore.

As soon as I'm back with everyone else, I quickly track down Alison and inform her that we are going to give Nathan the silent treatment for the rest of the night. She agrees instantly, and the two of us spend our remaining time at the Alpha Omega house finishing our drinks and dancing to the music blasting on the speakers.

The buses eventually arrive, and Juliette announces that we each need to be seated on our assigned bus within the next five minutes. Reluctantly, I

track down Nathan in order to check us into our seats, which only takes a moment.

Being friends with the person who plans these events — Ashley — has its perks after all, because Alison has been assigned to the seat right beside mine. We both hold strong to our silent treatment agreement against Nathan for the majority of the ride, which he immediately picks up on.

Eventually, he gives up on talking to us and slouches down in his seat until we pull past the tall gates of the venue.

The venue itself is a mansion, to say the least. Factoring in the Grecian-style look, the size of the building, and the spouting marble fountain that sits in the middle of the circular driveway entrance — I would say this place cost roughly one-hundred grand to book out for a three hour date function.

The inside of the venue is even more beautiful than the outside. Crystal chandeliers cascade from the ceiling — which appears to be made from some sort of opalescent tiling. The brightly lit walls are filled with paintings of the Seven Wonders that are framed in gold, and marble sculptures of historical figures watch over each pair of doors within the mansion. While a Greek mansion technically isn't the most fitting setting for a horse-racing themed event, this is quickly made up for by the perfectly-selected decorations that Ashley has chosen for the event.

A massive wall of light pink roses comes into view as soon as we enter the check-in area, and a bright white light strip in the shape of a horse illuminates the room ahead. A bouquet of pastel-toned roses sits atop each table-clothed setting, and strands of flowers outline each table and chair. I can't even imagine how long it took to decorate this incredibly massive space.

As Nathan and I check in at the entrance to the ballroom, I notice that he's still in a solemn mood. I start to feel the slightest bit of guilt, given that I brought him here in the first place and now I'm making it absolutely miserable for him. Then again, it's clear that he is keeping something from me, and I can't act like everything is normal until I know what exactly that is.

Despite everything, I decide that it's still important to try and enjoy my first sorority function, so I turn to Nathan and extend an olive branch the moment we arrive at our table.

"Sorry," I say, punching his shoulder playfully. "I've always been a bit of a grudge-holder. I'll stop giving you the silent treatment for now."

He laughs lightly, but still appears a bit down. “For now?”

“For now,” I repeat. “Until I hear what you have to say, at least.”

He agrees to this, and the two of us part ways for the time being.

Luckily, I spot Alison and Imani near the ballroom floor in under a minute, and we spend the next half hour dancing all of the alcoholic drinks out of our system. By the time we’re done, all of our fascinators have settled around our necks instead of the tops of our heads, and our hair is a mess.

When we’re all seated again, my thoughts begin to wander to where Summer might be. She definitely wasn’t at the pregame—though she lives in the Alpha Omega house—and I haven’t seen her in the ballroom at all.

Yet again, another investigation-related topic is plaguing my thoughts on a night that I’m supposed to be having fun.

Right as my mind latches onto Summer’s absence, I notice Ashley and Kimberly passing by the area we’re sitting, and I immediately wave them over to us. Even in my drunken haze, I completely forget about my theory of the two of them rooting through my desk, and instead am still focused on locating Summer.

“Have either of you seen Summer tonight?” I ask.

Ashley cringes.

“She couldn’t make it,” she says. “Food poisoning, apparently.”

Great excuse, Summer.

I wonder what she’s actually doing right now.

“Oh no!” I paste on a smile as I speak, praying that they can’t sense my obvious dislike for their close friend. I thank them for their help, and they are quickly back on their way towards the buffet section.

Soon, dinner is served, and the rest of the night flies by.



I spent the entire second half of the date function dreading the imminent talk between Nathan and I later tonight, and was barely even able to stomach any of my food at the venue.

Now, the time has come and we’re in my room, and I’m seconds away from learning the truth. I don’t know if that’s a good thing or a bad thing.

Nathan confidently leans forward before speaking, clasping his two hands between his knees. I can tell that he’s been planning this delivery all

night, and my heart beats in anticipation of what he might say.”.

“To understand my side of things, you have to realize that I went through a lot last year,” he begins. “I lost both of my grandparents, and my classwork was reaching its pique volume. It was harder than ever to keep up with my grades, and I couldn’t do it on my own.”

He pauses for a minute, but I urge him to continue.

“When things got too hot to handle, I made some...questionable decisions.”

He hesitates.

“Like what?” I ask.

Nathan drops his head.

“Like drugs, Leighton. I was hooked on prescription pills for pretty much the entire fall semester,” he says sorrowfully. “That’s why whenever you ask me about the girls’ disappearance, I can barely give you any details. My memories of the Fall 2023 semester are limited, and I was in and out of rehab five days a week during the bulk of the investigation.”

He pauses before leaning forward to go on.

“But I swear, after a few months of therapy and help from my family, I got my life back on track.”

I’m not sure how I should react to this.

On one hand, I appreciate his honesty, and the reveal wasn’t as bad as I was expecting.

On the other hand, a drug addiction is serious to me. I also can’t get rid of this burning feeling in the back of my head that this alleged *memory loss* could mean something more serious than he’s letting on.

“So,” I press. “What were you like when you were on these pills?”

It’s clear that he doesn’t want to answer this question at all. Thankfully, he takes my interrogation like a champ and responds in detail.

“Angry. Violent. You name it,” Nathan lists. “I’m not proud of it, Leighton. But I think you deserve to know these things about me, and I hope that you don’t think of me any differently.”

I remain silent. I’m not ready to make that guarantee just yet—I need time to think first. Just as I’m about to send him off, he speaks again.

“There’s one more thing...”

His eyes are now refusing to meet my own, and I can tell that he’s about to disclose something worse than the drug habit. Since I feel that it’s my turn to take things like a champ, I sit down for his reveal.

“Go on,” I say, crossing my legs in preparation.
Nathan takes a deep breath.
“I slept with Riley Walker.”

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I have no clue how to respond.

From our second meeting, I have mentioned Riley's name nearly a hundred times, and Nathan never felt it was necessary to tell me that he slept with her last year.

This goes beyond manipulation in my mind.

Though he is speaking to me in the background of my thoughts, I can barely process anything he's saying.

"It was only one time, and I don't even remember it— I just know it happened," Nathan swears. "I can swear to you that we only ever hung out twice, and it was just a one night stand. It didn't mean *anything*, Leighton."

He continues to beg for my forgiveness for the next several minutes, but I still haven't had time to think about anything. This is a lot to process, and I can't tell him whether I believe him or not until I've had time to reflect on the information at hand.

For this reason, I need him to leave.

Immediately.

"Thank you for telling me," I say nicely. "But I need to think about everything for a little while, and then we can talk."

I pause for a moment.

"For now, I think you should probably go."

Resentfully, he gets up from his seat and heads toward my door to leave. Just before exiting, he leans back to say something.

"I had a great time with you tonight," he says. "Thank you for bringing me, and I'm sorry you had to find everything out this way."

He turns and leaves before I can think of anything to say. As soon as I'm positive that he is gone, I let out a long breath that I hadn't realized I was holding the entire time.

I can't believe that any of that just happened.

Nathan has been my person of interest, my friend, and my partner in crime since I got to campus. It's hard for me to think that he has been

keeping such a huge secret from me the entire time. What's even harder for me is the fact that I never saw it coming.

I fully trusted him, and now I'm unsure of what to think.

Of everything I learned tonight, by far the most disturbing thing that Nathan disclosed would be his lack of memory from the time period of Riley and Caroline's disappearance and investigation. He claims that he can't remember anything from that semester whatsoever, starting from the moment he began taking substances that made him behave violently. If he can't remember anything, who's to say he had nothing to do with what happened to them?

And to make matters worse, he had hooked up with one of the girls—Riley. How could I possibly look past this information? The combination of his addiction and his personal connection with Riley makes him look undeniably guilty of something, I'm just not sure what yet.

I need to tell Alison about all of this as soon as possible, but I have no idea where she is. When all of us got off the buses earlier, she told me she was dropping by Imani's place and then coming home immediately after, but it's been well over an hour since then. She should be home by now.

I shoot a quick text to her before resting on the couch for a while in waiting for her response.

Before I can wait much longer, the exhaustion begins to creep into my eyes, and my eyelids begin to droop.

Phone in hand, I fall asleep on the couch.



The next morning, I wake up to a text from Nathan.

10:32 AM

I'M SO SORRY, LEIGHTON. CALL ME IF YOU WANT TO TALK.

Even after sleeping on last night's discoveries, I still have no idea what to say to him right now, so I leave the message on *read*.

I'll answer him later—if I feel like it.

Afterwards, I lift myself up from my resting place on the couch to glance over at Alison's room, hoping that she'll be back by now. Unfortunately though, I'm still completely alone inside our dorm.

She must have spent the night at Imani's place, probably thinking that Nathan and I would be getting it on tonight. Little does she know, there's no chance of that happening now.

Eventually, I get the burning urge to peel myself off of the same spot that I've spent the past twelve hours, and I begin walking over to my room. It is at that exact moment when the hangover from last night kicks in, and the room begins to spin around me. Though I chugged an entire bottle of water before bed last night, it clearly wasn't enough to outweigh the sugar content of the store-brand white wine bottles that we downed at the function.

I grab a new cold water bottle from my mini-fridge and down a few painkillers before taking a seat at my desk, where I attempt to hold my head up with my hands. If I lay back down right now, I might throw up.

As I'm sitting here, my thoughts flash back to two evenings ago, when I returned home to find the items of my desk rearranged and my drawer left open. Even now, in my hungover hazy mind, I still think that someone must have come into my room in search of something—I'm just not sure of what.

Alison had mentioned the fact that Ashley and Kimberly had been in our dorm room unsupervised for a short amount of time on the same day, so it seems almost too coincidental that we had visitors within the same hour that I returned to find my belongings relocated.

The real question is: *What would they be looking for?*

Momentarily, I snap out of my lethargic state to re-check the contents of my drawer. Aside from a missing foundation bottle cap, though, nothing appears to be out of place.

Maybe I really *have* been overthinking it.

Just as I fully slide the drawer back into place, it slides slightly off its track, and I catch the sound of an unfamiliar rustling noise coming from the back of the desk. When I move the drawer again—attempting to place it back into the correct spot—the sound can be heard again, and my curiosity begins to get the best of me.

With both hands, I completely pull the drawer off its tracks and place it on the ground. When I turn back to the empty space, a gleam of tape draws my eye to a stack of index cards that are taped to the side of the desk in the space where the drawer once was.

Though I'm overwhelmingly excited about my new discovery, I take the moment to shut the door in case of Alison bringing home unexpected

visitors. If I'm reading these index cards, I'm doing it alone.

My partner-in-crime is no longer trustworthy, so this is officially a solo investigation once again.

I carefully detach the tape from the siding, then place the stack of papers upon my desk. Once I'm confident that I can piece apart the cards without ripping them, I space them out individually across the surface and order them from top to bottom. As soon as each of the fifteen cards has a place, I finally take a moment to examine them.

Some are white; some are multi-colored. It's clear that their owner has pulled them from their own backpack at varying need-based times. Each row of the cards is filled with varying series of initials and clipped paragraphs—some longer than others. Many of the entries are evidently written in anger. It's clear from the holes where the pen has roughly ripped through the page, as well as the increasingly sloppy handwriting beside underlined initials.

I'm unsure of whose room was whose when Riley and Caroline lived in our dorm last year, but I'm absolutely certain that this stack of cards belongs to one of them. The nasty comments made about their peers in these entries mirror the behavior that I've heard so much about from those who talk about the girls, and this has them written all over it. Once I uncover exactly what these are, and what person each pair of initials stands for, these cards could be the key to solving my investigation.

Especially since I'm one hundred percent sure that the Brookwood Police Department never saw this.

I sit back in my seat, flipping over the paper that was atop the stack when I first removed it. The blank spot at the top of the index card is filled with gel-pen writing, and I notice an identical title above each few sets of initials.

The writing itself at the top of the cards intrigues me, and I lean in closer to examine it. In cursive lettering, it reads:

The Hot Sheet.

31

Riley Walker

OCTOBER 2023

(One Month Before)

It's been nearly two weeks since either of us have had any contact with Summer.

We've seen her several times in various social settings—like the bid night parties and our shared class—but she makes sure to sit or stand in the farthest place from us at all times. Many of the times I've seen her she's been clinging to the hip of Ashley Worthington, who seems to be her new friend.

Personally, I don't mind her replacing us. Her recent behavior has been a constant drain on my life for the past few weeks, and I have been sleeping more peacefully without her in my life. As expected, though, Caroline isn't so thrilled about it.

By now, word of Noah and Summer's involvement has spread within the sorority, and the majority of the chapter has taken Caroline's side in the matter. Not Ashley.

Other than a quick chat we had on the night of the mixer, I've never spoken to her, so I've been unable to make out her reasoning for befriending the current outcast of the chapter. I had assumed it was some type of performative social charity, but Caroline's theory is a bit more credible. She thinks that Ashley could only benefit from a friendship with Summer if she is hiding a secret of an equally shocking nature. For that reason, she's been scrambling to uncover any sort of dirt there is to find on her.

But it's all been to no avail.

Ashley is seemingly perfect—on paper, at least. She spends more time in the classroom than anywhere else, and her dedication to her future medical career is admirable in a way that nearly makes me sick. If that

wasn't enough, she's now considered a shoe-in for next year's Alpha Omega Executive Board.

Everything in her life appears to be going swimmingly, and I'm not sure if even Caroline could dig up something negative about her.

Nonetheless, I know she'll die trying.

One positive thing that has come from this whole situation is that Caroline has backed off of Gracie Franklin and her other victims—given how overwhelmed she has been while dealing with the Noah and Summer disaster.

As of right now, she and Noah are broken up, but they've been together every single night in secret. I had assumed that the public humiliation of the situation would finally get her to be done with him for good, but I guess I was wrong about that.

I'm keeping my fingers crossed that this whole disaster can be a learning opportunity for her. Whether she knows it or not, Summer claimed she only slept with Noah after Caroline started being such a terrible friend—meaning this entire situation could've been avoidable by simply being nicer. The two of us are sophomores in college now, and we have to grow out of these vicious behaviors and actions eventually.

I'm not sure why it is taking her so long to realize that.

Other than her several midnight rendezvous with Noah, Caroline has mostly been spending time in our dorm room. She can't spend any time with him in broad daylight, so she's been attached to my hip for weeks. Dinners at The Starship, trips to the grocery store—you name it, she's been by my side for it.

Although this would usually get annoying to me after a while, her attitude has been better than ever, so it's actually been quite enjoyable to be around her so often. I think that the constant extortion causes more of a drain on her life than she'd like to expect, and that she's finally getting a taste of freedom without it.

But she would never admit that.

In hopes of convincing her to break up with Noah tonight, I've proposed going to dinner at our favorite restaurant sometime this evening. She instantly agreed, and we both decide to eat at seven.

As I'm blending the concealer underneath my eyelids, I catch Caroline's silky red hair peeking into the doorframe through my peripheral vision.

“I’m ready whenever you are.”

“One minute,” I reply. “I’ll be right out.”

I quickly brush on the remainder of my makeup before grabbing my purse and heading out the door with Caroline in tow. As we walk to my parking space, I notice a wide smile stretching across her face.

“What are you so happy about?” I ask.

“Nothing,” she teases. “Maybe I just woke up on the right side of the bed today.”

That sounds ominous.

“It makes me nervous when you’re excited,” I confess with a laugh. “It normally means you’ve done something bad.”

Caroline is grinning even wider than before. “It depends on how you define ‘bad’.”

I stop in my tracks before unlocking my car, my hand hovering above the door handle. “Oh god. You didn’t kill Summer or something, did you?”

I say it in a light tone, but I’m only half joking.

“I wish,” she laughs. “I added her name to *The Hot Sheet*, but other than that, I haven’t even thought about her.”

I shoot a skeptical glance at her as I turn the key in the door, and we sit down in the blazing-hot car.

“Really, though,” Caroline continues. “Slashing her tires with a steak knife totally mellowed me out, I swear.”

One thing I’ve learned about Caroline is that—when she repeatedly insists that she’s fine—she never is. The more she tries to convince me that she’s gotten over this Summer situation, the less inclined I am to believe her.

Still, I play into her little game.

“Then what *did* you do?”

She stretches back in the passenger seat, now absently scrolling on her phone. “I’ll tell you when we’re there. I’m too hungry to think right now.”



Fifteen minutes later, I’m making the familiar left turn into the Marciello’s parking lot. This place has been our favorite local restaurant since the first few weeks of freshman year, when a few of the older sorority

sisters took us here for a sisterhood date. We come here at least once every other week, and the servers know our orders by heart at this point.

We walk past the “Seat Yourself” sign just inside the door and claim a corner booth with a window view of the street. The waitress comes around with our regular drink order, then asks if we’re having the usual today — Gnocchi Alla Sorrentina and Pasta Primavera—which we confirm.

The food will take a few minutes to come out, so I figure this is the perfect opportunity to find out what Caroline is so chipper about.

“So,” I begin. “Are you going to tell me?”

She blushes, which automatically confirms to me that whatever she is going to tell me has something to do with Noah.

“Well...” She slowly sips from her cup, antagonizing me with her ability to draw things out to the farthest extent. “I broke up with Noah.”

That’s not what I was expecting.

“Really?” I ask. “Thank God.”

“I know,” Caroline begins with a sigh. “Things just couldn’t be the same again after I found out what he did. I don’t even know how many times they...you know...*did what they did*, but I think it was more than once. It’s bad enough that he cheated on me, but to embarrass me like that? It was unforgivable.”

I’ve been waiting weeks to hear Caroline say these exact words, and I couldn’t be happier that she’s finally seeing what we’ve all been seeing.

I take a swig from my drink. “He wasn’t even that hot anyways.”

She raises an eyebrow at me.

“Okay,” I admit defeat. “But seriously, Noah had no personality at all.”

She snorts. “Maybe he and Summer are perfect for each other then.”

On that word, the waitress arrives with our entrees, and we spend the remainder of the time eating quietly.

When the time comes to pay for the food, I tell Caroline that I will cover the cost since dinner was my suggestion. I walk to the counter with our pre-printed check, but I quickly notice that nobody is manning the cash register at the moment. They’ve been notoriously short-staffed as of late, so I know it could possibly be a while before I get to pay our tab.

Instead of sitting back down while I wait, I peruse the brochure stand that sits beside the counter area. Each flyer is coated with a thick layer of dust, and it’s obvious that nobody has taken one from the stack in several

years. The stand presents several tourist destinations and local attractions, including state parks and serene locations.

Maybe one of these could be a good place for Caroline and I to go to get her mind off things.

I swipe a brochure off the stand before noticing that someone is now manning the counter, so I pause my action to go pay our bill. The regular cashier greets me in her sweet, southern-Alabama accent that I'm so used to, and quickly settles our tab with a hefty discount. Afterwards, we say our goodbyes to the staff and exit the building, then make the short drive back to campus.

When we're nearing the stop sign before our dorm building, we slow down across from a brand-new silver sedan that looks similar to Summer's old car prior to it being vandalized.

Even from all the way across the intersection, I can see her familiar brunette hair and thin-framed face through the windshield—it's Summer.

Caroline seems to have noticed her presence as well, because she stares at the car as it passes. She mutters under her breath with a laugh.

"I guess Daddy bought his little angel a new car."

"Well," I reply. "I guess she couldn't walk to class forever."

From my spot in the driver's seat, I try to read Caroline's face for any signs of bitterness or anger. I'm still positive that she is plotting something against Summer, and I'm scared that I won't be able to stop it if she doesn't let me in on the plan beforehand. She didn't tell me about the vandalism until several days after it happened, and that was only because I made the connection from Eleanor's speech.

She got lucky with that whole situation. Summer was too embarrassed by Caroline's reasoning to press charges, and she didn't want to admit to her father that she had slept with her best friend's boyfriend. Instead, she passed it off to both her family and the sorority as a random act of vandalism by local hoodlums. I'm nearly a hundred percent certain that they could tell she was lying, but nonetheless, they couldn't do anything about it.

If Caroline's behavior gets any more irrational than it's been in the past few years, I'm worried her next scheme will buy her a ticket to the county jail—ruining any future career opportunity for herself.

I hope she isn't planning anything.

I hope she can move on from this situation with grace.

I hope she can learn to live life like a normal person.
But only time will tell.

32

LEIGHTON

2024

It's hard to understand exactly what I'm reading.

The use of initials instead of names makes for a guessing game as I read each entry, and there are zero signs of a date or time on any of the cards—making it unclear when each one was written. I've now made it through nine of the eleven cards in the stack, and each one has been more confusing than the last.

So far, the third card in the collection has been the only one to yield any helpful information.

On this one, I was able to find an entry labeled with the initials *MB*, which stated that the referenced person had “flirted with the wrong man”. This section was connectable to Maya Belton given the details I've been told about the situation, and the list of Cabot business courses listed below her section. These are likely the names of the classes Maya was taking when Caroline cooked up the cheating scandal, as she would've needed to know which classes Maya was testing for that week.

The following cards yield little-to-no useful information, and I'm still unable to make specific connections to the majority of the initials. Disappointingly so, because the entries on these papers are filled with shocking revelations and about the lives of our fellow students—presumably all of whom are members of Alpha Omega and Theta Mu. These girls certainly did their research on their fellow peers, because there are over fifty sets of initials throughout the varying cards.

Since I'm striking out on pairing names with monograms, I take a moment to update my case notes with the exact words written under Maya Belton's entry—just in case it becomes of any importance later down the line. As of right now, this is the only case of blackmail that I have any proof of the girls' involvement in, so it's crucial that I keep everything

documented. After all, I've been unable to derive any important details from any other entry so far.

Just as I am beginning to get discouraged, I notice a pair of initials on the tenth card that ring familiar to me.

The Hot Sheet (#10)	
GF —	Selling pills out of the ao house
—>	75 % of proceeds to me
—>	*is sending me her customer list
Ba + Mp —	Pulled over after party, <u>DUI</u>

Though this could be about anyone, the initials “GF” immediately make my brain jump to Gracie Franklin—the girl who yelled at me at the White Rose Ceremony. Given her behavior that evening, I wouldn’t even be remotely surprised if Gracie was on some sort of drug. She was absolutely neurotic.

The girl makes great fake IDs, but she’s a massive bitch.

My thoughts trace back to that moment, when she embarrassed me in front of the room full of recruiting members. She had told me to “watch my back”, and even stated that I wasn’t off to a great start in the chapter before storming out of the room. Following this interaction, Juliette came around to explain away Gracie’s behavior.

In our short conversation, Juliette had passed off Gracie’s outburst as emotional troubles from recent personal events—but I soon learned from Maeve that this wasn’t necessarily true. She had mentioned to me that—according to another member—Gracie was not allowed to recruit the previous year due to her uncontrollable attitude, and that she’s been an attitude problem since the moment she joined the chapter.

Could her actions be attributed to a drug addiction?

Or even the fallout of a bad business deal?

I'm also not sure what to make of the bullet points below the entry. The addition of "75% of sales" and "Is sending me her customer list" makes me think that either Riley or Caroline could've been involved in this alleged drug business, but I'm hesitant to jump to any conclusions just yet. The world of drug trafficking is a dark place, and if I go down that road, I might find myself in a situation where I'm in over my head.

In hopes of confirming my suspicions about the purpose of these cards, I peruse the remaining entries on the tenth sheet. I spend a minute analyzing the sets of initials in hopes of finding a matching person for each one, but I'm striking out on the rest of these. The previous cards held little information for this same reason—it's almost impossible to match initials to full names when I've hardly met anyone yet.

Eventually, I give up on the tenth *Hot Sheet*. These names are clear of no relevance to me, or else I'd be able to determine them easily. Finally, I place my hand over the final card in the stack.

Just as I'm about to flip it over, though, I hesitate.

Assuming that these sheets are the handiwork of Riley or Caroline, this last card could contain a critical piece of information regarding the investigation. Although this could be great for my investigation, a wave of pressure begins to fall over me, and I feel an internal conflict beginning inside me.

If I discover something important, do I bring it to the police? In theory, it seems like the right thing to do. But as I've heard time and time again, the Brookwood Police Department is notorious for overlooking important case information to hide their own incompetence. I wonder if things would still be the same way, even if undeniable evidence is thrown directly in front of their faces.

After a long moment of consideration, I carefully flip the card. I'll make my decision once I've seen what's on it.

The Hot Sheet (#11)
NM — ADDICT . <i>WRONGED US</i>
-> next money source?
SH — Slept with NB!!! HOMEWRECKER
AW — SLEPT with PROF D for ADMISSION INTO CABOT

Immediately, I'm able to connect Nathan to the entry at the top of the card. The timeline would match up with everything he has told me, and as I recently discovered, he was hooked on prescription pills at the time. It hurts to see his name listed among others who have made overwhelmingly poor choices, but I can understand why it's there.

The bullet point below his name is what interests me the most. Referring to Nathan as a potential new income source makes me think that one or both of the girls were targeting on-campus drug dealers, then holding their wishes for secrecy above their heads in exchange for hush money. Based on the accounts of their behavior from their time at Cabot, this seems like something that they would have done.

Or according to Nathan—something that Caroline would've done.

When I first mentioned the case to Nathan, he was quick to defend Riley's involvement in the extortion schemes. He claimed that Caroline had been the ringleader of the majority of these actions, and that Riley simply got sucked into that lifestyle. If there was any truth to his claims, then it's safe to assume that these cards have mostly been written by Caroline.

Then again, I'm not sure if I can actually trust a word that comes out of Nathan's mouth.

I move down to the next entry on the eleventh card, hoping I'll get lucky with making a connection. Luckily, the initials are easily recognizable.

SH.

Summer Harding.

This entry confirms that Caroline and Riley were aware of Summer and Noah's involvement—as I suspected—and that the two first connected on

the night of the mixer. This perfectly aligns with the date scribed upon the wall at the Theta Mu house that Nathan found.

Another thing I notice is that Summer's section of *The Hot Sheet* was clearly written by an angry hand—as visible by the sloppy handwriting and the harsh impressions on the paper. Based on the manner of the writing, it can be assumed that the falling out of the friend group must've happened right around the time that this was written. If Caroline was aware of what Summer did, it's hard to believe that she would have just stood idly by and let it happen.

I wish I had an idea of what she did to retaliate.

Next, I read the final entry on the card, which sits directly below Summer's section. The title of the entry reads *AW*, which my brain immediately connects to the only person I know with these initials—Ashley Worthington. Though the actions described in the entry don't seem like something Ashley would do, I can't think of anyone else with these same initials.

Clearly I'm missing some context.

Since I've known Summer and Ashley, the two of them have been close friends. Could this friendship have possibly made Ashley a target for one of Riley and Caroline's schemes? After the falling out between the main three, Caroline would probably not have wanted anyone to be in Summer's corner, and I can assume that she'd be angry with anyone who chose to support her.

By the time I've fully examined all eleven of the cards thoroughly, my mind is plagued with a million different questions.

Who are the other names on these sheets?

When they said Nathan 'wronged them', what did they mean?

What professor could Ashley have slept with?

Still, it's clear to me that this discovery has propelled my investigation to the next level.

I now have a mostly-detailed list of each victim of the girls' schemes, as long as I can match a person to each set of initials. I also have confirmation of Caroline's knowledge of the Noah + Summer affair, and reason to believe that Ashley was being directly blackmailed by the girls as well.

Despite my confusion about what I've learned, one thing is clear.

My suspect list just got a whole lot bigger.

A few days after my discovery of *The Hot Sheet*, an idea came to mind in the middle of the night.

Now, I'm standing in the third-floor hallway of the Alpha Omega house—hoping my grand idea will come to fruition. I've struck out on the first two floors, and this is my last chance to find anything useful.

From my jacket pocket, I pull out a folded sheet of paper containing a list of initials that I've compiled from the twelve cards, then fiercely begin to scan the framed photo in front of me. After a few seconds of searching, I'm able to locate a few names that could potentially match a few of the sets on my paper.

In most sororities, members are required to sit for a new photo each year that is photographed similarly to yearbook pictures. The final prints of the members are then compiled together and placed onto one composite setting—typically a plain-colored background that matches with the sorority's colors—and a title and names are then added. Once framed and finished, these are called *composites*, and they are a great way of keeping track of your fellow chapter members.

Or in my case, tracking down blackmail victims.

The third floor hallway holds the three most recent Alpha Omega composites, and I've easily been able to find several potential matches to the initials on my sheet in just a short window of time. I can't be positive that any of these girls are actually the ones being referenced in *The Hot Sheet*, but this is the best method of discovery that I could think of.

If I can find and talk to just one or two of the people mentioned on these cards, my efforts will be worth it.

"What are you doing?"

A sharp voice cuts in from behind me as I'm still nose deep in last year's composite, so I quickly hide the list of initials from sight. Once I'm

confident it's tucked away, I turn to see who is speaking to me—though I'm sure I recognize the voice already.

"Summer." I don't bother hiding the edge in my voice. "It's so nice to see you."

"Is it?" she asks.

The two of us stand for nearly a minute without speaking a word, almost as if we're in some sort of Western-style standoff. Even though no words are actually being said, it's pretty clear how we both feel at the given moment.

Summer breaks the silence with a question.

"Do you want to talk?"

I nod and quickly follow her into her room, which is only a short walk from where I was standing in the hallway. Once inside, she closes the door lightly behind us before staring at me inquisitively.

"Alright," she begins. "What's up with you lately?"

Though I know it'd likely be best to keep my composure in this situation, I haven't had a chance to speak with Summer face-to-face since the day she denied the possibility of her and Noah being together. I've been burning with rage since the moment I saw the two of them together at Roxy's, and have had no opportunity to release my anger.

Until now.

"Did you have fun the other night?" I ask. "At Roxy's?"

I raise a judgmental eyebrow as I speak, hoping she'll pick up on my accusatory tone.

"What are you talking about?" she asks in a confused tone.

I maintain my composure.

"I think you know."

Summer scans my face, then squints at me for a moment. After a while, she drops her expression and walks over to the bed, laying down casually in defeat.

"Okay," she sighs. "So what? It's not like you have some God-given right to keep tabs on who I'm hooking up with."

That's a good point. From an outside perspective, Summer couldn't possibly know how much her dishonesty would set back my investigation. Still, from my perspective, I have every reason to be angry at her.

"It's about the principle, Summer," I argue. "Aren't Alpha Omega sisters supposed to be honest with each other?"

The words felt sickening coming out of my mouth, but it was the only defense to her remark that I could come up with on the fly.

She rolls her eyes. “As if you care about any of that.”

“What if I do?”

Summer leans forward from her spot in bed. “Tell me—why exactly *do* you care if I’m hooking up with Noah? What’s it to you?”

Her words render me silent. There’s no answer to this question that doesn’t entirely reveal my personal investigation, and Summer is the absolute last person whom I would want knowing about that. After all, she’s my highest-ranked suspect at the moment.

“Oh my god,” she gasps, finding an answer in my silence. “You think I might have *killed them*, don’t you?”

My cheeks fill with heat, and I’m rendered speechless once again. After biting my lip for a moment, Summer begins to go off on a long rant.

“You have a lot of nerve, Leighton,” she fires back. “You came to this school a month ago, yet somehow you think you have everything figured out already.”

Summer waves her hands wildly as she speaks—visibly furious about my accusation against her.

“They were *my* friends, not yours, and you didn’t even know them,” she continues. “How *dare* you accuse me of something all horrific when you have no clue who they were, or how our friendship operated?”

She continues to ramble on as I attempt to find a way to respond. I’m currently trying to analyze her body language to determine whether or not she’s being honest, but I can’t get a good read on it.

Eventually, her rantings slow down, and I find a chance to cut in.

“I’m not accusing you of anything,” I say calmly—my anger temporarily sedated by her long-winded tirade. “But you have to admit, it’s pretty suspicious for you to be sleeping with your missing so-called *best friend’s* ex-boyfriend.”

I pause.

“And I know about your falling out, too.”

Summer snaps her mouth closed, glaring at me from the bed. “And what exactly do you think you know about that?”

“I think that either Riley or Caroline found out that you hooked up with Noah, and they retaliated,” I remark. “You’ve already confirmed to me that Caroline orchestrated Maya Belton’s expulsion solely for sleeping with a

guy that she had liked, so I can only imagine what she'd do to a friend who slept with someone she was *dating*."

Her lips twist even further at my statement, and I can tell I've struck a nerve. Still, she doesn't even attempt to defend herself.

"So is that a yes then?" I ask.

Summer huffs, then gets up from her place on the bed. She barrels over to the door and swings it open with force, yelling in my direction.

"I don't have to take this, especially not from you. Get out."

She gestures towards the empty hallway that is now visible through her open doorframe. On her word, I shuffle toward the door with an obvious smirk on my face. I don't even mean to appear smug as I make my way outside, but I'm sure she can read it all over me.

Just as I make it to the door, she places a rough hand on my shoulder to momentarily keep me from leaving.

"For what it's worth," she begins—a shining tear now visible in her eye. "I loved Riley and Caroline, and they would've forgiven me for what I did if they had gotten the chance. For you to have the nerve to undermine that..."

She lifts her hand and steps away, allowing the door to slam in my face without finishing her sentence.

As soon as the silence settles, I glance around the hallway to see if anyone heard the excitement, but see nobody. I guess I should be thankful for that—after all, I'm not even initiated yet. This argument might not have been the best look for me to my future sisters.

Then again, I'm not sure that I care whether I get initiated or not.

I wave goodbye to a few other members as I walk through the house and towards the exit, then make my way back down the street towards Norman Hall. On the way home, I busy up my mind by replaying the conversation with Summer in my head as many times as I can fathom.

Every detail, every comment, and every question.

During the interaction, Summer had reacted explosively to my accusations on more than one occasion. She brought up a few question-raising points, and even more reasons to establish doubt. Still, the one thing that she didn't do even once was deny involvement in their disappearance. Even during her minute-long monologue of a rant, she never made any attempt to cause reasonable doubt in my mind.

Why?

If I had been accused of hurting or killing one or two of my closest friends—say Alison and Imani for example—I would likely do everything in my power to establish my innocence. Providing an alibi, offering alternative suspects, or even relaying the reasoning behind my prior actions.

At the very least, I would say: “That’s not true.”

But she said nothing of that matter.

Without thinking, I whip out my phone and draft a text to Nathan about what just happened. It’s only when I’m halfway through with typing that I remember that the two of us are no longer on speaking terms, and my reaching out to him may cause some confusion. Looping him in on this could be useful, but I don’t want him to get the idea that things are alright between us.

Nonetheless, I need to tell *someone*.

I hold down the backspace bar on my keyboard, deleting the words I had already typed to Nathan.

That can wait.



After waiting in my room for a few hours, I finally hear the main door of our dorm room open and close.

Alison must finally be home.

I immediately slide on my slippers and rush out to her, where she is already sitting comfortably on the couch in her sweats. She reads the anticipation on my face within seconds and sits up straight in her seat, patting the empty spot beside her invitingly.

As soon as I sit down, I begin to spew off the details of my entire interaction with Summer—only leaving out the part where I basically accused her of killing her friends. Instead, I tell Alison that she made the assumption all on her own.

“That’s so weird that she would think that,” Alison says with a hint of disgust in her tone. “But honestly, I can see her being a murderer. She’s always rubbed me the wrong way...I’m not sure why.”

I let out a sigh. “I never thought poorly of her until recently. When we first joined the sorority she was always so nice to me.”

“I know,” she replies. “I thought you guys were going to be Big/ Little.” Right. I had completely forgotten about the upcoming Big/ Little reveal.

In sororities, each new member is assigned an older, more experienced sister of the chapter who is meant to serve as their mentor throughout the pledging period and onward. According to a few things I've read online, the new member and the older member both get an equal say in deciding who becomes a part of their sorority family.

Originally—like Alison—I had assumed that Summer would eventually become my Big when the reveal came around. Now, I'm not so sure.

"I wonder who I'll get now," I say. "Maybe I need to start talking to more people."

Alison laughs. "It might be too late. Kimberly told me that the reveal is sometime this week."

Great. I better hope I'm not going to be stuck with Summer—I'd rather have literally *anyone* else.

In an attempt to drive the thought out of my mind, I direct the conversation onto Alison.

"Do you think you'll get Kimberly? As your big?"

She nods. "I'll be pissed if I don't."

I get up and grab leftover pasta out of the fridge, then pop it in the microwave for two minutes. As I wait, I begin to wonder aloud about all the potential pairings.

"I wonder who Imani and Maeve will get."

Alison shrugs. "Ashley for Imani, and someone else for Maeve." She pauses for a moment, then smirks. "Or Gracie Franklin."

The both of us laugh off the idea before heading to our separate rooms for the rest of the night.

As Alison suspected, Alpha Omega's Big/ Little Reveal event is officially set for tomorrow afternoon.

Typically, the date and time of the yearly reveal is supposed to be kept secret from the younger members in order to make things as exciting as possible. In my case, Kimberly accidentally let the news slip to Alison, who then relayed the information to me, so we are likely the only people who won't be surprised tomorrow.

Thankfully, I've never been a fan of surprises anyway.

Our Vice President of Membership sent out a form in our New Member group chat, requesting for us to submit our top picks for our Bigs ranked from strongest connection to weakest. In hopes of erasing any assumption that our past two months of bonding meant something, I avoid putting Summer on my list entirely. She's the absolute last person I want to end up tied to as my sorority family.

Plus—short of killing my best friends or sleeping with their boyfriends, I'm not sure what she could possibly “mentor” me on.

Just before I make it to my bed, a text comes in from an unfamiliar phone number, and I hold my phone up to read it closely.

11:46 PM

TOMORROW NIGHT, WEAR A WHITE MINI-SKIRT AND AN EASILY-REMOVABLE TOP. I'LL HAVE AN OUTFIT WAITING FOR YOU. —XOXO, YOUR FUTURE BIG

I attempt to compare the texting style with those of other Alpha Omega sisters in hopes of finding out who is messaging me, but to no avail. The wording is pretty simple, and I can't find any specific phrases or wordings that could give away this mystery texter's identity.

Still, one thing this message *does* tell me is that Summer can't possibly be my Big. After everything I accused her of during our interaction the other day, there's no way she would text me in such a nice manner, nor would she have chosen me in the first place.

But if it's not Summer, who could it be?

I really only know a handful of older girls in the chapter, and most of them are already tied up with one of my other friends. Ashley and Imani are a shoe-in, and same with Kimberly and Alison. I'm unsure of who Maeve has her eye on, but she hasn't mentioned anyone of interest yet, so maybe I'm not the only one who will be surprised by their assignment.

Even if I end up getting a random member who I've never met, I'll be happy. Just as long as it isn't Summer.

I lay out my white mini-skirt and a pair of short beige sandal-heels at the foot of my bed, then head to the living room to confirm our wakeup time with Alison—eleven in the morning. Our pledge class is supposed to report to the Alpha Omega house at twelve, but we both know we'll need almost the entire hour to get ready.

After setting my alarms, I peacefully drift off—dreaming of the life I had before I let sorority drama navigate my personal decisions.



“Who do you think you'll get?”

As we park the car in front of the Alpha Omega house, the nerves in the car are palpable. Joining a sorority was a hard enough feat for me, but the prospect of acting excited about being assigned as the property of a girl I barely know is somehow much harder.

“No idea,” I reply to Alison. “It must be nice to already know who you're getting.”

She raises a brow as if I've said something bad.

“Don't jinx it.” Alison shudders. “There's always a chance I could get Psycho Gracie.”

We step out of the car and into the front yard, where the other members of our pledge class are dressed in minimalist outfits that will work as a perfect blank slate for their future Bigs' outfit plans. Imani and Maeve are easily visible underneath one of the shaded porch areas, so we make our way over to prevent our makeup from melting in the sun.

Imani catches sight of us once we're a few feet away, greeting us with a wide smile.

"Loving the outfits, guys."

I take a moment to examine the clothing items we've each been told to wear. Alison and Maeve are dressed in vibrant shades of pink and blue, while Imani and I are wearing similar blankly-colored skirts and heels. These outfits are a bit more casual and mismatched than what we're all used to seeing one another wear.

"I could say the same to you," Alison laughs. "Any idea what you guys are supposed to be?"

Maeve shrugs. "Mine told me to wear a pink skirt, so I'm thinking it's ballet themed or something."

"My guess is angels," Imani cuts in. "My text said to wear all white."

I've been so focused on making sure that Summer isn't my Big that I hadn't even considered what theme my white skirt may be previewing. Luckily for me, my outfit is pretty much the same as what Imani is wearing, so I can just use her answer.

"Same. Angels."

I look to Alison in order to divert the question, and she glances down at her blue mini-shorts and white tank.

"Maybe something ocean-related?" she says. "No idea, honestly."

Mid-conversation, the grand doorway begins to open, revealing Juliette and another girl who I recognize to be a member of the Executive Board. During our first few weeks of membership, we had a series of meetings with the board with a purpose of familiarizing our class with our resources, and the girl standing beside Juliette looks very similar to the Vice President of Membership—*Emma* or *Emily* maybe?

Without knowing, Juliette answers my question.

"Good afternoon everyone. Thank you all for arriving on time, you won't regret it. Today is a very special part of Alpha Omega tradition, and it will surely be one of the most meaningful moments of your membership."

She smiles softly at all of us.

"Without further adieu, I'm turning today's activities over to our VP of Membership, Emilia."

The crowd claps for Emilia's introduction, who is much more visible once she steps forward. Much like I remembered, she is a medium-height girl with short, dark hair brightened with warm-toned highlights. Her smile

appears warm and genuine—unlike a few other members I’ve met in the chapter—and for the first time today, I feel a sense of relief washing over me. Though I barely know this girl, I trust her to have made a good assignment when it comes to my Big.

Following her warm welcome, she begins to relay to the group how exactly the reveal process will work, which can be summarized as follows:

Each of us will receive a paper bag that contains both an outfit to change into, and a numbered card. The number on our card will match with a number assigned to a sectioned-off space somewhere in the living room, which has been cleared out to create a large open space for the reveal to take place. Once we are led to our allotted spots, we will be directly across from a decorated box—which our future Big will be hiding in. After we’re all in place, the reveal will commence, and we will run to our Bigs through our section.

As soon as Emilia finishes giving us the much-needed directions, we are told to remain in place while our bags are distributed—after which we can go change in the side bathrooms. It only takes a few moments for our bags to be given to us, so we head to the changing area as a group.

Once inside my changing stall, I open up the bag to get a better look at the contents. I immediately catch a glimpse of my number-card; I’ve been assigned the number six slot. Beneath the card is a folded up white shirt and a silver tinsel skirt that will fit perfectly over the skirt I am wearing, as well as a plastic bag full of silver accessories. I swap out my gold hoops for a pair of silver ones in the bag before pulling out the full outfit I’ve been given.

When I unfold the shirt, it is revealed to be a football jersey with the number two on the front and back—my last name standing in place of an actual athlete’s, and the word “*Little*” written across the front in white rhinestones. I quickly pull it over my crop top, then tie the string of silver tinsel around my lower waist.

Once I’m confident that I look half decent, I slide the lock over and step outside of the stall, where Alison is already fixing her makeup in the mirror.

She is now wearing a teal, low-cut halter dress that is carefully threaded with orange and green beads. The fabric on her left hip drapes down to her mid-thigh, and a mesh green trim outlines the cut of the dress, which gives the illusion of seaweed drifting each time she moves her leg.

It looks like the Great Barrier Reef threw up all over her, but in the nicest way possible.

“Are you a mermaid?”

I make her do a spin as I ask the question, hoping to get a better look at the full outfit she has been given.

Alison shrugs. “Must be. I’m not even half-dressed yet.”

She gestures towards a pile of jewelry on the bathroom counter which contains several starfish rings and a golden seashell crown.

“Kimberly really went all out,” I observe. “I love it.”

The second stall soon unlocks and Maeve steps out, revealing her outfit to Alison and I. She has been given a matching pink skirt and top, the latter of which is designed to look like a cropped button-down vest. A striped white ascot is tied around her neck, and a pilot’s hat in a matching shade of pink is sitting atop her head. From first glance, it’s clear that she’s supposed to be a flight attendant.

Alison squeals. “I’m so jealous. That outfit is *so* cute.”

Maeve takes a glance into the mirror I’m currently using, then squeals even louder than Alison with excitement. She quickly makes a few adjustments to her outfit, then turns and knocks on Imani’s stall.

“Hurry up,” she says. “I want to see your outfit.”

“Sorry,” Imani’s voice echoes from inside. “I got distracted. Coming out now.”

I flip around as soon as the stall door swings open, and I’m shocked to see Imani in the exact same outfit that I’m wearing. I glance down at my shirt and then back at hers, noticing that the number on my jersey is two, while hers is the number one.

Her eyes fill with excitement. “No way...”

Though I’m confused, I jump up and down with excitement along with Imani. Once the exhilaration fades, I finally cut in to ask the group what exactly our matching outfits mean.

Maeve is the first to respond. “You guys must be twins!”

“Twins?” I ask.

“It means you both have the same Big,” Alison explains. “Which also means that it probably isn’t Summer, which is great news.”

Imani nods. “That’s true. She barely talks to me, so she wouldn’t take me as a Little.”

After adding a few final touches to our outfits, the four of us make our way into the living room to take our place in each of our numbered slots. Alison was given the number ten, and Maeve is a bit further down the line with the number thirteen, but all of us are decently close together once we fall into the lineup. Just as Emilia said there would be, there are tall boxes sitting about twenty feet down from us—one for each numbered slot.

The boxes stand at about four feet tall, so I can't help but laugh to myself about the fact that all of our Bigs must be crouched down uncomfortably inside of the small space. Just as I'm about to relay the thought to Imani, she points across the room toward our specific box, which reads *DRAFTED THE BEST LITTLES* in bold black painted letters.

"Do we know anyone that likes football?" Imani asks in a concerned tone.

"Does Ashley?" I ask.

"I hope so." She leans in closer to whisper into my ear. "To be honest, I barely know anyone else."

I'm glad I'm not the only one.

"Me neither," I admit. "If we turn around and it's a random girl, let's just act excited anyways."

We both agree to the plan, then peacefully wait for Emilia to kick off the Reveal. After a few short minutes, everyone has taken their place in the line of future Littles, and she finally steps forward to speak. She relays new instructions to the group—explaining that the reveal will happen on the count of three, and that each of us must stay facing the opposite wall until the count is over. Afterwards, we will turn and run into the arms of our brand-new Bigs.

The more Emilia describes Big/ Little reveal, the cornier it sounds in my head. I'm ready to just turn around, find out who my Big is, and go back home. Thankfully, my wish is granted within the minute, and all of us are soon directed to face the wall opposite from where the boxes sit.

The sound of rustling and hushed footsteps can be heard in the background before Emilia's voice comes booming out from a megaphone. Before I know it, she is counting down from the number three amongst other voices in the large room.

Though I know they are all counting normally, the nerves in my stomach make it feel as if each number is being shouted in slow motion.

Several thoughts of nervousness swirl throughout my head as the numbers get lower and lower.

“Three...”

Please don't let it be Summer.

“...two...”

Anyone but Summer.

“...one.”

Finally, Imani and I spin around to face our new Big.

And it isn't Summer.

But I can't quite believe who it actually is.

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Juliette Lane is standing directly across from me, and Ashley

Worthington is immediately to her right.

The two of them are excitedly jumping up and down, waving for Imani and I to run to them from within the wide box. Without thinking, we grasp hands and run the short distance to where they are standing—immediately getting embraced in a group hug the moment we reach the two girls.

For a moment, I'm confused.

Is Juliette my Big?

Or is it Ashley?

Before we ran over to them, it was clear that Juliette had been directly motioning for me to come to her—not Imani. But is the president of a sorority even allowed to take a Little? I had assumed it would be against the rules in some way, to avoid favoritism or something.

When we break from the hug, I take a look at Ashley and Juliette's jerseys, which match with the ones Imani and I have on. In the place where *Little* is written on our chest, both of their shirts say "*Big*" instead.

If Juliette's shirt says Big, then she must be taking a Little this semester.

Am I the president's Little?

I tilt my head up to meet Juliette's gaze, throwing her a puzzled-but-grateful look. Despite no words being said, she immediately catches on to what I'm trying to convey.

"You guys might be confused," she laughs. "Ashley and I had the same Big, even though I'm in the class above hers. That makes us twins—and you guys cousins."

I'm still a little confused, but I try to grasp the situation anyways. I look back to Juliette.

"So you're my Big?" I ask.

She nods, and Imani turns to ask Ashley the same thing.

"And you're mine?"

Ashley and Juliette both confirm this, immediately sending our group back into a large hug now that we understand our new family dynamic. We spend several minutes taking photos, entering contact information, and creating a new group chat with the four of us. We're all so overwhelmed with excitement that I don't think to look for Alison and Maeve, who have both discovered their matches already.

After the elation fades once again, Imani and I temporarily part ways with our new family to find our friends.

We spot Kimberly and Alison within seconds, who are taking photos against an intricately-painted box that looks like a scene from a scuba-diving excursion. Kimberly is dressed as a sailor, and the box reads "Mer-made for Each Other", which I admire the cleverness of. We decide to move on without interrupting the two—we didn't want to kill their moment.

It takes a bit longer to find Maeve, who has moved outside to take photos with her Big. I recognize the girl she's been assigned as one of the older sisters who bottle-fed me vodka during Hell Week, but I can't quite remember her name. She may be a bit hardcore compared to Maeve, but that might be a good thing—your Big is supposed to be able to get you out of your shell.

We examine each and every new pairing throughout the room, making comments on whether or not we think the couples are happy with their new Big or Little. Once we've finished looking at the last few sets of girls, I make a note to myself that I haven't seen Summer at all today—I'm not sure if she even took a Little at all.

I've been so worried about running into Summer all day, but now I can't help but feel unsettled by her absence. I haven't seen her since our little chat in her room last week, and she seemed a bit deranged when I left her. Everyone we know in the chapter is here, except for her.

So where is she?

"Are you guys ready for lunch? I'm starving."

Juliette interrupts my train of thought with the question, grabbing her car keys from the area of the floor behind the box.

All of us nod in agreement, then start heading out the back door to where Juliette's car sits in the reserved President's Parking Spot. As we all pile into her SUV, I shoot out a quick text to Alison letting her know I'll be home in a few hours, and that I can pick her up later if needed.

As soon as I hit *send*, Juliette starts up the engine, and the four of us are soon pulling out of Greek Row.



A few minutes later, we are seated at a high-top table inside a lunch restaurant just a short distance from campus. The place they chose is coincidentally the same restaurant Nathan chose for us to go to one time, so I spend part of our meal pushing away the thoughts of him that naturally come to mind.

Otherwise, lunch with my new family goes extremely well.

Juliette and I actually have a lot more in common than I realized. Prior to today I had only spoken to her on a few occasions—mainly recruitment and Hell Week related things—so neither of us ever really got to know each other before.

Like me, she's an only child. She grew up in rural Virginia, so she understands what it's like to be an out-of-state student from a small, redneck town. Plus she was part of her high school's student government. With each new hobby and experience she brings up, I wonder more and more why we have never talked more before today.

Ashley and Imani seem to be clicking perfectly, but that was to be expected. As Juliette and I bond with each other, they sit across from us and laugh about varying things that Imani has pulled up on her phone. Neither of us really understand what they're laughing about, but we're happy it makes sense to them.

The only problem is, I can't shake the memory of the final entry on the eleventh Hot Sheet. The sentence was titled with the initials AW, and it claimed that this person had slept with their professor in exchange for admission into Cabot University. Ashley Worthington is the only person I know with the initials AW, and I'm almost positive the entry must have been about her.

But then again, I'm not convinced that Ashley is capable of doing something like that. From what I've seen of her, she's an incredibly nice and hardworking student, who just-so-happens to have a bit of a drinking problem. Other than her alcohol-related habits, I have a hard time seeing her breaking any other laws.

The girls must have been wrong, and even if they weren't, it must be some kind of misunderstanding. I trust her, and Imani trusts her.

I already love my sorority family, and I couldn't be happier with how things worked out. None of that matters anymore.

Things are finally starting to work out for me again, and this new family could be the start of a new chapter for me. Maybe I'll even start actually genuinely caring about my membership in the sorority, and not just use it as an informational pipeline for my investigation.

I guess we'll have to wait and see.



When we arrive back at the Alpha Omega house parking lot, Imani and Ashley immediately dash up to her room and leave Juliette and I sitting in the car. Ashley had given me the passenger's seat in order to be in the backseat with Imani, so the two of us sit in the front seats of the car playing songs on her screen display instead of going inside.

After a few moments of just sitting there, Juliette breaks the silence.

"Look, I know you might be a little confused as to why I'm your Big, and not Summer," she sighs. "I hope you're not disappointed, but some rumors have been swirling around these past few weeks about you two, and Emilia and I thought it would be best to match you both with other people."

Shit. I guess it's common knowledge that Summer and I are on the rocks. I'm internally hoping that nobody knows the details—specifically the fact that I basically accused her of murder.

"Rumors?"

She cocks her head at my question. "The Executive Board was told that you guys don't get along anymore...something about Noah Banks."

I motion my hand to cut in, but she stops me.

"You don't need to explain," Juliette says "I have my own thoughts and opinions on that whole situation, and they don't favor Summer."

She continues her explanation.

"But I had already met you a few times, and you really stood out to me during the Leap of Faith. I thought that we would make a good duo, even though I'm graduating in the spring."

"Trust me," I laugh. "You're the better option by a million."

We both say goodbye for now, and I soon climb back into my car that was just a short walk away from where we were parked.

Once inside, I turn my key in the ignition and the display comes to life—revealing the time to be 6:15. I knew we had spent a while at the restaurant, but it hadn't felt like four whole hours. I throw my car in reverse and back out of the parking lot, now making note of how dark the sky is. The sun has fallen completely behind the buildings by this time, and I have to turn on my headlights just to navigate my way out of the Greek Row drive.

Since the drive should only take a few minutes, I let the top song on my playlist play at a light volume and focus my attention on the road. Suddenly, as I roll towards the street that leads to Norman, my vision begins to be obscured by the reflection of a vehicle's bright-lights in my rearview mirrors.

The fluorescent light fills my entire car, blinding me as I attempt to pull up to the stop sign. By the time I come to a stop, the car—an SUV of some sort—is within inches of hitting my car, and the driver seems to be aggressively inching closer by the second.

I don't recognize this car.

What is going on?

Is this person trying to hit me?

My palms begin to fill with sweat as I slam on the gas and speed across the intersection—hoping they'll get stuck behind a passing car or something. Still, it's to no avail. This person is riding my tail straight through.

It's only a 200-foot straight shot to Norman Hall, but I'm worried this person is going to run me off the road before I can get there.

I'm driving as fast as I can.

And they're getting closer by the second.

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Riley Walker

OCTOBER 2023

(One Month Before)

Not much has changed over the past few weeks.

Caroline has been surprisingly okay since the breakup, and she's even found a few hobbies that make her much more tolerable. She recently joined a book club that she learned about through a girl in another sorority, and she's been spending a lot of time with the people in the group.

Normally I would be jealous of anyone stealing time with my best friend, but after weeks of constant togetherness, I'm pretty relieved to get a break.

Other than constantly making sure Caroline is okay, I haven't been doing much socially. Just last week, I decided to temporarily switch my Alpha Omega membership to a half-active status in hopes of alleviating some of the stress that's coming from my increasingly difficult academic schedule. Even though this means I won't be able to take a Little or attend many social events, it was a necessary decision.

I've always cared greatly about my academics—especially in college. I was the salutatorian of my high school, and one of the only students to be accepted into a prestigious school. My acceptance into the Bradshaw program was the result of thirteen years of blood, sweat, and tears poured into homework and exams, and I could not be more grateful to be enrolled in the classes that I'm in.

But the pressure becomes harder to deal with each day.

A few weeks into the semester, I had noticed the amount of classwork and learning material gradually increasing with each class, but thought nothing of it at the time. Sometimes college professors load their students with work the first few weeks in order to weed out the weak ones early on,

so I had simply attributed the heavy workload to that and moved on—hoping things would get easier as the semester went on.

Now, it's October, and I'm still drowning in academic-related stress.

In theory, taking a step back from my involvement in the sorority should help to alleviate my stress. Instead, I've found that the lack of constant intoxication and social distractions has significantly worsened my situation. I recognize it most when Caroline isn't home, and I'm left alone to simmer in my thoughts and stressors all day long.

On harder days, I imagine how freeing it would be to run away from it all. The overwhelming amounts of schoolwork, the endless late nights, and the heartburn-inducing anxiety of receiving an imperfect grade. Sorority drama, friend-group drama, and family drama. When I think about it, I've barely ever had a chance to lay back and enjoy life without some type of overpowering stressor in my life.

I wish I knew how to change that.

Though running away would seemingly fix everything, I could never actually go through with it. I have the funds, the ability, and the spirit to leave town and never look back, but I couldn't possibly leave everything behind. I've worked so hard to get to where I am—even despite everything I've faced with my mom, dad, and sisters. I could never just throw all of that away.

Instead, the tough times have led me to turn to a more temporary solution:

Drinking five days a week.

It may sound like a recipe for liver failure, but believe me when I say that five days a week is nothing in comparison to the drinking schedule of the average college student—especially one at Cabot University. Besides, I only have a few drinks each night, so I'd say I haven't progressed to a full-blown alcoholic quite yet. At least I'm not drinking as soon as I wake up in the morning.

Not as of right now, at least.

As I sip my white wine and finish off the last paragraph of my writing assignment, my phone begins to vibrate from an incoming call. It's Caroline.

I swipe across the screen to answer. "You never call me."

"It was easier than texting," she laughs through the speaker. "Anyways, I have a really random favor to ask."

There are chattering voices in the background of wherever she is, making it difficult to hear what she's saying.

"Okay." I turn up my speaker volume. "Let's hear it."

I hear shuffling on Caroline's end for a minute before she asks her question. "Remember when your mom and sisters came to town for Family Weekend last year, and we went to that Mexican restaurant after the Parent's Cocktail?"

I had forgotten about that weekend—or maybe I just did everything I could to push it out of my memory. That was the first (and last) time I ever allowed my family to come visit me, and it naturally culminated in a huge fight between the four of us. They all left within 24 hours of arriving, even though they had booked a two-night stay.

Good times.

"Do you remember what it was called?" Caroline asks. "Or do you have that photo we took?"

My camera roll is full of photos from date functions, parties, and events, but I eventually find the photo of the group of us at the restaurant after several long seconds of scrolling.

Caroline's family wasn't able to make it that year, so she decided to spend the day with us that night instead of skipping the family weekend activities entirely. My mom insisted on taking a group photo to mark our time together, so the five of us had a passerby snap a picture of us in front of the building.

All of us look utterly miserable in the photo—except for Caroline.

"Found it," I say as I'm hitting the share button below the photo. "But why do you ask?"

"No reason," she says suspiciously. "The girls in my book club just wanted a recommendation for a good Mexican place. Thought I'd help out."

"Mhm." I don't really believe her, but I can't think of another reason why she'd need the photo. "When are you getting back?"

The voices coming from her speaker appear to suddenly get louder, as if she's just entered a room full of people. "I'm not sure. It might be late... we're in the middle of reading a really good one right now."

"What book?" I ask.

She hesitates before answering, increasing my suspicions. "Sherlock Holmes."

I tell her to have fun, then we say goodnight and hang up the phone. Just as I said earlier, Caroline has been gone a lot recently. She's basically never home.

I guess it's just another night with me and my wine bottle.

37

LEIGHTON

2024

My foot pushes harder on the gas as I crest the hill.

The speedometer is now clocking my speed at 55 miles per hour in a 20, and the roadside speed monitors flash red and blue lights at me as I pass, but the tailgater is relentless.

I finally skid into the turn for the parking lot—my tires drifting as I come to a halt—and the car zooms past on my original path. The intensity of the situation keeps me from actually getting a look at the vehicle before it speeds off into the distance.

My heart is pounding with stress, and I can't take a deep breath in. My nervous system hasn't seemed to have registered that the danger is over yet.

I'm not really sure what just happened. For a moment, I think it's possible that I could have imagined it, but it's impossible. If that was just a run-of-the-mill reckless driver, they probably would have hit me.

No—this felt personal.

I first encountered the car when I was exiting Greek Row, so theoretically the person is a resident in that area. Their headlights were also even with my side mirrors, so the vehicle-type must have been an SUV or a hatchback like my own car.

Could it have been Summer?

She wasn't at Big/ Little Reveal today, and I haven't seen her in at least a week. I spent half of the day thinking she must be out of town, but now I'm wondering if she saw me outside the house when I got out of Juliette's car. She would have had plenty of time to run down from her room, get into her car, and drive after me.

It's entirely possible.

Whoever was trying to run me off the road must know I'm onto something, and that makes Summer my number one suspect—yet again.

I wonder if I'm closer to the truth than I realize.

Suddenly, I'm struck with an idea, and I rapidly throw my car into park and run inside the building. The elevator is taking far too long, so I run to the stairs and book it up all four flights of stairs to our room.

This cannot wait.

When I open the door, Alison is in the living room talking on the phone, and I calmly wave hello to her before quickly shuffling into my bedroom.

As soon as I'm inside, I shut my door quietly and drop to the floor beside my desk. I pull out the two larger drawers and place them beside the footspace, then shine my flashlight inside the empty drawer openings to check for any more taped-up papers or cards. When I find nothing, I repeat the process with my university-furnished dresser drawers, which I strike out on as well.

I pat around the edges of my closet, check behind the bed, and even lift my desk off the ground to check the floor underneath, but still find nothing. Just as I'm thinking that there might be no information left to find, another idea comes to mind, and I begin lifting up the corners of the carpeting throughout my room.

I sure hope this works, because if not, I'm ruining my carpet for absolutely zero reason.

The search underneath the carpeting remains fruitless for the most part. I find a few old candy wrappers from past residents, along with a few other pieces of garbage that don't help my investigation whatsoever. It doesn't seem that I'm going to find anything useful.

That is, until I check the floor in my closet.

As soon as I begin to pull up the corners of the carpet, I can instantly hear the familiar sound of crinkling paper in the back left section. Once it is completely pulled out, I carefully extract the papers and carry them over to my desk to examine them beneath the light.

On the top of the two-paper stack is a piece of lined notebook paper with a handwritten message on it, and the top of the page has a piece of tape stuck to it—as if the sheet had been stuck upon a wall prior to being placed below the carpet. The message is scribbled in a different handwriting than that on the cards I found previously, but the way it's written tells me that a girl left this message.

MEETING AT CSP @ 10:00

I flip over the paper to examine the back—finding nothing—then check the second paper in the pile. It ends up being a printed-out screenshot of a text message addressed to Caroline from someone named Taylor, who claims that she saw Summer Harding and Noah Banks sneaking off to a room in the Theta Mu house the night of a mixer—presumably the same one Nathan had mentioned to me before.

This immediately confirms to me that my room was originally Caroline's room, and that she is the one who had hidden all these items throughout the nooks and crannies of this place.

Examining the first card once again, I try to think of any place I know of that matches the initials CSP.

Could it be a store?

A restaurant?

A classroom building?

A dormitory?

On a whim, I decide to assume that the initials could possibly stand for Greek letters, so I search Cabot University's Greek Life website for a fraternity or sorority under the name *Chi Sigma Phi* or *Chi Sigma Pi*.

Luckily, a result comes up instantly.

Chi Sigma Phi is a nationally recognized fraternity at Cabot University, with the well-respected Eta Mu Chapter being officially founded in 1932. Their local philanthropy is the Brookwood Homeless Shelter, which they have raised hundreds of thousands of funds for over the past decade. The chapter currently stands at 210 members, and is housed on the Cabot University Greek Row.

Address: 106 Greek Lane, Brookwood, AL, 36850

I click the linked address button, which directs me to my Maps app. Once it loads, I'm able to see that the Chi Sigma Phi house is only four houses down from Alpha Omega, so it's completely plausible that this could have been where they were meeting.

But why would they be going there?

I've never even heard of this fraternity, let alone met anyone from it, so it doesn't make much sense for either Riley or Caroline to be meeting with a member at 10:00 p.m on a weekend. Based on the pictures from the website, these boys don't seem like the type to have late night rendezvous with sorority pretty girls. Plus, news articles had said Caroline was dating

Noah Banks up until the last few days before her disappearance, so I highly doubt she was meeting with a new guy that quickly after a breakup.

The memory of the news article piques an additional interest for me. Every excerpt I've read about the case has stated that the girls were seen leaving Norman Hall around 9:30 p.m., which was the last time they were ever sighted. Leaving their dorm room at that time would have given them plenty of time to pick up an order at Marciello's, drive back to campus, then arrive at Greek Row by 10.

Could the taped-up paper I've found have been from the night the girls disappeared?

None of the articles ever stated whether or not they checked the cameras of each sorority or fraternity house, nor did they even mention an investigation of Greek Row at all.

I wonder if the security footage went completely unchecked by police, and if this could've held vital information to the case.

If I'm right, this could be huge.

This could solve the case entirely.

I just don't know exactly what to do next.

Nearly a week has passed since my discovery, and I still haven't been able to find one single connection between the girls and Chi Sigma Phi.

The clock is ticking faster than before on my Bradshaw application, so I need to at least make a minor break in the case soon. I have until the end of November to submit my application, and it's currently the third week of October, so my time is running out rapidly. If I can't solve the investigation within the next two weeks, I'll need to come up with a completely new idea.

There's no time for that.

Besides, I need to finish what I started. From this point forward, I'm fully committing myself to solely the case, and my classes.

Since my homework for the week is already complete, I spend the next hour scrolling through every website, social media page, or internet mention of Cabot's Chi Sigma Phi fraternity, hoping to establish any potential connections to Riley and Caroline. So far, the only thing I can find is a photo from a campus cleanup in 2022, which was labeled as an event that was required for all freshmen. The girls would have been in this picture, but it's difficult to find them amongst the hundreds of Greek life members in the photo.

It's not like it matters anyways—I'm pretty positive someone wouldn't try and kill two girls over picking up garbage a year prior.

The girls' accounts are still up on social media, so I quickly browse through their following to see if they followed any of the chapter's accounts, which quickly reveals that they did not. No connections to discover on the socials, and no connections to discover on the website.

It seems like I'm back to square one.

I check the time across my phone screen and see that it's only five o'clock. I've already finished my classes for the day, and I have nothing planned until the next day, so at least I have the entire night to work on the case.

With that thought in mind, I grab my car keys and walk out the door. I think I have an idea.



Twenty minutes later, I'm knocking on the front door of the Chi Sigma Phi house. I've spent the past few moments in the car rehearsing my plan to get information from these boys, and I can only pray that they'll go along with it.

Just as I'm mentally re-rehearsing my routine for the tenth time, the front door creaks open with force, and a pale boy with dark hair comes to the door.

"Can I help you?"

I crack a bright smile at him, hoping I can use my looks to get information out of him if needed, then begin to spew off my act.

"Hi there," I begin. "I'm Leighton, and I'm a freshman in Alpha Omega this year. With the one-year anniversary of the disappearance of our sisters—Riley and Caroline—coming up, we're hoping to memorialize them with a collection of words from their peers who knew them."

The ghostly boy stares blankly at me as I ramble on.

"We're going house-to-house to collect statements, and would love it if any of your members had any words to contribute."

The boy continues to stare for a moment, as if he couldn't process a word that I just said.

"I didn't know them," he says, still appearing puzzled at my request. Eventually, things seem to click for him. "But hold on. Let me get Giant for you."

I'm not sure who (or *what*) Giant is, but I'm hoping he can help me.

I nod politely, and the quiet boy disappears up the staircase. A few seconds later, a new boy that's probably almost seven feet tall comes thudding down the stairs towards the door.

This must be Giant.

"Hi," I say, extending my arm for a handshake. "Are you...?"

“Giant. Nice to meet you,” he smiles, accepting the handshake. “My real name is Jake.”

I decide to make a joke to warm him up.

“I’m Leighton.” I decide to make a joke to warm him up. “Why do they call you Giant?”

He laughs at this, then offers me a seat on the couch near the door. The two of us sit down, and I begin to ask him about his relationship to the girls.

“I knew Caroline from my Marketing classes,” Giant explains. “We weren’t really close or anything, but she seemed like a cool girl from afar.”

I nod again. “Did they know anyone else in the chapter? Anyone who might want to be featured on the memorial?”

He shakes his head with a smile, then shuts down my hopes of finding a connection.

“Trust me, those girls wouldn’t have given any of us the time of day. I’m the only one who ever got near either of them, and that was just because of our class together. They mainly hung out with the Theta Mu guys.”

Though I’m disappointed, I accept his answer and move to get up. I feel discouraged as I head towards the door, which I’m hoping isn’t obvious to Giant.

Right as I’m nearly leaving the house, he gets up and stops me. I feel excitement for a moment, thinking that he is going back on his previous answer and revealing something.

Instead, he cocks his head curiously. “Don’t you want to hear my statement?”

Right. I almost blew my cover without meaning to.

“Of course...sorry.”

I quickly scribble down Giant’s memoir for the girls, then head back to my car, somehow feeling even more discouraged than before. Clearly nobody in this fraternity can help my case whatsoever, and I’m not sure what to do next.

If *CSP* doesn’t stand for *Chi Sigma Phi*, I have no idea what else it could possibly be. There are no campus buildings or residence halls that match those initials, nor are there any restaurants, bars, or stores. Even after giving it hours of thought last week, I couldn’t come up with a single person I’ve met with some variation of those initials.

So what could it mean?

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Riley Walker

OCTOBER 2023

(Three Weeks Before)

I may not be an active member of my sorority right now, but there is no way in hell I'm missing out on the annual Halloween parties this weekend.

"*Halloweekend*" at Cabot University is famously known as one of the best periods of time for party-going students—second only to the Thanksgiving parties. If you're wondering what a Halloweekend might be, it is a weekend-long event in which every fraternity and sorority throws a series of Halloween-themed parties on Greek Row. Each member of Greek life can hop from place-to-place to find the best party at any given time, so it's easy to never get bored, and everyone is always drunk and happy.

It was a great time last year, and I can't miss it.

Additionally, it's a great way to get drunk with my peers and not be alone in my room for a change.

Since I made the decision to attend these parties at the last minute, I am in desperate need of a costume. Caroline hasn't seen me much lately, so she happily offered to drive the two of us to Costume Planet to pick one out. Now, we are perusing the aisles in an attempt to find an outfit that's a perfect combination of skimpy, iconic, and functional for multiple hours of being out of the house.

Caroline pulls out a bag that contains a shimmery dress that is laced in gold and teal, and several pieces of Egyptian-themed jewelry dangle from a clip off the hanger.

"What about this one?" she asks. "The gold might look good with your skin-tone."

"I'm pretty sure that's cultural appropriation," I say, physically cringing at the title of the costume. "I think I'll go with something else."

I sift through several different costumes upon the racks, finding multiple variations of vampire, werewolf, and movie character-related costumes. Some are more outdated than others, but I'm eventually able to find a handful of costumes to try on in the dressing room.

Caroline comes inside of the stall with me, offering her insight into my outfit options. She has already chosen a costume for each night of parties, so she says there's nothing much better for her to do anyways.

I'm actually glad she's in here though—her Halloween fashion sense is much better than mine.

The first one I try on—an incredibly skimpy version of a police uniform—just feels wrong, so I quickly move onto the next option. The sailor costume I had selected, though equally revealing, earned an immediate spot on the *YES* rack. Another option—a Wild-West cowgirl-esque look—ends up being my favorite by far, and both receive Caroline's full approval.

After changing back into my clothes, we return my unused options to their designated racks, then head to the front counter to purchase the two costumes.

Now, I'm fully prepared for the weekend, and the beginning is only one night away.

I hope this Halloweekend is the best one yet.



“Five minutes!”

Caroline's voice rings out from the living room as I hastily curl the final strand of my pigtail.

“Okay!” I yell out in response. “Who's picking us up?”

I see her entering my room from the reflection in my mirror. She's dressed as a classic vampire, and the plastic teeth that she has glued onto her canines actually looks pretty realistic.

“No idea,” she says. “I just texted one of the pledge drivers from the list”

I laugh. Getting a pledge driver to take you to a party is basically a rite-of-passage for every freshman or sophomore sorority girl.

In short, pledge drivers are new members of a fraternity who are yet to be initiated. Since they're technically not official members of the chapter yet, they are unable to attend any parties until initiation has taken place, so

they are instead added to the recurring driver list for parties until that time comes.

The list is typically just a compilation of unlabeled contacts sent in a fraternity group chat, so you never really know who you'll get.

That's the fun part of it all.

In the last moment before leaving, I untangle the brown fringe from the mini-skirt on my costume, then straighten up my cowgirl hat atop my freshly curled hair. The pigtails really topped off the look in my opinion—that, or the cowboy boots.

After one last chug of my third pregame drink, Caroline and I are out the door and down the stairs.

"What kind of car is he in?" I ask, drunkenly pushing open the door that exits to the parking lot. I can already feel the alcohol coursing through my system, even though my tolerance has been much higher lately.

Caroline shoots out a quick text, then looks up from her phone and scans the cars parked in front of us.

"That one," she says, pointing at a darkly-painted SUV idling in one of the handicap spots. "He looks like a pledge."

We walk over to the car, confirming that this is our ride when we hear the occupant unlock the car doors. As soon as we open the doors to step inside, I notice that our driver is wearing a full suit and tie—as if he's a professional limo driver or something. Since all fraternities make their new members wear suits in public settings for the first three months of membership, I guess he really does look like a pledge.

Our mystery driver has an incredibly douchey voice, but ends up being pretty nice. He welcomes us immediately by offering to play any song of our choice, then adjusting the temperature in the car for our comfort. October in Alabama means medium-temperature days and freezing cold nights, so the heat blasting from his vents helps to dull the goosebumps on my bare legs.

The ride is about five minutes long even with Friday-night campus traffic, so we spend the miniscule amount of time asking him about his experience in Theta Mu so far.

"Smooth sailing so far," he begins in his frat-boy accent. "We got our frat-families last week, so it'll be a lot better now."

His mention of Greek-life families reminds me of my lack of ability to take a Little of my own this semester, and the words sting for a moment.

Thankfully, Caroline decided to stand in solidarity with my choice and opted out of taking a Little two weeks ago. “*There’s always next year*”, she had said.

Seemingly unbothered by the reminder of our lack of sorority family, Caroline keeps asking the pledge questions.

“Who did you get?” she asks. “Riley and I know, like, all of the Theta Mu’s, so we’ll definitely know him.”

He laughs.

“Noah Banks. Know him?”

The car goes silent for a moment.

Caroline and I lock eyes through the mirror on her sun visor, and it’s clear she is slightly enraged. Nonetheless, she chokes back her words and makes her best attempt at remaining civil.

“That’s great,” she says with a hint of disdain in her voice. “Noah’s great.”

The pledge glances over to the passenger seat where she is sitting and observes her expression. “Shit. Are you Caroline by any chance?”

She nods, and the awkward silence begins again. We still have a few minutes left in the drive, so I put my mind to coming up with a possible subject change. Just as I’m about to pipe in with a comment about the weather, the pledge speaks up—and neither of us are expecting what he says.

“If it makes you feel any better, I think you’re hotter than Summer. And she’s kind of a bitch.”

Caroline and I burst out laughing, and it’s clear to all of us that the mood is back to how it was before. We spend the remainder of the ride to the Theta Mu house telling him which girls to avoid picking up today, and even end up giving him a cash tip for driving us. Before we know it, we are pulling into the short driveway in front of the house, where the yard is filled with hundreds of partygoers in decked-out Halloween costumes. We’re definitely in the right spot.

“Well, Happy Halloween ladies,” our driver says as he brings the car to a complete stop. “Call me if you need a ride later...you have my number.”

The two of us shimmy out of the car quickly to avoid flashing the crowd of people, but I turn to speak to him through the open door before we go.

“Thank you for driving us,” I say before stepping away from the car.
“You’re so much better than your Big.”

Just as we’re about to walk inside, Caroline turns back around.

“What was your name again?” she asks.

The pledge puts his sunglasses on as he answers, as if he thinks he’s in some sort of action movie.

“Tanner,” he says. “Tanner Beaumont.”

On his last word, he throws the car in reverse and whips it out of the driveway—nearly hitting a group of girls walking into the party from the bottom of the road.

I turn back to Caroline.

“He was nice.”

She laughs at my description. “A bit of a douche, but nice.”

The two of us joke about Tanner’s strange demeanor as we walk inside—mentally preparing for the night we have ahead of us.

Who knows what could happen on Halloween night.

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Riley Walker

OCTOBER 2023

(Three Weeks Before)

A few hours into the party, I'm feeling more drunk than nearly ever before. I lost Caroline awhile ago, and I've been hopping between varying girls that I know from Greek Life ever since.

Honestly, I'm having the time of my life.

Some girls in my pledge class spotted Caroline and I as we were walking into the party, and somehow they convinced each of us to pound several shots before heading into the main party. Afterwards, we spent an hour dancing around with everyone else before eventually splitting up.

Though we haven't been able to find each other, we're mentally aware that the other is perfectly fine, so neither of us have made an attempt to text or call one another.

We'll reunite later.

Instead of trying to locate my friends, I'm sitting comfortably inside the bathroom and gazing into the mirror. I can barely even stand up straight from the intoxication, but I somehow am able to swipe on a decent-looking coat of lipstick to re-up my appearance. My makeup has smudged throughout the night from the constant physical contact with the crowd's arms and legs—it's unavoidable at these crowded parties—but I surprisingly still look pretty good.

After finishing my makeup, I blink my eyes in front of my reflection a few times in an attempt to sober myself up. Even after building my tolerance with a heavy drinking schedule for a few weeks, I still have fallen victim to the cheap vodka and sugary punch that is put into the party juice.

I eventually accept the fact that I'm heavily drunk and decide to leave the bathroom to find Caroline. If she's half as intoxicated as I am, it might be time for us to leave soon.

But just as I open the door, I'm distracted by a girl that is pushing her way through the crowd—soon turning down the hallway in the direction of the bedrooms. I only see her face for a split second, but I would recognize those features anywhere.

Brown hair.

Tan skin.

Striking eyes.

Was that my little sister?

I rub my face with my hands for a moment, hoping that my liquor lens has fooled me into thinking my sister could somehow be at a Theta Mu Halloween party hundreds of miles away from where she lives. That would be impossible.

When I look back up, the girl has disappeared around the corner of the hallway—as if she was never there.

Even though I'm mostly sure I imagined the whole thing, I decide to round the corner on my own to give myself some peace of mind. I stumble over in the same direction that the girl was walking in, then poke my head around the hidden hallway when I reach it.

Nobody is there.

I take another moment to shake off the thought of my sister—who I despise more than nearly any other being on this Earth—crashing the weekend of parties that I value the most. I might need another shot after all of this.

Satisfied with my search of the hallway, I spin around and walk into the main area beside the bathroom I had been in. I'm not sure where Caroline might be, but I'm sure I'll be able to find someone who can point me in her direction. Luckily, I'm able to spot a few girls whom Caroline mentioned as being in her book club when she first joined, so I head over to where they are standing.

When I reach the girls, they appear confused by my presence. I've never actually met them before—which could explain the hostility—but normally the shared drunkenness makes everyone at a party open to meeting other people.

“Hi,” I say, smiling at the group to the best of my impaired ability. “I'm Riley, Caroline's roommate. Have any of you seen her?”

The hostility from the group of girls continues on, and they throw even more confused looks in my direction without saying a word. After a few

seconds of uncomfortable silence, one of them finally responds to my question.

“Caroline?”

I nod my head at her.

“Caroline Rowe,” I say. “She mentioned before that you were all in her book club, so I thought you might have run into her tonight.”

The two other girls who have remained silent suddenly burst into giggles, and they all begin looking at me as if I’m insane. I might just be drunk, but I have absolutely zero idea what is going on right now.

“I’m sorry, but we have no idea what you’re talking about.” A blonde girl on the far right is speaking now, in a very clipped tone—as if I’ve done something to make her mad. “We’re all in the book club, but Caroline Rowe has never been to a single meeting.”

The other two nod in agreement, with one speaking up. “She doesn’t even like us, honestly.”

Now I’m even more confused than I was before. First I see what might’ve been my basically-estranged sister in my favorite frat house, and now Caroline has been lying about book club for the past month?

I must be losing my mind.

“Are you sure?” I press, hoping that this might be some sort of strange misunderstanding. “You meet on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays, right? She’s always out late on those nights.”

The girls continue to uncomfortably laugh at my confusion.

“I’m not sure what you want us to say,” the blonde snaps. “But clearly you guys have some things to figure out.”

I blink in confusion, then turn and walk away as quickly as possible.

I need to find Caroline.

Right now.

She has spent several hours out of every week supposedly going to this book club, even going as far as to give me titles of the books they were reading at the time, and now I find out she’s never been a part of the club. If that’s the case, then what has she been doing in all that time that she’s been gone?

Phone in hand, I barrel past the dance floor and head straight for the entrance area. When I can’t find her there, I bite the bullet and comb through the faces upon the dance floor—though there are too many people to count.

Eventually, I give up, and head to a quieter area to make a call to her.

Just as I reach the spot I'm heading for, I am distracted by some type of commotion coming from the backyard, along with several partygoers motioning for people to come outside and see something. I shove my phone into one of the pockets in my mini-skirt and rush outside with the others, planning to call Caroline after I've found out what is happening.

I try and fail at pushing my way through the crowd, then end up deciding to just walk around everyone else. The loud voices coming from inside the circle appear to be arguing about something, but I'm unable to make out any of the words being said with all of the other noises interfering.

But as I get closer to working my way inside of the group, the voices begin sounding more familiar to me.

Suddenly, my need to push into the middle of the crowd increases greatly, and I get an extra push of strength. When I finally make it to the center, my fears are unfortunately confirmed.

I guess there will be no need to make that phone call to Caroline now.

Summer and Caroline are in the middle of the group, loudly berating one another with terrible and graphic insults. A few Alpha Omega girls that I am familiar with are holding each of them back from hitting one another, but the blood on Summer's face tells me that this fight has already gotten physical.

Now that I'm aware of the situation, I jump forward to help the girls from my sorority to restrain Caroline. But even when I'm grabbing her arm, it seems as if she is seeing right through me—as if she can only see or speak to Summer.

"Caroline, *stop*," I yell as she continues to yell in front of everyone. "You're going to get kicked out of the chapter."

For the first time since I arrived, she turns to speak to me for a split second. "It's worth it, Riley. You know what she did to me."

Summer suddenly snaps back into the fight.

"Don't worry, Caroline," she sneers. "Noah will fix this bruise right up for me...can't say the same for you."

Suddenly, Caroline breaks from our restraint and lunges at Summer—hitting her and pulling her hair like some type of wild animal. The crowd begins to cheer for the chaos as myself and the other girls attempt to break up the fist-fight. Flashes from phone cameras light up the scene like a

boxing match, and the Theta Mu boys are loudly shouting bets across the crowd on who will win the smackdown.

This is an absolute disaster.

After several clean hits and nearly thirty seconds of constant fighting, the frat boys eventually decide to make themselves useful and step in to separate the two. It takes about eight pairs of hands, but we are finally able to pull them off of each other.

As Summer is pulled back, she screams loudly.

“I will fucking *kill you* Caroline Rowe. You’re dead.”

Caroline smirks through bloody lips. “Not if I get to you first.”

I grab Caroline by the shoulders and pull her far away from the commotion, eventually settling on the same bathroom I spent time in earlier in the night. We spend a while cleaning off her face with the limited amount of skincare products we are able to find in the cabinets, then get to work on scrubbing the blood out of her hair.

Thankfully, her choice to dress as a vampire tonight is making the blood look like part of a costume, so she won’t stand out from the crowd too much.

She has a large cut above her eyebrow that is dripping with dark red blood, and both her nose and mouth have sustained injuries as well. We take a moment to make sure all of her teeth are in place, and luckily only the false vampire teeth have fallen victim to the fight. Afterwards, I wad up some toilet paper to apply to her injuries for the time being.

“We probably need to go home,” I say with concern. “Your face looks really bad.”

Caroline smiles at me, and it’s evident that this fight has only sobered her up a small amount. “Thanks. Yours does too.”

“Not what I meant,” I huff. “But seriously...we need to go.”

After a second of protest, she agrees to leave after observing the blood dripping down her face in the mirror. I make sure to grab all of our belongings from the counter, then take her arm to lead us outside.

On the way out, I dial Tanner from Caroline’s phone and ask him to come pick us up in the same spot that he dropped us off at, and he lets me know that he’ll be here in five minutes.

We manage to get out of the house without having any conversations about the fight. A select few high-five Caroline in passing, but the others mainly just point and whisper.

I guess I can't blame them. I'm sure the two of us are quite a sight to see.

A drunken, bloodied-up vampire, and her cowgirl friend with blood streaked down her clothes.

After what feels like ten minutes of making our way through the house, we eventually reach the front yard and stand in the driveway where Tanner is supposed to meet us. Within seconds, we see his familiar black 4Runner pulling onto the cemented section, and we book it over to the car before anyone else can see us.

"What the hell happened to her?" Tanner asks as I throw Caroline into the backseat and scoot inside.

Caroline pulls herself up by Tanner's headrests and smiles at him.

"Battle scars, Tan-Tan."

I roll my eyes. "She fought Summer. It was really bad."

"You mean *entertaining*," she says, pressing a finger over my lips as she speaks. "She had it coming anyways."

Tanner laughs along with Caroline and insists on seeing footage, which we unfortunately didn't have.

"You better hope they don't kick you out," I snap at her. "Summer is probably calling Eleanor right now."

She throws her head back, then lays down with her eyes closed.

"I'm droning you out," she mutters. "In the morning, you'll realize how necessary this was. And screw Eleanor anyway."

At that moment, I remember the reason I had been looking for her at the party before the fight began.

The book club.

Now doesn't seem like the right time to bring anything up, given that Caroline is possibly going to be kicked out of Alpha Omega and is sporting a few different bruises on her face. She probably wouldn't give me a straight answer right now anyways.

But once the smoke clears, it's the first thing on my list.

Halloween is this weekend, and Alison and I are dressing as 1920s Flappers.

We found matching costumes in different colors earlier in the month, and we've been counting down the days until we get to wear them ever since.

Finally, that day has come.

According to pretty much everyone on campus, Cabot University is the best place to be on Halloween weekend, or as they call it, "Halloweekend". Our older sorority sisters have been talking about it nonstop, and it seems like everyone will be there.

We can't miss it.

Since my investigation has been all over the place as of late, I've decided to dedicate the weekend to enjoying myself. Getting drunk at a fraternity party might be able to knock me back into reality, which I desperately could use right now.

Besides, it's my freshman year of college. I need to be making memories outside of scanning case files and accusing my peers of murder. I'll have one fun weekend with no responsibilities, then resume my investigation on Monday.

No big deal.

After my train of thought comes to an end, I wrap the final string of pearls around my neck in a 20s-esque style, then adjust my headband and wrist cuffs. Once finished, I walk over to Alison's room—my necklaces rattling with each step I take.

"You look great," I say to her from the doorway, observing her identical outfit to my own. "I think we'll be the hottest Flappers there."

“Definitely.” She smiles as she ties her headband tightly upon her forehead. “By the way, Kimberly is picking us up at 8:00.”

I glance down at my phone to check the time. We have a little more than twenty minutes before we have to go, so I pour a combination of day-old cranberry juice and inexpensive vodka into two of our cups and serve one to Alison. She chugs hers in under a minute—inspiring me to do the same—and we repeat that same process until we receive the *Here* text.

Once we’ve made our way downstairs and into Kimberly’s car, I settle into the backseat and work on finishing the to-go drink I made for myself. Since this is the only weekend I’ve allowed myself to enjoy since college began, I’m trying to have as much fun as possible.

“We’re going to the Alpha Omega house first,” Kimberly says as she pulls out of the Norman Hall parking lot. “We’re pregaming there, then going to Theta Mu at ten or eleven.”

Alison and I acknowledge the plan, then we all converse about varying happenings from the previous week. After a moment, Kimberly pipes in with an important piece of information.

“By the way, Summer will be there tonight,” she begins. “She said she needs to talk to you.”

My eyes lock with Alison, who seems unnerved by Kimberly’s comment. Neither of us are sure what Summer could possibly want to talk about, and honestly, I have no interest in finding out. Still, I attempt to sound somewhat civil when responding to Kimberly.

“Okay,” I mutter. “Thanks for letting me know.”

I spend the remainder of the quick car ride staring out the window at the sidewalk, which is mostly filled with young people in costumes. As we pass them by, I remember how much I love the wholesomeness of Halloween. People spend hours getting dressed up to look like their favorite celebrity or character, and for one short weekend we are given an opportunity to escape our bodies and be someone else. Add in the binge-drinking, candied treats, and constant partying—that’s every college student’s dream.

Let’s hope tonight lives up to the expectation.

When we arrive at the Alpha Omega house, Maeve and Imani are already half-drunk at the outdoor bar. They’re both wearing bodysuits paired with strappy high heels, but in opposite colors. Maeve is in all red with red devil horns, while Imani wears a white outfit and a feathery halo. It seems like they’ve chosen to do a duo costume just as Alison and I did.

“Cute costumes,” Alison says, examining the girls’ headpieces and comparing them to our flapper headbands. “But I think we’ve got you beat.”

Imani laughs and agrees. “It’s definitely very *Roaring Twenties*.”

“Have you guys started drinking yet?” Maeve asks, shifting the subject.

Of course we have. It’s the Halloween night of our freshman year of college...we’ve been drinking since six.

“Obviously,” I say, “but I’m fresh out.”

Imani quickly fixes up two drinks for Alison and I, then we all temporarily split up to say our hellos to the other sisters. In an attempt to find Juliette, I head towards the crowded kitchen area and find her in an instant.

“Leighton!” Juliette reaches for me from across the room, breaking past the other girls to get to me. “You’re finally here...and you look amazing.”

“You look even better,” I say. “I love this costume.”

I examine her costume, which appears to be some sort of low-cut NASCAR bodysuit. She’s holding a green flag in the same hand as her drink, and her long blonde hair is curled down her shoulders. So far, hers is the best costume I’ve seen so far.

“Thanks,” she says through a bright smile. “So, how’s your first Cabot Halloweekend going so far?”

“Great as of now, but I’m more excited for the party,” I answer. “I just wish I had eaten something before I left the house...I was too busy drinking to remember.”

Juliette laughs. “Don’t worry — Ashley is catering food for tonight. It should be here soon, actually.”

Thank god. I was downplaying it before, but all of this pregaming has made me feel absolutely starving.

“Actually,” she cuts back in, “I need to go find her anyway. I’ll let you know when the food is getting here...go have fun for now.”

Juliette shoos me off before disappearing into the crowd in search of Ashley, so I take the opportunity to track down my own friends again. After a few quick minutes of searching, I eventually find that they have regrouped on the bottom few steps of the grand staircase.

“I have great news,” I announce upon my reunion with the girls.

“They’re catering food for us, and it’s supposed to be here soon.”

“Amen to that,” Imani says, standing up from her place on the stairs.

“By the way — what time are you guys heading to Theta Mu?”

I look at Alison. “I’m not sure.”

“10:00, I think,” she replies. “Hopefully the food is here before then.”

We all wait around awhile, talking and dancing as the minutes tick by. Alison and I both lose some of the fringe from our dresses from bumping into people throughout the pregame, but considering we’ve been drinking all day, the costumes have held stronger than I expected.

After what feels like an hour of waiting, the grand entrance swings open once again, and four girls carrying large catering boxes enter the room. Ashley leads the pack, directing the helpers to place the food upon a white pop-up table in the living room area. As soon as the food is settled in place, I grab Alison’s hand and drag her to the food line, where Imani and Maeve are already holding a spot for us.

“What are the options?” I ask, trying to get a good look at the food selection from our place in the back of the room. I’m absolutely starving, and I’ve been counting down the seconds until it arrived.

Maeve squints at the tables, but seemingly can’t get a clear line of sight. “I guess we’ll find out when we’re up there.”

We gradually move up in line, hoping to be able to eat before it’s time to head to the frat house. I try to distract myself from the hunger that’s eating up my stomach by talking with surrounding friends, but it’s only a slightly successful tactic. Eventually, though, the girls in front of us grab their plates and make their way to the serving station.

But when I’m finally able to see what’s on the menu, I’m no longer hungry.

Instead, I stare at the logo upon the boxes with my mouth agape—my mind suddenly racing with a new idea.

Marciello’s.

The restaurant Ashley has catered from is the exact restaurant that Riley and Caroline called an order into before disappearing.

Earlier in the semester—near the beginning of my investigation—I had dragged Alison to the place after learning of its connection to the case. We both ordered meals, talked with wait staff, and looked around the restaurant space, but I found nothing that stood out to me at the time.

However, I vividly remember laying eyes upon a short brochure stand that sat against the wall of the restaurant, near the checkout area.

These brochures and flyers listed details and addresses for several local attractions, from petting zoos, to local parks, to nearby shopping centers.

While nothing upon these brochures stood out to me at that moment, my mind has suddenly made a connection with the sheet of notebook paper I discovered underneath the carpeting in my closet last week.

The note scribbled upon the paper had been a simple message:

MEETING AT CSP @ 10:00.

While I previously tried to connect the acronym with other on-campus organizations or buildings, I now have a new potential idea.

Placed in the middle of the top rack of the flyer stand were several brochures advertising Cheaha State Park—a nearby recreational area in North Alabama that is known for having the highest natural point in the state. It's roughly a thirty minute drive from Cabot's main campus, and is a popular area among students given its secluded camping and partying areas. The area is entirely wooded, but the brochure displayed several pop-up points throughout the park that are popular with varying age groups—such as Lover's Lookout or the Rustic Ridge Campground.

Cheaha State Park.

CSP.

The timeline adds up, and the girls constantly visited Marciello's. They would have definitely seen that flyer during one of their many dinners, and even possibly found it to be a meeting place for one of their many victims of blackmail. It's entirely plausible that they were heading to Cheaha State Park on the night of their disappearance.

My brain is swirling with theories, and I'm so lost in thought that I can't even bring myself to move forward and grab a plate. I can hear my friends snapping their fingers and trying to bring me back down to Earth, but I don't react.

"I'm sorry," I mumble breathlessly. "I have to go."

The moment the words leave my lips, I'm running as fast as I can out the door, down the steps, and past the driveway. The fringe dangling from my dress shakes relentlessly in the wind—tapping my legs with each stride. I hear the echoing voices of my friends behind me, desperately calling for me to come back, but I keep running.

Faster than ever before.

When I finally reach my room, I breathlessly search my room for the note. When I first made the discovery, I vividly remember throwing the note inside of the white shoebox that contains my self-compiled case files. Now, it's nowhere to be found.

Whatever. I don't have time to look for it right now, but I'm positive it said *CSP* anyways.

I whip out my phone and type in the directions for Cheaha State Park, which is luckily only a twenty minute drive at this time of night. Though I drank heavily earlier in the day, waiting on the catered food at the pregame left me plenty of time to drink water and sober up. I'm definitely okay to drive now.

Without another thought, I grab my car keys off my desktop and race out the door—still dressed as a dancer from the 1920s. As I'm quickly making my way downstairs, I receive several phone calls from Alison, who is clearly wondering why I ran off from one of the biggest parties of the year without a word. I'd love to tell her everything, but I can't clue anyone in on this just yet. All of my evidence in this case is circumstantial, and I don't want to risk anyone thinking I'm mentally unstable.

For now, she'll just have to wonder.

As soon as I enter my car, I jam the keys into the ignition and fire it up. I throw the gear selector into reverse and lift my foot from the brake, then slowly back out after clearing the lane. The Maps app quickly routes my journey to Cheaha, and within seconds, I'm pulling out of the Norman Hall parking lot.

Just before I go to make the turn off of campus, I quickly pull over into a side parking lot that's designated for faculty members during school hours, then pick up my phone once again.

I can't do this alone. In the case that I find something important, someone should be there with me.

And I know just who to call.

42

Riley Walker

NOVEMBER 2023

(Two Weeks Before)

Caroline and Noah are officially back together.

Somehow, last weekend's events actually made him more interested in Caroline, and less interested in Summer. According to her, Noah was told by his friends that Caroline had been crowned the champion of the beatdown between the two, and he loved the idea of all of that attention being focused on him.

As it turns out, guys actually like it when girls fight over them—just as much as girls like it when guys do.

Despite my deep-rooted hatred of their relationship, I've remained pretty neutral around her. As long as she doesn't break out into any more brawls in public spaces, I really don't care what she does.

Except for one thing.

On the same night of the fight, I had an interaction with girls whom I believed to be in Caroline's book club while attempting to find out where she was. During that conversation, the girls claimed that Caroline has never once attended a meeting or book-reading for their club, even though said meetings have been the reasoning behind her constant absence from the dorm for nearly the past month. Ever since I spoke to them, I've wondered what she was really doing all those countless hours.

Tonight, I plan on asking her.

She's leaving for Noah's house in about half an hour, so I'm planning to casually strike up a conversation with her as she sits in the living room. That way we have plenty of time to discuss, in case her answer is long and complicated.

Right now, Caroline is sitting on the couch just outside my room. If I pretend to grab something out of the fridge and strike up a conversation, she

won't suspect anything going into it.

I walk forward and pull open the fridge, scanning the shelves to find something to grab. Eventually, my hand settles on a carton of strawberries.

"Can I have some of these?" I hold the carton up to her line of sight.

"Sure," she says, squinting to see what I'm holding. "But guess what?"

I walk over towards the couch, listening closely.

"Noah dropped off a box of Summer's things today," Caroline begins—a wide smile pasted across her face. "Apparently she cried on the porch for an hour when she found them. Ashley Worthington had to drag her inside to get her to stop hugging the box."

Though I know Summer's actions were unforgivable, part of me feels terrible hearing what Caroline has said. She used to be our best friend, and she's clearly in a terrible place right now. As a child of divorce, I can speak from personal knowledge when I say that heartbreak can change someone's entire being. My mom was never the same after my dad left us.

Still, I'm in no mood to try and defend Summer's actions to Caroline.

"You better be careful," I say. "She *literally* threatened to kill you last weekend."

She laughs, pointing to the scabbed-over cut above her brow. It's actually healed pretty well, especially considering the fact that we cleaned up the wound in a disgusting fraternity house sink.

"If this is the best she can do, I'm not too worried."

"Well, you won the competition for Noah anyways." I pop a strawberry into my mouth. "Maybe now we can just leave her alone."

Caroline smirks at me. "I guess we'll see."

For a moment, I forget why I started this conversation in the first place. Just as I begin to get up from the couch, the thought pops back into mind, and I quickly spin to face her again.

"What are you guys reading in the book club this week?"

Caroline looks up from her phone, visibly searching her brain for an answer. "Sherlock Holmes."

"Weren't you reading that last month?" I press. "Why re-read it?"

"Why do you care?" She's now squinting at me, searching my expression for clues as to why I'm pressing the matter.

I set the strawberries down beside me, now fully locked into eye contact with Caroline. Leaning forward, I continue my interrogation.

“Remember when you pointed out that group of girls on campus, and you told me they were your friends from the book club? I talked to them at the Halloween party—right before your little spat with Summer actually.”

I pause for a moment, hoping she'll break down and confess. When she remains silent, I continue on.

“They told me that you've never been to a single meeting, Caroline. I found that pretty interesting, considering you're gone *all* of the time for these club meet-ups.”

She mumbles under her breath, shaking her head at my reveal. “Those bitches...”

“So,” I prompt. “What exactly have you been doing lately?”

Caroline refuses to meet my eyes anymore—an unusual behavior to see from her. I've never seen her seem so bothered by someone calling her out.

She breathes deeply, then gives a short response.

“I can't tell you yet,” she says softly. “But Riley...I've figured out something big. I just need a little bit more proof, and then I'll tell you. You're not going to believe it.”

I wait for her to say more, but she ends her sentence there.

“And you can't tell me because...?”

Her brows furrow with concern, as if the matter she's discussing is of personal relation to my own life. “Just trust me. I'll tell you soon. Next week.”

Before I can say anything more, she gets up from the couch and announces that Noah is waiting for her. She quickly shuffles out the door and turns the lock behind her, leaving me confused and wondering on the couch.

What could she possibly be talking about?

Caroline has always been one to dig up information where nobody else would think is worth digging, but I don't even have a general idea of what she could've discovered this time. My best guess is that it relates to Summer, but then again, she would probably just tell me about that. There would be no reason for secrecy if this was about someone we already dislike.

I'm not sure I can wait until next week to find out what information Caroline is sitting on, but I know better than to think that I can get the truth out of her on my own. She's far too stubborn for that.

Next week it is.

43

LEIGHTON

2024

Through the beaming headlights, I see the tall hooded figure approaching my car through the shadows.

Before I can get a good look at the person's face, he grabs my passenger door handle and swings open the door, dropping the hood the moment he's seated beside me.

"You scared me," I say. "You look like a murderer when it's dark."

Nathan smiles at me from across the car. "Is it the hoodie?"

I nod, playfully hitting his shoulder.

"Thanks for coming with me," I smile lightly. "I figured going into a 3,000 acre forest on Halloween night wasn't the best thing to do by myself."

He shakes his head. "That's true. Nice outfit, by the way."

I look down at my torso, somehow just now remembering that I'm wearing a flapper dress. One glance in the mirror tells me that my headband is still perfectly in place as well.

"There was no time to change."

Nathan leans back in his seat, stretching out to a comfortable position.

"So," he says inquisitively. "Why exactly are we going trailblazing in a state park in the dead of night?"

As we drive through miles of backroad to reach Cheaha, I tell Nathan the entire story of my bedroom discoveries—including every detail and word on each note. Since he's been clued in on my investigation since the beginning, he wasn't too surprised with my findings, but still seems engaged with what I'm saying. He also agrees that Cheaha State Park is the best bet for finding anything good, especially given the brochure stand at Marciello's.

When we finally reach the wood-and-stone gate that stands at the entrance of the park, the locked gate is visible through the windshield. A large map of the park's hours tells us that it has been closed to visitors since 5pm, and that any and all trespassers will be prosecuted.

Nathan and I step out to gaze at the sign from closer up, then turn to lock eyes. As if we've made a decision telepathically, we simultaneously jump back into the car and park down the road—outside of any security camera viewpoints. I throw on a hoodie from my backseat, then the two of us sprint across a partially-wooded field to reach a high fence in a secluded section away from the visitor center. My high heels attempt to sink into the dirt with each step I take, but it doesn't slow us down.

As soon as we touch the fence, Nathan grabs me by the hips and thrusts me onto the gate—giving me a three or four foot head start. The toe of my shoes protects my feet from the chain-link fence as I hoist myself up and over the top, then carefully step back down.

I'm happy I went with close-toed shoes today.

Nathan drops down from the fence shortly after me. For a moment, we attempt to redirect ourselves towards the main visitor area to find some type of map, but he quickly offers a solution.

"Hold on," he says, pulling out his phone and opening the internet. "I'd bet there's a map on their website."

Not sure why I didn't think of that. Good thing I brought Nathan along. He points to a photo that has now loaded onto his screens.

"Should we try Lover's Lane?" Nathan asks. "We don't know who they were meeting...maybe it was a fling of theirs."

I shake my head.

"I don't think so. I can't explain it, but it just doesn't seem like somewhere they'd go." I lean in closer. "Where else is there?"

He hands his phone over to me so that I can get a better look at the varying spots on the map. I zoom in on a few—hoping to find a name that stands out to me—but strike out for the most part.

After a few seconds of scanning with my finger, my eyes lock onto the name of a lookout spot that's not far from where we are right now. The name is typed in such a small font that it'd be easy to miss it, but the moment I see it, I get a confident feeling. Screenshotting the name of the location, I point to the spot on his phone.

"There."

He squints his eyes. “White Rose Point?”

I nod my head. “It’s an Alpha Omega thing. Trust me.”

“Okay,” Nathan says, shrugging his shoulders. “You’re in charge.”



After what feels like miles of hiking through mud, sticks, and briar patches, we’ve finally reached a small wooden sign that reads the name of the place we were looking for. I turn to Nathan, who is now holding my high heels as I prance barefoot through the woods. They ended up slowing me down eventually.

“White Rose Point.” I point to the sign.

He nods, then sets my shoes and keys down on one of the picnic tables nearby. After looking around for a moment, he points down the road.

“That’s the parking area,” he says. “Should we check there?”

“I feel like they would’ve gone somewhere more secluded,” I reply. “If they were meeting someone late at night in a park, it was probably about something pretty serious.”

We walk to the parking lot, scanning the surrounding area once again for anything of interest. After shining my flashlight around the perimeter, I eventually notice an unofficial pathway that leads into the heavily wooded area beside the lot. I wave for Nathan to come over to me, then we light the way with our flashlights as we plunge into the woods.

We walk for several minutes—trudging through briars and bushes that have overgrown the path from lack of travel. After a while, the both of us begin to get a bit restless.

“Should we turn back?” I ask Nathan.

“Hold on.” Suddenly, he dashes forward and leaves me far behind. He turns back momentarily and motions for me to come with him, then takes off once again.

When I finally reach him again, he’s standing in a clearing where a large boulder sits surrounded by the path. From where we are, I’d guess we’re a half mile from the parking lot.

“Shine your flashlight around,” he directs me. “We might actually find something here.”

I nod my head. “It does seem like a good meeting spot.”

Nathan and I get on our hands and knees to search the entire surrounding area, leaving no stone unturned.

I'm circling through the wooded area around the boulder, when suddenly, my body is struck with an uncomfortably familiar feeling. A feeling that I've only felt once in my life—when I was just sixteen.

As Nathan and I discussed on our first night alone together, the two of us have dragged our families on some pretty uncommon tourist destinations on past vacations. Our fascination with true crime has caused us to yearn for crime-scene locations instead of a relaxing day at the beach—leading us to visit the exact spots where people have lost their lives. While Nathan and I have been to separate crime scenes for separate killers, both of us mentioned the same general feeling:

A strange, tingling sensation tends to take over your body when you're standing in the same place where someone was killed.

Right now, I'm getting that feeling again.

Just as I go to grab Nathan's attention, I shine my flashlight over to where he is searching the woods, and I quickly notice that his face has gone as white as a sheet.

"Leighton...come here."

His voice is hushed to a whisper now, and it seems as if he had to choke out his words. From where I'm standing, I can see that he's holding something in his now-shaking hands and examining it closely.

As soon as I reach him, I'm able to see exactly what he had found.

A phone.

A phone dressed in a pink case, to be exact. The screen is shattered, it's covered in dirt and leaves, and the phone is unable to be powered on, but it's definitely a modern cell phone. Nathan taps the screen a few more times in an attempt to turn it on, but the phone doesn't react.

Just as I go to touch it, he speaks again—fear causing a tremor in his voice.

"Look at the back of the case."

I raise my brow—unsure of what he's alluding to. At his request, I flip the phone over in his hands and shine my flashlight onto the back of the case to get a look at whatever he's talking about.

And when I see it, I can't believe my own eyes.

On the very top of the phone case, an old, tattered sticker is clinging to the plastic for dear life. The paper is torn heavily, but I'm still able to see

the color of the sticker and the words that were once there.

In a sparkly pink design, the sticker has two letters written in a cursive font.

Alpha Omega.

It's been a little over a week since that night in the park.

The events of the past few days have been so unfathomable that it's hard to even process reality, but nonetheless, it's all true.

It really happened.

What started as an innocent investigation—a pipeline for my acceptance to Bradshaw—has led to my involvement in something more serious than I could have ever imagined.

On Halloween night, Nathan and I entered Cheaha State Park with the hopes of finding some sort of lead to help progress my investigation. Neither of us expected to find anything of significant importance, or really much of anything at all.

When we found the phone, the both of us immediately recognized how important our discovery was to the case. As soon as we finished the two-mile sprint back to the car, we dialed the local police and had them meet us in front of the main entrance to the park. They were originally focused on our confession of trespassing, but as soon as we filled them in on what we had found, their tone quickly shifted.

The park rangers came in around midnight to open the gate for police, and we rode in a cruiser to lead the Brookwood officers to the exact spot where we had found the cell phone. Once they had cleared the area and taken a quick look around the boulder, they called in for backup and asked the squad to bring in Search & Rescue. Nathan and I sat in the back of the car for hours as we watched dozens of government vehicles pulling into the parking area, and we were interrogated countless times—the same questions over and over again.

“What were you doing in the park at night?”

“What made you think the park might relate to the girls’ disappearance?”

“Why did you ignore the trespass warnings?”

For a while, we were treated like criminals. That is, until the sound of a whistle accompanied by barking dogs echoed out through the woods.

The officers immediately rushed into the forest with stretchers and medical supplies at hand, but all of us knew that whoever was in the woods would be far beyond saving.

It wasn't until they returned to the area with a zipped-up white body bag that the weight of the matter hit me.

The body in that bag is Riley Walker.

Or Caroline Rowe.

Whichever one it was, I was sure that the second body would be found soon after. The two girls disappeared together, and it only made sense that their bodies would be found near each other.

But that's not what happened.

Not yet, at least.

Within a few days, DNA testing confirmed that the body found in the woods belonged to Caroline Rowe. The cause of death was declared to be a single gunshot wound to the heart, which resulted in nearly immediate death. My heart breaks more and more with every intake of information, but I'm able to find comfort in knowing that their deaths were quick and likely without much pain.

Though her body had been in the woods for a while, most of the clothing that Caroline had worn that night was still intact, and there was blood belonging to both girls found upon the white fur coat she was wearing. Because of the presence of both girls' DNA found at the scene, the Brookwood Police Department officially declared both Riley and Caroline to be dead—the former only legally.

With that, the case was re-opened. The department was scrambling to find answers—going as far as to question each member of Alpha Omega about every detail of Riley and Caroline's life. Even those of us that didn't know them.

Eleanor Stephens might have shut down the investigation back in the beginning, but she can't touch it anymore. Things have gotten serious quickly.

Alison and I were questioned in the same block of people as Imani and Maeve, so we all sat around as we waited to be called into the interrogation room one at a time. There were roughly twenty other sisters at the station at the same time as us, so we were able to hear about the current chatter

throughout the sorority house from an inside perspective. From what we hear from the older members, it seems as if everyone is utterly shocked by this outcome.

According to the girls we talked to, Summer all but disappeared after they found Caroline's body. Ashley and Kimberly did their best to support her—knocking on her door, leaving notes, and dropping off gifts—but Summer would barely let them in. None of them could figure out if she was scared, angry, or simply shocked about the outcome. She wouldn't talk, and nobody could get close enough to find out anything.

That is, until November 10th came around.

It was a Sunday evening, and we were all sitting in Chapter—the weekly Sunday meetings that all sorority members must attend. Most of the time, the Executive Board member covers the important points for that given week, then everyone goes home. This one, however, was a bit more interesting.

About halfway into the VP of Finance's presentation on the importance of paying our dues on time, the heavy door in the back of the room opened up—revealing several uniformed officers charging into the room. The leading cop quickly located Summer's assigned seat as we chatted amongst each other in anticipation, all wondering why the entire police squad was at our sorority house.

Before we could wonder any further, the officers swiftly walked over to where Summer was sitting, then stood her up to place her in handcuffs. Juliette stood and questioned the Brookwood officers—hoping to determine a reason for why they've suddenly stormed into our meeting. Nonetheless, they took Summer out of the room whilst reading her rights aloud, then shut the door without a word.

The chapter was immediately dismissed, and everyone went home in confusion. Alison and I spent hours attempting to research her arrest details online, but couldn't find a single thing. We were just as in the dark as everyone else was.

Thankfully, that wouldn't last long.

Not even twenty-four hours later, the Brookwood Police Department made an official statement on the website regarding the investigation into Caroline and Riley's murders, and the campus ran wild with the information.

Summer Harding had been arrested for the murder of both girls.

Her own friends.

The two girls she claimed she loved the most.

The Brookwood Police think that she killed them.

I'm inclined to believe the police in this situation. As someone who is unnaturally obsessed with true crime and the legal system, I'm perfectly aware of just how much evidence is needed to justify the signing of an arrest warrant. It's by no means a small amount.

Whatever they have on her, it's real.

Summer Harding is a murderer.

THE SORORITY MURDERS:

HOW A GREEK-LIFE LOVE TRIANGLE LED TO HOMICIDE

BY: *Brenda McNeese*

The Brookwood Press

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Sororities can be cutthroat.

We've all heard the horror stories of young college women in Greek life organizations—getting dropped from recruitment, participating in ludicrous hazing practices, and being relentlessly bullied and harassed by their peers. While these activities are harmful and concerning for girls their age, there are two young women in Northern Alabama who have experienced much worse.

Caroline Rowe (19) and Riley Walker (20) were young, bright students at Cabot University, who also happened to be members of a campus sorority—Alpha Omega. It was through this organization that the two girls met some of their closest friends, including fellow sophomore Summer Harding (19). The three girls were thick as thieves for years, and nothing could separate them.

That is, until Noah Banks (20) came along.

Noah Banks was Caroline Rowe's boyfriend in the months leading up to their disappearance. The two had been dating for almost an entire year when it was discovered that Summer Harding had slept with Noah Banks on the night of a fraternity mixer between Alpha Omega and Theta Mu (*Banks's fraternity*). Word quickly spread throughout the school, and Caroline was openly furious about the situation.

Hence, a feud was born between the girls.

Over the following months, Rowe and Walker are believed to have vandalized Harding's vehicle together to the point of no fixing, and the girls are said to have been very cold with one another in social settings. Allegedly, a large brawl even broke out between Rowe and Harding at a separate fraternity party just a few short weeks before the disappearance of the two girls, and Summer was heard verbally threatening one of the girls by several other partygoers.

"I will kill you, Caroline," recounts one of the partygoers who witnessed the fight between the girls. Our source wished to remain anonymous in this article. *"You're dead. Those were her exact words."*

When asked if any of the other people at the party deemed her threat to have any validity at the time, our source added:

"Not really, no. We all knew about the love-triangle situation going on, and everyone knew by that point that Caroline had vandalized Summer's car. Everyone assumed it was just a meaningless threat...at the time, at least."

Only twenty days later, Rowe and Walker disappeared without a trace, and nobody saw or heard from them again. Police searched tirelessly for the two girls in the first few months of the

investigation, but as time went on, more and more leads ran cold.

Almost a year later, the community was no further to the truth than we were in the beginning. That is, until Leighton Adams (18) arrived at Cabot University for her freshman year. With a plan in mind—and the means to solve the mystery—she worked day-by-day to uncover leads in the investigation. Her tireless search for answers eventually led her to a local state park, just twenty minutes from campus.

It was there—the Cheaha State Park in Clay County—that the body of Caroline Rowe was discovered, along with traces of Riley Walker’s DNA. The murder weapon was confirmed to be a 9mm handgun of some variety, and Caroline is said to have suffered a fatal shot to the chest. The remains of Riley Walker are yet to be found, but the Brookwood Police Department has declared her to be legally dead due to the traces of DNA found at the scene.

Following this discovery, questioning of the girls’ friends and acquaintances was conducted. These interrogations—which can be accredited to great police work from the Brookwood Police Department—would lead to a shocking arrest just a few short days after the discovery of the bodies.

On the evening of November 10th, 2024, Brookwood officers entered the university-owned Alpha Omega house in the Greek Row section of Cabot University’s campus—conducting the swift arrest of Summer Harding in a very public manner. The night of the arrest, officers additionally carried out a full search of Harding’s bedroom, vehicle, and other personal items in her possession. It was during this search that a 9mm handgun was found—buried deep inside of Harding’s clothing drawers. After a few days of ballistic examinations and DNA testing, police reported their findings publicly on their website.

“...We believe that Harding arranged to meet with the two young women with the full intention of ending their lives. Following the search of the Defendant’s phone records, our detectives have found reason to believe that Harding’s actions were deliberate, and likely based on jealousy surrounding Rowe’s ex-boyfriend. Reports have confirmed that the gun found in Harding’s possession was the weapon used to commit the heinous acts against Rowe and Walker, and we are confident that we have the right suspect in custody...”

— Mick Hilton, Brookwood Police Chief

Harding is set to face arraignment this afternoon (Wednesday, November 13th, 2024), and bail will be determined at this time. The Brookwood Press will continue to inform the public about new developments in the case, so be sure to stay updated on our social media pages (@brookwoodpress).

My life has been anything but normal as of late.

Each day, my inbox is flooded with emails from news reporters requesting a statement about my discovery of the bodies. It's as if they have zero sympathy for the fact that we experienced something terrible that night in the woods.

The media are vultures.

When I walk to my classes each day, most people point and stare in my direction. Everyone has heard about the news by now, so there's no way to escape it. I've officially received the title of *the Alpha Omega girl who found the bodies*, and that's just who I am now.

Since I've become a bit of a social outcast in the past few weeks, I spend the majority of my time thinking about things.

About my investigation.

About Summer.

Summer was my saving grace at the beginning of my membership in Alpha Omega. At the time, I had thought she was a trustworthy and reliable friend who could help me through my pledging period while simultaneously aiding me through my investigation. I couldn't have been more wrong, of course.

Though I was the very first person to throw out the possibility of Summer having killed the girls, I never truly thought that the idea had any traction. It was clear from the beginning that she was hiding something in relation to the girls' disappearance, but once the truth about her relationship with Noah came to light, I kind of assumed that there wasn't much more to tell. The only reason I continued to press the idea of her being a murderer was to push her to reveal other potentially important case facts if she knew of any.

I never actually expected to find anything of substance.

That being said, I can't help but think that the police have arrested the right person. Through three months of my underground investigation, the

only commonality between all of my important discoveries was their link with Summer.

Everything I've heard about the Maya Belton situation, and Summer's awareness of the truth in the matter.

Her relationship with Noah, and the secret affair between them that outlasted Caroline's life.

The notecards I found taped to my desk, which had Summer's initials written on the most recent card.

All of these little details had clearly led me to one conclusion: Summer Harding murdered her friends last November, then essentially took over their lives in their absence. It was right in front of my eyes all along, and somehow I looked past everything.

The arraignment took place this past Wednesday, and Summer's charges were formally presented to the world. I watched it from a livestream, which was provided by the court at no cost due to the popularity of the case online. Even though I couldn't find it in myself to actually show up in person, I knew I needed to stay updated with the case, so I created a burner account under a fake name and hopped onto the stream. I needed to stay as low-profile as possible.

The burner account worked to hide my identity, and I made it through the entire arrangement without receiving any side messages from other viewers. Nonetheless, my privacy ended up being the least of my concerns.

When the judge took her seat in front of the open courtroom, it was clear from her expression that she wasn't planning to take it easy on Summer whatsoever. At most, I was expecting Murder Two—maybe even Manslaughter. The police have yet to locate Riley's body, and from what they've disclosed, they haven't been able to find any evidence linking her to the actual crime. It seemed highly irrational to think that Summer would be charged to the highest extent.

Yet, that's exactly what happened. In a stern and fixed tone, the judge formally read the charges aloud for the courtroom.

Summer was charged with two counts of first-degree, premeditated murder—the most serious charge one can face in the American justice system.

The camera was fixed upon the Defendant's table throughout the proceeding, so I was able to get a clear look at Summer's expression as the charges were delivered. She did an okay job of holding it together for the

court camera, but it was clear that she was sobbing throughout the majority of the judge's statements, and she visibly shook at each mention of the victims' names. If I were to watch this from an unbiased perspective, I might actually believe that she was innocent.

Summer pleaded Not Guilty, of course, and was soon remanded to the Kalluah County Jail without bail. Afterwards, the media swarmed her team on their way out of the building—snapping hundreds of photos and begging for a statement on the murders. Her splotchy, teary-eyed face is now plastered across the TV screen of each and every citizen watching the local news this evening, with online debate now sparking about whether she is innocent or not.

The real question is—if Summer didn't murder those girls, then who did? It seems like the Brookwood Police have stopped investigating any other leads at this point, and the case against Summer seems strong enough for me to cast aside my reasonable doubt.

As I mentally comb through my suspect list, a loud crash outside of my room interrupts my train of thought. Given the events of these past two weeks, I'm much more on-edge than usual, so I pull my canister of pepper spray from my drawer before tiptoeing to my door to investigate the noise.

I quietly turn the knob before cracking the door open and peeking my head around the corner. To my immediate relief, I only find Alison—who is crouched down to pick up several colorful plates that have fallen onto the floor.

Thank God.

It's just Alison.

Not a murderer.

She must hear my movement from behind her, because she turns her head to face me as soon as I step outside my door.

"Sorry," she says, placing her hand over her mouth. "Were you asleep?"

I laugh. "Please. I haven't slept since Halloween."

Alison's face shows a flash of concern, but she quickly goes back to normal. Since everything has been so weird lately, I've asked her to keep our interactions as casual as possible, and to not mention a word about Riley, Caroline, or Summer unless absolutely necessary. Thankfully, she's done a pretty good job of keeping things cool so far.

"About that..." Alison trails off for a second, suddenly quieting her tone. "I talked to Kimberly today, and she told me that Summer's Alpha

Omega membership was placed on suspension until further notice.”

“I know,” I nod. “Juliette told me last night.”

Juliette has been another saving grace in this entire fiasco. Not even once has she made me feel like a public spectacle, nor has she mentioned the case on days I don’t feel up to talking about it. She even reached out to ask for my permission to revoke Summer’s active status in the chapter—something I was fully in support of, of course.

I suddenly notice Alison examining my face, as if she’s trying to gauge my opinion on Summer’s current imprisonment.

“What?” I ask.

She stands up, now leaning in close to the area I’ve moved to. “You know you can tell me anything, right?”

I nod at her, motioning for her to get on with her point.

“Okay,” Alison sighs. “Do you really think that Summer did it?”

“Oh.” I’m caught off guard by the question. I pause for a moment, unsure of what to say. “I guess I’m not sure what to think yet. How about you?”

She flops back onto the couch and speaks confidently. “I think she did it. 100%.”

“Really?” I ask. “What makes you so sure?”

Alison clears her throat, as if she’s about to drop a bucketload of information on me.

“First of all, I’ve gotten a weird feeling about her ever since she drove us home—the night of our Leap of Faith off the cliff. As soon as you brought up Riley and Caroline, she started acting *so* strange. It was clear that something was off about her...Kimberly said so too.”

I raise a brow at her. “Is that it?”

“Of course not.” She continues to list off the reasons behind her suspicions. “That night at Roxy’s—when we found her with Noah—she seemed way too excited about snuggling up with her dead friend’s ex-boyfriend. I can’t really think of a reason that any decent person would be okay with doing that to their own friend, let alone to a missing person.”

She sighs once more.

“And of course, there’s the fact that she got extremely defensive any time you would bring up the idea that she could be hiding something. She also went fully into ghost-mode the second the bodies were found, which I think is a bit suspicious. She didn’t even show up to the vigil.”

That's true. Cabot University held a late-night memorial for the two girls following the discovery of Caroline's body, and pretty much the entire town came by to show their support for the families. Yet, Summer—the girls' alleged best friend—was nowhere to be found. Even Gracie Franklin showed up, and we've all heard the rumors of her past feuds with the victims.

Summer's absence *was* incredibly suspicious.

"I guess you're right," I say with disappointment. "It's just hard to imagine...she was so convincing at first."

I've spent a great amount of time reflecting on the night of End-of-Summer Cocktail—the evening I first got to have a real conversation with Summer. This was also the night of my discovery of the fact that the two girls were in Alpha Omega, which greatly increased my interest in joining the sorority in the first place.

As she sat in her room telling me her perspective on the case, she was more than convincing when it came to pretending to care about Riley and Caroline's disappearance. In that interaction, nothing stood out to me as suspicious, and I believed every word of what she said. It was only as time went on that my thoughts began to change.

Alison interrupts my mind once again to announce that she's leaving.

"If you need anything, just call me." She grabs her keys off of the hook on the wall. "I'll be back by tonight."

I don't bother to ask where she's going, and instead simply wave her off before returning to my room to take a mid-day nap.



Moments after I drift off, I wake to the sound of my ringtone blaring throughout my room. Still half-asleep, I scramble to find my phone through—eventually locating it underneath my blanket. On what's likely to be the last ring, I quickly swipe the screen to answer and place the phone to my ear.

Before I have a chance to get a word out, a loud automated message begins to blast through the speaker. At first, I go to hang up—thinking it's a scam caller or some type of sales company.

Until I hear the words being said.

“You are receiving a collect call from the Kalluah County Jail from Inmate #237: Summer Harding. Press 1 to accept this call.”

I freeze in place—my finger hovering over the *1* button on my keypad.

Do I really want to talk to Summer right now?

Or ever?

After everything she’s put all of us through, I can’t imagine that she actually thinks I would accept this phone call. Summer has evidently run out of other friends and supporters, and has had to revert back to me in a state of desperation.

It won’t work.

With a great amount of personal satisfaction, I press the *End Call* button with my index finger and flop back downward onto my pillow—immediately closing my eyes in the hopes of falling back to sleep.

Even if I did theoretically sit down at the jail with Summer to hear her out, how could I possibly be sure that she would even speak the truth? As of right now, she’s only proven to be capable of spewing countless lies.

Maybe one day I’ll be ready to hear Summer’s side of things.

Just not today.

46

Riley Walker

NOVEMBER 2023

(One Week Before)

“So, what are your plans this week?”

Caroline casually asks the question from across the table as I glare at her in response.

We’re back at Marciello’s once again, this time with the purpose of Caroline finally disclosing whatever secret activities she has been participating in for over a month. She’s fully aware that we’re here specifically for that reason, so I’m not sure why she’s trying to divert the conversation.

“Caroline,” I snap. “You promised.”

She lets out a long, agitated sigh, then digs into her bag to find something—eventually pulling out a red folder and placing it on the tabletop. Before opening up the folder, she looks up and stares directly into my eyes.

“Before I tell you anything, I need to explain a few other things.”

I glance at her warily, and she keeps talking once she notices that she’s gauged my interest.

“I’m going to tell you what you want to know,” she says. “But first, it’s important for you to know that I broke up with Noah yesterday...and that I told him I think he should get back with Summer.”

I nearly spit out my drink when her statement crosses my ears. This was completely unexpected news, especially after everything that’s happened since the news of Noah and Summer’s affair first broke.

“But, why?” I ask.

Caroline glances off to her left in thought, as if she doesn’t even know why she broke up with him herself. Eventually she begins to laugh, and it’s suddenly clear that she’s not bothered by this breakup whatsoever.

“It’s hard to explain...but it’s like this,” she tells. “I fought with Summer for Noah’s affection for months, and by the time I finally got him back, I realized he wasn’t really worth fighting for.”

She nods at her own words—confirming that they make sense. “I mean, he literally *cheated on me* with one of my *best friends*. It’s obvious that he wasn’t my future husband.”

“Good point,” I say in agreement. “But why would you tell him to get back together with Summer? You can’t stand her.”

“That was true up until a few days ago,” Caroline says. “Then I realized that they’re both just desperate, and kind of pathetic. I actually think they’re perfect for each other.”

She pauses.

“And on that note, I’m planning to extend an olive branch. You know how we have that mandatory morning chapter before Thanksgiving Break?”

“Yes,” I confirm. “The Sunday after the Turkey Bash party?”

“Exactly,” Caroline says. “I’m going to ask her to pick us up from Norman that Monday, and after chapter, we can go to lunch and talk things out.”

I raise a brow at Caroline in suspicion. Not once in our year of friendship have I ever heard her be willing to forgive someone—let alone repair a friendship with someone that has wronged her. Just a couple of weeks ago, the two of them were basically scratching each other's eyes out at a fraternity house.

Now, suddenly, she wants to be friends with her again?

Nope. I don’t buy it.

“What’s the catch?” I ask.

“There’s no catch,” she insists. “Like I said—I think she’s pathetic, and I don’t even really want to be her friend. With that being said, this little feud between us is getting old pretty fast, and I’d like to be able to go to parties in peace again. Wouldn’t you?”

That’s a good point. It’s been getting old for a while now, and I was internally hoping that it would end sooner rather than later. I just didn’t think the time would come so soon.

“Okay,” I concede. “Well, keep me updated on that.”

The topic of Summer and Noah distracts my mind for the time being, but after a few minutes, I remember the point of this entire excursion. As Caroline pushes food around her plate with her fork, I speak back up.

“You still have to tell me what you’ve been up to, though.” I cross my arms. “You’re not getting out of this one.”

Her face drops.

“If you insist.”

Caroline sips her water before starting her story—now speaking in a more serious tone than before.

“I guess everything started a few months ago, right when we first found out about Summer and Noah. Once we stopped hanging out with her, and she didn’t have any more friends to turn to, she started spending a lot of time with Ashley Worthington. Do you remember that?”

“Yes,” I nod. “But what does that have to do with anything?”

“I’ll explain,” she says patiently. “At the time, I was super angry at Summer, but almost equally mad at Ashley for providing her with a safe haven after what she did to me. I know she didn’t owe me anything—we weren’t even friends—but it still really pissed me off.”

She looks off into the distance.

“So...I started looking into Ashley’s personal life to see if I could uncover anything odd or suspicious about her, hoping I could...you know...”

“Blackmail her into ending their friendship,” I insert, finishing the sentence that I’m sure she was implying. “But I don’t understand. You already told me you were digging into her life. Why the secrecy now?”

Caroline shushes me, then continues in a whisper.

“I started by looking into her drinking habits. I’ve always heard the stories of her getting a bit too plastered at frat parties and mixers, and I thought I might be able to use that against her if she thought it would affect her spot in the nursing program. Sadly, I couldn’t find anything that had quite a shock factor to it, so I needed to look for something else.”

I roll my eyes, but my disgust at her behavior doesn’t keep her from carrying on with the explanation.

“The week after, I tracked down a few of her acquaintances from the Nursing School and paid them off to tell me about her.”

She holds up her hand—pausing the story.

“I know it sounds ridiculous, but you have to remember how angry I was back then. This was around the same time that I destroyed Summer’s car.”

“Yep,” I laugh. “A true woman scorned.”

Caroline laughs. “Exactly. Anyways, pretty much the only thing that any of her classmates knew about her was that she spends most Mondays at Roxy’s for Karaoke Night. I didn’t really think I’d find out anything new about her from watching her on stage, but considering it was my only lead, I decided to check it out the following week.”

The waitress suddenly comes to refill our drinks, and the two of us remain dead silent other than thanking her. In a small town, you can’t risk dropping hot information in local restaurants.

Word travels fast around here.

As soon as the waitress returns to the kitchen area, Caroline picks back up with the story in an even-quieter whisper.

“That Monday night, I drove to Roxy’s alone and parked my car a block down the street, then speedwalked up the street in a well-planned disguise of a hoodie and sunglasses. After I got past the bouncers—thanks to the fake ID Gracie made for me, by the way—I sat in a far corner seat at the bar and kept an eye out for any blondes that looked like Ashley. Thankfully, I didn’t have to wait very long.”

I lean forward in my seat.

This story is finally getting interesting.

“Around eleven or twelve, I saw a blonde girl walk into the bar and directly back to the booth area, where she sat down with a man that had been there awhile. I wasn’t able to get a good look at her face from where I was sitting, but I recognized the man—Professor Darcy. His dad basically owns the school, and he’s a teacher in the business program or something.”

I raise a brow. “Ashley was with him?”

Caroline taps the red folder. “It didn’t make sense to me at first either. Ashley wouldn’t have met Professor Darcy through any of her nursing program classes, and they probably wouldn’t have run into each other on campus. I spent nearly an hour trying to get a good look at the girl’s face to make sure it was even Ashley, but the spot they were sitting was obscured from nearly every view, so I wasn’t able to see her. Then, just as I was about to give up and go home, I saw them getting up to leave.”

I nod, motioning with my hand for her to keep going.

“So, I snuck over to a seat beside the exit and settled there, propping my phone camera against my chest in a discreet way to snap a photo of Ashley with Professor Darcy as she passed.”

She suddenly stops speaking—tightening her lips in nervousness. It's clear that she doesn't want to disclose whatever comes next in the story, but I'm not going to give her an out. I need to hear this.

"And?" I press.

"And," Caroline says with a nervous breath. "It wasn't Ashley."

I've just lost all interest in this story.

I'm not sure what Caroline is playing at, but clearly there was no point in dragging her here to talk about this.

"Whatever," I sigh. "This story sucks, and I don't think I care anymore."

As I go to stand up and walk to the cash register, Caroline grabs my hand.

"Riley," she says warily, now speaking in an almost unsettling tone. "You'll want to see this." Glancing around the room, she speaks again. "Let's wait until we're in the car. I'll go pay our tab."

When the bill has been paid and our table is cleared, we walk out of the restaurant to a dark sky. Once inside the car, Caroline moves us to a more secluded side of the parking lot and flicks one of the overhead lights on.

She gently places the red folder in front of me, holding it closed until she finishes speaking.

"Have a look whenever you're ready."

Still annoyed, I take my time before turning the first page of the folder open—expecting nothing that will actually surprise me or pertain to my life whatsoever.

But I was wrong.

So wrong.

On the very first page of the folder sits a photo of a girl and a man—the latter of which I can safely assume to be Professor Darcy. I take the printed photo out to take a closer look at the faces on the page, now focusing mainly on the blonde girl in front of the man.

I almost don't recognize her at first—the blonde hair is a switch-up from the brunette locks I'm used to—but I'd know that face anywhere.

Caroline was right.

The person meeting Professor Darcy that night was not, in fact, Ashley Worthington.

It was my sister.

47

LEIGHTON
2024

The phone calls from Kalluah County Jail have become more persistent.

Only a few days have passed since the first one, but Summer has called at least twice a day ever since. I didn't really think that prisoners had any free time to be able to sit around by the telephone station, but I guess they don't really serve any other purpose inside those walls.

Despite her persistence, I haven't accepted a single call. Thanks to the United States corrections system, I have the wonderful choice of declining any call that she makes to my mobile number, and I have definitely employed that right. However, the closer the date gets to the one-year anniversary of Riley and Caroline's disappearance, the more I consider picking up each time.

If I did accept the phone call and arrange a visiting hour with Summer, it wouldn't just be for me. So many things about the law enforcement theories don't add up, and so many people would kill to know what truly happened to the girls. The whole world needs answers in this case—especially the families of the victims—and for some reason, I think she'd be willing to give them to me. After all, I was almost her Little. That has to count for something.

As I attempt to complete my Bradshaw application, I try not to let my mind wander to thoughts of when the next phone call might come in. The busy events of these past few months nearly distracted me from my entire purpose of coming to this school—my acceptance to the Bradshaw program—and I now have something worth writing about in my letter.

Speaking of the program—Professor Boswell reached out to me around the time of Summer's arrest. He congratulated me on my advancements in the case, along with thanking me for working tirelessly on a case that

involved people I never knew. In the bottom line of the email, though, was a note that made my heart skip a beat when I read it.

You have great investigative initiative, and it would be a shame to squander that talent on any non-Criminal Justice major. Hope to see you in more of my classes going forward.

Best,

Professor Seth Boswell

Though my recent discoveries have caused more harm than good in my life recently, it seems that they may have helped my chances of getting into Bradshaw even more than I expected. At least some good can come from all of this chaos. As I type my way through this application letter, I try to remind myself of that.

Just as I begin on the second paragraph, my ringtone blares out of my cell phone from across the room. My heart thumps loudly inside my chest as I warily walk to where my phone is sitting. I flip my phone upwards—revealing the caller to be the same number that I’ve received countless calls from this week—and my nerves are quickly justified.

Yet again, Summer is calling me. I listen through the familiar automated voice message as I try to make a split-second decision on whether to answer.

“—press 1 to accept this call.”

It’s now or never.

With a deep breath, I press my finger down on the *1* button.

“Hello?”

48

Riley Walker

TEN HOURS BEFORE

The anger that is coursing through my veins hasn't left my body in almost seven days, and I'm not sure if it ever will.

When Caroline showed me the photo of my sister with Professor Darcy, everything changed. All of the rage that has built up inside of me this year suddenly bubbled to the top, and I couldn't hold it back any longer than I already have. Out of all of the ridiculous, screwed-up events of the semester, this is by far the one that has successfully brought the largest reaction out of me.

I knew exactly what the photo meant the moment I saw it.

My sister—whom I believed to be attending high school on the opposite side of the state—has been seducing her way into receiving an acceptance into Cabot University. Like the calculated, cold-blooded individual she is, she tracked down the youngest and most-lustful major figure at the school, then slowly twisted the poor bastard into her little web.

That's just who she is.

And that's exactly why I didn't want her at this school.

Earlier in the semester, she was messaging me nonstop about needing help with her Cabot application. I ignored each and every text with the hopes of driving her away from the school, but it seems that she simply chose to find another source of help—in the most unethical way possible, that is.

This isn't surprising behavior from her, though. With my knowledge of how she was in high school, the revelation about her and Professor Darcy seems to mirror the pattern of bad choices she has made in recent years.

Choices I had hoped she would eventually grow out of.

To preface the story, it's crucial to understand my sister had never really been an easy child, and the divorce of my parents took even more of a toll on her emotional state. From elementary school to late middle school, she

was an absolute nightmare to live with—throwing household items at our heads, screaming at us for the slightest wrong move, and even hiding our beloved items from us when we would anger her. With no father figure to keep her in check, and a still-present parent who couldn't make it through a day without downing a bottle of vodka, she quickly learned that she could get away with much worse.

I've covered the story of my senior Prom—where she was arrested for hooking up with my boyfriend in a dimly-lit parking lot—but that was only one example of many. Ever since she hit puberty, my sister has made every effort possible to exploit her physical appearance to get what she wants from men, and she's successful nearly every time.

Even when it hurts everyone around her.

On the night of the Prom, she used my boyfriend to get back at me for borrowing a pair of her earrings without asking. She didn't even like him.

Her junior year, she slept with her college-aged manager at the riverfront restaurant in town to get paid \$15 an hour instead of \$12. She quit that job the moment the season picked up—completely screwing them over during their busiest time of year.

Now, she's using Professor Darcy to weasel her way into Cabot University—knowing damn well she would never get in based on grades alone.

That's the kind of person my sister is.

A disloyal, non-empathetic user.

And she's taken things a step too far this time. The more I think about it, the more my heart fills with bursting amounts of anger.

I whip out my phone and shoot a quick text to Caroline.

1:52 PM

WHERE ARE YOU?

Through the deep breaths I'm taking in an attempt to calm myself down, I glance back and forth at my phone periodically in hopes of a response. There's nobody else I can text about this specific situation, and if Caroline doesn't answer soon, I can't promise that I'm not going to do something extreme.

In between phone-checks, I catch a glimpse of my display of half-full wine bottles sitting on our shelf, and I can't help but think that a quick glass of wine might dull my anger for the time being.

Earlier this morning, Caroline asked if we could skip out on the Turkey Bash tonight—Theta Mu’s most anticipated event of the year. Last year’s party was one of the best nights of my freshman year, and I had been excited to see how this semester’s party would go, so I hesitated to say yes at first. After how last month’s Halloween parties went for us, I wanted to find some redemption at Thanksgiving or Christmas.

Still, it was clear that Caroline wanted to skip out, so I took one for the team and agreed to a quiet night in instead.

Given recent events, though, I can’t say I’m too bummed about missing the Bash. Every party I’ve been to this year has involved either an uncomfortable conversation, a physical fight, or police activity, and I don’t know how much more of that I can take.

The only issue—now I have no reasonable excuse to get drunk tonight. But that’s never mattered to me before.

After taking all of this into consideration, I decide that a glass of wine can’t hurt. I’m in desperate need of some type of sedative for my anger about my sister, and intoxication is typically the best solution for me.

Yet, as I drain a third glass of my favorite fine wine, it seems that the exact opposite is happening. I feel noticeably more volatile and vengeful by the second—as if an enraged spirit is slowly entering my body and taking over my mind—but I can’t seem to keep myself from downing the entire bottle.

By the time that every last drop has worked its way into my bloodstream, Caroline still hasn’t answered my text, and I’ve already made a decision in my head.

I grab my phone from beside me, angrily enter a phone number into the keypad, then press the call button.

It’s time to solve this issue for myself.

49
LEIGHTON
2024

Sixteen minutes.

That's how far I make it into my drive before beginning to second-guess my decision to do what I'm doing right now.

The Kalluah County Jail is a forty-five minute drive away from Norman Hall, so I only have about thirty minutes to decide whether or not I'm turning back. The sooner I can make a decision, the better.

My phone call with Summer to set up our meeting lasted less than a minute. I tried to ask her my most burning questions in our limited time, but the only time she spoke was to insist on my coming to visit her—something about evidence pertaining to the case.

Though attending visiting hours at the county lockup is pretty much the last thing I want to do today, Summer's tone was convincing enough to get me to agree to a brief meeting. With as few words as possible, the two of us arranged a time that aligned with both her inmate schedule and my student schedule—eventually deciding on 6:00 tonight. Once I confirmed that I would set up a visiting time with the jail, Summer quietly thanked me and hung up.

What she doesn't know, though, is that I've only booked us a fifteen minute visiting slot. Whatever she has to say to me during this meeting, I'm positive she can get it across in that time window.

As I rack my brains to think of what evidence Summer might have scraped up in desperation for a lighter sentence, I decide to continue driving and commit to the meeting. This might be my only chance to talk to her about the case now that she's officially in the Hot Seat.

Once I've made my decision, the remainder of the drive goes by quickly. When I'm a little less than five minutes away, my ringtone begins

to sound from the display on the car, so I free up my right hand and tap the *Accept* button.

“I’m not there yet,” I say preemptively. “But thank you for checking, *again*.”

Nathan’s laugh sounds from the car speakers. “Okay, okay. I’m sorry. I just worry sometimes...”

Since I left the dorm half an hour ago, Nathan has sent multiple texts and made just as many calls to ask me if I think I’m making a good decision. The answer—I’m not really sure—but I’m not going to tell him that. I can’t back down from this meeting...not even to him.

I take the last few moments of the drive to reassure him.

“There’s going to be a security guard in the room with us at all times,” I insist. “I’ll be fine—I promise. Summer can’t kill me with her hands and feet cuffed to a table.”

Nathan’s silence on the other line tells me that he recognizes my point, and he switches the topic with a light voice.

“Fine,” he says defeatedly. “But try to be back at your dorm by 8:00 to get ready. The party starts at nine, so I’m picking you guys up a little bit before that.”

The party.

I almost forgot.

The annual Theta Mu Turkey Bash is tonight, and Nathan has been insistent that the two of us attend together. While I wouldn’t mind getting out of the house—it might even be good for me compared to my choice in activities for today—I really have no desire to go.

Nonetheless, Nathan wants to go, and so does Alison. There’s no way I’m getting out of this one.

“Right,” I say through a forced cheery tone that I’m hoping he can’t detect the inauthenticity of. “I’ll be ready by 8:30.”

Just as I finish my sentence, the sign for the jail comes into view from a distance. I take the hard left turn as soon as I reach it, then ride the short gravel driveway all the way into the parking area outside of the tall barbed-wire fences—sliding my car into park beside a red truck towards the back.

Without giving myself a moment to re-think my decision, I step out of my car and turn my key inside the lock.

There’s no turning back now.

I pull out my phone and check the time as I walk through the massive parking lot—5:46 *p.m.*

When I researched how to prepare for your first jailhouse visiting hour, most of the comments suggested getting to the facility at least fifteen minutes early to account for the time it takes to be screened and cleared for entry. I have a little bit less time than that, but I'm hoping I'll still make it in time.

Though every alarm bell in my head is going off, I continue to follow the marked signs to find the armed guard on duty.

As I walk closer and closer to the gate, I notice the hairs on my arms are standing up stick-straight and surrounded by goosebumps, and I can no longer take a full breath of air from all of the tightness in my chest.

Something is wrong. Really wrong. But I won't know what it is until I'm face to face with Summer.

50

Riley Walker

THREE HOURS BEFORE

I smack my handwritten note on Caroline's door, sealing it onto the wood with a strip of packing tape I found inside my desk.

The note contains the time and location of the meeting I've arranged with my sister for tonight—which is just a short three hours from now. My phone call escalated from the moment she picked up the phone earlier, and it was clear that an in-person meeting was going to be necessary to resolve this matter.

She insisted on it, actually.

When I dialed her number into my keypad and made the call, she didn't pick up for the first five rings—irritating me even further than I already was. When she eventually answered, I barely let her get a word in before I began berating her for the morally repugnant choices she has been making. As expected, she fired back with any possible deep-rooted insult she could think of in an attempt to distract from what I knew.

Until I mentioned the photo of her and Professor Darcy.

As soon as there was mention of photo evidence, my sister's attitude turned around completely. For the first time in her life, I could hear that her strengthened facade was beginning to crumble down right in front of her eyes, and the realization made me happier than I've felt in months. She finally realized that someone had the upper hand over her.

My sister has officially met her match in Caroline Rowe.

The moment I mentioned reporting her actions to the Cabot Board of Admissions, her attitude changed once again—this time shifting from defeated to absolutely volatile. She insisted on meeting tonight to “*resolve the matter*”, so I had to scramble to think of a good secluded location that wouldn't be crowded the weekend before Thanksgiving. Luckily, the informational packet I picked up from Marciello's a few months ago was

sitting directly in my line of sight atop my desk, so it didn't take long to confirm a time and place.

Cheaha State Park—the main feature of the brochure I selected from the stand below the cashier's counter—is a huge, preserved wooded area roughly a half-hour from campus. A few of the girls in Alpha Omega go there to walk their dogs throughout the week, but otherwise the park is mostly used by recreational sports teams and families with children. Therefore, it should definitely be empty at 10 p.m. on a weekend—especially on a holiday weekend.

After internet-searching the most concealed and private areas of the park, no results were available, so I eventually settled on an area with the same name as the official flower of our sorority—White Rose Point. I spit out the place and time of our meet-up through the phone, then smashed my finger against the *end call* button before she could say a word in protest. If she truly wants to resolve this, she'll show up wherever and whenever I ask her to.

Caroline still isn't home yet, and I'm not sure where she is, so I left the note on her room door for her to find when she's home. I used the state park's initials when describing the meeting place—it's become a habit when writing on our *Hot Sheets*—but I'm sure she'll be able to decipher it. For now, I'm going out.

There are a few more things I need to do before tonight.

51

Riley Walker

THIRTY MINUTES BEFORE

“Are you ready?” I ask. “We’re going to be late.”

I check the time on my phone for a third time in anticipation.

“Riles, it’s a twenty-five minute drive.”

Caroline continues to carefully sort my newly-printed photos into her red folder. After finishing, she places my meeting note in the spot where the folder sat before—underneath her carpeting in the closet.

“We’re not meeting her til ten...that’s an hour from now.”

I throw my head back in defeat. “Fine. But can you at least hurry?”

The folder that Caroline’s currently sorting is full of every bit of negative and blackmail-worthy information I could scrounge up about my sister. I compiled every screenshot, text message, and incriminating picture that I’ve saved over the years into one document, then printed everything in the student library.

Once again, free printing for full-time students saves the day.

“There, I’m done,” Caroline says as she places the photo of my sister and Darcy at the very top of the stack. “But before we go, can we order some pasta? I haven’t eaten all day.”

I check the time yet again. “We don’t have time. They close at ten, and we’re supposed to be at Cheaha by then.”

Caroline glances down at her phone as well, also checking to confirm that we don’t have time to make any stops.

“Okay,” she sighs, suddenly gasping with an idea. “What if we called it in now, then picked it up on the way back? Marciello’s does pickup orders until 11.”

After some convincing, I hesitantly call in an order to our favorite restaurant, then confirm with the waitress on the phone that we’ll be picking up the order later tonight. Now that I’ve satisfied Caroline, I look to her for permission to get going.

“Okay, we can go now,” she says finally. “But I’m driving. You’re seeing red a bit too much to be behind a wheel right now.”

That’s a good point. Each hour leading up to the meeting, my anger about the situation has increased immensely.

“Fine,” I say defeatedly. “But we’re taking my car—she’ll need to be able to recognize us from the parking lot.”

Without further protest, the two of us pull on our heavy jackets, and leave our room—booking it downstairs to my car.



When five minutes remain in the drive, I go over the game plan with Caroline once again.

“As soon as she gets to where we are, we’ll show her the folder, then give her the ultimatum,” I relay to her.

She raises a brow. “Which is?”

“She can either stop sleeping with Professor Darcy, or this folder goes straight to the admissions office.”

Personally, I think the choice is easy.

“Got it,” Caroline says. “And what is our plan if she goes psycho on us?”

“Don’t worry,” I laugh, pulling a bright pink taser out of my bag. “I brought us a Plan B.”

The two of us laugh for a moment before Caroline’s face suddenly drops.

“Shit,” she mutters, staring ahead through the windshield as she brings the car to a stop.

I follow her lead and stare in the same direction, now seeing a large gate standing directly in the road that we need to drive on.

“Well, shit,” I mutter similarly. “I didn’t think to research closing times.”

Caroline shrugs, reversing the car to get back out on the main road. “Don’t worry. There’s always a way in.”

A little ways down the road, she brings the car to a second stop outside of the fence in an area that’s concealed by bushes and trees, then slides the gear shift into park. She smiles at me menacingly from the driver’s seat while I try to understand her new plan.

I stare back at her. “What are we doing?”

Caroline laughs, but her words are completely serious.

“We’re breaking in.”

“Absolutely not,” I assert. “A felony would get both of us kicked out of school, and I’d be kissing any criminal justice program goodbye.”

She rolls her eyes in response.

“Riles, we’re literally going to be here for an hour. We’ll go to the Point, meet with your sister, get our point across, then get out of here and pick up our food. Nobody will catch us, I promise.”

I take a moment of consideration.

The whole thing is beginning to feel like a bad idea, but it’s far too late to back out now. Caroline seems to think it’ll be okay, and she normally lucks out with these kinds of things. Maybe I’m overreacting.

“Okay,” I sigh. “Let’s go.”



The walk to White Rose Point takes longer than we expected. It’s surprisingly warm for a late November night in Alabama, but it’s still cold enough to where I’m thankful we brought jackets for this trek through the woods.

A little while later, we arrive at a sign reading the correct name of our decided meeting place.

The Point is completely surrounded by forest, but a few picnic tables and camping spots surround the large parking area that we’re standing in. On a hot Summer day, I imagine this place is filled to the brim with families and couples looking for an outdoor adventure, but right now—a cold winter night—it stands completely empty.

From where we’re standing, the noises of cicadas and other insects sitting against the trees surround us, and it’s almost impossible to hear any other sounds of the forest. Down the street, a faded streetlight casts a shadowy glow upon the trees directly above it—causing the birds to chirp brightly as if it were morning-time. Squirrels and raccoons scurry across the parking lot at times, but otherwise, it’s just Caroline and I in this empty expanse.

“What time is it?” she suddenly asks, interrupting the serenity of the woods.

I glance down at my phone to check the time, seeing that it's just after 10:00. Before I can set my phone back down, a message comes in from my sister's contact, and I hesitantly open it.

10:02 PM

BE THERE SOON. WALKING TO THE POINT.

"Great," I tell Caroline. "She says she'll be here soon."

She rolls her eyes in response.

"Can't wait," she says in a mocking tone, her teeth beginning to chatter from the cold. "I never really liked her—this whole thing just gave me even more of a reason—but making us wait for her in the cold is about to be my last straw."

Caroline is verbalizing everything I've been feeling since we made this discovery. My sister has been a nightmare my whole life, but sleeping her way into acceptance at a school that I had to work hard for my entire academic life to get into is utterly unforgivable.

I decide to simply nod at her. "Let's just hope she's receptive."

We agree on my statement, then return to sitting in silence.

After a few more minutes pass, though, the silence is suddenly broken by the sound of twigs snapping and gravel overturning. I call out loudly, hoping that whomever or whatever is coming towards us will identify themselves before getting any closer, but nobody answers.

I look at Caroline and hush to a whisper. "Do you think it's her?"

"I don't know," she says, squinting in the direction that we heard the noise. "But I'm getting a little scared."

That's the first time in my life that I've heard Caroline use the word *scared*, so I know the situation must be serious. We continue to look down the road in hopes of identifying the culprit of the noises we heard, but nothing comes into view.

Until a few seconds later, that is.

Underneath the orange-ish glow of the streetlight, a silhouette of a person begins to come into view. It's clear that whoever is coming towards us is a female—the hair gives it away in an instant—but I'm unable to tell that it's my sister until she comes closer towards us. Once I'm sure, the two of us stand our ground and await her presence.

More time passes, and she grows closer and closer. And the closer she gets, the clearer my view of her gets.

As she completely passes by the dampened streetlight, something in her right hand suddenly gleams in the soft light—casting a beam of light onto the gravel for a moment. I squint my eyes, hoping to narrow them in on whatever she is holding, and eventually I am able to get a good look.

Suddenly, every bone in my body goes numb, and my heart drops into my stomach the same way it does on a rollercoaster.

My sister is, in fact, the person in question that is heading directly towards where Caroline and I are standing. Even with the blonde hair, I'd recognize her from a mile away. She's walking with a purpose now, and I'm positive she's seen the two of us.

Even from how far away we are, it's evident that she is angrier than I've ever seen her before.

Most importantly, she's holding a gun.

And it looks like she's ready to use it.

52
LEIGHTON
2024

Summer has never looked worse.

Even through the filthy speckled glass, it's clear that she hasn't gotten a good night's sleep in days. Her hair is thrown into a messy bun atop her head, and dark circles plague her undereyes—which are already red and splotchy from over a week of constant tears. If Summer is trying to put on a battered victim persona for the media surrounding the trial, she's definitely doing a great job.

The moment I sit down, her eyes slightly brighten at me. In a surprised tone, she speaks through the plastic telephone to her right.

“You came.”

I lift the phone to my mouth. “I'm not here for you. I came for answers.”

The brightness in her face fades, but she nods understandingly.

“So,” I prompt. “What did you want to tell me?”

Just as she's about to speak up, Summer breaks into a coughing fit that takes up nearly a full minute of our already-minimal time slot. She looks even worse than before by the time she's finished coughing, but once she gets back up, she chokes out her statement from before.

“Listen, Leighton. I know you won't believe me about half of the things I'm going to tell you right now, but believe me when I say that every single word is true...every word.”

Summer waits for my response, but I'm not going to give her one. I won't play her little game.

Eventually, she rolls her eyes and begins with the elaborate story.

“I slept with Noah Banks,” she says.

I roll my eyes right back at her.

“I already knew that.”

“Just listen to me, Leighton,” she says insistently, nearly yelling at me through the visitation telephone. “I slept with Noah, and Caroline and Riley hated me for it—that much is true. But I swear to God, I did not kill anybody. I *loved* them, and they were my best friends.”

I can’t help but laugh at her. This is the third time she has said some variation of this exact sentence to me since I met her—which is funny to me in some ways. Instead of listening to her spew the same words on repeat, I decide to cut right to the chase.

“And do you have any proof of that?”

“That’s the thing,” Summer sighs. “I was with Noah that night—I’ve told you that before. He came to the Alpha Omega house sometime after eleven or so, then stayed until 7 a.m. the next morning. It might seem like that would be easy to prove, but Eleanor didn’t allow Brookwood PD to access any of the Alpha Omega security footage at the time, so all of the footage of Noah arriving and leaving eventually erased itself to make room for more data storage. None of it is on file because they were never able to view it. Therefore, Noah is my only alibi—which isn’t worth much in the District Attorney’s eyes.”

I consider her statement.

It’s true—it is common knowledge that Eleanor Stephens paid off the Brookwood Police Department to keep them from investigating any Alpha Omega members, as well as keeping Riley and Caroline’s affiliation with the sorority concealed from the media. Though she had claimed to have done so in the best interests of the members, it’s clearly coming back to bite those people in the ass even a whole year later.

“Okay, so,” I say with a twinge of doubt in my voice. “Why do they think you did it, then? I’m pretty sure they don’t lock people up for no reason around here.”

Suddenly, Summer raises a brow and cocks her head at me.

“I think you know.”

I’m not sure what she could possibly mean by that.

“Actually,” I snip, “I don’t.”

“The police told me about the anonymous tip that they got when they questioned the Alpha Omega members,” Summer says in a short tone. “My lawyer couldn’t get his hands on the exact name, but he found out the names of the fifteen people that were questioned during the block of time that the tip was received.”

She pauses before delivering the final line.

“And *your* name was on that list, Leighton.”

Knowing I wasn’t the one to make the report, I try to mentally visualize the day I was questioned in the Brookwood Police Department—hoping to remember the names of other girls I was questioned with that day.

Other than Alison, Maeve, and Imani, I can’t think of anyone specific that was there with us. After all, that was only a day or two after Nathan and I discovered the bodies, so I wasn’t in the clearest state of mind.

“That wasn’t me,” I insist, throwing my hands up in the air. “I was only in there for five minutes, and all we talked about was my discovering Caroline’s body. I swear.”

She examines me skeptically, clearly about to shoot back with words of doubt, but I cut in before she can.

“I need you to tell me exactly what the police think you did, and then tell me what you *actually* did that night. Then we can talk about the tip.”

Summer sighs, but gives in to my request—leaving out no details this time.

“It’s a bit convoluted, but I’ll try to explain as best I can,” she begins, clearing her throat before speaking.

“On the night of the Turkey Bash, I really did try to have fun for the first hour. Ashley and I danced and socialized while I was there, but I was too distracted to have a good time. See—Caroline had reached out to me the day before about talking things out the morning after the party, so that was pretty much all that was on my mind at the time. Since I couldn’t think about socializing, I decided to leave.”

Summer pauses in thought.

“It sounds bad, but I really did invite Noah over with the intention of ending things. We had talked a little bit at the party, and he had mentioned coming over, so I thought it would be the perfect time to break it all off. That way, I was going to be able to tell Caroline that Noah and I were truly done when we had our talk the next morning...I thought it might make her want to be my friend again.”

“Is that what you really wanted?” I ask skeptically.

She huffs impatiently. “Of course it was. I know the two of us had our differences, but the moment she even mentioned forgiving me for what I had done, I realized how much I missed our trio of friends. I just wish I hadn’t figured that out too late...”

“Anyways,” I gesture for her to continue. “Back to what you were saying.”

“Right, so—since the police can’t get the footage of that night from the Greek Row houses, they can’t prove that I ever actually went home *or* that Noah ever came over that night. I have no valid alibi because of that, so now they’ve come up with the most outlandish theory I’ve ever heard: That I drove over to the train station where Riley’s car was found, shot them both, then dumped their bodies in the woods completely alone—as if that’s even possible.”

I take a good look at Summer. Even before she went to jail, she was as stick-thin as a runway model, and I’ve never even seen her be able to lift a heavy box or a weight. She’s correct in saying that it would be super difficult for her to move two full-grown adult bodies through miles of woodland terrain.

Before she can continue, I cut in with a question.

“Do they think you had an accomplice?”

“That’s the thing,” she says. “They’ve asked me a few basic questions about my relationship with Noah, but otherwise, I’m pretty sure they think I did the whole thing myself.”

I shake my head. “There’s no way. You couldn’t have.”

“That’s what I’ve been saying, but nobody will listen to me.” Summer slinks back in her chair defeated, but suddenly jerks the phone back to her face. “And once they found the gun, of course, it was over for me. The police wouldn’t even listen to me when I said it must have been planted there—as if I don’t live with fifty other people who have access to my room at all times. They acted like it wasn’t even a possibility.”

“So the gun wasn’t yours?” I ask.

“Nope,” she shakes her head. “The only weapon I even own is a taser... Riley, Caroline, and I got matching pink ones after watching some Ted Bundy documentary freshman year.”

Reflecting back on Halloween night—when all of us pregamed the night’s parties at the Alpha Omega house—pretty much the entire chapter was present. Given how distracted everyone was at the time, the pregame would have been a perfect window of opportunity for someone to slip inside Summer’s room, plant the gun inside of her drawer, then re-enter the party as if nothing ever happened. Nobody would have noticed or suspected anything.

Outside of that night, hundreds of us convene at the house in a weekly manner to attend each chapter meeting. Before and after we're actively in chapter, everyone is free to roam around as they please, and would have direct access to any of the rooms in the house. We even had a chapter meeting the night that Summer's arrest was made and the search warrant was conducted.

Of course, either of these theories would only work if the person attempting to frame Summer is also a member of Alpha Omega. The weight of that matter is clearly beginning to set in on the both of us.

"Anyways," she cuts in, "Back to the anonymous tip. That's what really screwed me."

Other visitors get up from and sit down at the surrounding seats as we talk, but we remain quiet enough to keep our conversation private to us.

From my seat, I turn to check the analog clock on the wall behind my head.

6:13.

I'm worried about running out of time in our conversation, and I suddenly find myself wishing that I had chosen a larger time slot. While I mentally scold myself for not doing so, Summer keeps on with her story.

"My lawyer told me that whoever made the anonymous statement claimed that I never came home the night of the murders, and that they saw my room sitting empty sometime around 12 a.m., but that's impossible. Noah was there with me in my room, and my door was closed. That's how I know that whoever made the report must've been lying...I'm just not sure why."

She leans forward into the booth, boring her eyes into my soul, then begins to speak in a much more serious and formal tone than just a moment ago.

"Leighton...can you swear to me that you are not the person who made the anonymous tip about me to the police?"

Summer timidly looks at me as if concerned of how I might answer.

"Can you look me in the eyes and swear?"

I nod my head casually. I'm unsure of why she is acting so strange all of a sudden, but I'm still not planning to play any of her games, so I keep my answer as simple as possible.

"Yes," I say. "I swear."

Summer takes a deep breath, accepting my response with a nod.

“Okay.” Her voice shakes as she speaks. “Then I’m sure of it now.”

“Sure of...?” I ask in confusion.

She narrows her eyes in preparation for what she has to say, but just as she opens her mouth to say something important, the armed Correctional Officer from behind her seat begins to step over towards our booth.

“Visiting time is over,” he grumbles in a low voice as he grabs Summer by the wrist. “Return to the security checkpoint for dismissal.”

Summer unwillingly begins to stand up as the cuffs are placed back on both of her wrists—a pleading look in her eye. I quickly hurdle out of my chair and knock on the glass, hoping that he’ll be able to allow us extra time in our meeting.

“Sir,” I say desperately in between knocks. “I’m the one who set up the meeting—is there any way I can extend our time period?”

The burly, disgruntling officer stops what he’s doing in an annoyed fashion, then glances up at the clock. After playing with his beard in consideration for a moment, he turns back to face me and huffs out his words.

“Ask the front desk. I’ll wait here for five minutes, but I’m returning her to her cell if you’re not back by then.”

I quickly nod before dashing out the door towards the same desk area that I checked in at. When I arrive, there is a line of people waiting to be serviced, most of whom seem to be checking out of the jail. As the line slowly moves up, I watch the minutes tick by on my phone as the time reaches closer to 6:20. If I can’t request more time by then, I’ll miss my opportunity to talk to Summer any more today.

And things were just starting to get interesting.

Finally, the man ahead of me kindly thanks the front desk woman and steps aside. I swing myself over to the desk within an instant and request a fifteen minute extension from the stern woman I talked to earlier at check-in—virtually begging her to help me out.

The woman seems hesitant at first to grant my request. That is—until I pull out the tears, of course. I quickly make up a sob-story about Riley and Caroline’s case, claiming that one of the victims was my relative and that I need answers for their murders in order to move on. I was only half lying.

Since visiting hours end in just ten minutes, the woman is only able to give us until closing-time to finish our conversation, but I’ll take anything I can get.

One minute later, I'm pushing open the door to the visitation room just seconds before the clock hits the deadline.

Summer and the guard are still standing underneath the clock upon the wall, and I nod at him to confirm that my time extension has been granted. He hesitantly takes the handcuffs off of her before returning her to the chair she was in before the interruption. As she sits down, she mouths a silent *thank you* through the window.

As soon as he steps away from us, Summer's expression returns to the grave look she had on her face beforehand.

"Okay," she continues after picking the phone back up. "What I'm about to tell you is going to sound insanely far-fetched and borderline impossible, but I *need* you to at least consider it, okay? Can you do that?"

"Fine," I cave. "But we only have seven minutes now, so get it out quickly."

She gives a tilt of her chin and takes a breath, then relays as much information as she can in our limited time.

"My freshman year, Cabot had Family Weekend in the Spring instead of the Fall. Since Alpha Omega has more budgeting available in the Spring semester, they decided to host a Parent's Cocktail at the house for family members of sisters. Caroline's family couldn't make it, but Riley's mom and sisters came."

This story seems to be a huge leap from everything we had been talking about before the guard interrupted our conversation, and I hesitate to follow what she is saying. Nonetheless, she persists.

"They ended up leaving early the next day—Riley had some type of falling out with them—but I met them for a split second at the Cocktail."

"Okay," I say. "What does that have to do with anything?"

Summer holds up her index finger, motioning for me to wait to speak until she's finished.

"I've never been that good at remembering faces, especially when recruitment season comes around—too many people to process. If only I had just made the connection in the beginning..."

She throws her face into her hands, evidently torn up about whatever she's referring to.

I glance back to the clock.

6:25.

“Summer, we have five minutes,” I urge her through the telephone.
“You need to spit it out.”

She takes her own gaze at the clock, then suddenly snaps back into it.

“Sorry, back to what I was saying,” she says as she wipes her face with her hands. “Another year went by, and faces may still have not been my strong suit, but I knew that I recognized her from somewhere the moment I saw her. At first, I was able to chalk it up to the stress of school starting back up, or even some type of weird guilt thing about not being there for Riley. Then, all of this mess with the police came about, and I really started thinking about it...”

Summer’s ramblings are making absolutely zero sense to me.

“What are you talking about?” I ask, genuinely confused by the vague statements she keeps delivering.

My eyes drift back to the clock.

6:27.

“It would fit with the timeframe of the anonymous tip...and she could’ve easily planted the gun...”

She continues to shake her head and periodically laugh at her own words.

6:28.

“I can’t be sure, of course, but...”

6:29.

Too fed up to be patient with her any longer, I slam my hand on the dirt-covered glass—suddenly snapping Summer out of her incoherent haze.

“Damn it, Summer, *who*?”

My voice has raised to a yell, and the other visitors on my side of the room turn to stare in our direction, but this is too important for me to back down.

“*Who* are you talking about?”

With a quick turn of her head, Summer locks my eyes directly with her own—now back to her normal, concerned self.

And what she says next is the last thing I’m expecting.

“*Alison*,” she shouts. “I think Alison is Riley’s sister.”

Riley Walker

We're running.

Running.

Running.

Running through the forest.

As fast as we can.

Suddenly, my brain stops my body dead in its tracks.

"Caroline," I say with a whimper. "The keys."

Her face drops the second she processes my words, but she quickly goes into survival mode.

"That way." She points behind my back before sprinting off in the direction of the parking area—me not far behind her.

In the heat of the moment, the two of us took off into the woods as soon as the gun became visible in my sister's hands. We were so distracted by trying to save our own lives that we forgot the most important part—our escape plan.

I'm positive that my sister saw us before we hid ourselves in the tree line, so I keep an eye out for figures in the trees as we run. When we finally make it back to the spot we were sitting just before, my car keys are no longer sitting in their place, and my sister is nowhere to be seen.

We take a second to figure out our next step—completely clueless on what to do—but the snapping of a nearby branch causes our fight or flight to kick back in. Caroline yanks my wrist, causing my body to sway in the direction of a nearby path that branches off from the lot we were just in.

We keep running.

And running.

When we finally reach a clearing, we hide behind the large boulder we've stumbled upon and draw out our phones to view the map of the park. I quickly type in the website name—misspelling every other letter from how hard my hands are shaking—then click *search*.

But it won't load.

Nothing will.

"Do you have any service?" I ask, trying to remain calm.

Caroline shakes her head gravely. "I'm on *SOS Only*."

Shit. Who knew the middle of the forest would be such a dead zone for cell phone service.

"That's okay," I say. "We'll go back to the parking lot quietly, then find the car by going back the way we came from. We had service there, so we can at least make a call or send a text. Maybe we can get somebody to pick us up."

"Maybe Summer can," she suggests. "If she's not with Noah, of course."

The two of us laugh for the first time since the beginning of this nightmare, but after a moment, Caroline starts expressing her concerns.

"Riley," she says in a shaky tone. "She won't actually *shoot us*, right?"

Until tonight, I've never seen Caroline crumble in such a way. Though she's holding up pretty well given the situation we're in, her expression makes it clear that she's more afraid than she has ever been before.

"I don't know," I reply gravely. "But I think we should give her the folder."

Caroline hits my arm. "Are you crazy? That's our only leverage."

"Leverage won't matter if she *shoots us*." I pull the folder out from where it's tucked beneath my arm. "If we give her the folder, she doesn't need the gun."

"Fine," Caroline sneers. "But if you ask me—she shouldn't get to be a student at a school she couldn't even qualify for. Even if we hand over the folder, we need to make a report to the Board of Admissions."

As I'm trying to listen to Caroline, something draws my attention away. From behind my right shoulder, I hear a familiar sound ringing in my ear.

Metal scraping as it slides back.

Click.

Metal jetting back and locking into place.

The same exact sound I remember from the first grade, when my father would show us his gun collection at the local shooting range. He was a collector of sorts, with over fifty firearms in his possession. Though he had so many, he always favored one kind of a handgun.

9mm pistols.

He told us that he'd buy us each our own before we left for college. Of course, we never saw him after that year—but I'll always remember the sounds of him racking his favorite 9mm before each round at the range.

After all, it's one of the only memories I have of him.

I whip my head around the moment my brain comprehends what is going on. Before I can register what I'm seeing, a flash of skin and gleaming metal passes my eyes before making direct impact with my temple.

The pain hits me like a tidal wave, and the blood comes almost instantly.

I feel the warm liquid dripping down my left cheek and into my ear as I try to make out the words being said beside me. My injured brain can only make out a few excerpts of sentences.

“—why would you”

“We know what you...”

“Give me the—”

I narrowly avoid passing out, but after a minute the feeling returns to my body, and I'm able to begin slightly lifting myself off of the ground.

Beside where I've ended up in the dirt, I see Caroline's phone laying face down. While the two remain distracted behind me, I jam the numbers *911* into her emergency call keypad, then attempt to click the *call* button.

But there's still no service.

Suddenly, a deafening sound rings out through the forest—echoing off of the trees around us. The shot sends me into even more confusion than before, but I'm able to turn my head slightly towards the action in an attempt to see what just happened.

Caroline is now barreling over towards me. She quickly yanks me off of the ground and begins pushing me through the woods as we sprint even faster than before—the blood streaming down my face as we run. I can't quite process what is going on right now, but I hear footsteps echoing from behind us that are clearly running just as fast as we are.

The folder is still clutched tightly underneath my jacket despite whatever injury I just received a few moments ago, and I have to fight the cold wind to keep it from falling out onto the ground. As we get further and further into the wooded expanse, the echoing shots begin ringing out once again.

Though my brain is fully aware that what I'm hearing are gunshots, the sound is more similar to a whip splitting on some kind of wood.

Pop.

Pop.

We keep running.

Pop. Pop.

The bullets whizz by our ears as our legs move as fast as they can.

Pop.

We're still running.

Until, suddenly, Caroline drops to the ground beside me—her body seemingly paralyzed with pain. I drop to my knees immediately despite the approaching footsteps behind us.

"Caroline." I shake her by the shoulders. "What's wrong?"

She can only let out a slight whimper, but the moment she looks downwards at her chest, the gravity of the situation sets in for me.

Through her white, faux fur jacket that the two of us found on the discount rack at our local boutique—a crimson stain is beginning to seep through. With all of the pressure I can apply with my numb, freezing-cold hands, I push down on the jacket in an attempt to keep Caroline from losing any more blood. She groans in response—clearly in a lifetime of pain.

"You're going to be fine," I say with a cheerful tone, trying to keep her and myself as calm as possible. "We just need to get back to the car, and then we can call someone to help us."

Caroline shakes her head gravely as she tries to speak.

"Riles...you have...to go." She presses the folder underneath my jacket with her finger, implying that I should take the evidence and get out of here.

But I can't just leave her.

I can't just leave my best friend to die in the woods, all alone.

Without meaning to, I begin openly sobbing to her. "I can't."

The footsteps are coming closer and closer from behind us, and it seems like my sister is only seconds away from reaching where we are.

Caroline grabs my hand lovingly and attempts to choke out a few more words. "You...have to...call for help."

With the knowledge that this is likely my only chance to save my only friend from my deranged sister, I give Caroline a knowing nod before taking off into the woods as fast as I can—the evidence folder still in my

possession. After a few seconds, the sound of my sister's enraged voice fills the trees around me.

"Riley!"

The echoing of my name through the trees fuels me to go faster.

And faster.

And faster.

Until suddenly, all of the adrenaline leaves my body at once.

I slink down behind a large tree—nearly laying down as I try to get my breathing under control. Everything that has just happened feels like a complete fever dream, and my brain is sending itself into a panic as I attempt to process what is going on.

Is Caroline dead?

Will I make it to the car in time to call for help?

Does anyone know where we are?

Can anyone help us?

At that moment, I remember that Caroline and I both flipped off our locations on our cell phones earlier in the night—hoping that nobody in Alpha Omega would be able to track us and ask what we're doing. It seemed like a good idea at the time, but now I'm mentally scolding myself for it.

Nobody can find us out here without our locations on.

The thoughts swim around in my head as I blow deep breaths in and out of my mouth. The icy-cold November air captures every breath in a visual form, and I finally begin to feel just calm enough to continue my dash back to the car.

But just as I stand up, a dark figure steps into my view, obscuring my path through the forest.

"I found you," my sister sneers. "You always *did* suck at Hide and Seek when we were kids."

In fear for my life, I resort to the only option I have left.

"Please," I beg—now on my hands and knees in desperation. "You don't have to do this. We're *sisters*."

"As if that ever mattered to you, Riley." She looks at me with disgust. "And *you* didn't have to get yourself involved in this little situation. If you and Caroline could've minded your own business *for once*, none of this would've had to happen."

I stare at her in shock. "*Had to happen?*"

My tone is now back to anger, but I can't keep the tears from streaming down my face. I always knew my sister was a monster, but this has gone farther than anything I ever could have expected.

"*None* of this had to happen," I yell. "You couldn't accept the fact that we had the upper hand over you, and as usual, you took it to the absolute extreme—that's who you are, and who you always have been."

"Enough with the sob story, Riley," my sister huffs. "Give me the folder, *now*, or you'll meet the same fate as your best friend over there."

With a cold face, she gestures towards the area of the woods I just ran from. The place where Caroline is sitting—cold, alone, and afraid.

At the mention of Caroline, my body recoils in anger and sorrow, and I suddenly feel a blast of energy bursting through my veins. Without a second thought, I ensure the folder is still clutched against my chest, then stand up from my place and sprint to the left of my sister.

I won't let her get her hands on this folder.

Not if our lives depend on it.

My legs are on autopilot now, but they carry me exactly where I need to go. My heart pounds outside of my chest—feeling as if it could explode any moment—but I keep going.

Running.

Faster.

And faster.

Until I hear the sound.

The familiar, echoing noise of a gunshot ringing through the woods.

Pop.

Before I can stop myself, my legs crumble to the ground, and my face slams into the cold, hard, dirt.

In a last ditch effort, I attempt to shout out my sister's name—hoping that she still has a shred of humanity left in her heart—but my voice comes out in only a whisper. "Alison..."

The sounds of branches snapping and leaves crunching fill my ears as I hear her footsteps slowly coming towards me.

And then everything goes black.

Alison Hartnell.
My roommate.
My best friend.

My sorority sister.

Summer must be mistaken. From the very moment I stepped onto Cabot University's campus, I have relentlessly investigated Riley and Caroline's disappearance—leaving no stone unturned. It's impossible to think that the answer could have been right under my nose this whole time.

I check the time on my car's display.

7:40.

Right now, I'm supposed to be driving back to Norman Hall to get ready for the Turkey Bash. Nathan is supposed to pick Alison and I up at 8:45 to head to the Theta Mu house, but factoring in the forty-five minute drive home, I'd need to leave right now in order to make it in time.

Still, I can't seem to start up my car and make the drive home. I have far too much on my mind.

When it comes down to it, I trust Alison much more than I do Summer. She's been there for me through it all this semester—the highs, the lows, and the absolute disasters. Summer, however, has proven time and time again to be untrustworthy and unreliable. If there were a competition to earn my trust between the two, Alison would definitely have a head start.

That being said, there are a few things that don't add up—as well as a few similarities that are hard to ignore.

When Summer made the suggestion that Alison might be Riley Walker's younger sister, one thing specifically came to mind. The day I

moved into Norman Hall and coincidentally received the same room that Riley and Caroline had been in, I was also notified that my roommate assignment had been changed. A few months after move-in, I encountered my original assigned roommate—Marley—at an on-campus coffee shop, who was incredibly hostile and acted fearful of me.

At that moment, I knew something was off about the situation, but I couldn't put my finger on what it was.

Could Alison have threatened my old roommate in order to take her place in room 433?

And then, there are the similarities. Riley and Alison share the same height, weight, and eye shape. They're both vegetarians, and Riley was an in-state student from a town across Alabama—just like Alison. The list goes on.

The day I first met her, Alison mentioned that she had an older sister who had been a member of a sorority.

Could she have been talking about Riley?

The information is almost too much to process. If Alison is truly Riley Walker's younger sister, then there would be no reason for her to lie about her identity unless she was the person that murdered the girls. If that's the case, I've been living with a murderer for the entire first semester, and I've had no idea.

I continue to sit in the car, staring out into the dark abyss that my car is facing. The lights from the jail barely light up the trees across the field, so this is the perfect blank slate for me to look at as I try to decide my next move.

My brain combs through every interaction I've had with Alison since the moment I met her—hoping to discover any proof that she is or is not related to Riley. From the day she asked if I'd attend the fair with her, to this afternoon, when I conversed with her just before leaving. Eventually, my mind jumps to a few more non-ignorable things.

Alison could have easily been the one that went into my room the night I found my things misplaced. I had assumed it was Ashley or Kimberly at the time, but now I can't be sure.

Alison was in my block of people the night the Brookwood Police brought the Alpha Omega girls in for questioning—coincidentally the block of time that the anonymous tip against Summer was made.

Alison would have had every opportunity to plant the 9mm gun in Summer's drawer, especially the night the search warrant was conducted. We were all in chapter together, and there were a few moments when I wasn't sure of her whereabouts.

Lastly, Alison has been the number-one supporter of my theories against Summer from the beginning. Though she didn't know her as well as I did, she never hesitated to press the idea that Summer had likely killed her friends.

When all of the evidence is piled together, it seems almost undeniable that Summer was right—Alison Hartnell is actually Alison Walker.

Still, I need proof before I can make any decisions.

Real proof—not just speculation.

Until proven otherwise, Alison is my best friend, and I think she deserves the benefit of the doubt.

At that moment, an idea pops into my head, and I turn the keys in the ignition before I can change my mind. Flooding the gas, I fly out of the gravel parking lot and turn left onto the road heading towards Cabot.

I know exactly what to do.

By the time I park in my regular spot outside Norman Hall, it's nearly nine o'clock.

Looks like I'm going to be late to the Turkey Bash.

My phone starts flooding with text messages the moment I near the building, and I realize that I must have lost service at some point on my drive home. I've missed several calls from Nathan and Alison, who are probably wondering where I am and why I'm not ready for the party yet.

Instead of attempting to make contact with either of them, I push my way inside of the building and ride the elevator to the fourth floor—partially expecting to find the two of them waiting for me inside of our room. However, when I turn my key in the lock and open the door, it appears the room is completely empty.

After ensuring that nobody is home, I rush inside of Alison's room and begin rustling through her drawers in hopes of finding something, *anything* that might lead me to a conclusion.

Old photos.

Old school IDs.

Anything.

Her desk and dresser drawers bear nothing of any interest, so I move on to checking out the area below her mattress. Nothing seems to be taped to the bed frame or stuffed inside of the mattress foam, so I quickly move on from that section of the room as well.

Eventually, my eyes are drawn to the large, leafy plants that sit directly below her window sill. I've never taken a close look at the plants—I've never really had a reason to—but the closer I get to them, the more fake they appear to me. I always just assumed they were real from the beginning.

At this realization, a new idea comes to mind.

I step forward to examine the two plants from up close. Flipping over one of the leaves on the tallest plant, I suddenly notice a *MADE IN TAIWAN*

tag that is connected to the stem.

This plant is plastic.

Now directing my eyes downward, I grab the plant by the bottom of the stem, then pull upward and outwards. Once I set the fake dirt-covered plant aside, I'm able to see a large, taped-shut plastic container that was sitting below the plant beforehand—which I instantly grab with my hands and place in front of where I'm sitting.

After carefully removing the tape, I remove the lid from the container and take a glance at the remnants inside of it. Though there isn't much inside the box, I'm able to identify a Driver's License, a red folder, and a handwritten list that's been scrawled in red ink.

Deciding to examine the license first, I pull out my phone's flashlight in an attempt to get a better look. This is the moment of truth.

Just as I do so, though, the sound of a door slamming behind me suddenly causes me to jump out of my skin. I turn around—already knowing exactly what I'm going to see, but still dreading the moment.

Alison is now inside of the room—clearly dressed for the Thanksgiving party and holding her keys in hand.

“What are you doing?” she asks, looking at me with confusion as I ransack her room.

As we lock eyes, the reasoning for my actions suddenly clicks for her, and she lunges forward to yank the box from my hands.

I struggle against the pull of her arms as she attempts to pry my fingers off of the edges of the container—causing the box to go flying across the room the moment we both release.

We stare at each other for a split second before both diving in the location that it fell, each of us clawing at each other's faces to get the upper hand. I've never been in a physical fight before, but all of the self-defense tips my mom has spent years drilling into my brain are finally paying off for me.

“Alison,” I spit out through the struggle. “Let's talk about this.”

Despite what I've said, she continues to fight for possession of the box—now acting completely differently than I've seen her act before.

Since I'm positive she won't answer my questions unless I have some sort of leverage, I ramp up my fight for the box and quickly yank it from her hands—running to the living room once I'm sure it's within my grasp. I back myself against the wall, not taking my eyes off of her for a second.

“*Alison*,” I yell in confusion. “What is going on?”

With an angry look, Alison walks over to her closet and reaches up to the top shelf—pulling a black item down in her right hand. She racks the object in her hand, now stepping towards where I’m standing outside of her room.

“I think you know, Leighton.”

Now only a few feet from my face, I’m able to see the unfamiliar eyes that have now taken over my best friend’s body. Every micro expression across her face alludes rage, anger, and desperation at my taking of the container and its possessions, and she’s now pointing a 9mm handgun directly at my chest.

“What are you going to do?” I ask angrily. “Shoot me? Just like you shot Riley and Caroline?”

Alison sneers, remaining wordless at my statement for just a second. “I’m glad you finally figured it out, honestly. I wasn’t sure how much longer I’d be able to keep up the charade.”

“So it’s true, then?” I shout. “What Summer said.”

I stare at her in disbelief.

“Summer...” she says.

She laughs, waving the gun in the air expressively.

“If she told you that I’m Riley’s sister, then yes—that’s true. I can’t believe it took her that long to make the connection. Then again, she never was very smart, so I’m not that surprised. That’s exactly how I knew that she’d be the perfect person to take the fall for me.”

Even hearing it directly from Alison’s mouth, I still can’t comprehend that what’s being said is the truth.

Alison is Riley Walker’s sister.

And everything I thought I knew was completely wrong.

Alison has clearly lost her mind—although given recent discoveries, I’m not sure if she was sane to begin with—but I attempt to reason with her anyways. After all, she has a gun trained directly on me.

It’s just like my mother told me: *Always reason with an attacker who has a weapon, especially if you don’t have a weapon at your disposal.*

“Listen,” I say cautiously. “If I give you the box, can we talk about this?”

“Talk? About what?” Alison rolls her eyes. “Just because you wanted to play detective doesn’t mean that you deserve to know everything.”

I'm pleading to her for answers—hoping it will distract her from her itchy trigger finger for as long as possible.

"I just want to know why you did this. *All* of this."

Alison considers my request for a moment—seemingly searching her brain for an answer that might justify her behaviors. After a while, she nods her head and speaks again.

"Killing Riley was easy—I had wanted to shoot her since the second grade—but that bitch Caroline was trying to ruin my life," she huffs. "Even though I'd only spent a day with her before everything went down, I could always tell that she had a knack for sticking her nose in places where it didn't belong."

Alison sneers.

"She had it coming someday, really, I just moved the process along."

My body shakes with disgust at the lack of empathy she speaks about the girls with. Still, I hold my head up and continue my line of questioning.

"What did they catch you with?" I ask. "What could've been so bad that you had to kill them?"

I'm playing dumb, but I want to see what she'll tell me if she thinks I'm in the dark about everything.

"More like *who* did they catch me with," Alison responds. "Professor Darcy—the one you saw me talking with outside of Starship that one time...it was earlier on in the semester."

My mind suddenly flashes back to the day I was standing outside of the dining hall in the Student Union, when I was watching Alison converse with a man who I had assumed to be college-aged from a distance. When she told me that the man was her professor, I vividly remember making a comment about not being above sleeping with college professors, and that I thought he was cute.

Little did I know.

"So you were sleeping with a teacher, they found out about it, and extorted you for it." I summarize. "That's it? That's why you killed them?"

She rubs the gun against her head in thought.

"My relationship with Professor Darcy was more of a business arrangement than anything—I was only sleeping with him to ensure my acceptance into Cabot," Alison explains. "But when Caroline caught us at Roxy's, the two of them cooked up some sort of plot to tell the Board of

Admissions about us. They were going to keep me from attending my dream school, and I wasn't about to let them."

Making note that my questions are distracting Alison from any potential violent actions, I continue.

"And the tip about Summer to the police? That was you too?"

"Obviously," she smiles proudly. "The gun too—it was foolproof."

Quickly running out of things to ask, I throw out a question that has been burning on my mind for the past few weeks.

"And," I begin. "You were the one who tried to run me off of the road a few weeks ago? Outside Norman?"

For the first time in our conversation tonight, Alison seems confused by my comment. Though it seems for a moment as if she might ask me to elaborate, the confusion quickly arouses her from the distraction I've been putting up, and she angrily raises the gun once again—this time pointed directly between my eyes.

"Nice try, roomie," she laughs. "But I'm not answering any more of your little questions."

Alison lifts the gun once again, now focusing the barrel directly onto my chest. Her eyes darken as she moves her finger closer to the trigger.

"Now, it's time to hand me that box."

My mind is racing.

I've been around guns my entire life—I'm from rural Tennessee, after all—but I've never had one pointed directly at me.

I don't know what to do, but I'm sure as hell not handing over this box.

Everything I remember from my mother's teachings have vanished from my mind within an instant, and I'm left to come up with a way to save my own life in the spur of the moment.

Alison clicks the gun into place, presumably loading a bullet into the chamber. She soon lets out a long sigh before speaking again.

"It's now or never, Leighton."

Suddenly, her words make something click for me, and the gears begin to turn inside my brain.

Alison is right.

It's now or never.

Before I can re-think my decision, I lunge toward Alison and divert the gun to the right with my hands. With a glimpse of shock in her eyes, she pulls the trigger within a second of me springing forward, and a blast soon

rings out of the barrel that shakes the entire unit. In that moment, I begin to feel a searing pain in my right arm, and the warm feeling of blood begins to course its way down toward my hand.

I look to find the cause of the pain—soon finding that a bullet has streaked my bicep and taken off a decent amount of skin and muscle in that area of my arm. Though the damage is evident, I thankfully only feel a surface amount of pain at the moment.

That must be from the shock.

As soon as I register the worsening injury, I hear the sound of the gun loudly clattering to the floor and sliding across the wood. Alison and I lock eyes in an instant, but she is the first to lunge to the ground towards the couch to grab the gun.

As she desperately reaches underneath the low-rise couch, my eyes are drawn to the door, and I take the opportunity to grab the box of Alison's things and run out the door as quickly as I possibly can.

My arm is dripping with blood as I move down the hall, but I keep going. I soon hear the door slam behind me, and I know that Alison is only a few seconds behind me—gun in hand once again.

From behind the doors that I'm rapidly passing, I hear mumbling and commotion from excited partygoers, but somehow see nobody in the hallways.

Nobody can help.

"Help me!"

I'm screaming to the residents of Norman Hall now—hoping someone will hear my desperate cries for assistance.

"Someone call the police!"

My eyes are drawn to yet another door—this time the one for the secluded Norman Hall exit that leads to the back parking lot, which is mainly used by maintenance workers and building employees. Alison wouldn't expect for me to go through this exit, and if I take it, it might throw her off my trail.

Without thinking, I yank down the handle and pull the door out, then rush down the empty staircase as fast as I possibly can.

A few steps down, I decide to stop and look around to see if I can hear Alison approaching. Just as I look to where I was just walking, though, I notice something that sends a chill down my spine.

A long line of crimson, shiny liquid is trailing up the staircase in the exact places where I was just running, and it goes as far as I can see.

I'm leaving behind a blood trail.

Alison is going to be able to find me.

Just as the realization clicks, I hear the fourth-floor entry to the staircase re-opening—with loud, slamming footsteps coming along with it.

Shit.

She found me.

Before I can allow myself to come within Alison's view, I race down the remainder of the stairs and swing open the door to the back parking area—rushing outside and onto the campus grounds. The cold hits my skin like a brick upon exiting, but my feet are swiftly carrying me through the small forested area that comes out to the Student Union. I take the back way instead of the main way to prevent my blood trail from being traceable upon the concrete of the sidewalks.

If I can just make it there, I'll be okay.

I secure the box underneath my arm even tighter than before, then push past the final few trees to reach the sidewalk outside of the Union. I nearly cry of happiness at the sight of the building, but I'm far too out of breath from running.

Just as I take my first step onto the concrete, though—I feel a hard object slamming into my head in just an instant, and a wave of confusion suddenly takes over my entire being.

Without being able to control it, my body slams into the ground, and the objects inside of the box spill out onto the surrounding area. Just as my face meets the pavement, I swing around to face Alison, who is once again pointing a gun directly at me. We're still far enough from the main entrance of the Union to be completely away from any other students, so I know my cries for help will be pointless, but I try anyway.

After all, reasoning with Alison doesn't seem to be very possible.

"Help me," I attempt to yell. "Please."

My voice is quiet and hoarse from the running I've just done, but I keep trying. Alison stares at me as I weakly cry out, but simply smiles eerily.

"Thanks for the box," she sneers. "See how easy that would've been?"

She places her finger over the trigger.

"Please..."

Tears begin to fall down my face as the reality of the situation sets in.

“Please don’t...”

Alison scoffs, but keeps her smile pasted on.

“Sorry, Leighton,” she says. “It was great being roommates with you. It sucks that things had to work out this way...”

For the final time, she sets the gun forward and locks a bullet into place with a click. As I close my eyes to accept my fate, I hear Alison step closer to me, and I soon feel the cold, hard barrel of the gun make contact with my forehead.

In a split-second decision, I decide to open my eyes. In my final moments, I want my attacker to have to watch the life drain from my face. That’s the punishment that truly never leaves someone.

Alison smiles softly as she locks eyes with me as I take a deep breath.

Just as I’ve completely come to terms with what’s happening, though, something unexpected happens.

Out of the corner of my eye—as if in slow motion—a dark figure comes shooting out from the wooded area I just ran through, then races over to tackle Alison with a loud shriek. Everything happens far too quickly for me to get a good look at who my savior might be, but I’m able to see flashes of their face as they wrestle Alison to the ground a few feet away from me.

It takes a moment for my brain to start working again, but I soon begin to slowly back away from the scene that’s unfolding in front of me. Through the struggle, the person fighting off Alison yells out to me aggressively.

“Call the police!”

I reach down to my pockets to find my phone, but quickly remember that I left it somewhere inside of Alison’s room. After all, I was fleeing from my gun-wielding roommate, so it wasn’t really the first thing on my mind.

After a few seconds of searching to confirm I don’t have my own, I suddenly see a familiar phone laying face down on the ground beside the remnants of the spilled box. I recognize the phone as Alison’s, so I jump over to grab it as the fight continues on in the background.

As fast as I can, I jam the numbers 9 1 1 into the emergency call keypad, then connect with an operator. Once I’ve disclosed the address and requested help, the female operator assures me that a few units are on the way, so I hang up the phone and rush over to help my mysterious savior keep Alison incapacitated until the police arrive.

The struggle is mostly over when I near them, and the mystery person now has Alison held face-down in the grassy area beside the woods. Alison is putting up a good fight, but the other person has kicked away her gun, so she's as defenseless as ever now.

I slowly approach—stepping as carefully toward them as possible. As I cross the grass, I kick the gun even further away to prevent any possible chance of Alison getting her hands on it again. I've seen every horror movie to exist, and I know that the killer always tries to get the last word. Not on my watch.

From over my shoulder, my savior speaks in a much calmer tone.

"Thanks," she says. "Trust me—she's already done enough damage with that thing. I don't want any more."

The voice isn't familiar. I turn to face the person, who has now dropped their hood during the struggle with Alison. Slowly, she turns to look at me, and a cast of light from the street lamp illuminates her solemn face and dark hair.

When I finally get a solid look at the face of the person who has saved my life today, I almost can't believe my eyes.

I've seen some incredibly shocking things in the past few weeks, and I truly thought I had seen it all by this point.

But I was wrong. Because right now, I'm seeing a ghost.

My mysterious savior is Riley Walker.

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Riley Walker

NOW

On that fateful night, when I woke up face-down in the dirt and covered in my own blood, I thought I had been sentenced to my own personal Hell.

My best friend was dead.

All the proof I was previously holding was now gone.

My own sister tried to kill me.

I had nobody left.

The grief was unimaginable in the moment, but my injuries kept me from focusing too much on the truth of things. All I could think about was getting help. For myself, yes, but mainly for Caroline. At the time, I truly thought it was possible that she might have survived the gunshot wound, but I'm now able to look back and see that I was experiencing extreme denial in the moment.

It took quite some time, but I eventually peeled myself off of the ground and began walking towards the last spot I remembered seeing her—painfully clutching the hole in my rib cage with each step. I knew it was somewhere closer to the parking area of White Rose Point, so I trudged in that general direction for as long as it took to find her.

That's when it happened.

In the moonlight, I suddenly stumbled across a heap of white laying across the floor of the forest—the color of maroon gleaming from the fur coat. I ran to check on her, but by the time I reached where she was, it was clear that I was far too late.

There was nothing that could be done.

I had never seen a dead body before. Only in movies, TV shows, or plays—but never in real life. It was traumatizing enough, but the realization that I had dragged Caroline onto the trip that led to her death was absolutely earth-shattering to me.

I spent almost an hour with Caroline, sobbing over her body and praying for everything to be a dream. It didn't feel right to leave her behind in pursuit of my own rescue, but I eventually realized that I was going to meet a similar fate if I didn't find my way out of the freezing-cold wilderness soon—especially considering the gaping wound in my torso.

With all the strength I could muster, I left Caroline behind in the leaves, then trudged my way through the remainder of the forest until I reached the main road. It was still late at night—probably two or three in the morning—so nobody was on the road at the time. There was pretty much no hope of rescue from a random passerby.

I didn't have my keys, and I wasn't able to find the spot where my car was parked as I crept along the road, so I kept walking.

And walking.

Until soon enough, in the distance, I was able to spot the familiar blue coloring of a run-down phone booth.

The sight nearly brought me to tears of joy, and I had to keep myself from sprinting to it, but I eventually stumbled up to the phone with barely any energy left. I nearly had a panic attack when I realized I didn't have any change for the machine, but luckily enough, there was a tin can full of quarters laying atop the phone, and I was able to use a few of them to make a call.

At first, I went to dial *911*.

Everything that transpired that night was undoubtedly a crime, and myself and Caroline were both in need of immediate medical attention for our injuries—though I knew Caroline was unsavable by that point. It seemed that calling the police was the only solution to the matter at hand.

Until a thought came to my mind.

When my sister shot me, and I completely blacked out, I had zero idea how long I was unconscious for. My sister could have done anything she wanted in that period of time—including placing my fingerprints upon the weapon that was used to murder Caroline. Knowing how sick and dangerous her mind is, I wouldn't have been at all surprised if she were to try and frame me for everything that happened in an attempt to get off scot-free from the situation.

By that point, Alison had been given far too much time to orchestrate some type of plan to throw me under the bus. The police weren't a safe bet, and I knew I would be better off if I called someone else for help.

But who?

I didn't know that many phone numbers off the top of my head. Most people only exchange text messages with people in their Contacts list, so I didn't have the numbers for my closest friends memorized. Only Caroline's.

However, I eventually remembered one phone number that I had exchanged a few messages with earlier in the semester. I never saved the contact information to my list in fear of Caroline seeing it, so each time I would send a text to this person, the phone number became further engraved into my mind.

Without a second thought, I dialed the number into the phone and waited for the ringing to begin. After a few rings, the person finally answered my call, and I told them the name of the rest area I was waiting at in hopes of being picked up and taken to a hospital. After confirming they'd be there, I sat around clutching my wound and willing myself to stay conscious for a bit longer.

A little less than an hour later, a black car with shining headlights pulled into the parking lot of the rest area, and I emerged from my hiding space as soon as the agreed-upon signal was given: three flashes of their brake lights. After walking the short distance to the car, I finally climbed into the arms of my savior.

Gracie Franklin.

She was shocked, to say the least, by the story I relayed to her. As someone who was previously unaware of my family dynamic, or of the nature of Caroline and I's friendship, I'm sure it was a tough situation for her, but she quietly comforted me through everything as I explained my theory about my sister's plans to frame me.

Just as I figured—she agreed with me.

My sister was absolutely planning to make me take the fall for Caroline's murder, and it was far too late to do anything about it.

The trip to the hospital was difficult to swing, but Gracie and I devised a plan on our way over:

Once inside, I would request help under an anonymous name and wait to be treated. A gunshot wound is serious, so we knew there would be questions, but our agreed-upon strategy was for me to deny the cause of the injury as much as possible. I needed to get in and out quickly—before Alison could realize I was alive and begin searching hospitals for me—so

we decided I should stay to receive the main medical treatment before fleeing from my room between nurse checks.

A few obstacles hindered my path, but we were able to make it out of the hospital before the sun came up. Afterwards, Gracie snuck me inside of her room at the Alpha Omega house and gave me stuff to eat and drink—along with a warm change of clothes.ýp

That’s where we came up with my plan.

Alison was going to frame me, and I was no longer safe where I was. There was no good possible outcome in sight, so I knew extreme measures needed to be taken in order to protect myself.

And from that point on, the idea we devised was set into place.

Gracie was already a professional at making fake ID’s, so it was easy for her to print a Driver’s License with a new name, age, and identity for myself. She made me a few different copies with several variations of names—in case Alison were to track me down eventually—then sent me with a collection of cash she had acquired from her drug-dealing business.

I initially refused her money, but she insisted that I kept it. I think that, deep down, she feels grateful for my saving her from Caroline’s blackmail scheme.

The next part of my plan might come as even more of a surprise, but believe me when I say that it was effective.

Through a series of buses, trains, and ride shares, I fled the state of Alabama and hooked rides all the way to the Upper East Coast. It took an entire twenty-four hours of traveling, but every mile further away from my sister that I would be, the happier I was going to be.

The entire way over, I stayed in contact with the old friend I was planning to meet in coastal Massachusetts in order to arrange our meeting. When my bus finally pulled into the Plymouth Train Station that night, I barely recognized the face of the person who was there to pick me up. I hadn’t seen them in over a year, and we hadn’t ended on the best of terms, but they were somehow sympathetic enough to my situation to offer their help.

To make a long story short, she offered me a job at the coastal bar owned by her family—Belton’s Bar. Even after everything Caroline did to her, Maya was big enough to allow me a new chance at life, where I could completely start over and try to move on from the events of the past few weeks.

It wasn't easy, but after a while, I started coming to terms with my new life.

I made new friends.

I started acquiring regulars at work.

Maya and I rekindled our friendship.

And other than Maya, I never told any of my new acquaintances the truth about my identity.

Thankfully, Caroline and I's case never gained much attention in small-town Plymouth, so my true nature remained a secret to those around me. Since the two of us were simply considered Missing Persons at the time, the majority of the public didn't think twice about our case, so it wasn't made public enough to reach those outside of Alabama.

As the months passed, I would periodically research the case to see if any progress had been made. As more and more time went by, I became increasingly surprised by the fact that Caroline's body hadn't been discovered by this point. After all—we had met Alison in a public park that night. Someone would've had to have found something eventually.

Without the discovery of a body, it was clear that the police weren't working hard to resolve the case. In their minds, we were runaways, and our disappearance wasn't worth the use of resources and manpower. This was what angered me the most about the situation, and the anger worsened with each news article I read.

When August rolled around, I had fallen into a bit of a depression. I couldn't stop thinking about the life I had just one short year ago—and how I would usually be moving into a new dorm room this time of year. Instead, I was hundreds of miles from home—hiding from my past and my own family.

That's when something interesting happened.

One night after work, I noticed that I had missed a call from Gracie earlier in the evening. Though we speak on the phone often, it was unusual for her to call me without letting me know in advance, so I made an effort to call her back immediately.

When she picked up the phone, she relayed an interesting piece of information about an experience she had earlier in the day at the annual White Rose recruitment ceremony. She had only spoken with one girl during the entire ceremony, but from across the room, she had noticed a

potential new member who bore a striking resemblance to my sister—Alison.

I'd shown Gracie the photos of my sister a million times—hoping that she might run into her on campus and be able to lead me to her. The moment she told me she had potentially seen her, I knew it was serious, but when Gracie forwarded a photo that Alison had sent to be featured on her fake ID, I knew it was time to take action.

A few weeks later, I was approved for a month-long leave from my job, and I soon was flying into a town outside of eastern Brookwood. Gracie picked me up from the airport, and the two of us set up a livable space in a local hotel that I had sectioned aside money for.

Afterwards, we got to work.

For nearly two months, Gracie and I followed around Alison and her new roommate—another freshman named Leighton. Since they both joined Alpha Omega, it was easy for Gracie to keep an eye on the two of them at social events and pledge meetings, but we sometimes had to resort to desperate measures when it came to monitoring them outside of the sorority house.

Not long after we started following the girls around, I began to make note of Leighton's interest in Caroline and I's disappearance. The visits to Marciello's, the friendship with Summer, and the relationship with Nathan made her interest in our lives evident from the beginning, and it became undeniable after a while. Because of this, I developed a soft spot for her early on. The two of us share so many similarities—we even had the same major and joined the same sorority—and I could truly see myself inside of her.

I felt that, if I allowed Alison to victimize her in the way she did Caroline, it would be a complete betrayal to everything the two of us went through.

I couldn't let that happen.

So, from that point forward, I set up a plan to catch Alison in the act—this time leaving behind no casualties. If the police, the school, and the sorority were finally able to see her true nature, I thought I might have a fighting chance at getting my life back again.

Now—almost exactly a year after everything started—my biggest wish has finally come true.

Alison Walker is going to prison.

Probably for the rest of her life.

And I finally feel a sense of hope again.

Leighton—who I have become quite close with in the last few days—barely believes the story when I tell it to her. She has nearly a million questions, but I don't mind answering all of them. It's natural to be confused about such an unbelievable situation.

"So," she says, her jaw wide open. "You stayed off the grid for almost an entire year? How did you survive without a bank account?"

"I got by on cash," I reply. "Almost every business takes it as a form of payment, so it wasn't as hard as you might think."

She nods understandingly, then suddenly lights up with another question.

"What about doctor's visits? How'd you get seen without a valid ID?"

"Maya has a Doctor in her family, so he did my physical at home for free," I say. "No questions asked."

Leighton's line of questioning continues for a while, but our conversation eventually boils down to Alison once again.

"I just can't believe she's a *murderer*," Leighton says. "She was my best friend, and I genuinely trusted her with everything in me."

I nod.

"She can be very convincing." I grab her hand. "But believe me—she is an incredibly dangerous, manipulative person. She's better off getting the help she needs in prison. Trust me."

Leighton shakes her head sympathetically, and it's clear that everything about this situation still bothers her. I can't blame her, really—even a year later, it's still hard for me to accept the truth.

"Can I ask you something?" I cut back in. "Throughout your investigation, did you ever once suspect Alison?"

When we first met, Leighton told me of her semester-long investigation—in which she spent months tracking down leads and information related to our case. She was having a hard time accepting the irony of the fact that the person she was looking for was one door away the entire time.

"Not really," she answers. "But in hindsight, there were a few things that should have stood out to me. If only I had realized earlier..."

"Like?" I ask.

Leighton glances off in thought right as the waitress at the cafe comes to refill our drinks. After a few seconds, she's gone again, and we continue

with what we were saying.

“Well, for one thing, I only ever found *The Hot Sheet*’s because I noticed some things in my room were out of place,” she explains. “At the time, I assumed that Ashley or Kimberly had been the ones looking for something, but now I’m realizing that it was Alison.”

“I see,” I nod. “But you can’t blame yourself. You couldn’t have known.”

She shakes her head again.

“Even if we go back to the beginning, though...there were so many things I missed. She mentioned that her sister had been in a sorority, she was a vegetarian, and she even looks just like you. I should’ve been able to tell.”

I laugh.

“Trust me—the blonde hair fooled me too, and I lived with her for sixteen years,” I say. “And there are millions of vegetarians and sorority girls in the world. Unless you were a psychic, nobody could’ve expected you to make the connection.”

Despite my reassurance, it’s clear that Leighton still feels some sense of guilt about this whole thing. After letting her reflect for a few moments, I reach forward and speak to her again.

“Leighton. If you had figured out the truth about Alison, she probably would’ve killed you—trust me, I know. Instead, she’s finally paying for what she did to Caroline, and she can’t hurt anyone anymore. Without your efforts, who knows what would’ve happened.”

I pause.

“And most importantly—without you, I wouldn’t have gotten a chance to take my life back again,” I say. “For that, I could never thank you enough.”

Finally, it seems like my words have gotten through to her.

“Thank you, Riley,” Leighton says through teary eyes. “If one good thing has come from all of this, it’s you.”

Suddenly, a familiar voice cuts in from behind us.

“Try two good things,” the person says. “My temporary stay at the county jail has really made me learn to appreciate the good things in life.”

Leighton and I turn around—smiling at the arrival of Summer, Kimberly, and Ashley. Over the past few days, the five of us decided to let bygones be bygones and rekindle our friendships. After all, we may have

had our ups and downs, but we also went through something terrible together. That type of bond can never be severed.

These people are my family now.

With a heart that feels full for the first time in a long time, I sit down with my four best friends, and we all enjoy our lunch together. And for the first time in forever, everything seems like it's going to be okay.

LEIGHTON

ONE MONTH LATER

Life has seemingly returned to normal—just with a few exceptions.

For starters, I have officially received my acceptance into the Bradshaw School of Criminal Justice. Just as I assumed, the board of admissions was extremely impressed with my thoroughly-conducted investigation, and they were even more pleased with the fact that I took some of the negative attention off of the school.

I was recovering from my gunshot wound inside of a hospital room when I learned the news. Given our pre-established relationship, the program gave Professor Boswell the honor of delivering my acceptance in person, so he came to my patient room to tell me.

I nearly ripped my stitches from excitement when I found out.

Now, I will officially be enrolled in my dream courses come spring-time, and I couldn't possibly be more excited.

Outside of school, my relationships have been thriving since everything came to light. My friendship with Summer, my relationship with Nathan—you name it. As it turns out, being around a deranged murderer 24/7 can actually take quite a toll on your personal relationships, so as soon as Alison was removed from the equation, things were better than ever before.

Speaking of Summer—she was officially released from prison just a few short days after Alison was arrested. She was angry that it took so long to be released, but in the end, I'm sure she was just relieved to finally have her name cleared for the murder of her closest friends. Plus, she got one of her best friends back during this whole situation—one of whom she had thought to be dead.

Riley has been another guiding light through the dark days that came after the arrest was made. Though her re-appearance into the world came as quite a shock to me, so did pretty much everything else I had learned at the

time, so I didn't have much time to process the confusion of the situation. Instead, I allowed her to help me to understand the truth about Alison, and I finally learned of her true nature as a person.

Even a month later, though, it's hard for me to accept that the person I thought to be my closest friend was truly a psychopath, a liar, and a murderer.

Not once in our three months of living together did I suspect anything of the sort—even though I was quite literally investigating the murder of her own victims. The realization that she was truly guilty of the crimes made me question my own investigative ability, and I nearly went through a career crisis because of this.

She seemed so normal.

So forgiving.

So kind.

How could she be the monster that everyone is claiming she is?

Maybe one day, I'll fully understand everything. I'm still young, and I still have a lot to learn in life. Until then, I'll simply be left guessing how all of this could have happened.

Maybe one day, I'll even listen to Alison's side of things. The person I know to be my best friend is still inside of her somewhere—hiding behind the exterior of a violent narcissist. If enough time passes, and she gets the help she needs, maybe she can truly be capable of being a good person again.

It would be wrong for me to completely move on from her. Though I know her true nature, I still feel a deep connection to Alison.

After all, she's my sorority sister.

And sisters are forever, right?

EPILOGUE

ALISON WALKER

It was easy enough to fool everyone.

I dropped the “Walker” from my last name, and simply went by my mother’s maiden name instead—Hartnell.

I had recently dyed my hair blonde—I’d heard they have more fun—so a physical change wasn’t going to be necessary.

I even changed my vocabulary, my facial expressions, and my style.

I was committed to the act.

Surprisingly, the hardest part of my plan was getting myself assigned to Room 433 of Norman Hall.

It was crucial to my plan that I would be living in the same room that Caroline and Riley last resided in. Knowing the two of them, I was nearly positive that they would have evidence linking me to their murders hidden throughout the room. Though I wasn’t even sure if the police would ever even find their bodies, I wanted to get on top of eliminating evidence as early as possible.

Marley Harris was a tough nut to crack. I first reached out through my personal account—asking if she’d be willing to switch rooms nicely. When that didn’t work, and she simply ignored my message, I decided it was time to resort to extreme measures.

To make a long story short—Marley had a change of heart when I anonymously emailed her a folder that contained her internet search history, a private album of her photos, and a few controversial text messages she had sent and received in the past few weeks. It seemed that she wasn’t big on the idea of these documents being made public, so she submitted for a room change within the hour.

Afterwards, all I had to do was find my way into the online housing system and paste my name into the place where her name once was.

It couldn’t have been easier.

Joining Alpha Omega was simple as well. I already knew that I was pretty enough to make the cut, but I had also spent weeks researching the best things to say and do as a potential new member in sorority recruitment. By the time I was going through the rush process, I knew exactly how to play up the sisters in order to guarantee my acceptance.

Everything worked out perfectly.

I had infiltrated my sister's past life, and everything was working out the way I had planned for it to before Riley and Caroline tried to ruin it all for me.

Things were finally looking up.

Yet, there was something I hadn't accounted for.

The moment Leighton told me that she was pursuing a criminal justice degree, alarm bells rang off in my head. Every Bradshaw program student I know is obsessed with true-crime, and it would've been foolish for me to assume that she didn't know anything about the case. Riley and Caroline were big news locally, and the lack of answers in their disappearance drew a bunch of law enforcement-wannabes to Brookwood to try their hand.

I knew exactly what she was doing.

As time went by, I tried to sway her opinions about the case more and more. Each time she would bring up their disappearance, I would throw in the fact that the girls were both hated by the majority of Cabot's campus, or even name specific possible suspects. When that didn't work, I knew I needed to shift the blame onto someone more believable.

Summer Harding.

Everyone was aware of the issues between Summer, Riley, and Caroline in the months leading up to their disappearance, so I knew she would be the perfect candidate to take the fall for their murders. Plus, she certainly wasn't helping to clear her own name considering she was still sleeping with Noah Banks, so I knew that Leighton would believe me when I said she wasn't trustworthy.

The night at Roxy's—when we ran into Summer and Noah—was just pure luck. As soon as I saw the two of them, I made sure that Leighton would notice their togetherness, then ensured that the alcohol would help to fuel her anger. From that point forward, she believed every word I told her about Summer.

For a while, it worked. Leighton solely focused her investigative strategies on proving Summer's guilt, and she was doing a pretty good job

considering her subject of investigation was innocent. What I didn't expect, though, was for her to find the body.

When word broke of the discovery, I had to improvise.

I was honestly unsure of whatever evidence I might've left behind at the scene, and I knew that some questions would come to light centering around Riley's car being moved to the train station. I had originally done so in order to make investigators think that their disappearance was simply a runaway case, but now that there was evidence of murder, that was no longer believable. At first, I planned to make the police believe that Riley had committed Caroline's murder and ran off, but I knew it was only a matter of time until they found her body as well.

So, when our turn for questioning came around, I framed Summer up for the crimes to the best of my ability. Luckily, it didn't take much convincing for the police to make an arrest—a public one at that.

At that point, my plan had completely fallen into place, and things were looking up more than ever.

Until the final, fatal flaw in my plan came to light.

Riley was alive.

I never checked her pulse before leaving her behind that night in the forest, and that simple, careless mistake cost me everything.

Still—even from behind bars, nobody can stop me from getting exactly what I want in my life. I may be facing life in prison, but believe me when I say that there is no jury of twelve people who will convict me for the crimes I'm being accused of. Manipulation has always been my strong suit, and I'll have no problem convincing them that I'm being framed for something that I didn't do.

I'll be out before she knows it, and then I'll come back for her.

As for Leighton, I'm not particularly worried. Despite her strong will and intelligent mind, I'm nearly positive that she still sees some sort of goodness in my heart. She doesn't know me quite well enough to be able to accept that I'm simply maniacal, and I can't blame her for that. I gave my best performance yet when I was acting as her best friend.

She won't forget about me.

I'm sure of it.

After all, sisters are forever.

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Thank you for reading!